Knifepoint

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31844620.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe – Criminals, Immortality, Smut, Angst with a Happy Ending, Slow Build, Lovers to enemies to lovers, Getting Back Together, I can't say exes because they never break up they just keep fucking while they're fighting, Temporary Character Death, Temporary but very repeated, listen they're immortal okay it's not a big deal to die, Implied/Referenced Abuse, Modern AU but still Canon Species

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Catradora AUs by n7punk

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Summary

There have always been rumors about immortals, but the general populace dismisses it as a fable from a time before science could explain someone's recovery. Rumors have continued to circulate in the criminal underground, however, of individuals who can pull off job after job, never seeming to face consequences or even gather scars. When Adora receives a fatal injury during a heist and wakes up alive and unharmed in her bed, she is forced to accept that there is more to the legend than just mysticism.
There is an entire group seeming to possess the same miraculous abilities fresh on the scene in the Fright Zone, and the Alliance is starting to cut into the Horde's take now. With the knowledge that they all could be like Adora, she is sent to join them undercover and spy on them, but fears begin to rise that Adora has truly turned her back on the Horde – and Catra.
(Catradora immortal criminals modern AU)

Prologue

Chapter Notes

> CWs: I have issues with violence and that's not the point of this fic, but there will be some triggering content throughout it. As such, this is a blanket **CW for the entire fic**: Character death/suicide (immortal characters will die, repeatedly and often on purpose. They will use traditional methods of suicide to regenerate their bodies), verbal/emotional abuse (Shadow Weaver is in this fic), manipulation (see previous), mentions of/allusions to torture (not depicted outright), and some violence/blood/weapons use. Also mentions of starvation/eating issues for one background immortal in particular.
> If you have read my fics 'smile like a switchblade' or 'a strange disease like me', I don't intend to get any more graphic in this than I was in those. If anything additional comes up, I will make a note in the individual chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"She's going to get you fucking killed, Adora," Catra hisses to her. Adora glances over her shoulder even though she knows no one followed them up here. Back when they were both cadets the Horde had taken in, they weren't allowed out of the Horde's base of operations, but they found a way to sneak up here to the very top of the industrial complex for moments of privacy. Now that Adora is a captain, she isn't watched as closely, but she still is hardly ever allowed to leave.

It isn't safe to go wandering around in a city so infested with crime and corruption that everyone calls it the Fright Zone, even its politicians. If a rival group recognized her on the street, they might seek out retribution or even ransom from the Horde. It's safer to stay here, even if she and Catra have to be secretive about their affection

within the walls of the Horde's headquarters. Relationships are – in theory – banned in the Horde.

No one seems to give a shit about that rule except for Shadow Weaver, but she was the one who brought them into the Horde and she is their mentor. She has turned a willing blind eye to others, but Adora and Catra are her protégés and she is a lot stricter with them. She applies rules to them more harshly – but she also trusts them, or at least Adora, with more than she would with the others.

"She knows I can handle it, Catra. She wouldn't have promoted me to captain otherwise. Yes, the jobs and positions she's been giving me since are riskier, but that just goes with the title," Adora dismisses, shaking her head and looking out over the smog-filled skyline. At sunset, it tinges an unnatural red shade from the pollution put out by the factories the Horde has hidden its base of operations in the middle of.

"*No one* can handle it, Adora. You only survived the last job by the sheer dumb luck of the dispatcher getting the address wrong. If the police had arrived in twenty minutes like they were supposed to, you would have gotten shot or arrested. You were a sitting duck," Catra shoots back, her ears pinned back and tail lashing. Adora frowns, scooting a little closer so they can press their sides together.

She knows that Catra is annoyed right now, but it's so rare that they get time alone together. They aren't together, they've never even talked about it, but relationships being banned hasn't stopped them entirely. Shadow Weaver argues that relationships are distracting, but Adora knows that she doesn't have that problem. Catra makes her better. One day she will convince Shadow Weaver of that and they can finally be together, but right now they are best friends and that is all, their physicality hidden and any hope at romance a forbidden wish.

Catra reluctantly sits up, curling into Adora's side. Adora wraps an arm around Catra, a little relieved that she is willing to cuddle despite her annoyance. Adora does see where Catra is coming from – the

danger Adora has been expected to take on skyrocketed when she was promoted to captain – but she also knows that Shadow Weaver has grand plans for her, even if she won't say what they are. There is no way that she would just throw Adora's life away.

"Did you ever think that maybe it wasn't an accident that the police went to the wrong address?" Adora returns. Catra's ears twitch back and she looks up to glare at Adora. Adora just raises an eyebrow at her. "You *know* we have people in the force, even if Hordak is secretive about it. That bank was loaded. It would have been worth calling in a favor for a late arrival on-scene," Adora points out. Catra growls, turning to look out towards the rolling hills just barely visible beyond the city.

"Sure, maybe she did that because she never tells us anything and we're supposed to blindly trust the Horde. What about the job before that, then? And the one before *that*? The positions she's assigning you to are reckless," Catra grits out, spitting out the last word like it has burned her. Shadow Weaver loves to apply that word to Catra. Adora knows that it's a bit hypocritical for her to use it and then make these plans for them, but-

"It's working, Catra. And the Horde has been losing ground lately. We need to take more risks if we're going to keep our grip on the city," Adora points out. Catra scoffs, but it's true. The Horde is mostly focused on things like gambling dens and heists, but they have a territory built up to protect their casinos from rivals. They provide those inside it with protection from violence at the hand of other organizations and the corrupt police. Adora and Catra are part of the heist teams, hitting cash strongholds so that the Horde has funds to combat the other groups that would hurt people.

Recently, a new gang has swept into town. It only has seven members, but somehow they have caused a major disturbance in the city's well-entrenched crime organizations. They're cutting into the Horde's protection fees, stealing directly from them, and even worse, they're undermining their authority. If people lose faith that the Horde can keep them safe and stop paying in, how can they

keep affording to protect them? Their territory will shrink and even their gambling operations will be at risk. They have to take these big, risky jobs.

Adora knows why Catra is afraid, but there isn't any other way. Adora was raised at Shadow Weaver's right hand, and Catra at her left. Shadow Weaver saw potential in them when they were just two street rats, clinging to each other to share body heat at night. Adora can't let her down, not after she spent so long clothing, feeding, and training them. If Shadow Weaver believes that Adora can pull these jobs off, then she will. Their mentor has far more experience than them in this business – more intel, too. She knows what risks she is weighing when she sends them out.

"It' s working *for now*, Adora. Do you really want to die for some fucking money?" Catra shoots back. Adora startles, not expecting the heat in Catra's gaze as she glares at Adora, challenging her . The answer is no, Adora isn't going to die for money, but it isn't just about the take from the individual job. It's about supporting the group that raised her. It's about doing what is expected of her and not failing her team.

"I'll be fine, Catra," Adora responds. It isn't the response that Catra was looking for. Catra hisses and stands, turning and leaping down from their perch before Adora can even hope to stand to follow her. She watches Catra disappear around a corner below, not daring to shout after her and draw attention. The last thing she sees is her tail whipping around the corner.

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Catra sleeps in Adora's bed. Even once they were protected by four walls and didn't need to share body heat anymore, they didn't want to be separated. It wasn't like they knew if these strangers who took

them in could be trusted. Actually, it turns out that they *couldn't*, but they're here now. Their needs are provided for, and people don't just walk away from the Horde if Adora even wanted to try.

Catra sleeps at the foot of the bed now – partially because Adora fucking punches in her sleep and partially in case Shadow Weaver decides to make the rounds and finds them too close together – but sometimes she sneaks up to the head of the bed when the others are asleep. It's too risky to fall asleep there, but in the darkness of the bunk room, one of the few rooms without cameras, Catra can lay with her head on the pillow beside Adora's and kiss her.

They aren't dating, not really. They rarely hold hands even. They're best friends, and sometimes when they get a moment alone together, they press their bodies together. They wouldn't risk having sex in the bed, but they can kiss, Catra's hands buried in Adora's hair and Adora's on her waist, holding her close as they both do their best to stay silent and not wake any of the others.

They aren't girlfriends, but they aren't anything *else* either. Catra has always been whole-heartedly dedicated to Adora, and when her friend's eyes started lingering on her during puberty, Catra took a chance. Their first kiss was in the showers. The locker room is the only other place that they know doesn't have cameras.

It isn't surprising how qickly they got physical considering their only place to so much as kiss was where they were both already naked. They don't talk about it, and Adora never indicates that she is yearning for more the same way Catra is, but it isn't like they could have it anyway. Shadow Weaver would fucking kill her. Catra can be happy with Adora's friendship and her touch.

Adora gives a soft sigh against her lips. It is qiet enough to not risking waking anyone else, and Catra drinks down the noise greedily. She loves any sound that she can elicit from Adora without putting them at risk. She loves *Adora*, plain and simple, even if she can never say it. She can never even have her, not the way she wants to. It's the curse of falling for Shadow Weaver's protégé

Technically Shadow Weaver mentors both of them, but there is pretty clear favoritism going on when Catra's punishments are being beaten and Adora's are *watching* Catra get beaten. Shadow Weaver isn't afraid to leave marks on Adora either, but they aren't as effective at controlling her. Catra shivers lightly as Adora's hand sneaks beneath her shirt, the tips of her fingers tracing along a bumpy scar that is visible even through her fur.

Adora knows a lot of her scars by heart. She traces her fingers up, following the lines, some visible and some not, until she can spread her hand between Catra's shoulder blades and hold Catra close as she kisses her, slow and purposeful. It is almost loving, the way Adora holds her in secret, but that word has no meaning here – or at least, not in the Horde. The only place that Catra has ever felt loved is in Adora's arms, but it is always in stolen moments like this.

It's too much of a risk to talk about it. Even now, Catra hears a soft grunt elsewhere in the room and pulls back, moving lightning-qick to the end of the bed despite how she knows it was probably just one of the younger street kids making noise in their sleep. It usually is. She wishes that she and Adora could move out like kids that the Horde takes in are supposed to when they start making enough to keep some of the cash, but Shadow Weaver wouldn't allow it.

Catra feels cold without Adora wrapped around her. She hates to break an embrace suddenly like that, even if they have to do it often. Cautiously, she reaches to the edge of the bed and flips the blanket up so she can expose Adora's leg. She presses a qick, soft kiss against the top of her shin before flipping the covers back down and settling into her usual spot.

One day they'll be in a position in the Horde where they have enough power that Shadow Weaver can't keep them apart anymore. It is everything that they have worked for. Adora being made captain was the first step. They'll get there. One day, Catra is going to hold Adora in her arms and kiss her slow, *touch* her slow, in a bed that they share without any worry for someone interrupting them. They have to. That dream is all Catra has.

--

"Catra would do better on the infiltration team than I would. The position is perfectly suited to her skills," Adora pitches, gesturing at the whiteboard that Shadow Weaver is debriefing her on. Shadow Weaver pauses the same way that she always does any time someone says something that could be construed as challenging her, deciding whether it is worthy of punishment or a valid point.

"Catra is better with technology than you are," Shadow Weaver returns, but her gaze is appraising. She is giving Adora an opening to make her counterargument, she just needs to be convincing. In truth, Adora hates this whole plan. The Palatial Casino is notoriously well-guarded. It is used as neutral ground for dealings between the various criminal enterprises in the Fright Zone. Adora accompanied Shadow Weaver to a deal there once when she was freshly twenty, brought along to observe how these things go.

They foster the neutral environment carefully. Their security is intense and trigger-happy. Hitting them is a big risk. It isn't a risk the Horde would have taken a year ago, but the new upstarts are really disrupting things in the city. Shadow Weaver has been having a lot of meetings with Hordak ever since. Most of the time they both leave fuming. Shadow Weaver doesn't tell anyone what happens in those meetings, but clearly it isn't good news.

Adora knows there is nothing that she can say to change the plan – she tried that with the last one Shadow Weaver made and her response wasn't kind – but she *can* make an argument for who should be in what roles, no matter how much Adora hates the positions that Shadow Weaver has laid out for her team. The person securing the hatch is a sitting duck, but Adora isn't about to let it be Catra.

"Catra can climb through the shaft the fastest. If she heads in first, she can hit the vault and have the duffels mostly loaded by the time that Lonnie and Rogelio have hit the vault. She can get out faster too and back me up if it becomes necessary. We won't need to account for so much time loading in the vault and it will be less time with one person exposed since she can cover for me,"Adora argues.

"Besides, you said it yourself, this thing will do the hacking for us. Catra is better with tech, but I can get it hooked up. It doesn't matter which one of us is holding it in the end,"Adora finishes, gesturing to the piece of tech on the table. Yes, Catra's claws will be necessary to cut into the security system's shell to hook it up, but she will still be there for that part and can help regardless of her final position in the heist.

To Adora's surprise, Shadow Weaver looks oddly *proud*. Well, okay, she looks satisfied, but it's satisfied in Adora's general direction and as a result of something she said, so it's basically the same thing. Shadow Weaver straightens up, nodding her approval. Adora is certain that she is smiling, though it's hard to tell considering Shadow Weaver took to permanently wearing her heist mask before she even took Catra and Adora in.

"Good. I've already reqisitioned the eqipment for Catra to be on the infiltration team,"Shadow W eaver returns. Adora blinks at her in shock. She wants to ask why Shadow Weaver told her that she would be the hacker then, but Shadow Weaver has that *don't question me* look about her. Adora pauses, her gaze flitting between the board and Shadow Weaver before she nods.

It was a test. And she passed it. She doesn't know why Shadow Weaver felt the need to run it, but she proved that she knows her team's strengths or whatever it was that Shadow Weaver wanted her to do. Catra is going to be on the infiltration team. Every position except driver is risky in this heist, but Catra won't be sitting out in the open waiting to be shot at, at least as long as Adora does her job.

And she will. She has to.

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Catra can't tell if she is seething or downright terrified as she sits through Adora's debrief. Not for the first time, she laments the Horde's structure. If Shadow Weaver had the guts to lay out this plan to all of them where she – once again – puts Adora in a position that threatens to riddle her with bullets, Catra would challenge her right then and there, regardless of the punishment.

"Has Shadow W eaver lost her fucking mind? The Palatial? With *no prep*?" Catra demands, her claws out as she gestures at the floorplan laid out on the table they are gathered around. Sure, Shadow Weaver got them a map of the place and the codes to the vault, but there is no information on their security measures. They've been told how to get in and out and they're just supposed to just trust that the plan accounts for anything.

How their mentor expects them to trust her when she has nearly got Adora killed four jobs in a row now, Catra doesn't know. She can't understand that woman and she was *raised* by her. Kyle physically flinches at Catra's outburst, looking quickly over his shoulder like Shadow Weaver will sense the disrespect and materialize out of thin air. Actually, that's fair – she seems to do that a lot.

"Shadow W eaver did the prep, that's how she came up with this plan. It will be fine, Catra. It isn't any riskier than the last job," Adora shoots back, huffing as she sends Catra a look clearly meant to cow her, but Catra is never going to bend to Adora's newfound authority. She has been there for Adora as much as Adora has been there for her. She refuses to view them as anything but equals.

"Y eah, that's not comforting, Adora," Lonnie mutters, eyeing the map between them. It's not much backup, but Catra looks back to Adora, gesturing to Lonnie as proof that this is ridiculous. Adora is

technically just the messenger relaying the plan to the rest of them, but she is also the captain of this team and supposed to stick up for them.

Unfortunately, the most unreasonable expectation has been placed on Adora, supposed to guard their entrance single-handedly so the rest of them don't get locked into a death trap. Of course she expects that of herself. The entire plan hinges on security not figuring out where their entry point is and sending a team there to secure the shaft.

"You're trusting her to do all the research without telling us why or how this would work?" Catra responds, gesturing violently at the map with her claws unsheathed. She can't stop them from sliding out, desperately wanting to tear up the map and leave this entire plan behind. She can't believe how much faith Adora is putting into their unhinged mentor. She didn't gain the scars on her back to hide them and pretend they never happened – her skin is living proof of how little care Shadow Weaver has for her fellow mankind.

She has been torturing them since they were children, and Adora really thinks that she suddenly cares about them now? Shadow Weaver doesn't care about anything but maintaining her position as Hordak's second, and now it seems that she is willing to put Adora's life on the line to do so. Adora sets her mouth in a thin line, looking back down at the map. After a long moment, she sighs and looks up pleadingly.

"Listen, this plan is the only way anyone is ever going to have a *chance* at getting in and out of the Palatial. We'll be legends if we pull it off. We're moving out on Friday night, when they'll have their hands full with guests. They won't be expecting a hit right before their big weekend crowds. We'll have the element of surprise," Adora returns, sending Catra a hard look. Catra knows that look.

It means that Adora is backed into a corner too. It means that Adora already knows that Shadow Weaver isn't backing down on this plan. Catra *hates* this. She feels so trapped. She thought that once Adora

was promoted to captain and she was given her own squad with Catra as her second, then they would finally have some freedom.

She keeps her mouth shut through the rest of the meeting – well, no, she never could do *that*, but she stops berating the plan no matter how much she hates it. There isn't anything they can do. You don't talk back to higher-ups in the Horde. They feed you, they clothe you, they help you get back on your feet, and in return, they own you. If the Horde says to give your life, you're supposed to do it. It was never yours to begin with after they built you up.

Yeah, right. Catra wouldn't give a hair on her back for this organization – but she would give nearly anything for Adora. It kills her to see Adora going along with this, just accepting that her life is expendable. It *isn't*. Catra doesn't know what game Shadow Weaver is playing here. The woman doesn't have a heart, but even from an objective perspective, it doesn't make sense to spend so much time raising a kid only to send them to their death.

Shadow Weaver raised Adora up to be her perfect protégé, and now she seems so willing to abandon her. When Adora does manage to miraculously succeed at these suicide missions, Shadow Weaver isn't even *impressed*. She just says something about how Adora didn't disappoint her and moves on. Adora breathes in the scant praise, but she deserves more than that.

Catra stews for the rest of the debrief. When the others leave, heading back to the bunks, Catra lingers, leaning against the wall with her arms crossed. Adora is silent as she rolls back up the blueprints she laid out for the meeting and begins to stow them away. Catra's stomach hurts from the roiling emotions inside her. They have been working up to this for their entire lives, certain that if they just make captain status, they'll finally be happy.

It all feels *hopeless*. Catra doesn't know how much longer she can take watching Adora walk into death and then miraculously limp back out, assuring Catra that she's fine and the next job will be better. They never are – they just get worse and worse, spiraling down into

blackness. Adora is the one thing that grounds her, but now it feels like she is driving her mad too.

"Adora, I can't lose you," Catra whispers, her voice small. Adora stops, hunching her shoulders as she leans over the table and hangs her head a little. Her back is to Catra, but she doesn't need to see her face to pick up on the building tension within her.

"You won't. I'm no use to anyone dead. It will be fine," Adora returns. Catra growls, shoving off the wall. It *won't* be fine. Adora can't just keep saying that and hoping that it's true. Catra can't keep hearing it.

"Say that Shadow Weaver is risking your life. Fucking say it. Tell me I'm on the level here," Catra demands, gesturing angrily despite how Adora can't see it. She doesn't care. Adora is supposed to keep her sane, not parrot Shadow Weaver's bullshit back at her. The consequence of *not talking back* is that Catra feels like she is the only person who can see how fucked up it is here. She is losing her mind. Adora is silent for a long moment.

"She just knows that I can take it. She's right. I've done it before and I'll do it again. I'm not letting you guys down," Adora replies, eventually, her voice low. Catra feels a burst of anger, fighting the urge to turn around and slash at the wall. This is all so *wrong*.

"Sorry, I forgot you were *special* for a minute," she spits back, parroting Shadow Weaver's words herself now as she turns on her heel and storms from the room. She knows she shouldn't be mad at Adora - Shadow Weaver is the one who doesn't care about Adora's life - but Adora is going along with it. Catra doesn't know if she has bought into Shadow Weaver's bullshit about how special she is, but she continually does shit like this.

Catra growls to herself as she heads to the bunks and pointedly climbs into her own bed. She is still seething with dread and anger when Adora makes her way to the bunks almost an hour later. Catra is no closer to falling asleep, but she pretends to be when Adora

stretches up on her toes beside the bed and peers up at her top bunk.

She can smell her disappointment as she goes to remove her outer layers and crawl into her own bed, conspicuously alone. Adora apparently has no problem with taking risks that threaten to leave Catra alone, though.

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They should have made up before the job, Adora thinks distantly. She should have cornered Catra yesterday and made them talk. Instead, every time Catra slipped away, Adora let her go. She was hoping that once the job was done and Catra saw that it was fine, her anger would fade. Adora doesn't know what she is angry about, truthfully, but she supposes it doesn't matter now.

Catra is mad about the positions that Adora has taken in the last few jobs, but Adora was certain she could do it. She wasn't about to start fighting Shadow Weaver on this. How was she ever supposed to secure a better position for them if she was disobeying her mentor, especially by telling her that she can't meet expectations?

Adora was set on meeting and *exceeding* them. She thought she just needed to do well enough in these jobs, be impressive enough, that Shadow Weaver felt like they had finally succeeded as protégés and gave them more autonomy to operate on their own. Once they had that, they would be safe and could finally be happy together. Adora just hadn't proven herself yet.

She won't get the chance now. All she can think about is that they never got to be happy. She never even got to tell Catra how she feels. She can hear Catra's claws scrabbling in her earpiece and echoing down the shaft as Adora weakly continues to fire her gun,

every pull of the trigger sending a new flood of blood gushing from her shoulder.

Something went wrong – Catra was *right* and there was a flaw in the plan. The entirety of the security team converged on Adora as soon as the infiltration team was in the vault. Adora couldn't move. Even when she had the energy left to, she had to stay and make sure the grate stayed open so Catra and the others could get out. She had to make sure that Catra was okay, at least. It's definitely too late for herself. Adora has been a starved kid living on the streets in the dead of winter, but she has never felt cold like this.

Her arm stops responding. Their cover fire is gone. After so long training to be able to hit the moving targets of arms and legs, it all turns out to be useless. The security team realizes quickly that the shots have stopped and those still able to walk duck out from their hiding places and start approaching her. Adora isn't capable of talking anymore, but she needs to warn the team that their exit is about to be closed off. She can't give in to the blackness, not yet.

Gunfire rings out beside her, the sustained fire of an automatic. It isn't the kind of weapon the security team is using. Adora's vision swims as Catra materializes in the center of it. Tears are streaming down her face and she is definitely yelling, but Adora can't hear anything but noise anymore. All she can think is she never got to *say it*. As blackness takes her, she thinks *I love you* as hard as she can and hopes that Catra knows it.

--

"You left a third of the take behind," Shadow Weaver says. If Catra was capable of feeling any emotion, she would light up with anger and fling herself at the woman, shredding the stupid mask she wears beneath her claws. As it is, Rogelio is holding her up, and she can

hardly twitch as she just stares at the woman. Adora is *dead*. Catra abandoned her duffle bag to try to carry her body, but she had to leave her behind when the police showed up.

Lonnie and Rogelio had to drag Catra away and shove her into the getaway car. Catra was fighting them as they drove them away. Adora is *dead* and Shadow Weaver cares about how much of the money they managed to bring back. She hasn't even mentioned that Adora isn't amongst them. She is seething, so she must have already heard about the death on the police scanners, but she hasn't acknowledged that she got Adora killed.

"Shadow Weaver, please," Lonnie says, her voice deadly quiet. Lonnie won't challenge Shadow Weaver to her face like Catra would if she could *think*, but she just lost a friend too. Shadow Weaver straightens, drawing herself up to her full height as she considers them. In the morning, Catra is going to kill the woman. Right now, she feels empty. Nothing matters, not even this disrespect to Adora's memory.

Catra watches numbly as Shadow Weaver dismisses them with a wave. Rogelio picks Catra up without hesitation, carrying her through the halls. Catra doesn't care where they are going. It doesn't *matter*. Adora isn't there. The bunk room materializes around them. Rogelio brought her where she could curl up in bed to cry. Good. Catra buries herself down in the blanket when Rogelio sets her down.

Things happen around her – sound and movement and time passing, probably – but Catra buries her face in the blanket and breathes in Adora's lingering scent until she runs out of tears. The bunk room goes dark at one point, lights-out hitting, and Catra crawls to the foot of the bed, curling up into a small ball beneath the blanket. It's like Adora is in the bed with her. Catra can close her eyes and pretend that the warmth of the blanket is Adora's body heat. As long as she doesn't shift and feel the absence of Adora's legs beside her-

Adora's legs are beside her. Catra shoots up, twisting to free herself of the blanket. She rips long gashes in it, needing to be *free* so she can look. Her heart is pounding, her own throat choking her, her ears roaring as she turns and blinks in the darkness of the room. Her night vision means she can see Adora laid out in the bed with perfect clarity, her chest rising and falling peacefully as she breathes in and out, life in her and *no bullet wound* in her neck.

Catra launches herself forward, gripping Adora's shoulders just like she did when she was dying and shaking her desperately. This time, Adora's eyes fly open and she blinks up at Catra. Catra freezes, swallowing as she stares down at the woman she *watched die*. Adora looks confused as she glances down at her body.

"I made it?" she asks. Her voice is a thin whisper, but it isn't the rasp it should be after that ordeal. The words don't shake Catra out of her stupor. All she can think is, *no, you didn't*.

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Catra refuses to let go of Adora. Even Shadow Weaver gives up on separating them despite how they aren't usually allowed to touch like this. They are both kind of dazed after everything that happened last night as Shadow Weaver leads them into her inner sanctum. They've been here before as kids, but they only caught glimpses of the conspiracy boards Shadow Weaver had hung everywhere before they were caught and heavily punished.

Now, Adora is invited in, and Catra is clinging onto her arm, unwilling to let go. Adora wasn't going anywhere without Catra. Shadow Weaver seems willing to make exceptions considering she was dead across town a few hours ago, and then she woke up here, Catra staring at her like she was a ghost. Now, Adora can see that the hanging wall clippings all have a centralized theme.

"Almost every culture in history has stories of immortals in some way," Shadow Weaver says, almost *proudly* as she gestures to a board dedicated to the miracles Christian saints have performed that involved raising the dead. Adora and Catra both stare at it.

"Magic isn't real," Adora manages, but it comes out a lot more questioning than she intends it to. Shadow Weaver is unmoved by her words, pointing to a nearby bookshelf covered in textbooks, all appearing to be focused on religion and history.

"Call it what you will. Some ancient religions considered these people blessed, or gods themselves. Any area that saw a rise in the belief of Christianity quickly saw a fall in reports of immortals, if people continued to believe they existed at all. They attributed the miraculous recovery of these people to God or saints, but there is a wealth of historical evidence for individuals who could miraculously regenerate their bodies upon death even after that," Shadow Weaver tells her.

The room looks like it belongs to a lunatic. If it hadn't just *happened* to Adora, she would say that Shadow Weaver had lost her mind. Beside her, Catra tenses as Shadow Weaver steps forward and reaches out to cradle Adora's head in her hand, forcing her to look up and meet her eyes.

"The evidence was too great for me to ignore the possibility like so many do now. When I met you as a child, I recognized the signs in you. I knew you were special. You only proved it over the years. You are one of the chosen few, Adora," Shadow Weaver tells her. Adora's heart is pounding as she leans into the touch. She still feels lost, but those words soothe her some. They give her something to hold onto.

"What are the *signs*?" Catra asks at her side. She sounds scared. She is reeling even worse than Adora is. At least Adora didn't have to experience being dead. She passed out, and then she woke up. In that time, Catra was mourning, believing that Adora was gone

forever. Shadow Weaver glances down at Catra, appraising her for a long moment.

"Immortals are beings of love, and Adora has a vast capacity for it," Shadow Weaver says, cryptically, before she drops her hand and turns away to approach a map of the Fright Zone that she has hung on her wall. Adora watches as she folds her hands behind her back, a satisfied air pouring out from her.

"You're going to change everything for us, Adora," Shadow Weaver says. Her voice is low, smug and dark. Catra's fur bristles as she presses closer into Adora's side. The words sound like a threat, but they can't be, right? Even if they were, Adora is immortal now, apparently. She'll be okay. It will all be okay.

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If it weren't for the irrefutable evidence in front of her, Catra still wouldn't believe Shadow Weaver. The historical examples mean nothing to her – she doesn't take the beliefs of any religion as evidence of some misunderstood fact. The whole thing sounds about as real as vampires, but according to Shadow Weaver, those come from a historical basis involving the immortals too. What Catra can't deny are the facts around Adora's death.

She *watched* Adora die. She crawled into their bunk alone. Suddenly, Adora was just there. There isn't a security feed inside the bunkroom itself, but there is just outside of it, and no one went in or out. Shadow Weaver's contacts in the police gave her the report on Adora's death. Adora was in a body bag, and then when someone went to retrieve it, the bag had been "replaced" with one that was empty. There wasn't a trace of her blood on the roof either.

The police have assumed that she is dead and the Horde sent in cleaners because they didn't want her DNA analyzed and linked to other crimes. There weren't any cameras on her or the DNA evidence when it vanished. They just turned around and it was gone. There is already an internal investigation since it seems obvious there was corruption on the scene, but those never go anywhere in the Fright Zone. They would have to fire the entire force.

According to what Shadow Weaver has found, immortals die – seemingly endlessly – and then they wake up in their beds, alive and unharmed. They are an error in the fabric of reality, she claims. She can use whatever science terms she wants to explain it, it won't make it sound any more logical. Just because Catra can't deny what happened doesn't mean she wants to rely on it happening *again*.

"She has been sacrificing you on purpose," Catra murmurs, her voice quiet. She said it before and Adora denied it. This time, she is silent, staring blankly at the wall in front of her. They are in a dark closet, so it isn't like Adora can see anything anyway, but this is what it takes to have a moment of true privacy in the Horde. After a long moment, Adora sighs, her shoulders slumping.

"Yeah, she was. But she knew I would be okay, too," Adora returns. Catra wants to scream. This whole thing is *insane*. Shadow Weaver turned out to be right, but what if she *wasn't*? What if Adora was just some girl? Shadow Weaver sent Adora to slaughter, but Adora is willing to just forgive it. It isn't okay, it never could be. Catra still isn't convinced it will work a second time and she is terrified to find out.

She drops her head forward, resting it on Adora's shoulder. She wants to scream, but instead she curls into her friend, their legs awkwardly tangled together on the closet floor. It's bold for them to duck into a closet like this, but Adora has been granted more privileges since her miraculous recovery, and the other members of the Horde have been looking at her with awe. Catra doubts anyone is going to tell on them. Adora had the "privilege" of a personal meeting with Hordak this morning.

Apparently he has known about Shadow Weaver's obsession with immortals for a long time, but he didn't believe that Adora was one of them. All of Shadow Weaver's weirdness around Adora is suddenly starting to fall into place. She claims that from the moment that she first spotted them in an alley she knew that Adora was different. She claims she wasn't concerned about Adora's death when they returned from the job because she knew that she would be back.

Catra *knows* that's bullshit. She was numb at the time, but there was a seething darkness in their mentor that night. Adora hadn't reappeared yet and Shadow Weaver was livid that she was wrong. She still won't explain why she came to suspect Adora was one of the "chosen." All she will explain is how this immortal thing is supposed to work, according to her research and the information recorded by the ancient civilizations where immortals lived openly.

Adora dies. After a while, she wakes back up in her home. The injury that caused her death is gone without a trace, but even her old scars are oddly faded now, some of the fainter ones vanished completely. Shadow Weaver wants to use Adora's newfound abilities to plan heists that no one else could ever pull off – the kind of heists that rumors about led to Shadow Weaver researching immortality in the first place, decades ago.

"We're going to be okay," Adora whispers to her, pressing a soft kiss to Catra's temple. Catra wishes she believed her. Adora is determined to see this through. She says that this is how they'll get promoted and work their way up to a position of power. Catra hates it. The Horde got Adora *killed*, regardless of Shadow Weaver's intentions. Adora is buying into all of Shadow Weaver's bullshit about how special she is. She's leaving Catra *behind*.

Catra is just a mortal that Shadow Weaver never liked but kept around for unknown reasons. Shadow Weaver once told Catra that she reminds her of herself at that age. Catra thought, for a while at least, that Shadow Weaver was raising her as a protégé despite her clear dislike for her as some kind of twisted revenge fantasy on her

own younger years. Now she can't help but wonder if she only kept her around to keep Adora happy.

Catra might be the best infiltrator the Horde has – but she isn't obedient. Shadow Weaver has always considered her second-rate, no matter how hard she tries or how much she succeeds, because she won't bend her knee like Adora does gladly. Adora got promoted to Captain – Catra became her second only at Adora's insistence. She had to fight for Catra to even be considered second-best to her.

If this newfound ability of hers does secure her more authority, Catra doesn't have a lot of faith that it will improve things for the both of them. Adora has been doing everything she can to please Shadow Weaver lately. It already felt like she was pulling away before all this – now, Catra is terrified of where their future is headed. She shifts up and kisses Adora, desperate and pleading.

Adora doesn't understand her. She kisses Catra back like she always does – happily, without an inkling of the storm inside of Catra's chest.

Chapter End Notes

> Welcome to the Fright Zone. It's a piece of shit but the citizens cope by making jokes that no one else could handle their world. It's basically Gotham in that sense.
> The Horde is meant to be mafia-esque, but it's based more off the Horde in the show than the real mob (especially when it comes to terminology. Catra is a cadet, not an associate and Adora is a captain, not a soldier). It's an organized crime syndicate that has a number of focuses. Catra and Adora's experience of it was more cult-like than anything else tbh, but we'll get to that.

Lamb (to the slaughter)

Chapter Notes

> There's going to be a lot of unreliable narration in this fic. Truths will be revealed over time, but if something seems.of f to you, it's intentional.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora's training was always different from the others - now she knows why. Shadow Weaver is planning heists around Adora's abilities, placing her in situations that she can't get out of, but it shouldn't matter as long as she disrupts the security for long enough. They get two weeks between the mission that changed everything and the next one, but they make it out alive by the skin of their teeth this time.

"Y ou should have taken the shot. You would have been fine. You dragged your team down by making them help you to the getaway car,"Shadow W eaver snaps at Adora the next day. Adora spent the night in the med bay after taking a bullet to the thigh. Catra was there with her too, her ribs bruised from a shot to her K vlar vest. As they laid together last night, Catra whispered to her that she was so relieved that Adora made it out. Now, Shadow Weaver is angry that Adora tried to survive.

"If I thought they couldn't make it with me, I would have had them leave me behind,"Adora returns, her voice qiet. It is true, and it was true even before Shadow Weaver dropped the bomb of what she is on her. Shadow Weaver scoffs, turning to narrow her eyes at her through the slits in her mask.

"Y ou took an unnecessary risk by delaying their escape and you're wasting medical supplies,"she shoots back. Adora wants to shiver , but she suppresses the urge. Shadow Weaver isn't talking about dying, not really, not when she'll be okay in the end, but it still feels

like a threat despite how Adora knows that she should be perfectly fine.

"We don't know how it works - if it will even happen again, or if I only get a limited number," Adora whispers, her voice quiet. *Catra doesn't want me to die*, she doesn't say. She doesn't need to direct Shadow Weaver's ire onto her friend. Shadow Weaver pauses, and then she softens, reaching out to cup Adora's cheek.

"Adora, are you afraid? You don't need to be. I have researched this for decades. The universe doesn't let people like you fade, you're too important. I wouldn't put you in this position if I didn't know that you would be okay," Shadow Weaver promises her, her voice a gentle croon. Some of the roiling emotion within Adora quiets, but she *is* afraid. She has never seen Catra like she was the night that Adora woke up. She doesn't want to put her through that again.

"I'm just," Adora trails off. She doesn't know what she can say. Shadow Weaver assured her that she would be fine. She has been right so far. Catra is mad about Shadow Weaver "killing" Adora, but Adora knows that she wasn't actually doing that when she was certain that Adora would regenerate. Adora has to believe that she knew what she was doing, if only because Shadow Weaver raised her and it makes no sense to throw away all that effort and time on a chance. Above her, she watches Shadow Weaver's expression darken as her hand falls away, tucking inside of her jacket.

"I told you that you would be fine, Adora. I will *show* you," Shadow Weaver promises her, her tone dark. Before Adora can fully register the words, pain blossoms in her gut. Shadow Weaver slipped her hidden knife out before Adora could even look down.

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Adora is called into a meeting with Shadow Weaver as soon as she can walk. Catra waits for her return in the med bay. The Horde practically has its own hospital so their injured don't get arrested while receiving medical attention. Catra waits. And she waits. Her annoyance grows with every second of rest that Shadow Weaver steals from Adora. Eventually, she can't just sit there waiting anymore. When she seeks out Shadow Weaver, she finds her alone.

"Where' s Adora?" Catra demands, her tail lashing as the needles of fear prick at her limbs. Shadow Weaver only turns her head slightly to acknowledge her, sending her a dismissive look as she continues walking.

"I believe she laid down to rest of f her injury," Shadow W eaver replies. Catra swallows, watching Shadow Weaver's retreating back, seeming unbothered by Catra's distress. Her feet feel rooted to the ground, but she manages to turn and force herself to walk to the bunk room. She is terrified to arrive and find the bed empty.

It isn't empty. Adora is lying in their bunk, breathing deeply in what appears to be a restful sleep. She wouldn't have come back here. She knew that Catra was waiting for her in the med bay. Catra sits on the edge of the bed with her heart in her throat, lifting the sheets to get a look at Adora beneath them. There is a slash in the stomach of her shirt, though her skin is unmarred beneath it.

Catra grabs the waist of Adora's pants and wrestles them down without any thought except that she needs to *see it*. Adora wakes groggily at the manhandling, peering down at Catra in confusion as she partially strips her. Catra is too busy staring at Adora's newly-exposed thigh to look up, her mind spiraling over the fact that there is no bandage, wound, or even *scar* marking it.

"That *bitch*," Catra hisses. Adora blows out an unsteady breath, propping herself up on her elbows to look down her own body. She winces at the sight of the slash down her shirt, but she flexes her thigh experimentally.

"The pain is gone," she murmurs. Catra looks up at her, incredulous. Adora's expression is tired, almost worn down despite the fact that she just regenerated. She shrugs. For the first time, Catra sees a tinge of helplessness in her gaze. "I'll turn this into something that we can use, Catra. How can being immortal be bad news?" Adora tries to assure her, reaching out to place a hand on her shoulder. Catra swallows heavily.

She doesn't know the answer to that question yet, but she is pretty sure that they are going to find out.

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Shadow Weaver wants to prove a point, probably. The next plan hinges on Adora infiltrating first and cutting the power to the security system – she can do that, sure. It's just that the security doors will close behind her and, without power to their circuits, lock her inside. When Adora asks what she is supposed to do then, Shadow Weaver wordlessly gestures to a gun on the table behind them. Adora feels kind of sick, but she nods. She'll be fine, she assures herself when she lays out the plan for her team later.

She has never seen Catra's expression as dark as when she asks Adora what her exit is and Adora doesn't reply. Catra storms away and doesn't look back. Adora finishes debriefing the others, ignoring the way that they side-eye each other. Shadow Weaver has forbidden anyone from talking about what happened with Adora. Their three teammates keep asking how she made it back and recovered, but Adora doesn't know how to explain it even if she was allowed to.

She just picks up the gun, her skin clammy and sweating, and then she wakes up back in their bunk, far from the bank with Catra clinging to her. The job went well, but Catra still looks upset. Adora

stayed there as long as she could to ensure that they got away before she pulled the trigger. She was scared to do it. If she knew without a shadow of a doubt that she would always be fine, she wouldn't be scared, but part of her still doesn't believe it despite how she has regenerated three times now.

"Your fear is holding you back, Adora," Shadow Weaver greets her when she calls Adora into her office. Adora can't help but glance at the door in the back wall that leads to Shadow Weaver's sanctum where all her research is hidden away. It is, she can't deny it, but it feels weird to think about. She has never been afraid to die – it's more the fear of dying *needlessly* that's holding her back.

"It just seems so...impossible. I spent my entire life knowing magic isn't real," Adora tells her, looking down at her lap and fidgeting with her own hands. Shadow Weaver doesn't reply, the silence heavy with disappointment. Adora glances up, nervous and knowing that she needs to do better. "If you would just explain more, I think I would be more comfortable," she tries. She doesn't know that is true, but she hopes it is.

Shadow Weaver has said that they will have to learn through experimentation, but she clearly knows more than she has said. It's frustrating knowing that she isn't human and Shadow Weaver has answers but won't give them. Shadow Weaver sighs – scoffs, really. She narrows her eyes at Adora before standing abruptly from her desk. She turns and walks to the door into her bedroom, pausing as she waits for Adora to follow. Adora scrambles to stand, hurrying after her as Shadow Weaver unlocks the door.

"Years ago, the daughter of two members of the Horde died on a collections mission," Shadow Weaver says, startling Adora. Adora blinks at her, confused, as Shadow Weaver crosses the room to reach into one of her filing cabinets. She pulls out a thick folder, the corners tattered and no label on its cover. Shadow Weaver lays it open on the table and beckons Adora closer. Adora approaches, eyeing the pages curiously.

It's a dossier on a job – collect protection fees that have been withheld. Adora scans the report, getting the gist that the mark shot at the Horde team upon their arrival. Adora frowns down at the page as it mentions the death of the captain – someone named Scorpia – as well as another woman on the team. Adora definitely met Octavia, but now that she thinks about it, she hasn't seen her in probably five years.

"Her body went missing after the police arrived on-scene, the same way yours did. It was known that she died, but I knew the truth. It took weeks of encouragement for her mothers to admit that Scorpia reappeared in their home after her death. They considered it a miracle and smuggled her from the city so she could leave the life of crime behind," Shadow W eaver explains. Adora's head snaps up, looking Shadow Weaver in the eye. She knows what *encouragement* means.

Worse still, Adora knows that no one leaves the Horde alive. She has grappled with it over the years. The Horde hurts people, but she knows that they are a lesser evil in a city with few options. They have to do it to maintain order, and they're good to the people they protect, unlike some of the other gangs or even the police. When traitors are taken out, it's a necessary evil. If they spilled any secrets, it would endanger every other member of the Horde, including the street kids with nowhere else to go.

Scorpia's mothers took advantage of Scorpia being announced dead to sneak her out when the Horde wouldn't be looking for her. Adora feels oddly *jealous* . This explains a lot – the tight leash that Shadow has always kept them on, how she knew enough about immortals to be so certain that Adora was one, and why she has been so odd with Adora ever since her ability was revealed. She doesn't want a repeat of before.

"What happened to her?" Adora asks, her voice quiet. Shadow Weaver's expression doesn't so much as twitch as she reaches out to close the folder with a snap, whisking it away. She turns back to the filing cabinet, retrieving another folder. This one Adora knows the

contents of on sight. She blinks at it in shock as Shadow Weaver sets it on the table and then places her hands down on either side of it, staring her down.

"She is now a member of the Alliance. And given the way they have been operating, they *all* appear to be immortal. History indicates that immortals would often find each other and live in pairs or triads. Now, seemingly seven of them have found each other, and they're using their abilities to wreak havoc," Shadow W eaver tells her, tense anger in her limbs. Her tone is bordering on threatening. Adora swallows, blinking down at the closed folder.

She has never gotten to read it before, but she has seen it on Shadow Weaver's desk many times over the last few weeks. With it this close and facing her, she can read the tabs on the side. The top one is labeled *Scorpia*. Adora reaches down to flip the folder open, greeted with two side-by-side photos of Scorpia. One was clearly taken within the Horde base and the next is from the news. She may be wearing a mask in the second photo, but her silhouette is identical.

Adora's heart is pounding from her storming emotions. She usually shoves them down and pretends they aren't there so she can focus on her duties, but she can't do that when so much is being thrown in her face. Scorpia got out – she was *free*. Adora can't imagine returning to this den of cruelty. The entire city is like the Horde – there isn't anywhere safe to go. There's another crime syndicate on every corner. Shadow Weaver seems to sense at least some of the conflict within her.

"Being killed changes people, Adora. All she cares about is taking out the Horde, no matter who will be hurt in the process. You're stronger than she ever was. You can't give in to viewing mortals as expendable. The Alliance needs to be stopped before more people die in the crossfire," Shadow W eaver tells her. Adora's hand trembles slightly and she clenches it in a fist.

Scorpia died and came back before her. Many people have. If the entire Alliance can use their powers without fear, they will be able to do things that Adora can't while she is holding herself back. The longer they operate, the more orphans end up on the streets like her and Catra once were. Adora flexes her arms as she thinks it over, trying to talk herself out of her fear. If she can do this, she will help people. Not only that, but she will prove herself to Shadow Weaver.

She has always been determined to do everything that she can to make their life here the best that it can be. She knows that Catra thinks that she is oblivious, but she does know what their situation is – she just also knows they never had a chance at escaping it by the time that it was clear that they should, so she has done her best not to dwell on it. If Shadow Weaver is going to use her like this, then Adora will let her, but she has a condition.

She isn't going to keep making sacrifice after sacrifice just for Shadow Weaver to move the goalposts on her again. Every time she did something, it was with the implied promise that it would better their situation. No more implications. No more *just one more job*. Adora has told herself that again and again and it never amounted to anything. If this isn't the moment to take a stand, there never will be one. She looks up, making eye contact with Shadow Weaver, her expression set with determination.

"Whatever you want me to do, however you want me to use my abilities, I'll do it. But let me have Catra. Stop holding us back," Adora challenges. She's not an idiot. Shadow Weaver knows about how she feels. She has made that clear with how she has tried to warn Adora off from growing attached to Catra. Despite the rule against relationships often being broken by others, her protégés were held to a higher standard. To Adora's surprise, Shadow Weaver doesn't grow angry.

Shadow Weaver pushes off the table, drawing herself up to her full height and folding her hands together in front of her, looking down at Adora with narrowed eyes. It almost looks like she is smiling beneath her mask, but that can't be right - Shadow Weaver never smiles.

There is a twinkle of satisfaction in her gaze that throws Adora off as Shadow Weaver looks her over, actually thinking about it. Adora's breath feels a bit short, but she doesn't break eye contact as Shadow Weaver looks down at her.

"Your next job will require necessary separation in order to be successful, but I will allow you to pursue a relationship as long as you can behave in front of others," Shadow Weaver tells her. Adora stares at her. A cold feeling of shock spreads through Adora's body as her heart *pounds*. It's another set of goalposts, but this- this is an explicit promise. Shadow Weaver has never gone so far as to acknowledge their entanglement this way before.

"What kind of job?" she asks, a bit breathless.

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Adora comes out of her meeting with Shadow Weaver seeming to tremble with some mixture of excitement and nerves. Catra's heart immediately jumps into her throat, but she is shocked when Adora grabs her hand and pulls her towards the path up to their platform. Holding hands in front of cameras – holding hands as they *pass others in the hallways* – is bold. Catra's chest pounds as she wordlessly follows.

"What happened?" she demands as soon as they reach the top, her tail lashing. Adora just took a big fucking risk, and they both know which one of them she was endangering if Shadow Weaver finds out. For all they know, she is checking the cameras right now and planning Catra's punishment. To her surprise, Adora turns and takes both her hands in her own, a tremulous smile on her face. Her nerves are obvious, but so is her excitement.

"Shadow W eaver has a job for me. A big one. But the reward is worth it,"Adora tells her . Catra swallows, unable to tear her eyes away from the excited fire in Adora's eyes. Her gaze is hypnotic as she steps closer, her eyes falling hooded until she leans forward and kisses Catra. Catra feels like she is lagging several steps behind as her own eyes fall closed, a shaky breath escaping against Adora's lips.

Adora kisses her with all the energy humming through her body. Catra isn't used to this passion from her unless one of them is pinned against the shower wall and naked. She feels swept up, doing her best to meet Adora in kind before she remembers *big job* and *Shadow W eaver* and, oh right, Catra is going to get her fucking ass kicked tonight when Shadow Weaver finds out about Adora holding her hand in front of others.

"Adora-"she starts, pulling back to demand to know what' s going on, but she draws to a halt when she sees the way Adora is looking at her, her eyes blazing with passion and her cheeks flushed. Adora' s arms have moved to wrap around her, Catra realizes. She did it at some point during the kiss. Catra feels a bit shell-shocked. Adora seems to realize that she is being a *lot* right now, her expression turning a bit sheepish as she releases Catra and takes a half-step back, rubbing at the base of her neck.

"Y ou won't get in trouble. Shadow Weaver finally gave us permission to, you know, just *be*. As long as I took the job and we still kept it quiet around others,"Adora tells her . Catra stares at her, shock flushing through her body as Adora's smile turns a bit tremulous. That- that *can't* be. It's a trap to get them to admit that they've been breaking the rule, and now Shadow Weaver will punish them for-

"Hey , look at me,"Adora cuts in, her words soft. Catra hisses, wanting to pull away, but Adora's hand doesn't even pause as she reaches up to stroke her cheek, trying to assure Catra before she has a full-scale panic attack. Catra screws her eyes shut, leaning into the touch. "It' s a big thing that she wants of me, okay? It' s worth giving us this much for it. But I'll be fine. It's really happening,"Adora

assures her, her voice low. Catra's heart hammers as she nods into Adora's touch.

If Shadow Weaver is letting them be together, then this job must be so dangerous that she has to promise a big reward. Catra swallows, her hands trembling as she raises them to wrap around herself. She has never wanted anything more in her life than to be held by Adora, but she is terrified of what Adora signed away to make it happen. Catra knows Adora wouldn't have asked for this explicitly, so it must have been something huge if Shadow Weaver was willing to put affection on the table for it.

"What's the job?" she asks, her voice a bit tremulous. Adora's arms squeeze around her. Catra forces herself to drop her arms to hug Adora back instead of herself. She pulls back just enough to meet Adora's eyes, finding her expression a bit nervous. Adora bites her lip, clearly thinking about how she is going to answer that question.

"The Alliance? The new group that has been causing shit with just *seven people*? Shadow Weaver knows that one of their members is immortal. She thinks they all are. She wants me to try to join them and get insider intel," Adora tells her, her tone cautious. Catra startles, taking a half step back to stare at Adora. There are obvious flaws with this plan – Adora is a shit actress most of the time, even if she can usually lie well under pressure – but Catra isn't thinking about any of them.

For the last few months, ever since Adora was made captain, it feels like the gap between them has grown larger. It was always there when they were somehow friends who fucked secretly, but even their friendship has had strain on it. Adora has been working herself to the bone trying to prove that Shadow Weaver made the right call in promoting her. She hasn't been listening to Catra, doing anything that Shadow Weaver so much as hints that she should.

Catra has had the growing fear that she was losing Adora, even outside of the suicide missions Shadow Weaver was sending her on. She still can't quite believe Shadow Weaver is finally letting them be

together, but it seems that the price for her getting Adora *is* to lose her. Adora said they could be together, but Catra doesn't see how when Adora is supposed to be undercover. Anxiety pricks at her skin, the worry of *what if she doesn't want me after*.

"How long will you be gone?" she asks in a whisper. She knows that no matter what happens with this job, Adora should be fine eventually, but it's the fear of distance that is gripping her right now. Adora's expression is gentle as she takes a half-step forward, wrapping Catra in her arms again almost cautiously, like she expects Catra to pull away. Clearly she anticipated how conflicted Catra would be about this. She still leaves enough distance between them for them to make eye contact.

"I don't know how long it will be, but you'll be my contact while I'm undercover. Shadow Weaver is going to have us move out to separate apartments during it, but we can have the same place after. We can be together," Adora tells her, her eyes burning with excitement. Catra's heart thuds heavily in her chest. She doesn't trust a word out of Shadow Weaver's mouth, but the woman relies on subtle manipulation. She doesn't usually renege on explicit oaths - it would undermine their effectiveness.

"Promise?" she breathes. She doesn't believe it. It's so out of character for Shadow Weaver to give them anything, but especially to give Catra *freedom*. She needs to hear Adora swear it. She trusts Adora. Adora smiles, the expression seeming to come easy to her despite how this shouldn't be a promise that she gives lightly.

"I promise," she returns. Catra blows out a breath, nodding slowly. She has to believe in one thing in the world, so she believes in Adora. If Adora promises, then it will be okay.

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Shadow Weaver is working on finding Adora an opening to approach the Alliance. In the meantime, Adora and Catra get their apartments. It's weird to finally move out. Most Horde members don't live in the headquarters, but the street kids that they pick up do so they have a place to stay. Shadow Weaver and Hordak are the only other members of the Horde who have permanent lodgings in the base. Usually the kids move out once they're older, but Shadow Weaver wanted Adora and Catra to stay so they could learn the Horde's inner workings.

Adora can't help but suspect now that it was actually so she would regenerate back in the safety of the base once she started dying. According to Shadow Weaver, immortals always regenerate in the safety of their home. She has admitted to knowing more that she is withholding, but only because Adora is a bad liar and her lack of knowledge is going to be part of her cover story. It's frustrating, but Adora does need to minimize her lies if she is going to pull this off.

Shadow Weaver has at least told her that she should start regenerating in the apartment once she has settled in, but that they will keep her bunk clear until she has done it at least once. She comforts herself with the fact that she and Catra are finally getting a taste at freedom. Adora has imagined her and Catra getting their own place many times over the years. She always imagined them doing it together, but they can both move into Catra's apartment once this is all over.

They go out shopping together. It's something that they have done many times before, but usually for clothes or supplies. They have plenty of money from their heists, so buying themselves cars isn't a big deal, but it still isn't something that Adora has ever been capable of before, and not just because Shadow Weaver wouldn't approve. Buying a car kind of requires having an identity – something Adora hasn't had until now.

Well, she does, but she doesn't remember it and she's probably been legally dead for over a decade. Adora remembers her birthday and the vague impression of a father in her life, but that's about it

before she ended up on the streets. Catra was an orphan who actually remembered her and her parent's names – it was easy for her to get her identity established once she turned eighteen and wouldn't be brought back into the system.

Shadow Weaver helped her do it just so she wouldn't have any problems if she got stopped. The ID in Adora's wallet might as well be her real one for all the doors it suddenly opens for her. It's for her cover, but Shadow Weaver has gone to some work to establish *Adora Gay* as an identity that will hold up under scrutiny, so she hopes that she gets to keep it after this. Her birthday is right and everything, so she could even buy alcohol with it now that she's twenty-one.

Shadow Weaver gets her an identity, and lets her buy a car, and lets Catra get a motorcycle – well, okay, she told them both to get cars and Catra definitively did not do that, but it only made Shadow Weaver's eye twitch a *little* and that could have just been the fact that they were holding hands when they came back – while she sets up Adora's cover. They have the cars for two days before Shadow Weaver allows them to actually move out.

She needed to select a location for Adora's apartment that was outside of Horde territory but still safe enough for her to live. Catra gets to choose her own, the only limit that she stays inside the Horde's territory. Neither of them has much in the way of personal belongings despite the amount of cash they have amassed from their various jobs over the years – there wasn't much room for things in the bunkroom or time for frivolous shopping – so they get to not only move out at the same time, but to go shopping to decorate their places together.

Adora is ridiculously excited about holding Catra's hand as they browse the aisles. When they're done, they go back to *Adora's apartment*, a phrase that still makes her giddy, with boxes stuffed in her trunk and their hands intertwined on the stick shift. Adora got a classic car, because she has always had a soft spot for them and part of their training was driving pretty much any vehicle that they

could conceivably come across for a job. Adora is pretty sure she could get her forklift license if she wanted to try.

"Shadow Weaver really picked a place that looks like shit," Catra observes as they carry things into the apartment. Adora laughs, knocking their shoulders together and then stretching up to kiss the top of Catra's head. Catra ducks away from the affection, but she is giggling and blushing as she does so. Neither of them is used to being allowed to just *interact* like this. Even over the last few days, as they have been cautiously getting used to the idea and trying things, they have had to be careful of being seen by others.

There are no others in Adora's apartment. She puts down her boxes, approaching Catra and pausing just long enough for Catra to put down her own load before she sweeps her up and kisses her with a burning passion. Catra meets her in kind, kissing her with fiery passion. They made out in the backseat of Adora's car as soon as they bought it, and then again when they left the base in it today, but they have still been living in the bunkroom and unable to embrace like this.

When Adora was dying, all she could think about was how she loved Catra but never got to say it or even *show* it. Even afterwards, she couldn't do it. It was too dangerous within the walls of the Horde headquarters. This is Adora's apartment. It's bugged, but there aren't cameras. Adora isn't comfortable saying the words when she knows Shadow Weaver could be listening, and she knows Catra wouldn't be comfortable with her doing it either, but she can show Catra.

She can kiss her like she wants to know nothing in this world but the shape of her mouth. She can run her hands along her body and squeeze, heat flaring between her legs at how it causes a slight shiver in Catra's muscles. If it weren't for how the bedsprings would give them away – they have both learned to be near-silent with their moans – she would take Catra to bed right now, but that is an activity that's going to have to be reserved for once Catra moves into her own apartment.

Adora is moving into hers effective immediately to make it look lived in. Catra has selected one, but she doesn't move in for two more days. In the meantime, Shadow Weaver is allowing Catra to stay at Adora's, they just both have to be cognizant of the listening devices that Shadow Weaver has planted in preparation for Alliance members potentially coming over once Adora has gone undercover.

They still get to crawl into bed together, lying side-by-side in each other's arms. They have always slept fully-clothed, others mere feet away, but now Adora gets to experience Catra stretched out naked beside her. Neither of them would dare do anything, but Adora finally gets to experience the softness of Catra's fur against her when it is dry, humming softly as she wraps around Catra that night. Catra's breath hitches as she nuzzles underneath Adora' s chin.

"I can't believe we get to have this," she breathes, sounding awestruck. Adora's heart leaps into her throat. Catra sounds so happy that she can't believe it's *real*, and it's because of Adora. She leans forward, closing the gap to kiss Catra softly. She still doesn't know how the hell she is going to pull off this whole double-agent thing, but she does know that she has the best motivation that she could ask for. It will all be worth it if she gets to have this.

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Catra picks out a simple studio apartment that, unlike Adora's place, *doesn't* have the clear outline of a patched-over doorway to the next apartment in the plaster of the living room wall. It's weird how blissful her two days of living in Adora's apartment feel, almost no obligations and no eyes on them, even if they both have to be careful of what they say. They know some rudimentary sign language for communicating – both with Rogelio, and during jobs where they have to be quiet – but they don't know how to say anything they would want to say in secret, really.

Catra does manage to shut down an argument before it begins with it, though. Adora tries to argue that Shadow Weaver wouldn't be listening yet since she hasn't even made contact with the Alliance, to which Catra signs back that the fact that Adora didn't even voice it is enough to prove she knows it's a possibility. Adora got flustered and gave up. Catra knew she was looking forward to when Catra moved into her own place, but that is tainted too.

There shouldn't be bugs in her place, but Catra has no way to sweep for them, and as Adora helps her carry things from the back of her muscle car to the building, Catra notices a man loitering across the street. He's smoking a blunt, but Catra recognizes him. It takes her nearly the entire elevator ride up to her place to realize that he's an associate of the Horde. He isn't a member technically, and Catra would bet that Shadow Weaver was relying on him being just another human to her, but she has lived at the base all her life and has met just about everybody who has ever been associated with them.

"There's an associate watching us outside," Catra mutters to Adora when they're in the elevator. Adora's eyes storm with anger as she glares at the doors opposite from her. She is holding the box containing Catra's new end table. Her arms flex as her grip on it tightens with annoyance.

"She promised we could have a relationship. Not after – *now*," Adora says, but she doesn't sound like she is trying to convince Catra, just annoyed at the intrusion. Catra grunts. Yeah, but Shadow Weaver fucking *lies*. Everything she does is based on lies and manipulation. When they reach her apartment, she checks the window to find him looking away and wordlessly points him out to Adora. Adora immediately flips off the side of the man's head and then retreats to the kitchen to sulk.

"I'll talk to her when we debrief," Adora mutters, glaring down at the kitchen table they moved in earlier. Catra raises a brow at her. Adora is silent for several moments before she sighs and sends Catra an apologetic expression. "Okay , no, I won't. It's still better than what we

had before, right?" she asks. She sounds a bit pleading. She knows that Catra would prefer she bust down Shadow Weaver's door and demand privacy, but they both know she won't do it.

Catra is still shocked that they are here at all. She hates that everything has to be a fucking compromise in their life, but at least she can finally take Adora's hand when they are done moving things and lead her into the bedroom. The curtains are drawn and Catra doubts that Shadow Weaver would have taken the risk of placing someone Catra might recognize outside to watch them if she had put bugs in Catra's apartment.

"You'll have to go home tonight. Shadow Weaver will know if you stay over," Catra cautions even as she pushes Adora down into the bed and climbs over her. Adora pulls a face that manages to elicit a chuckle from Catra. She reaches for Adora's waistband despite her wrinkled-up expression.

"Can we absolutely not mention her within six feet of sex?" Adora requests, her tone joking. She happily lifts her hips for Catra to slide her pants and underwear down in one go. It occurs to Catra as she discards the clothing that she doesn't have to be *efficient*. Yes, Adora should go back to her own apartment tonight to make sure Shadow Weaver doesn't get angry, but they can take as long as they want to do this. No one is going to walk in on them.

Catra blinks down at Adora spread out beneath her, one of her legs propped up and her shirt still on, the corner of the hem a bit frayed from where Catra's claws caught on it a year ago. She is splayed out, happily awaiting Catra's touch, clearly growing confused with every second that Catra just stares at her, the realization sinking in that she can take her time and just have Adora like she has always wanted to. This may be her last chance to, in fact.

They have a debrief with Shadow Weaver tomorrow regarding Adora's mission. Catra might be her contact, but they aren't going to be able to freely see each other like this once the job starts. Catra is terrified of the distance it will force between them. They have never

been apart long enough to sleep in separate beds even. When one of them went to the med bay, the other accompanied them. Catra ducks down, kissing Adora firmly as her hand finally reaches for her hem, pushing it up slowly. She wants to get her naked, but then she is going to take her time.

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Adora loses track on the fourth time she comes – or maybe she only almost comes. She doesn't really know the difference anymore. She was, if she's honest, nervous about their first time in a bed. They've done this in the shower countless times, usually messy and quick, with Catra always keeping an ear out for someone approaching and both of them quiet as the grave. They've even ducked into a dark corner or two, but Adora didn't know how being in a bed – doing this the way people *normally* do – would change their dynamic.

Apparently it makes Catra go a bit feral, but Adora can't really blame her considering she feels similarly. Catra has never bitten her before, but now she can't seem to keep her mouth off Adora, leaving faint traces on her body where her clothes will hide them. She works her mouth over Adora's chest, something that makes her *scream*, apparently, but this is the Fright Zone, and no one in their right minds would call the cops to make a noise complaint. The cops wouldn't answer a call coming from this block anyway.

Adora didn't anticipate that finally being able to make noise would somehow heighten the whole experience, but she kind of loses herself beneath Catra's touch. Eventually the fever that took Catra seems to subside – which is good, because Adora feels amazing but also a bit overworked - and they're left to slow grind against each other, Catra's leg thrown over her own so they can press their bodies together. Grinding like this isn't enough for her to come, but Adora

doesn't need to come again and the point of a touch like this is *connection*.

They've never been in the position to just luxuriating in rolling their bodies together, feeling the other wet and responsive beneath them. It's messy and not enough, but at the same time, it makes emotions well up in Adora's chest until she is wrapping her arms around Catra's back and flipping them so she can lay Catra out beneath her. Despite telegraphing the move for her, Catra flushes and blinks up at Adora in surprise. Adora smiles hopefully at her, skating one hand along Catra's body and luxuriating in the softness beneath her touch.

"It's your turn," she explains, but it comes out with a bit of a question to it. *Can I touch you?* is the implicit question, one that they have both gotten used to not voicing. If someone overheard them discussing turns, that could be about anything. Saying anything too explicit or obvious would be a dead giveaway. Adora knows that her screaming orgasm kind of alerted all their neighbors to what they were doing, but old habits die hard.

Catra's ears twitch for a moment before she smiles softly, seeming a bit *nervous*, and relaxes back into the sheets, nodding her silent permission. Adora gladly presses forward, kissing Catra slow and languidly. Foreplay started an hour ago and Catra certainly doesn't need more, but Adora lets herself just lose herself the slide of their lips and shape of Catra beneath her hands. This is as much for her as it is for Catra, refamiliarizing herself with someone she knows so well, though not in this context, dry and relaxed beneath her.

It's more than the fact that Catra is laying down this time. It's also that she isn't listening for intruders – it's also that she worked herself up taking care of Adora and seems to have burned off energy. She stretches almost lazily in the bed beneath Adora when she massages Catra's thigh, enjoying the fullness of it in her hands. Catra gives a quiet, rolling trill of satisfaction when Adora tugs her lower lip between her teeth, careful not to be too harsh.

Catra has never liked harshness. They've had intense sex before, one of them pressed up against the wall and struggling to stay upright while the other fucked them with their fingers, but Adora would never use any more pressure with Catra than necessary to hold her up or get her off. Catra wouldn't want her to. Catra doesn't scream the way Adora did when she touches her, but Adora touches her soft and slow, like how they were grinding together before. She kisses her, drinking in every gentle pant Catra gives.

"Ah, *Adora*," Catra breathes into the next kiss, a rough and *thrilling* moan that Adora didn't know was missing from her life, but now she can't imagine going on without. Adora kisses her greedily, forcing herself to channel her desire for Catra into the kiss instead of the touch. She wants to keep things light and gentle, just how Catra likes. Catra *whimpers*, shifting and twitching beneath Adora, seeming eager for any touch she can get.

Catra doesn't scream – in fact, her noises are so quiet Adora can't help but wonder if she's been making them the whole time, hidden by the sound of the shower spray – but she still *loses herself*. As Adora works her over, her desperation builds until she is twitching, writhing, even kicking her legs a little and panting. She can't keep up with the kiss, so Adora ducks to scatter kisses along the side of her face, and that only seems to drive Catra further into desperation until she finally breaks.

Her moan is loud, scratchy, and cracks in the middle. It rises, an *uh* at the beginning that warps to follow almost the exact cadence of Adora's name, even if no words can be found within it. Catra's tail goes still and puffs out, the fur along her shoulders raising too. Adora has never seen her do that before. It could be that water slicking down her coat prevents it, but it could also be from just how lost she seems after being worked up for so long.

Catra goes utterly limp in the sheets, purring like her motorcycle engine. Adora swallows, staring down at Catra with her mouth dry. She has never wanted to say she loves her more, but now, when Adora is going to slip out of her bed and possibly her life for months,

isn’t the time. She satisfies herself with cradling Catra close against her chest as she soaks in the endorphins.

Adora is immortal now. There will be time.

Chapter End Notes

Just a sidenote for those who don’t follow my tumblr , this AU was inspired by video game respawn mechanics. I haven’t watched a movie in five years (or even a trailer thanks to adblock + lack of interest) and I hadn’t really heard of the Old Guard before y’all started commenting about it. I saw one post about fandom issues involving it (which then led me to believe it was a historical romance novel, for some reason) so I had heard the name but I had no idea it had immortals in it. Anyway, I don’t mind comparisons, I’ve just had multiple people bring it up now and it’s odd when I’ve never even heard of what you’re comparing 😅

First Contact

Chapter Notes

> This is the only time I'm going to repeat the CW from the first chapter. That blanket CW applies to the entire fic, but this chapter in particular has a vague allusion to real suicide/suicidal thoughts outside of the immortality cycle.

"I don't like it," Catra says, her arms crossed as she stares out the side window of Adora's car. There's a long moment of silence before Adora sighs, her hands dropping from the steering wheel as she leans back in her seat. They're parked in Catra's apartment parking lot, but it just started raining and Catra can't leave the car without saying how much she hates this plan anyway. The rain gives her an excuse to stay put in case there's still someone watching her apartment block.

She looks out the window, watching the rain hit the glass and refract the beams of the streetlights, a dance of sparkling light in the middle of the night that doesn't distract her from how bad the next few weeks are going to be. Shadow Weaver didn't give them a timeline on this job. She doesn't know how long it will take and she hates admitting that she isn't omniscient. Still, it's clear that it will take weeks at an absolute minimum.

Shadow Weaver has built Adora a cover story that is largely true and will be easy to stick to, Catra can admit that much, but it still enforces a level of distance between them that they've never had before. They'll see each other once a week. They're used to being together for nearly every hour of the day. The part she hates the most is how Shadow Weaver is sending Adora into a fucking den of immortals while understanding nothing about how they work. Shadow Weaver knows it all, but she claims Adora has to be clueless for this cover to be plausible.

Catra would prefer that Adora learn to lie over being introduced to an opponent that she knows nothing about - especially because that introduction involves admitting her lack of knowledge. Shadow Weaver can't get her story straight either. One second she will say that the Alliance doesn't care about mortals and in the next she will emphasize that it doesn't matter what their motivations are, they're hurting people and they need to be dealt with. Catra can read between the fucking lines.

"She's lying. There's more to them and she knows it," Catra adds on, because Adora is silent. Catra has her knees tucked up against her chest and her arms wrapped around them as she hugs herself tight. Shadow Weaver is sending Adora into a deathtrap. Sure, she'll regenerate – but what about the pain in between? What about the fact that the Alliance will know that and might try to keep her alive?

"This is the way to make it work, Catra. I don't like it, but she's right," Adora replies. Catra's tail lashes against the seat beside her.

"We both know that you're a better liar than she's giving you credit for," Catra points out. Shadow Weaver could tell Adora more than she is. Adora lies well with the right motivation and enough pressure on her. In the seat beside her, Adora undoes her seatbelt and shifts, reaching over to pet Catra's arm soothingly. Catra doesn't look at her, but she can't stop herself from leaning into the touch. This is the last time that Adora will touch her until their first check-in next Friday.

"Yes, but I'm not telling her that. It's better that she thinks we've been holding back this whole time. Admitting that I've lied to her is probably more dangerous than whatever she has me walking into," Adora points out, her tone a bit cajoling. Catra growls to herself, but Adora is right. Adora has blatantly and gladly lied to Shadow Weaver's face before with their mentor none-the-wiser. This job will be dangerous, but having Shadow Weaver find out about the times they snuck around under her nose would be worse.

She reluctantly unfurls, leaning into Adora's touch until Adora is awkwardly leaning over the center console to hug her. The rain is still

drumming against the windows, but Catra wouldn't be inclined to let go even if it weren't there. Tomorrow, Adora makes contact with the Alliance. This is the last embrace she's going to get for a while. She clings to Adora, desperately hoping that whatever Shadow Weaver is hiding isn't that dangerous.

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It isn't hard to find Scorpia, at least not once Shadow Weaver has already done it for her. Letting Adora glance over a few isolated pages of reports gives Adora all the information she needs to show up on a block where she has been chasing off the Horde's enforcers from expanding their territory recently. Adora hangs around on the corner, waiting for a few hours in the heat. She isn't really running surveillance, just waiting. She spends an hour texting Catra on her new phone about nothing.

They've never really texted before. They had a phone, but both of them shared it and it was mainly for communicating with other members of the Horde. Catra has that phone now and Shadow Weaver gave Adora a new one for the job. She doesn't know if it is bugged, but probably. Neither she nor Catra mention what she's doing – Catra isn't supposed to know – and instead Catra explains the plot of a made-for-TV horror movie to her that she's watching on her new television set.

Adora is in the middle of smiling down at her phone and typing out a reply to Catra's criticism about the terrible realism when she is interrupted by a tap on her shoulder. Adora looks up, blinking in surprise at Scorpia. Scorpia looks displeased, which is kind of an odd expression on her, but her mouth is set in a thin line as she looks Adora up and down. Adora was expecting this – inviting it, really – but she is still surprised that Scorpia managed to sneak up on her.

"This isn't your side of town," Scorpia points out. Adora, after taking a moment to recover, shakes her head and tucks her phone into her pocket. They've met before. Adora didn't remember it even after Shadow Weaver told her, but it would be smart for Scorpia to keep track of the faces of Horde members. Shadow Weaver only managed to definitively verify that she was in town three weeks ago when she started protecting this block and there's still no proof that she is the scorpioni in the Alliance.

"I don't really have a *side of town* right now. I came looking for you," she admits. Scorpia looks skeptical at best, raising an eyebrow and casting a glance around the block like she expects an ambush in the shadows.

"Talk," Scorpia instructs, folding her arms and doing her best to look down at Adora intimidatingly. It probably *should* work on her, but for some reason Adora isn't fazed. She glances around to ensure that there's nobody else loitering within earshot, but the closest person is waiting at the other end of the block for the light to change so they can cross. Anyone smart doesn't hang around in disputed territory.

"Shadow Weaver says you're like me," Adora tells her, raising her chin a little, both in challenge and to look Scorpia in the eye when she's drawn up to her full height. Scorpia blinks at her, her expression blank for a moment before her brow furrows.

"A lesbian?" she asks, sounding honestly bewildered. Adora immediately flushes, instinctively ducking her head.

"We haven't even met, how did you know that?" she hisses, a demand as she catches herself glancing around again. Scorpia raises an eyebrow at her, still visibly confused.

"Stories from Octavia. I know who you are," Scorpia replies. Adora winces, looking away as she sheepishly rubs at the base of her neck and nods. Yeah, that makes sense, actually. She doesn't like the idea of Octavia knowing about her and Catra back then, but if she

ever told Shadow Weaver, clearly she didn't put too much credence into her words. Everybody knew they were thick as thieves, at least.

"Okay , so then you know that Shadow Weaver has always been a freak about me, and now I'm two gunshots and a stab to the gut deep but she still won't fucking explain anything," Adora returns. She doesn't mean for it to come out as a frustrated hiss, but that's the price for her cover story being *real*. Her vague gesture is just a bit violent from her annoyance, but she seriously needs the Alliance to accept her if only so she will finally know what's going on with her.

That gives Scorpia pause, her arms unfolding and dropping to her sides in surprise as she blinks and then narrows her eyes at Adora, scrutinizing her . Adora doesn't know if immortality is something you can spot by taking a hard look at someone, but she straightens up and gestures her hands pointedly at her neck, and then at her temple. There are no marks from her deaths, but somehow she thinks Scorpia will get it.

"I don't know what' s going on, but she told me she dealt with somebody like me before. You're my only lead," Adora tells her . Scorpia pauses, scrutinizing her for a long moment.

"Y ou realize Shadow W eaver will kill you for talking to me, right?" Scorpia responds. Her tone almost sounds like she's testing her. Adora blinks at her for a moment.

"She already did," Adora returns. A dark look hardens in Scorpia' s eyes as she nods. Before Adora can react, a sharp sting in her thigh causes her to gasp, numbness spreading through her entire body. She is so used to being around Catra, she didn't even think twice about Scorpia's tail sweeping to the side. Blackness surrounds her in moments.

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Adora stops texting her back. Catra sends a few more texts about the movie before she realizes something is wrong. She finds herself gripping her phone with fear, staring down at it as she checks the timestamps. Eleven minutes since Adora last responded. In all likelihood, her mark finally showed up and she dropped the conversation to concentrate, but Catra's heart is thudding too loudly in her chest.

She isn't used to this. She and Adora always had an unspoken policy against abandoning the other in the middle of something. If they got interrupted kissing, they would switch to joking around as friends instead, silent reassurances that they were still there for each other and cared. Catra isn't used to Adora just going dead silent on her.

She sends Adora some question marks to indicate that she has noticed the silence, but the casualness of the texts doesn't reflect the storm in her heart. She tries to turn her attention to the truly terrible movie she found while flicking through the channels, but all she can think about is what Adora could be doing right now.

She doesn't get a text back for the entire runtime of the movie.

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"She's with the Horde," a woman hisses.

"Yeah, but so was I!" Scorpia shoots back. They have been arguing since Adora started groggily waking, but those are the first words she has managed to understand. She is tied up, which is a terrible sign for her ability to reach for her gun, but she is sure that they would have already taken it away. She keeps her eyes closed,

breathing slowly as she listens for any information on what happened after Scorpia stung her.

"Signs indicate that she' s waking," another woman' s voice adds, this one sounding far less concerned. Well, shit. The other voices in the room fall silent. Not for the first time, Adora wishes for Catra's senses. Reluctantly, Adora opens her eyes. She is greeted by blackness. Okay, not what she was expecting. She turns her head and feels the cloth brushing against her nose for the first time. They put a sack over her head.

It isn't secured – she doesn't feel anything on her neck – so she tries to jerk her head to the side to throw it off. She dislodges it a bit, light flooding in from under her chin, but immediately a hand yanks it down again. Adora makes an indignant noise, trying to shake her head again before someone grabs the cloth and yanks it down harshly, holding it in place and making a point.

"That stays on, and we ask the questions," the first female voice speaks up again, warning her. She sounds a bit vehement – and also *young*. Adora frowns beneath the sack, but she holds still. This has to be the Alliance, or at least people Scorpia trusts, so she's getting close. Getting kidnapped wasn't part of the plan, but to be honest, there wasn't much of a plan beyond *make contact with Scorpia and worm your way in* .

"Seriously , she might shoot you just to test that you're telling the truth," Scorpia warns, her voice hovering above Adora' s head. She's the one holding down the sack cloth then, but to Adora's surprise, she sounds genuinely concerned for her. A gunshot wouldn't be that bad. Her first one was, but that's just because of its location and how slow it was. Her second shot was definitely her best death so far, and she would at least prove herself to them.

"Great, so she'll do the same thing as Shadow W eaver. Have at it, then," Adora responds. There' s an indignant squawk across the room even as Adora tilts her head up, offering her forehead for the

gun. She feels a bit stiff still from the paralyzing venom in Scorpia's stinger.

"I am nothing like her or anyone else from the Horde. I don't kill people," the voice returns, sounding angered. Adora feels herself recoil just a little, surprised and confused.

"The Horde doesn't kill people. Ask Scorpia," Adora returns. There's a slight murmur in the room around her – shit, there are more people than she thought – and then shoes come stomping towards her, something plasticky crinkling beneath them. Adora reels when her hood is suddenly pulled off. She immediately flinches at the light, but after a few moments of blinking and squinting, things come into focus.

She is in a plain room, no decoration or furniture inside it, just her and what seems to be at least five people. The door in the wall looks like a standard bedroom door. There's a window with a few sheets thrown over the curtain rod to block out all view to the outside and a rather concerning paint tarp immediately beneath Adora, but aside from that, it just looks like a room. It even has carpet. Clearly this is an impromptu interrogation space.

She can see four people in front of her, all dressed like members of the Alliance, although Scorpia is standing over her and she can see the outline of other people behind them in her periphery. Everyone is wearing masks, but Adora is facing a woman with a gun in her hand, two more hanging back with a man against the opposite wall. She blinks up in surprise at the short girl directly in front of her.

"Why don't *you* ask Scorpia if the Horde kills people?" she returns. Adora doesn't know why those words send a chill through her. She knows what must have happened to Scorpia's mothers, but traitors are exceptions. She shakes her head, not daring to look back behind her.

"I spent years training to shoot non-fatally . It takes a lot more time to learn than just aiming straight. The Horde trains you to act

nonlethally,” Adora returns. She realizes her hands are shaking a bit where they’re tied behind her back. It must be from the venom still working through her system. The short girl seems to sneer behind her mask, but then her eyes glance up and she freezes. Adora pauses, craning her head up to find Scorpia standing over her with a sad expression that makes her heart stutter.

“It’s true. You know I was the same,” Scorpia says. Her tone is regretful. Adora feels a pervading sense of loss emanating from her as Scorpia sighs and then moves, shifting to stand beside Adora and then dropping down to sit cross legged. A shiver runs up Adora’s spine when she feels Scorpia’s tail wrap around her, but there is no sharp stab from her stinger. She seems to be holding Adora in place as she levels Adora with an almost beseeching look.

“The Horde is stratified. The people who kill, murder, and torture are kept separate from the others by the upper level. It’s how they trick so many people into joining them, telling them they’ll never have to hurt others. But every job in the Horde hurts others, because it fuels the beast that eats up everybody in front of it,” Scorpia explains. She sounds sorry, like she doesn’t want to shatter Adora’s worldview like this - and it is shattering to hear. Probably because Adora, on some level, knows its true.

She looks away quickly, unable to take that look of kindness in Scorpia’s eyes. Adora has never seen a single person die at the hands of the Horde, but what she has seen is almost worse. A small, lost, and malnourished magicat kitten, covered in bruises and fur matted with blood, whimpering softly with every breath as she suffered the pain of disobedience. Adora doesn’t even remember what Catra did that first time to earn the punishment.

It doesn’t matter what it was – there is nothing that a child could do to truly earn that. Adora thought that if they were just obedient, then they wouldn’t get punished, and they would get three meals a day. Now she wishes she could go back in time and tell her younger self to turn and run in the opposite direction. It was the first time she saw Catra like that, but it was far from the last.

"They have my girlfriend. Shadow W eaver has held her hostage for years. I don't know what to do. I don't want to hurt people, but I can't refuse and let them hurt *her*,"Adora admits, her voice a whisper . It's too true, too much to admit for a cover. This is all spiraling out of control far too fast. Shadow Weaver was right – Adora can't lie. She flinches at the touch on her shoulder, twisting awkwardly in her bindings to find Scorpia's eyes lit with a fiery look of determination.

"W e'll help you,"she promises without consulting anyone else in the room first. To Adora's surprise, Scorpia's words are met with shifting and muttering, but no one challenges her. Adora is even more surprised by the way all the air leaves her lungs at the words.

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Catra texts Adora after twenty minutes of silence. And again half an hour later. She sets her phone aside and kneads into her brand-new throw pillow until it is shredded beneath her hands. She forces herself to cook dinner. It has been an hour now. She texts again. Again, she gets nothing. Catra gets up, her fur itching, and goes down to the gym across the street.

She's pretty sure the gym owner is spying on her – he operates a business within the Horde's territory, so he must be on speaking terms to make his payments – but she ignores the way his eyes linger on her as she makes her way to a beaten and patched punching bag. Her phone is tucked into her sports bra. She would feel and hear it the moment it went off, but it doesn't. She pummels the bag until her back is burning. She doesn't bother with any of the other eqipment, heading right back across the street with her body tired but her mind no qieter .

She doesn't want to run in circles worrying about what happened to Adora, but it's the only thing she can think of as she rides the

elevator up to her floor. At least, that's true until she reaches her front door. She pauses, staring at the door handle. She was initially unsettled by a slight shift inside, but now that she knows to look for it, she feels her jaw clench at the faint trace of Shadow Weaver's scent lingering in the air.

Catra opens her front door already scowling and glaring. Shadow Weaver is sat on her couch, lounging with far too much comfort for a space she was uninvited too. It's unnerving being able to see this much of her face. She wears a veil for anonymity when she goes into the city – her distinctive scarring might get the cops called on her, even here – but it is transparent enough for her to see through it, and thus for her to be seen as well, especially in interior lighting.

No one really looks twice at her on the street - drows are commonly photosensitive and veils aren't uncommon to protect them from severe burns - but it means that Catra can clearly see her facial expression as Shadow Weaver looks down on her from her spot on the couch. Catra feels her tail lash as she heads deeper into her apartment, dropping her keys on the kitchen counter and crossing her arms. She meets Shadow Weaver's gaze with a dry look of her own.

"I don't recall giving you my spare key ," she comments, dryly . Shadow Weaver looks incredibly unimpressed. She might be curling her lip slightly in disdain - it's hard to tell with the notch in it already twisting her upper lip up near the end. Shadow Weaver has never told the story of her scars, but they look like the kind people don't expect you to survive. Catra doubts she would ever admit to getting her ass handed to her that badly.

"You forget your place. I own this building and every other in this district," Shadow Weaver returns. Her tone is dark, but she hasn't dropped down to threatening yet. Catra narrows her eyes at Shadow Weaver.

"Funny , I thought Hordak was the boss," she reminds. Anger flares in Shadow Weaver's eyes at being reminded of *her* place. Catra is

certain Shadow Weaver would murder Hordak in a heartbeat if she truly wanted to take over, but she doesn't seem that bothered when she is already practically running the entire Horde anyway. All that would be in it for her is a bit more profit, but she cares more about having power and freedom.

"Where' s Adora?" Shadow W eaver snaps back. That quiets Catra. Her tail instantly stills as a feeling of dread spreads through her. Catra is Adora's handler and contact while she is in the field. If she loses Adora, or anything goes wrong, it's her fault. It shouldn't be, but Shadow Weaver loves putting Catra is positions where she can only lose. If Adora does well on this mission, then she will be hailed as a great spy. If she fails, Catra will be tortured for being a poor handler. She grits her teeth, her hands tightening on her folded arms.

"I don't know . She hasn't checked in yet. She went to the location you gave her," Catra returns. Shadow W eaver narrows her eyes and then stands, snapping up abruptly and turning to face Catra from her full height. Catra feels her tail lash again as her ears pin back. Sometimes she hates being one of the shorter hybrid species. Shadow Weaver loves to leverage her height to loom over her.

"Y ou are her handler. Shifting the blame elsewhere will not be tolerated. Locate her," Shadow W eaver orders, her tone dark. Catra fights the urge to shrink back as she feels her claws slide out, her body instinctively ordering her to seek protection, but there isn't any here. The best she ever had was Adora, and she could only diffuse the lightest situations. The higher the tension, the more likely that Catra would get hurt regardless. Maybe not right away – maybe not even in front of Adora – but eventually.

"That would be easier if I was allowed to leave," Catra points out, even if she doesn't feel as brave as her words. Shadow Weaver claimed that it was necessary for the cover and that Scorpia wouldn't believe that Adora had managed to just get away. She's supposed to be on a few weeks of leave to sort out her *hysterical emotions* around dying, and in the meantime, Catra has to stay within Horde territory as insurance.

Shadow Weaver claimed that the man outside Catra's apartment is a plant in case the Alliance checks on Catra to verify the story. Catra is supposed to play hostage for Adora to return to while Adora "secretly" defects to the Alliance. The only problem with that is that Catra absolutely is a real hostage. She doesn't know if Adora really processed that. The cover story is far too real.

Shadow Weaver called it method acting. She claimed it was the only way that Adora could sell it. Catra is pretty sure she was actually trying to subtly threaten Adora, perhaps without her even realizing it, but it's hard to talk about when there is all this distance between them. One, if not both, of their phones are likely bugged, not to mention the recording devices they know about in Adora's apartment.

Given this encounter, Catra doesn't doubt there are some in her apartment too. She wonders how Shadow Weaver feels about finding out that Adora is a screamer. Shadow Weaver glares at her, crossing the apartment in just a few steps as Catra does everything she can to not shrink back against the counter. She swallows, her ears pinned back as she looks up at an angry Shadow Weaver with no hope that Adora will interfere this time.

"Try to leave Horde territory and you will find out what happens to traitors. Keep Adora and *yourself* in line, or you'll lose her forever. I won't even have to take her from you – she'll leave you on her own," Shadow Weaver instructs. Catra's breath hitches as the light of victory flares in Shadow Weaver's eyes. Satisfied, she turns away, sweeping from the apartment. Catra clutches to herself as she waits for the door to click shut and then stumbles over to lock the deadbolt.

She drops to the floor, leaning her back against the door and silently praying. *Please, Adora, come back.*

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Two of the women and the man are having a conversation in a different language on the far end of the room. If Adora knew shit about languages she would say they're speaking something European, but the best she has is that it doesn't sound like Spanish. The other three women around Adora don't seem to be at all concerned it. Scorpia couldn't undo Adora's binds without cutting them, so one of the women from the back wall came forward, as did one of the ones hanging back in the front of the room.

There's still one more woman lingering in the back, the shortest out of all of them, watching stoically as a tall and slender woman undoes the knots. All the members of the Alliance are wearing their gear from head-to-toe except for the woman sitting cross-legged in front of Adora. Her face is covered, but it's by a *welding mask*, and she's sporting purple pigtails and a raccoon onesie. Adora has some questions about that, but she really isn't in the position to ask.

"How'd you find out about me?" Scorpia asks her. Adora blinks up at her, turning her head to look away from Pigtails, who she is pretty sure is staring intently at her behind the mask, but she can't see her eyes through it to confirm the suspicion.

"Shadow Weaver told me when I wouldn't just keep marching into death. It was supposed to assure me that she knew what she was doing. She acted like I was being unreasonable for not wanting to die when we didn't even know how it works. Like, is there a limited number? Is it only from certain injuries? Can sickness still kill me?" Adora tells her, shrugging a little. She wants to gesture with her hands, but whoever tied her up was *thorough*. Directly across from her, Pigtails perks up.

"Oh, I know the answers to all that! I've experimented a *lot*," she responds, sounding proud. Adora does her best not to cringe. Behind her, the slender woman clears her throat.

"On herself, she means. We have a strict rule against dissection," the woman clarifies, her voice far too calm for the words she is speaking. Yeah, that definitely doesn't make Adora feel better, but the woman across from her nods her agreement enthusiastically.

"We can die however we want! We'll always regenerate. The more you do it, the more any old damage you have heals too. We can *die*-die, I call it Mega Death, but not via traditional means, so don't worry! Oh, and you won't age anymore and may notice an increase in your physical strength now that it doesn't deteriorate," the woman explains, far too passionate and chipper for the subject of *Mega Death*.

Adora swallows harshly, blinking at the woman across from her. That is both good and bad news. If there's someone who knows how to kill an immortal, it will be Shadow Weaver. She can't even begin to unpack the aging thing right now. She has a lot of questions about immortality and relationships, but they'll have to wait.

"How do I, um, Mega Die?" Adora asks, feeling her shoulders slump a bit as the last of the binds finally fall away. Pigtails doesn't reply. Adora glances to Scorpia to find her exchanging a look with the woman gathering up Adora's bindings. Scorpia never bothered putting on a mask and her expression is a little haunted. Behind Adora, the other woman speaks up again.

"Don't worry about it for now. You have to intend to do it. You'll be fine," the woman says. Adora frowns. She really doesn't like the sound of that. At her side, Scorpia nudges her gently. It has to be gentle, or her spikes would dig into Adora's arm. As it is, Adora is used to Catra's claws and just looks up at Scorpia to find her expression unchanged.

"They didn't tell me at first either. It can be a risk to tell new immortals and have them try it," Scorpia explains.

"Oh," Adora whispers softly, ducking her head. Yeah. Yeah, if anything happened to Catra- Maybe it is best that she doesn't know.

She flinches just thinking about it. At least she knows it's something that can happen now. That's far more than Shadow Weaver told her. Across from her, Pigtails ducks her head as if to make eye contact, but Adora still can't see her eyes through the mask.

"Outside of that, it really doesn't matter what you do. The universe will fix any death by popping you back to your home, safe and sound," Pigtails explains, gesturing vaguely with her hand. Adora frowns, but she nods. That isn't much more detail than what Shadow Weaver was able to tell her, but she supposes the mechanism of how she comes back doesn't matter so much as knowing that it will always happen.

The secret side conversation concludes in the corner of the room, the three people participating all turning to eye the huddle in the middle of the room. Adora gives them a hopeful smile as the shorter woman crosses the room to stand over her. Adora may be untied, but she has a feeling she shouldn't stand from her kneeling position just yet. The woman crosses her arms, clearly scrutinizing Adora through her mask for a long moment.

"Know that I don't trust you, but the nature of immortals means you're a decent person, so I'm willing to give you the chance to prove yourself," she says. Adora blinks at her. Okay, more questions for the pile, but she nods hesitantly. She pauses, biting her lip as she looks down. She doesn't know what's happening anymore. She doesn't know what *nature* she has to her that has made these strangers just untie her with minimal prompting.

"Shadow Weaver wanted me to find you," she whispers. There's a stir around the room as everyone's attention suddenly focuses on her. Adora cringes. This is not part of the plan. She was supposed to have stolen the intel that led her here, but-

"Explain," the woman commands, her voice hard. Adora blows out a breath, sagging where she is seated.

"Catra isn't allowed to leave Horde territory , so Shadow Weaver knows I'll come back for her. She let me see reports on Scorpia and the Alliance. That's how I knew where to go. It's all a set up to come find you, but I don't know what else to do. I just want to know what I am, and for Catra to be safe,"Adora explains. It' s too honest. Adora doesn't know what she's doing, playing for both sides, but she can't stop.

She feels compelled to be honest with them, for some reason. Probably because she knows that everything they have said is right and, unlike Shadow Weaver, they haven't threatened to torture the girl she loves even once. Adora can't stop thinking about how terrible the Horde is. If anyone knows how to get away from them, it's these people. Scorpia managed it once, after all.

"She took us in as kids. I thought she was just recruiting, but she says that she knew I was immortal the whole time. She was raising me just to *kill me*,"Adora adds on. She doesn't mean to sound that raw, but her voice cracks as she speaks. She hasn't really said it before, not even to Catra in their few days of peace before this job. She couldn't handle acknowledging it, not when there was no solution in sight.

"Adora, you can't know that someone is an immortal before they die. A mortal especially wouldn't have the frame of reference to make a guess, even if they knew exactly how it works,"the slender woman still sitting behind her says, her voice gentle like she is breaking bad news. She is. Adora feels her throat tighten, ducking her head so everybody in the room isn't looking at her as she rapidly blinks her eyes.

Oh. That's- bad. Adora swallows around the lump in her throat, thinking back to Catra's concerns over Shadow Weaver placing Adora in danger. Adora shoved it down by assuring herself that Shadow Weaver knew that she was immortal and that their mentor wasn't really putting Adora at risk. Except apparently she *didn't*. She thought so, clearly, but she didn't know that she was right before she put a bullet through Adora.

There's a comment in that other language again, but Adora is kind of busy having a spiral and doesn't even look up. She ignores the small debate that breaks out until Scorpia clears her throat, startling Adora and cutting off everybody else in the room. Adora's chest feels tight, but she looks up to find Scorpia looking over to the shorter woman.

"Y eah, the rest of us? Still have no clue what you're saying," Scorpia points out. Well. At least she's in the same boat with Adora. The shorter girl sighs, looking down at Adora.

"Mortals have always tried to exploit immortals, often by holding our loved ones hostage. We'll help you. We have set a mission to undermine the Horde until it collapses anyway. Help us with that, and we can free your girlfriend," the shorter woman says. Adora draws in a sharp breath, holding it for a moment before she nods.

She *wants* to help. She doesn't want Shadow Weaver to be able to hurt others like she hurt Catra. If all this goes south, she can claim that this was just how she worked her way in undercover and she always planned to return to the Horde anyway. She should be able to preserve their position somewhat, even if they lose trust. And if it works- well, maybe her and Catra can finally be free.

"I'm not killing anyone," she adds, because it needs to be said. The girl across from her rolls her eyes.

"Good, we don't want you to. W e have poison capsules for ourselves. They're quick and painless. I want you to take one to prove you're immortal and then return to the corner where we picked you up at noon tomorrow," the woman tells her . Adora lets out a breath and then nods. That doesn't sound bad. The woman gives her a curt nod and then turns on her heel, heading towards the door. Once it has swung shut behind her, Scorpia claps Adora on the shoulder.

"W elcome to the Alliance! It will be nice to have someone else from the bad side' around. It' s been a big adjustment," Scorpia tells her ,

happily. Adora winces a little, but she gives Scorpia a wavering smile. Across from her, Pigtails cocks her head.

"Where do you regen right now?" she asks. Adora pauses. She doesn't really know the answer to that question.

"The last three times it was my girlfriend's bed. I don't know what… determines that," Adora admits, shrugging. She watches Scorpia exchange a glance with the woman who untied Adora. The woman shifts, coming to stand before Adora.

"She knows you're an immortal?" she asks. Adora nods. As much as Adora knows, Catra does too. "How long have you been together?" the woman adds on. That makes Adora pause. She swallows, looking down as she instinctively wraps her arms around herself. That question shouldn't be as dangerous as it is, but if these people somehow tell Shadow Weaver, Adora can claim it was a lie to deepen the stakes for the cover.

"Five years. Since we were teenagers," she admits. She glances up, a bit startled by the sorrow in Scorpia's expression before she remembers that Scorpia knows exactly how the Horde views relationships. "We had to keep it secret because of the ban, but it didn't stop how we felt," she adds, shrugging a little. Scorpia sighs, shaking her head.

"Relationships aren't actually banned in the Horde. They just tell you that so they can blackmail you with the exception that they made for you when it inevitably happens," Scorpia corrects her, her tone a bit distant as she looks up to the slender woman. Adora has to force herself not to gape at Scorpia. She believes her – it matches up the attitude Shadow Weaver has had towards every other couple – but she also knows that she and Catra truly were banned from being together. Above her, the other woman clears her throat.

"We'll help you get your girlfriend back, but you should also work on coming to terms with the fact that she is a mortal," the woman warns her. Adora flinches, her chest tightening. Within moments, a panic

attack threatens to consume her, the very idea of living on without Catra making her blood rush in her ears. She doesn't want to- She *can't* think about that. Luckily, the door opens again, the shorter woman returning with the poison in her hand.

She seems startled by Adora struggling for breath in the center of the room, but Adora just reaches her hand out, desperate for the pill so she doesn't have to think about this. After exchanging a brief glance to Scorpia and receiving a nod, she holds it out for Adora. Adora takes it gladly, biting down on the capsule and swallowing. The woman was telling the truth. It is quick, and it stops the pain clutching at her chest.

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Catra has a panic attack, and then she pulls herself together. Let it out when no one is looking and then *move on*. She has done it before and she'll do it again. Usually she has Adora comforting her through it, but every moment she has that thought just extends the panic attack, so she pushes it aside. They should have anticipated Adora going dark for a good chunk of today. Scorpia would get suspicious if she had her phone out, but Catra's concern doesn't subside.

She takes a shower because she's already a wreck and might as well add on a little torture as a garnish. She hates showering without Adora. She has only done it a handful of times. Even when they were in separate stalls, Adora was still there while Catra was locked in the tight shower with the spray. Her apartment's shower is a bit bigger, but she still hates it. She growls and hisses throughout it, giving in to the noises if only to calm herself a bit.

When she gets out and sets to drying off, her growls give way to purrs as she attempts to soothe herself. She wraps the towel tightly

around herself when she's done, padding out of the bathroom with her chin tucked down. She has decided to keep her apartment warm, finally able to dictate the temperature to something more comfortable for her, but it still doesn't feel like enough as she shuffles over to her bed, ducking beneath the covers for warmth.

She balls up beneath her blankets, collecting her phone from the end table and tucking it in against her heart so any notification will wake her. Adora will call her eventually. Even if they killed her, she will wake up back in her apartment and then she can call Catra and let her know what happened. If Catra was able to go check, she would, but Shadow Weaver has made it clear that she can't take that risk.

The room shifts. Everything just *tilts* slightly, the air electrifying for the blink of an eye before everything clicks back into place and a second set of breathing joins Catra's own. Catra swallows, stirring slightly to feel another body at her back. She flips over qickly , popping her head up above the edge of the covers to find Adora stretched out in the mattress beside her, lying on her back and sleeping peacefully, her face relaxed.

Catra swallows, blinking down at Adora. The last time this happened, Catra was kind of out of it. She didn't notice any change. She isn't sure how she would describe what just happened except that it made her fur bristle. There was no sound, or light, or anything profound – everything just felt weird for a moment, and then the mattress was weighted down by another body. Carefully, Catra shifts closer and wraps herself around Adora. Adora doesn't stir, continuing to sleep peacefully beside her.

Shadow Weaver thought Adora would regenerate at her own apartment, but Catra isn't upset by this development. She knows she should shake Adora awake and ask what happened, but something tells her that Adora won't be easy to wake. Besides, this gives her an excuse to cuddle Adora and rest her head on her shoulder, purring from true content as she wraps around her warm body.

The debrief can wait for when Adora wakes on her own. Catra clings to Adora, rubbing her cheek against her shoulder and hoping that she doesn’t come bearing bad news. She came back. For now, that has to be enough.

Immortal Boys Club

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora doesn't wake for a long time. Catra drifts off, wrapped tightly around Adora at first. When she next wakes, she is draped over her. She watches Adora stir with the first beam of light that breaks through the window. Without seeming to fully reach consciousness, Adora turns over and curls around Catra. Catra purrs, nuzzling into the attention and marking along the line of Adora's jaw as Adora lets out a soft, sleepy grunt.

"You've had a full night's rest. Wake up, sleepyhead," Catra tells her, her tone far too affectionate. She cuts it by nipping lightly at the line of Adora's jaw. Adora lets out another half-hearted sound of protest, but her eyes slowly blink open, her gaze unfocused as it lands on Catra's face. Catra releases a soft breath before she catches herself and smiles at Adora like she was never worried.

"Hey there, dummy," she greets. Adora snorts, blinking a few times to bring her eyes into focus. Her gaze roams over Catra's face, seeming to take it in greedily before she surges forward and kisses Catra. It is far too passionate for first thing in the morning, but aside from a slight squeak, Catra meets Adora happily, kissing her back. For a few moments there is nothing but them, the warmth of the sun, and the softness of the bed.

Adora sighs almost dreamily when she pulls back, offering Catra a contented smile. Catra blushes, ducking her head and feeling her tail thump heavily against the bed from her fluster. Adora breaks eye contact to glance around the room, squinting as she seems to realize that she isn't back in her own apartment for the first time.

"Huh. Guess Shadow Weaver was wrong," she says. Catra, despite herself, shivers a little at the words alone. She pulls back far enough

to sign *listening* to Adora. Adora frowns, but she nods. Catra doesn't actually know if there are bugs in her apartment, but she is pretty confident in her guess that there are. Adora reaches up, gently brushing Catra's hair aside and out of her face. Catra leans into the touch, her chest buzzing with her purr, but she isn't just doing it because she is contented.

She's also anxious, worried about what happened yesterday and how Adora ended up in her bed. She leans into the attention, letting herself focus on it for a few moments of luxury before she is forced to face the truth and ask Adora what happened. Adora has a sad tinge to her gaze as her eyes roam over Catra's face. Catra can guess that Adora is thinking about the distance that is about to be between them.

"What happened?" she asks in a whisper. Adora's expression shifts to be just a little pained, but she doesn't stop gently stroking Catra.

"I think I talked my way in. I'm at least meeting up with them again today. They're...weirdly trusting. But they had me take poison to prove myself. It didn't hurt," Adora tells her. Catra swallows, nodding into Adora's hand. The details are scant, especially considering how long Adora was gone, but at least nothing went seriously wrong.

"You just stopped replying," she says. Her voice is low, like she thinks that if she whispers it then it will be less likely to convey the true. Catra hates being left hanging, suddenly dangling out in the void where any opportunist – *Shadow Weaver* – can pounce on her. Adora pauses, blinking at her before her hand suddenly pulls away. The whine Catra gives is involuntary, but it makes Adora smile despite the pinch to her brow as she reaches down to her pocket and feels it.

"Scorpia knocked me out with her venom. I woke up in room with a sack on my head. The Alliance was there. They must have taken my phone. That's where I told them the cover story," Adora explains. Catra frowns, nodding a little. That explains Adora vanishing on her,

even if she doesn't like the idea of someone else having their hands on Adora while she was unconscious.

"How many of them were there?" she asks. Adora pauses, seeming hesitant. Her gaze flicks to the side, as if to look out the window and count them.

"I don't know . I think all of them. They spoke multiple languages. It was hard to track. They asked questions about how I found them and my immortality, and then I told them the story about being stuck in the same situation as Scorpia, and she fell for it immediately. She ordered the others to help me. They agreed they would if I helped them destroy the Horde and proved that I was immortal," Adora explains.

Her voice is steady, but her face – her face is just slightly screwed up in concentration. Catra frowns, reaching up to stroke Adora's cheek. Adora lets out a shaky breath, leaning into the touch just a little too eagerly – desperately. Her eyes snap back to Catra, roaming over her again, her gaze almost hungry .

"Adora, what's wrong?" Catra asks, her heartbeat pulsing in her throat. Adora bites her lip, seeming conflicted. More happened that she isn't saying. Catra doesn't blame her with the possibility that they're being listened to, but it doesn't help the anxiety that has been buzzing in her chest since yesterday . Eventually, Adora sighs, her hand shifting to bury in Catra's hair.

"The last thing they told me was to be careful getting attached to mortals. It wasn't a fun reminder," she admits, her words hesitant. It's a punch to Catra's gut that has her quickly looking away , blinking her eyes rapidly. Right, she hadn't even *considered* that. Immortal means living forever – which she isn't going to do. It means Adora moving on from her eventually – maybe in a lifetime, once Catra has passed, maybe in ten years, when she can't take the relationship anymore, or maybe tomorrow.

Adora's hand in her hair tightens, tugging Catra forward. Catra is startled by Adora kissing her suddenly, a passion in the kiss that under any other circumstances would have a fire stirring in Catra's gut, but it can't light with the storm inside her chest. Adora realizes quickly, pulling back and biting her lip again as she sends Catra an almost pleading look.

"I don't care. Please. I have a feeling they're not going to give me much leeway. Let's just- have this morning. I'm here. I'm with you," Adora promises her. Catra swallows, blinking at the desperation in Adora's expression. Sure, Adora doesn't care right this second, but eventually she will. Eventually she will realize that Shadow Weaver was right, she really is special, and she'll leave Catra behind when she can't be bothered to deal with a mortal anymore.

Eventually. Catra is going to spend this evening panicking, but even if this turns out to be her last fucking time with Adora, she wants to seize it. She will take any second of Adora's attention that she can squeeze from her. Catra nods jerkily, and then she surges forward and kisses Adora.

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Adora hadn't planned to lie to Catra – well, she didn't plan *anything*, much less to spill her guts to the Alliance like she did – but she certainly can't tell her the truth if she thinks there are bugs in her apartment. Catra seems willing to put it all aside for the moment, even if the comment on her own mortality seemed to affect her as badly as it did Adora.

Catra kisses her with fiery passion and Adora meets her back in kind. She needs to do this. Everything about the future is uncertain, but she has Catra in her arms right now. Catra's kiss is desperate, but Adora manages to soothe it, kissing her back until the kiss is

hungry but missing that dark edge of escapism to it that it had at first. It felt like Catra would have done anything to not think for a moment.

Adora has kissed her many times when she needed a similar escape from their situation before, but she never liked it. It always felt exploitative even though it was Catra kissing her and she was the one to initiate everything. Adora wants to touch her in every way, but she is worried about doing that with so tense of a subject fresh on their tongues. Luckily, Catra seems willing to replace the words with each other's taste, the kisses easing into more sensual territory as Adora runs her hands over Catra's body.

Catra calms in her arms. She slows, kissing Adora languidly once the desperation has burned off. She is responsive to the slow hands feeling along her body, arching up into Adora's touch as she feels along her sides and squeezes at her ass. Catra even releases a small, playful growl at the action that Adora wishes she had been able to hear daily over the last two decades of her life, but unfortunately their lives have never been an idyllic paradise of make outs, sweet sounds, and wandering hands.

Adora still isn't used to the luxury of a bed. She can muss up Catra's fur, tracing the stripes along her back as she kisses Catra. Catra seems torn between kissing her with hunger and practically quivering beneath her hands. Adora knows they wordlessly agreed not to have sex in her apartment because they knew there were bugs there, but she doubts that Catra has gotten explicit confirmation that there are bugs here in the last twenty-four-hours.

She also doesn't *care*. She just needs Catra, and given the way that Catra trembles under her touch, she thinks Catra feels the same. They already had sex here once anyway. If there are bugs, the secret is already out. She runs her hands over Catra, squeezing and feeling her slight quivering beneath her hands.

Adora doesn't know why Catra went to sleep naked, but she is grateful that she did, because it means she can touch every inch of her without barriers. She would like to see her too, though. Adora

pulls back from the kiss. It's just supposed to be for a moment, but Catra chases her, trying to keep going. Adora chuckles, causing Catra to hiss indignantly and pin her ears back. Adora peppers a soft kiss along the side of Catra's face to make up for it.

Catra is blushing when she pulls back, apparently embarrassed by her neediness, but Adora loves it. She wraps her arms around Catra's back, carefully tipping them over. Catra makes a low noise, seeming caught between a growl and a purr, but she lets Adora lay her down in the sheets and shift back to straddle her thighs, looking down at the girl she has known – *loved* – for so long.

"You're gorgeous," Adora breathes to her, ducking down to nuzzle beneath her jaw like Catra loves to do to her. She kisses the soft, fuzzy fur there as Catra chirrups. Her blush deepens as her tail sweeps back and forth with excitement. Adora grins against her neck, nipping the side lightly before she continues on her path down Catra's chest. Despite thinking it for years, Adora has never been able to voice her compliments before. It was too dangerous. She presses a kiss directly over Catra's heart, burying her face in the fluffy patch of fur there.

"Beautiful. Dangerous. Smart. Deadly. My mind runs in circles for you sometimes," Adora admits. The very idea of living without Catra is enough to make her chest feel tight, but right now she has Catra here. She can't imagine life without her, but she isn't going to let it stop her from celebrating the beautiful woman currently in her arms. She is going to take every second she can get with the woman she loves. Catra trills, squirming a little beneath Adora. Adora glances up to find her face flushed, her eyes blown out until her pupils are round.

This look on Catra could convince Adora to do anything under the sun if it means keeping Catra happy. Her hands make their way to Catra's thighs, gripping and squeezing in order to deal with the vice-grip crushing her heart right now. Adora shifts, cautiously nudging a knee between Catra's thighs as she pulls them apart. Catra shifts immediately, her legs falling open and welcoming Adora in. Adora

breathes out slowly, nuzzling against Catra's chest again as her hands sweep up, massaging gently at Catra's inner thighs.

Catra's breath is coming fast, her body twitching and responsive as Adora continues to just feel her up with her hands for a few moments. She scatters kisses against Catra's chest, working her way down towards her stomach – though she takes a pause to kiss and suck against Catra's nipple, her heart jumping at the raspy gasp Catra gives in response and the way she wriggles beneath Adora, the slightest whimper caught in her throat. Catra is quiet like always, but those small sounds light a fire within Adora.

Adora releases her, kissing her way further down as Catra breathes heavily. Adora just kisses her soft fur for a few moments, her own arousal building at the hard muscle she can feel beneath it. Once she thinks Catra is steadied, she finally lets her hands meet her, tracing through her folds as Catra's tail twitches with anticipation. When Adora's fingers finally frame her clit, massaging around its base and squeezing carefully, Catra releases a gasping trill, seemingly too wound up to suppress it.

Adora *loves* that sound. It sends a jolt through her as she sets to touching Catra in earnest, her face still buried in her stomach. She likes feeling Catra beneath her as she ramps up the pace slowly to the firm pressure that Catra likes. Catra gasps, trills and soft groans beneath every breath as she squirms beneath Adora, too overwhelmed by the touch to hold still. Adora lets her free hand come up, palming Catra's breast and massaging at it, gently tweaking her nipple to not overstimulate her. Catra likes attention and pressure all along her body and Adora is more than happy to provide.

Despite how much Catra is clearly enjoying herself, it takes awhile. It's probably the dark specter hanging over them, but they don't have a time limit at this exact moment, so Adora just keeps going. She ends up with her free hand on Catra's thigh when she begins to worry about overworking her, shifting up to nuzzle against the other side of her chest and lave her tongue over her hard nipple again.

Catra gasps, sqeaks, moans, and even growls when she seems to be coming close but her body relaxes without any release.

Eventually, she is whining softly on every breath. Adora switches tactics, shifting her hand from Catra's thigh to press in with two fingers. The qality of Catra' s moaning instantly changes. Adora takes the hint, thrusting in firmly. Catra is open and soaking for her. It seems to be what she needed. After only a few moments, Catra whines loudly, her entire body tensing and curling forward into Adora's touch. Adora works her over until the tension in Catra's body *releases*, her limbs dropping back into the sheets as she goes limp. Adora holds her as she begins to purr, utterly spent.

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Catra's entire life has been laced with fear and pain, but somehow her current anxiety is fucking with her worse than anything that came before.

(She knows why – it's because she doesn't have Adora with her).

She is grateful for the time that they got to spend together this morning, even if it took her so long to come that when she offers to return the favor Adora just shakes her head and points out that they need to have breakfast. Apparently she is supposed to return to the Alliance at noon, so she's on a schedule. Catra's mouth twists, a spark of unease in her chest as she pulls on her clothes. She tries to shove down the voice in her mind that says Adora just doesn't want Catra to touch her. Adora has a perfectly reasonable excuse.

Catra tries to distract herself by drilling Adora for details about her meeting with the Alliance as she cooks, but that just serves to frustrate her. She doesn't know if the difference between how she would recount a conversation she had yesterday and how Adora

does it is just down to the fact that Adora doesn't have an eidetic memory or if dying fucks with her head a little, but her answers are vague. Shadow Weaver isn't going to like vague answers.

"Adora. Give me something that Shadow W eaver actually wants to hear," Catra eventually tells her , because if she doesn't demand it then she's going to snap. The last thing she wants to do right now is get angry at Adora. She wants Adora's lasting memory of her to be the noises she makes between the sheets – something she might actually want to come back to – and not her temper fraying. Adora winces, looking down at the counter she is sat at.

"It was a first meeting. They didn't give me much. I told them the cover story and Scorpia seemed willing to buy it. Another one – the leader, maybe? She talked a lot – told me she didn't trust me, but she was willing to give me a chance because I was immortal," Adora tells her. Catra can't help but scowl down at the oven while she watches the clock tick. She really hates this immortal boys club. Adora has bought Shadow Weaver's bullshit in the past and she's afraid of her buying the Alliance's now.

"I don't trust anyone who is willing to give you the benefit of the doubt just because of what you are," Catra comments, her tone just a little too bitter to be a casual observation. She wants to remind Adora not to trust these people, but she is afraid to when Shadow Weaver might be listening. She isn't going to say anything that could encourage her to suspect Adora. She glances up, finding Adora frowning down at where she is staring down at the counter, seeming lost in thought.

"They said something about it being in the nature of immortals to be decent people. I don't know what that means," she explains, shrugging a bit. Catra scowls as the clock ticks over and she bends down to open the oven. She is grateful for the excuse to not look at Adora. Catra never bought into Shadow Weaver's bullshit about how Adora was just inherently *good* while Catra was hardly worth feeding. She knows now that Shadow Weaver just wanted to use

Adora's powers for her own gain. She wonders what this new group's angle is. Probably inside intel on the Horde.

"Be careful with them. It sounds like they're trying to lure you into a false sense of security," Catra replies. Her chest is burning with something painful and angry. Adora is silent in response.

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It didn't feel false. It felt more genuine than a second of being in the Horde. Adora doesn't know how to explain it to someone who wasn't there. She just felt like these people were trustworthy. She can't explain more than that, and she can't say even that much in Catra's apartment. They have a tense breakfast where Catra tries to ask her details and Adora does her best to recount things without getting too detailed or reveal that she's hiding anything either. Catra is clearly frustrated.

Adora knows that she is afraid of Shadow Weaver being displeased with her report, but she keeps reminding her it was two brief conversations and she spent most of yesterday unconscious or dead. There really isn't much news to share. She manages to distract Catra by joking about how she managed to lose her new phone already, which at least gets her chuckling. They get a blissful hour of just messing around and gently ribbing each other – a little too gently, both of them aware of this weird, raw chasm between them that Adora doesn't understand the sudden appearance of – before Adora has to leave.

Adora makes it to the block twenty minutes early, but five minutes later a SUV with blackened windows pulls up and the back door opens to reveal Pigtails, this time without a mask. It's definitely her – the hair is pretty distinctive, but she's also wearing short Pikachu overalls, which definitely tracks with her attire yesterday – and she

beams at Adora as she waves her into the car. Adora ducks inside, turning around to slide the door shut behind her.

When she turns back towards Pigtails, she is holding a cellphone out to Adora. Adora blinks at it. It isn't hers, but Pigtails nudges it a little closer to her when she just stares at it, so she takes it. To her surprise, when she wakes it up she finds that the lockscreen is the photo of Catra curled up and sleeping soundly that she set her old phone's background too. She looks up at Pigtails, her brow pinched with confusion. The woman just grins at her.

"Y our last phone was way too easy to hack. It had spyware on it already. Two corporate, one definitely from the Horde. They were tracking your GPS. This one has all your data on it, but it won't give away our location. I killed your old phone before we brought you back to the base yesterday,"she explains. Adora blinks once again, looking down at the phone in surprise. She unlocks it, opening the photos app to find the bevy of Catra photos she took over the last week, plus their older photos she transferred from their last phone, all loaded onto it.

"I, uh, thanks. I'm not great with tech,"she responds, tucking the phone down into her pocket. Shadow Weaver is going to be mad about losing her tracker, but Adora is kind of relieved, and it must show on her face, because Pigtails beams with pride despite the inadeqate thanks. Adora is kind of touched, even though she knows this is mostly a safety measure to protect the Alliance from the Horde finding them.

"Entrapta' s brilliant with it!She' s a great engineer and hacker," Scorpia pipes up from the front seat as she puts the car in drive and pulls away from the curb. Adora smiles at Pigtails – Entrapta – and gives her a small and awkward wave. She doesn't know why, but this is technically their first introduction despite everything yesterday. There's a third woman in the car, though Adora can't see much but blonde hair considering she is in the passenger seat directly in front of her.

"It' s nice to actually meet you. I like your overalls," Adora of fers Entrapta, even though formalities feel awkward. Entrapta beams, doing an odd kind of shimmy in her seat as if to show off her outfit.

"Thanks! Perfuma got it for me," she says. Adora swears every sentence she says ends with an exclamation point, but Scorpia speaks similarly too. Adora pauses, shooting a confused look to Scorpia, but she's looking at the road right now and doesn't catch it. In the front seat, the blonde clears her throat and turns around to look at Adora around the back of her seat. She has a kind face, freckles dusting across her cheeks that make Adora think of Catra.

"I'm Perfuma. Entrapta and Scorpia are my girlfriends," she introduces, reaching her hand out to shake. Adora feels the confused pinch on her expression clear, reaching out and taking Perfuma's hand to shake it gladly. She can't help but think of what Shadow Weaver said about immortals finding each other throughout history – she can't help but think of the pre-emptive pain beating through her heart this morning at the very idea of losing Catra.

She gets only dating each other. It saves you the pain of losing someone to the march of time. There is nothing that could make Adora leave Catra's side, but she is kind of jealous of these three, knowing they can have each other's support forever. Adora's chest gets a bit tight. She has to derail this train of thought or she's going to have another panic attack.

"Where are we going?" she asks. Perfuma glances to Entrapta, seeming to pass the torch of the conversation back to her as she shifts back to face forward in her chair again. Entrapta seems happy to pick it up.

"Back to the base! W e have a penthouse not too far from here. Glimmer wants you to stay close so she can keep an eye on you, but if spending too much time away will make the Horde suspicious, we can talk to her," Entrapta tells her . Adora pauses, but then she shakes her head. No, nothing they do will make the Horde

suspicious. Adora can pass anything off as something that she has to do for the cover.

"Shadow W eaver gave me time off to 'sort myself out'. It should be fine as long as I keep going to visit Catra – which I *am* going to do," Adora tells them. Entrapta nods, her smile fading a bit as her face sets with seriousness.

"Relationships with mortals are hard. They don't feel the same way we do. But they're worth it. At least I think so. Some of the others tell me I'm young and things start feeling more different over time," Entrapta tells her. Adora was going to ask who the hell Glimmer is, but that derails her. She blinks at Entrapta, doing her best *not to think about Catra* .

"How old are you?" she asks. Questions about this whole immortality thing are useful and give her something to focus on other than what she is eventually going to lose. Entrapta's expression turns a bit sly as she shrugs.

"Depends how you count it! A lot of immortals tend to freeze by their late twenties. I was born in the 1980s, though. I met Perfuma about a decade ago. She was born in the 1940s. We both tend to say we're in our twenties. Age is kind of useless for immortals," Entrapta tells her. Adora doesn't mean to stare, but she can't help it. Okay, she understood logically when Entrapta told her she wouldn't age yesterday, but it's only sinking in for the first time now.

"Scorpia? How old are you? All Shadow W eaver said was that the Horde had an immortal in it years ago," Adora asks, looking into the front seat. Scorpia shrugs, seeming a bit sheepish.

"I'm still not used to counting it dif ferently. I'm twenty-one, but I'm also twenty-five. It's weird, but you'll get used to it eventually," Scorpia promises her. Adora doesn't know about that, but it's sinking in for the first time that in the grand scheme of things, she's practically a mortal for all her experience compared to her new teammates.

"Don't worry , we have people of all ages on the team! You, Scorpia, and Glimmer are all pretty new immortals. Technically I am too, but I know it's not the same," Entrapta tells her . Yeah, it's *definitely* not the same, but there's that name again.

"Who's Glimmer?" she asks, finally going to fasten her seatbelt. She kind of forgot about it. Not that a car crash would matter, but it would be annoying to reset and lose a few hours. She would just have to go back to that street corner and hope they came back for her.

"The short, bossy one," Perfuma supplies from the front seat, humor in her voice. Adora snorts.

"The one who threatened me yesterday?" she clarifies, watching the top of Perfuma's head bob with a nod. "Is she the leader , then?" she asks, even though it seems weird that someone so much younger would be in charge. That girl definitely wasn't that old, and if she's new to immortality than she can't have been around for that long after freeing either . To her surprise, that isn't a straightforward question. Everybody in the car makes an *ehh* sound, Entrapta waving her hand kind of vaguely as she does so.

"We don't really have a leader. Everybody votes. Democracy! Glimmer's mother is just one of the oldest immortals in the world, so she has a lot of connections," Entrapta explains, shrugging. Adora frowns, but she supposes it makes sense to appoint one person to ask the questions during an interrogation. The mention about her mother is interesting for multiple reasons – can immortality be passed down? – but Adora is still kind of stuck on the ages thing and how much they must see come and go.

"How old is she?" she asks. To her surprise, Entrapta grins, the smile a bit feral. In the front seat, Perfuma coughs into her hand.

"She's Roman. Not Greek – *Roman* . Glimmer's first language is Latin as much as it's English," she explains. Adora blinks at the back of the car headrest. Well, that explains why she couldn't place the

language they were speaking yesterday. It's *dead*. This is going to be interesting.

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Catra heads to headquarters an hour after Adora leaves. She needs to take that time to gather herself. She knew this whole undercover thing was going to suck, and hopefully it will get easier, but she can't imagine her anxieties easing up with time. She needs to report to Shadow Weaver, but she also just needs to clear her head, so she gets on her motorcycle and drives nowhere for half an hour before she forces herself to turn and head for headquarters.

She doesn't know if someone is following her. She hasn't been paying attention. She made sure to stay within the territory when she was just doing laps, so they wouldn't have anything to report if they were, but she hates that she feels as watched on the outside as they were before. They get to kiss openly now, which is definitely an improvement, but that's only when they get to be in the same room. Catra might have preferred to be trapped in the headquarters because at least then they were together.

She pulls into the headquarters reluctantly , parking her bike and sending a text to Kyle to see if he' s at the base today. Kyle was born into the Horde – he wouldn't be cut out for this life if any other option had ever been presented to him – so it isn't uncommon for him to be around the base not only for his own work, but if his dads are there. As Catra heads towards Shadow Weaver's office, she gets back the update that Shadow Weaver is on a warpath today. Catra sighs as she tucks her phone away and reluctantly approaches the last door that she wants to knock on.

"Come in," Shadow W eaver calls, her voice a harsh snap. Catra learned not to wince a long time ago, but her ears still twitch back as

she reaches for the door handle. Shadow Weaver is inside at her desk, her gaze fixed on her monitor as Catra enters and hovers by the door. Catra watches her eyes narrow, but she doesn't look up. "Adora," she prompts, continuing whatever work she is doing. Probably balancing a spreadsheet of extortion profits or something.

"She died and regenerated at the apartment. She reported to me before returning to meet up with Scorpia again. She's gotten in with the Alliance," Catra tells her . Shadow Weaver's mouse stills. For a moment she continues to face the computer, and then she turns slowly, facing forward and gesturing for Catra to sit in the chair in front of her desk. Catra steels herself and pushes forward, crossing the room and sitting in the uncomfortable chair. It's slightly too small for the average human, so Catra can only imagine how Rogelio must feel when he gets called in here.

"Which apartment?" Shadow W eaver asks. Catra feels her ear twitch. She *knows* that Shadow Weaver knows the answer to that question. There is no way she would break in and not plant a bug. At most, she hasn't checked the audio logs from today yet. Well, she'll be in for a fucking surprise once she does. Or maybe she already checked them and that's why she's so pissy.

"Mine. She appeared during the night," Catra returns. She has lied to Shadow Weaver many times and she'll do it again, but she never does it when she knows that Shadow Weaver can verify that she is lying. Shadow Weaver narrows her eyes, seeming displeased with that detail. Catra doesn't know why considering neither she, nor her apartment, are a secret. Catra is supposed to be Adora's entire motivation for joining the Alliance. It shouldn't be a big deal if she regenerates there.

"Full report," Shadow W eaver orders. She is tense, probably looking for an excuse to be angry. Catra has to do her best not to give her one. She draws in a breath before launching into the summary that Adora gave her, reorganizing it to go through all the details she got on a single part at once. It isn't much, but she has to volunteer

everything that Adora told her so Shadow Weaver doesn't accuse her of lying. She can at least start off strong.

Adora was able to paraphrase roughly what she said with Scorpia on the street corner. After that, she awoke with a sack on her head. Her story got fuzzier from there, although she also had more to track. Catra didn't fail to notice that Adora mentioned "the short one" gave orders, but she also never mentioned the sack being taken off. It had taken everything in Catra not to demand to know what game Adora was playing right then. Instead, she asked her if she may have been drugged, and Adora seemed to latch onto the excuse eagerly.

"She said everything felt weird during the interrogation. Her memories were fuzzy . . . When I asked her if it could be a result of dying, she said no, but that it's possible that they gave her other drugs while she was asleep," is how Catra chooses to report that. If Shadow Weaver does have a recording of the conversation, everything Catra just said was accurate, even if it is a purposeful omission of the fact that Catra was the first to bring up that possibility.

Shadow Weaver isn't happy with the report, but she doesn't challenge anything Catra says during it. Whether that is because she was honest or because Shadow Weaver wants to play the long game remains to be seen. She drills Catra for not getting more details, at which Catra snaps back that if she wanted details, she shouldn't have picked Adora for the job.

Catra loves the hell out of her, but she shouldn't be anyone's first pick for undercover work, she's just the only immortal they have. Shadow Weaver narrows her eyes, definitely sneering behind the mask as she points to her office door. Catra scrambles to take the opening to leave. She definitely doesn't want to stay in the woman's presence longer than she has to. She takes a deep breath when she gets out into the relative safety of the hallway, taking a moment to lean back against the wall and just relax.

In her pocket, her phone buzzes. She frowns, reaching for it and fishing it out. Apparently, Adora has a new phone, though she doesn't give details on why. Catra frowns down at the screen. That's definitely something she needs to report to Shadow Weaver, but she can't take going back in there when she *just* left. She shoves her phone back in her pocket and heads to the bunkroom. She walks there on instinct, almost halfway there before she remembers she doesn't have a bunk there anymore. Not really, at least.

Shadow Weaver said she would keep their old bunk empty until Adora started regenerating at her own apartment, but it doesn't make sense to keep it now that she has regenerated at Catra's. Actually, Catra didn't even think to ask about that this morning, but she really hopes Adora figures out how that works because it's *weird* that she regenerated in a place she's only been to once, even if it was an eventful once.

Catra keeps going, because she's already halfway there and she needs to kill time to steel herself before talking with Shadow Weaver again anyway. Catra arrives to find it exactly as it always is, though one of the younger kids loitering inside shoots her a confused look. She and Adora always stuck out as the oldest residents, and sometimes they were even expected to act like they were fucking RAs or something, but they were also the most senior people there and no one dared to eye them like that even after the others their age started aging out.

They've only been gone a few days, but apparently the others didn't expect Catra back. She *isn't* back, she just- she feels lost without Adora. It's pathetic, but it's true. She heads to their old bunk, finding it made up just as they left it, even if their trunk of belongings is gone, resting at the foot of the bed in Adora's apartments. Catra lays out on the bunk, trying to lounge casually like she used to in her downtime, but it feels weird now.

It's a mix of the others in the room eyeing her, the fact that she and Adora haven't fit in with this room for years anyway, and the shitty nightmare of the cot compared to her new bed. Catra sighs, curling

into a small ball on the mattress. This at least feels more familiar to her. Shuffling towards the end, she can bury her face in the blanket and imagine Adora right beside her. It's the same thing that she did on the night that she died, which just goes to show how well she's handling this. Truth be told, Catra still hasn't recovered from Adora dying the first time.

She watched the love of her life's body go lifeless and cold. That doesn't just go away because she popped back up. Catra entered a weird limbo of mourning, except there's nothing to mourn, except she's also terrified there somehow will be, and that has manifested into an intense fear of Adora leaving her behind. That fear has always been there, of course, but the fact that they are physically distant right now and her heart was already reeling has sent it into overdrive.

She nuzzles into the blanket, breathing deeply. It smells so familiar, like her and Adora and the entire bunkroom. They've had it for years and there are memories deeply associated it. Catra's mattress may be softer, but there's a difference between softness and *comfort*. She kind of hates who she is as a person – desperate – but she is absolutely taking this blanket home with her tonight before the bunk gets cleared out for someone else to use.

Catra sighs, shifting to sit up. She just has to go talk to Shadow Weaver first.

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Adora texts Catra as they drive just so she won't worry too much. Entrapta watches her do it, but it isn't anything incriminating to tell her girlfriend that she has a new phone. Entrapta waits until she's done to sweep her for bugs before they make it all the way back to

the penthouse. When she comes out clean, Scorpia turns them around and pulls into a parking garage they passed a block back.

The apartment building isn't tall – Adora's pretty sure a jump from the top could be survivable, if done right, though it would suck – so it doesn't take long to reach the penthouse. The elevator doors open up into a small foyer, separated from the rest of the apartment by the kind of thick glass doors that Adora knows at a glance are bulletproof.

On the other side of the glass is what Adora only assumes is the rest of the Alliance. Despite not being the leader, the woman Adora assumes is Glimmer based on her height is standing front and center with the rest of the group spread out behind her. Adora blinks in surprise at the *child* off to the side with her arms crossed – not that Glimmer looks like much of an adult either – as Scorpia claps her on the shoulder and encourages her forward.

The ages aren't the only surprise. The Alliance is bigger than she thought. Only five people have ever been seen in the field at one time for them, but given the differing builds spotted, it was estimated they had seven members. Three of them came to pick her up, but now another five are waiting for her. Entrapta keys them in through the door and Scorpia grabs the handle, all but flinging it open while grinning, one of her pincers on Adora's shoulder.

"Welcome to the Alliance, Adora! You're going to love it here. It's way better than the Horde," Scorpia assures her as she ushers her forward. Adora blushes for some reason, unused to being the center of such direct attention. Glimmer rolls her eyes, stepping forward and extending her hand.

"We're willing to give you a shot, but we'll keep an eye on you. I'm Glimmer. This is Frosta, Mermista, and Sea Hawk," Glimmer tells her, gesturing behind her to each of the members in turn as she introduces them. Adora is relieved to finally have not only faces, but also names. She worried this was going to be a codenames situation given how reluctant Glimmer was to talk to her yesterday, but she

also doesn't blame her for that. If this *were* the Horde that she had walked into, she would have been thrown in a cell as soon as she arrived.

"Hi. Um. Do I not get to know your name?" Adora asks, looking to the man directly behind Glimmer that she skipped over in introduction. Adora watches Glimmer's expression darken, surprising her as Glimmer turns to look at her with an intensity that has Adora immediately standing up straight. It isn't a Shadow Weaver-level of a threatening look, but it's close enough that Adora is at attention.

"This is Bow . Now look me in the eye, this is fucking important. He's mortal. We fuck around a lot here, but if you ever twitch a weapon in his direction or get reckless with his life, I'll make you wish you could die, you understand?" Glimmer threatens her , her tone dark and foreboding. Adora blinks, nodding quickly . She isn't sure why Glimmer is telling her – Adora wouldn't fuck around with anyone like that, immortal or no, and it tells her who is vulnerable if she had actual ill intent – but she can promise that easily.

"I came to you because I didn't want to hurt anyone else," she returns. Glimmer narrows her eyes at her, actually stretching up on her toes to glare at Adora a little closer from her unintimidating height, but after a long moment of Adora blinking at her and offering her a hopeful smile, Glimmer seems to be satisfied. She drops down on her heels, nodding and stepping back. Apparently that's some unspoken sign that she's in, because a moment later the rest of the group comes forward, greeting her warmly with handshakes and claps on the shoulder.

Adora is a bit overwhelmed by the sudden group around her, but she smiles to them all and returns the greetings. She really wasn't expecting a swarm of warm energy around her from these strangers who have no reason to trust her. She had no intentions of getting invested in these people when she came to find them, but if they can truly show her – and Catra – a life better than what they had in the Horde, Adora will follow them happily.

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Shadow Weaver isn't in her office. Catra texts her that she has an update and Shadow Weaver immediately responds to come to Hordak's sanctum. She is in a meeting with him, but apparently Adora is her top priority. Catra knocks lightly and is called to come in, taking up Adora's old position behind Shadow Weaver as the meeting continues around her. Catra may have been invited, but she isn't suicidal, so she isn't going to interrupt Hordak in the middle of one of his rants. Shadow Weaver sits through his rant until he runs out of steam and she can set to slowly diffusing him.

Catra feels her scruff prickle with anxiety, her fur beginning to bristle as she realizes that Hordak is looking straight at her, his eyes narrowing slowly as Shadow Weaver speaks. She swallows, continuing to look straight forward. She's more afraid of Shadow Weaver than she is of Hordak, but if she does a single thing that could reflect poorly on her mentor in front of their boss, the punishment won't be light. She really doesn't want to have to nurse wounds when Adora isn't around.

"Second, your squad," Hordak snaps suddenly, cutting off Shadow Weaver and startling them both. Apparently Hordak has moved on from his anger by focusing on something entirely different. Catra looks to him, feeling her ears twitch just a bit.

"We've exceeded all our benchmarks for the quarter despite setbacks," Catra returns, her chest buzzing with anxiety. Usually Adora does the reporting shit. Catra has seen her do it before, but never directly to Hordak. Adora rarely even meets with him. Catra is just her second, not quite a captain but still above a cadet. Hordak scoffs, frustrated, causing Catra's tail to twitch immediately. He shoots Shadow Weaver a displeased look.

"Yes, *setbacks*. The Alliance needs to be dismantled, but this plan was foolish even before it left our most profitable heist team without a captain," he admonishes. Catra's face twitches a bit as she realizes that Hordak is annoyed with Shadow Weaver, not her - though Shadow Weaver might take it out on her anyway. Catra keeps her back straight as Hordak turns back to look at her appraisingly.

"You've been second as long as Adora has led your team. And you are also Shadow Weaver's protégé. If she has any worth as a mentor, I expect you to be able to lead in Adora's place. We can't have the team out of commission for weeks. From now on, you are a full captain. I expect your team to return to work effective immediately," he orders. Catra swallows, dumbstruck for a moment before she does her best to smile graciously, though she knows the smile is a bit vindicative considering how Shadow Weaver is seething beside her.

"Yes, Boss. Right Away," Catra returns, bowing. Shadow Weaver may hate it, but she can't argue with a direct order from Hordak. Catra feels excitement spark in her heart. Shadow Weaver will still outrank her, but this gives her some actual authority within the Horde at last. If nothing else, it gives her something to do while Adora is away other than feel like a fucking prisoner. If Catra can be successful enough as captain, she may be able to improve their situation for herself.

Adora has certainly been trying for years and getting them nowhere. She feels her heart jump at the idea that she could finally do something *for* Adora. Adora has been the one taking care of her ever since they joined the Horde and Shadow Weaver became obsessed with her. Catra's heart hardens with resolve. She will do this. She will change things for them. She will prove herself to the Horde, and when Adora gets back, she may even be envious of what Catra has accomplished.

Catra straightens from her bow with her resolve set. By the time Adora is done with her job, Catra will have built something worth

coming back to.

Chapter End Notes

Entraptas overalls , thanks to metalesbo!
The next update will be in 2 days!

Truth Hurts

Chapter Notes

> I've added an additional blanket CW to the beginning of the fic for mentions of/allusions to torture. It's kinda included in the violence/blood CW, but given Events,™ I wanted to add it. Also, brief mentions of weed/drug use.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Alliance hosts a meeting in the living room after the greetings are done. They all ask questions about Adora and Catra's situation in the Horde, often looking to Scorpia after Adora gives her answers for confirmation that Adora's story matches up with her knowledge of the Horde. Scorpia responds with a pained nod every time. By the end of it, even Glimmer – who seems to have been determined to be a hard ass at first – is flinching when Adora speaks, her expression sympathetic.

"Listen, we're all criminals here - I mean, Mermista is older than this country, much less its laws - but we only take from people who have too much, and we try to give back to others. We're having fun and restoring a bit of balance while we do so. When Scorpia met Perfuma and told us what the Horde had done, we had to do something. That's why we're here now. We're targeting the Horde, stealing from them to cripple their operations where we can," Glimmer explains to her.

Adora likes the idea of that, honestly. She has free license to go against the Horde to maintain her cover, but the Alliance agrees that she shouldn't go on a job with them right away. It's a mix of them trying to figure out what can be done about Catra and her needing to establish trust first. She knows that she shouldn't trust these strangers so easily, but she does. It wouldn't matter if she did or not

– she knows that the Horde can't be trusted, and she is certain that these people are at least better than them.

Maybe with the Alliance, Adora can help the Fright Zone become safer. It will never be *safe*, but Adora has an entire immortal life stretching out in front of her and she can't keep funneling money into the Horde so they can hurt more people. If she can use her abilities to make things better for others, maybe she can find a purpose to outliving Catra. Adora is going to work for the Alliance and hopefully the Horde won't catch on. As long as Adora is willing to help them plan out heists, the Alliance seems willing to give her the benefit of the doubt.

They all live out of the penthouse, apparently. Glimmer agrees to give her a room to crash there too, but for now she's going to keep living out of her apartment and driving to that street corner to be picked up so she can be swept for bugs. Adora would point out that she could just tell the Horde anything she learned if she did have bad intentions, but considering that she doesn't want to do that, she is just grateful to have this excuse not to divulge the penthouse's location during her meetings with Catra.

Scorpia shows her to the room after a long conversation in which Adora carefully dodges admitting that this whole thing is supposed to be a true undercover situation while also insisting the Shadow Weaver definitely wants her to join the Alliance and purposefully showed her the reports that led her to Scorpia's location. Adora knows straddling the fence like this is risky, but if everything breaks bad with the Alliance and Shadow Weaver finds out, hopefully Adora can claim she had to admit it for the cover.

It's actually the same room they interrogated her in, just with the paint tarp removed. Adora is instructed to put together a box of things she would want if she regenerated there as Bow hauls in an air mattress for her. That immediately catches her attention. She already knows she'll be sneaking some of her and Catra's things into the box for safekeeping away from the Horde, but it also begs the

question of how regenerating *works*. Bow immediately calls Mermista to come answer the question instead.

"Nothing about immortality is straight forward, and given the small sample size, we can only make generalizations, but she's the one here with the most experience," he explains with a shrug. Mermista smirks a bit, leaning against the doorframe of the room as Adora and Bow work on inflating the air mattress.

"My first death was a witchhunt – literally. They burned me at the stake. I've had a long time to figure things out. Anyone who tries to tell you that there's hard rules to this is lying. All of immortality is the universe fudging details. We wake up wherever we're most comfortable being unconscious at that time. Usually that's your home, but if you have a partner, it's common to be tied to them instead," Mermista explains. Adora pauses, frowning down at the air mattress.

"Won't I always wake up in Catra's bed, then? That's where I've woken up every other time," she asks, looking up to Mermista. Bow and Mermista exchange side-long glances before Mermista shakes her head.

"Right now, probably. If that ever isn't your safest place to regenerate though, the universe picks the closest thing to your sense of home. You can influence it a bit with your own expectations too. If you go on a trip, you'll probably regenerate in the hotel because that's your temporary home. Chill in this room when you come over, get comfortable with it, and it will be a good backup for you," Mermista explains. Adora frowns, but she nods. That does explain why she didn't wake up in her own apartment last night at least, and it's more details than Shadow Weaver gave her.

Given Mermista's explanation though, Shadow Weaver might not have understood more details than "home" in her research. The Alliance in general is far more willing to give Adora information than Shadow Weaver was, though. She goes back to her apartment that night, packing a box of clothes, gear, and some personal effects, but

the Alliance promises to pick her up the next day so they can go over more. The next morning, she drives to the corner where Scorpia has met her twice now, and Scorpia makes a show of sweeping her car and things for bugs.

There aren't any. Adora is kind of shocked, but apparently Shadow Weaver was able to fight her own paranoia enough to know that it would be a dead giveaway. They continue onto the penthouse, where things seem more relaxed than they were yesterday. Maybe the fact that they weren't raided in the night helped them to believe Adora, or maybe being immortal just leads to people being more relaxed when they know nothing will kill them in the end. Adora certainly wouldn't have taken the risk of defecting before she found out.

Frosta is going head-to-head against Entrapta in a video game in the living room and neither of them even look up as Scorpia leads Adora inside. The entire Alliance – sans Bow, who is the only other person who doesn't live here full-time due to the risk of being a mortal associating with what is a self-proclaimed reckless group of immortals – are all gathered around the couches, though the meeting appears to be informal and perhaps accidental.

"You can't go guns blazing into Horde Territory, even if we send Adora in first. They'll shoot her and then Catra. We need to attack them so their grip on their territory weakens first," Glimmer argues. She and Mermista seem to be the de facto leaders of the group, democracy or not. Glimmer draws to a halt when she notices Adora hovering near the edge of the room.

She's supposed to have a date night with Catra once a week – the cover is that it's time for her and Catra that Shadow Weaver has allowed while Adora reorients herself, but it's also the only time Adora's even allowed in her presence – where she will report in. It's on Friday nights. They have the week to plan something, but unfortunately, Glimmer is right.

Adora isn't allowed to take Catra out of her apartment – for the cover, Shadow Weaver assured her even as she laid a possessive grip on Catra's shoulder – and if she did, she knows an alarm would instantly be raised. At best, they would manage to get into the car and begin a dangerous and potentially deadly car chase through the city. Adora sighs as Glimmer looks to her, clearly waiting for her opinion.

"Shadow W eaver wanted me to join you. We have some time before we have to worry about her confronting me about it. I don't want to put anyone at risk. If we undermine them first, it will be easier to escape. I think we should look into ways to sneak her in and out during the week,"Adora admits. She hates the idea of leaving Catra there, but they need to be smart about this.

Right now, the Horde doesn't know that she is genuinely trying to escape. They can use it to their advantage to plan something out. Glimmer nods, turning back to Mermista to gesture at Adora. Adora can already tell that Glimmer is a bull in an argument, hardheaded and certain that she is right, but right now she *is*. Mermista rolls her eyes, but she shrugs, apparently not bothered either way.

"W e can put Adora in the less visible roles in our heists for now, I'm just thinking about how precarious this position is for a mortal. Usually when it's a situation like this, you're dealing with two immortals,"Mermista replies. Adora feels her brow furrow at that. She starts forward, cautiously settling on an empty part of the sectional and looking to Mermista. She hates that she can feel hope mixing with her confused expression.

"How does someone end up immortal?"she asks, because she knows that Perfuma warned her that Catra was mortal, but Adora also has to hope. It's the only thing that can keep her sane when picturing living for eternity. She doesn't want to do that without Catra. To her surprise, the qestion elicits a reaction in everyone that can only be described as *awkward*. Several people cringe, Scorpia tries to sink down in her seat, and Glimmer's expression becomes strained as she qickly looks away .

"Yeah, no, tapping flower girl for this one. Hippie, do your *tact* thing," Mermista decides immediately, pointing to Perfuma. Perfuma sighs, but she nods almost reluctantly before standing to approach Adora. Adora feels anxiety build in her chest as Perfuma settles right beside her on the couch and reaches for both her hands, offering Adora a bit of a pitying smile. Adora is *not* comfortable with how close Perfuma is getting, glancing awkwardly down between their hands and Perfuma's serious expression.

"Mortals tend to be pessimistic, but the universe wants love to prevail. It selects people and saves them if they die before they've gotten the chance to share their love," she starts, ambiguously. Adora stares at her. That sounds like hippie nonsense alright, but a quick glance around the room finds expressions of agreement, though most look a little exasperated.

"Listen, she's wording it in an extremely *Perfuma* way, but all the evidence amounts to that. If you die before you get to lo-" Mermista starts, waving her hand dismissively as she talks, but she cuts off when Glimmer quickly grabs the closest thing to her – which turns out to be her phone – and chucks it directly at Mermista. Mermista makes an affronted noise, picking the phone back up from where it landed in her lap and throwing it right back at Glimmer, but Glimmer catches it before it can hit her in the face.

"Let Perfuma do it," Glimmer hisses to her. Adora's sense of unease is only building. She doesn't like whatever they're dancing around any more than she likes Perfuma's explanation. Perfuma sighs, leaning back from Adora to give her a bit of space. She even drops her hand to gesture towards Scorpia.

"I'm sure you've noticed how many couples there are amongst us," she points out. Adora nods a bit hesitantly. Frosta is the only single member of the Alliance, but considering she is trapped in a thirteen-year-old body for the rest of her life, Adora doesn't blame her. She got a raw deal when it came to dying too early. Perfuma's expression is pained as she looks back to Adora.

"Immortals are people with a special kind of love to give and special people to give it to – soulmates. Mortals can't understand how we experience love differently, and everyone's love looks different on the outside anyway, so it's not something someone else can know about you before you die for the first time," Perfuma explains. Adora stares at her for a long moment. That sounds *insane*, but so does magically waking back up in her bed after she dies. She swallows.

"Catra's my soulmate, then. She's immortal," she responds. Suddenly a lot of the instant trust she has had with these people just clicks and makes sense. She didn't believe Shadow Weaver when she tried to explain how this worked, but it doesn't feel like magic now that Perfuma says it like that. It just feels right. Of course her love for Catra can't be contained to a lifetime – how could it? Her heart falls and crashes through the floor at the pained expression pinching Perfuma's face in response.

"That's not possible. You only become immortal if you die before you get to be with your soulmate. If you've been together for years, she can't be your soulmate. That doesn't make your relationship any less important," Perfuma explains. She keeps going, assuring Adora that they always feel intensely in their relationships and repeating that it doesn't make Catra any less important, but Adora can't hear it for how her ears are roaring.

This can't *be*.

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Catra texts with Adora sporadically throughout the week. She knows Adora has to be busy with her cover, but Catra hates only hearing from her via text. Adora doesn't usually say what she's doing, though she mentions lounging around sometimes, which Catra takes as code for "safe and hanging out in my apartment." One evening they

even call, talking about jackshit but drinking in the sound of each other's voices.

Catra is desperate for her by Friday. When they called, she lied on her bed with her eyes closed, focusing on nothing but Adora's voice. She spends Friday morning unable to think about anything but Adora's impending visit. She's supposed to be working on a plan for a new heist – shockingly, Shadow Weaver suddenly doesn't give a shit about their team now that Catra is the one leading it and she has had to make her own list of targets in addition to planning out the jobs – but she's useless while she waits for Adora.

When there's a knock on the door, Catra bolts to answer it, throwing herself at Adora the moment she flings open the door. Adora startles, but she catches Catra instantly, hugging her back as a pathetic purr of relief begins in Catra's chest. Adora draws in a sharp breath, all but picking Catra up as she walks them both deeper into the apartment and holds Catra close.

"I missed you too," she whispers softly, pressing a kiss against the base of Catra's ear. Catra purrs, nuzzling against her neck and breathing in her scent. Her chest is aching at having Adora's comforting arms around her again. She has been sleeping curled up with their old blanket, but it can only do so much, and Catra is already afraid it's starting to smell more like her than Adora. She clings to Adora as she walks them over to the couch, sitting carefully so Catra ends up in her lap.

Catra purrs as Adora lifts one hand to pet through her mane. She knows they need to do their report, but this is more fucking important. After a minute of gathering herself and soaking in Adora's touch, she emerges from her neck, kissing her a bit too desperately for just five days apart. Adora kisses her back, but it is almost hesitantly, none of the same desperation contained within it. Catra's heart leaps into her throat and then falls through the floor.

She pulls back, intending to send Adora a questioning look, but she knows it must come out pleading. Adora looks pained back as she

signs back *listening* and then reaches down for her pocket, pulling out a phone and pointedly placing it on the coffee table. Catra glares at it. Great, so the Alliance replaced Adora's phone with their own bugged tech. Her tail lashes as she slumps down in Adora's lap.

It would be too suspicious for them to go into the other room to have a private conversation. If they want to avoid the Alliance suspecting Adora of being a double agent, then they need to be careful of how they do this report. Catra isn't comfortable with the idea of total strangers listening in on them making out, but at least this means they have an excuse to really make this into a date night, even if they're going to be dancing around the Horde *and* the Alliance for it.

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Adora doesn't know if her phone is actually hacked. She kind of believes that it isn't given everything she has experienced of the Alliance over the last few days, but she definitely wants Shadow Weaver to think that it is. It gives her an excuse not to share information about the Alliance - hopefully without causing too much suspicion - and buys them time. Adora texts Scorpia every morning to ask if she should come over, and most of them she replies affirmatively.

The Alliance hits the Horde the day before Adora's meeting with Catra and then again on the Monday after. Adora sits with Bow and watches him coordinate them remotely via earpieces. It gives her a feel for how their jobs play out, her only participation for the moment advising them on good locations to target during their planning meetings. Adora spends the week mostly hanging around the penthouse, slowly befriending the colorful group and trying to use them as a distraction from the knot forming in her chest over Catra.

Nearly two weeks to work through the news and she still doesn't know what she thinks. She loves Catra. She always has. She doesn't know if it really matters whether Catra is her soulmate or not. Angella lived for over two thousand years before she met hers. It's possible that Adora's match is just as far off and she should just accept the time that she has with Catra now. She certainly doesn't want to put distance between them, but the idea of outliving Catra is also terrifying.

She knows that Catra can feel how withdrawn she is when she arrives for their second date night the next week. Catra talks excitedly about taking over their old team and the jobs she is planning for them, but Adora can't get excited for her – all she can think about is how that money is going to go straight to the Horde, replacing what little the Alliance has managed to steal. Adora watches Catra talk about her heist plans for their team, casually mentioning that they'll be unstoppable once Adora comes back, and her heart just aches.

Catra catches onto her lack of enthusiasm. It sours her mood. There is raw ache sitting between her and Adora. Catra heaves an irritated sigh and walks away from the couch, returning quickly with a pen and paper. Adora swallows, watching anxiously as Catra suggests they watch a movie, her tone light but her body tense. She turns on the TV and then tucks into Adora's side to write messages to her that can't be picked up by the theoretical bug on Adora's phone. Fuck.

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Shadow Weaver was furious when Catra didn't get information out of Adora last week. Catra defended Adora, pointing out that she was bugged and couldn't say anything, but Shadow Weaver wasn't satisfied. Catra spent the weekend nursing a split cheek. Shadow Weaver called her a lot of things, but they all amounted to useless

and conniving, accusing her of helping Adora escape her. Catra was in tears when Shadow Weaver gripped her bleeding face and snarled at her, "Why would you help her leave you?"

Usually after a session like that, Catra crawls into Adora's arms and shakes, crying silently as Adora pets her, nurses her wounds, and whispers assurances to her. Instead, she has to go on a walk of shame through the headquarters, trembling slightly from the adrenaline and fear. She has gotten pitying glances from her team all week. Her fur covers her injury at a glance now, but she thought that Adora would notice it still.

Adora always cared when she was hurt before, but apparently she is too absorbed in her immortality to look at Catra closely now. Catra bought the paper pad yesterday, and now she is grateful for it but even more frustrated by the answers that Adora still won't give. The movie provides perfect cover for them to be quiet for anyone listening through Adora's phone, but Adora can't – or *won't* – answer most of her questions still.

She relays that the Alliance went on two jobs that she wasn't allowed to go on, but that they haven't trusted her enough to tell her anything except how things like regenerating work and that they want to cripple the Horde because of what happened with Scorpia. Catra writes back to ask what that was and Adora just responds *Shadow Weaver*. Catra cringes, but she nods, ducking her chin down to shy her cheek away from sight just on instinct. Finally, Adora notices. She knows that movement means that Catra is trying to hide the physical proof that she has failed Shadow Weaver.

Adora draws in a sharp breath, her expression pinching as she reaches up and carefully cups Catra's cheek. Catra hisses instinctively, which only causes Adora's expression to darken further as she exerts gentle pressure to encourage Catra to turn her head. Catra doesn't want to let her, but Adora turns her towards the light, ruffling her fur carefully and drawing in a sharp breath as she sees the marks hidden beneath it.

"Why?" she asks, her voice so strained it comes out a whisper. Catra snarls, pulling away as her frustration flares. She turns away to take a few deep breaths, flexing her claws into the air as she lets it work through her system. She doesn't turn back to face Adora. She can't take it.

"Why do you think? While you're *sorting yourself out*, I'm alone in there. Shadow Weaver's mad about how long you're taking," Catra grits back out. She barely manages to keep her tone from dipping into mocking as she refers to Adora's cover story. Adora is anticipated to be undercover for weeks or months actually, but she is supposed to be feeding information to them during that time.

Catra doesn't blame the Alliance for not trusting Adora with information yet, but so far Adora has given them nothing except confirming that she has met seven different members. According to the pad of paper, she doesn't even know their names – and the codenames they use are *ridiculous*. Who can take seriously a ringleader who goes by *Sparkles*? Adora doesn't even know where the base is. They have her drive to a meet up spot, sweep her for bugs, and then cover her head before bringing her to the headquarters.

Adora reaches out, placing a light hand on Catra's shoulder that she shrugs off, fear flaring in her heart. She already knows that Shadow Weaver won't be pleased with this report. Her face throbs with phantom pains at the thought of their meeting tomorrow. After a moment of hesitation, Adora places the hand on her shoulder again. Catra growls, but she doesn't shrug her off again. She doesn't have the energy to fight Adora – not ever, and especially not now.

Adora pulls her gently back into her arms, cradling Catra in her arms and pressing soft kisses into her mane and against her ears. Catra manages to keep her growl up for a few moments before she breaks down and resorts to purring, trying to soothe herself. Adora holds her through it, pen and paper forgotten in favor of a small moment of comfort.

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Adora is furious after her meeting with Catra. Catra didn't do anything wrong, just relaying what Adora told her. Adora doesn't know how Shadow Weaver expected more. Adora may be lying, but she thinks the average group wouldn't have trusted her with more by now. She writes a note to Shadow Weaver warning that if she pushes for too much, too fast then they'll suspect her even more than they already do and they'll get nothing from this. She has to hope it will be enough to spare Catra from another beating.

When she leaves that night, she kisses Catra's cheek featherlight, careful not to hurt her as she offers a silent apology. Her heart feels like it has been rung out knowing that these marks are her fault. If she told the truth – names, ages, the location of the base even – then Catra would be fine right now. She needs to get Catra out. She arrives at the penthouse on Saturday with a plan. She marches in with determination and immediately declares what she thinks their next target should be.

"I know the location of a vault away from headquarters where the Horde stores clean money. If we hit them there, it will shake them. The effects of that loss will start filtering down and they'll be spread thin trying to make it up. Then we hit a location far from Catra's apartment with a half team. It will draw attention away so the rest of us can bolt with her. After we have her, I'll give you fucking anything, so long as she's safe,"Adora pleads.

She knows she sounds desperate, but she *is*. The plan is risky and only half thought out. Adora expects resistance. Everyone in the room glances at each other before the attention slowly focuses in on Glimmer. She has been the most resistant to trusting Adora. Adora is surprised by the fire in her eyes as she slowly nods her approval.

Adora blows out a slow breath. Glimmer knows what it's like to love a mortal. She understands.

"If you think this is the best target, then we'll hit the vault. We'll get her out," she promises Adora. Adora won't breathe easy until Catra is in her arms again, but it won't be long now. She's coming for her. Explaining all the details of this afterwards is probably going to be volatile, but she doesn't care if Catra is upset as long as she's *safe*.

The Alliance gives her the weekend to plan the job. It isn't a complicated plan, but the biggest barrier is that they need a powerful cutting tool for the lock on the vault room. It takes two agonizing days for Bow to get one into the city. They need to do this as soon as possible. Every hour, every minute that they wait, Adora can't help but wonder if Catra is okay.

They text a bit over the weekend and Catra doesn't mention anything, but she's busy planning her own heist while Adora lays out the groundwork for hers. It feels kind of fated that they're finally ready to go on Monday night, the both of them pulling off jobs at the same time, even if it's on opposite sides of the city – and the fight. Catra just has to hang in for a little bit longer, and then Adora will be there for her.

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The letter Adora wrote works – for the weekend. Shadow Weaver narrows her eyes at it, but quite frankly, Adora is right and even their unhinged mentor seems to realize it. She dismisses Catra with an angry wave of her hand and Catra bolts gladly, returning to planning her heist for Monday night. She didn't take on the largest target on her list, but their team is down a man and she wants to feel out the new dynamic before doing anything too risky.

The heist goes off flawlessly. They don't even trip security. They walk calmly to the getaway car. Catra slaps Kyle's joint out of his hand when they reach it with a grin on her face and a giddy laugh in her chest. Kyle mostly smokes to give him an excuse to offer if security or police notice him loitering and ask what he is doing, but it also makes him a better getaway driver, steadying his nerves for car chases. There is no chase tonight, so Catra doesn't want to deal with how the scent burns her nose. Cheering fills the car when they've gotten far enough away to not draw attention.

The elated air is shattered when they get back to the headquarters. They are in the middle of taking inventory of their haul when Shadow Weaver does that *materializing* thing that she does. Catra feels the fur on her scruff begin to bristle. It tells her all she needs to know about who just appeared behind her. Catra turns slowly to find Shadow Weaver *seething*. Fear pours through Catra's veins as Shadow Weaver snatches a hand out to grab her. She drags her from the room without a word.

Catra has seen Shadow Weaver angry many times. She has never seen her like this. Catra trembles as she is dragged towards the soundproofed chambers in the heart of the base. If she weren't paralyzed by fear, she would pull on Shadow Weaver's grip and try to run, but she also knows that she wouldn't get far and it would only make the *encouragement* worse. Shadow Weaver practically throws her to the floor once inside, anger steaming off of her.

"The- the job went flawlessly," Catra starts to gasp – plead, really – but when she sits up to face Shadow Weaver, she finds her eyes cold and hard, unmoved by Catra's protests.

"The Alliance hit our external vault tonight. They brought a specialized cutting tool to get in - a tool that is necessary because of security that was added after Scorpia left," Shadow Weaver tells her, her tone low and dark as she looms over Catra. Catra feels her eyes grow wider as her heart pounds in her chest. Her mind races, searching desperately for an explanation that will satisfy Shadow Weaver.

"She- she had to give them something. They would suspect Adora if she knew about the job and she didn't warn them about the security. It's one vault. It will be made up when she comes back," Catra scrambles. It makes sense. There's no way for Adora to establish trust and get the information that Shadow Weaver wants without offering some in return. To Catra's horror, Shadow Weaver turns towards the table of tools in the corner of the room.

"Perhaps, but Adora received a gunshot wound during the heist, as did one of her accomplices. By the time that backup arrived, their bodies were gone, but neither of them walked out of the building afterwards. She has regenerated by now, but she hasn't appeared here or at either of your apartments. That just leaves the Alliance base. Her concept of home has shifted, and it doesn't include you anymore," Shadow W eaver sneers. Catra trembles in response, her heart hammering. That can't be true. Shadow Weaver must be wrong. Maybe she didn't die. Maybe she will still appear-

"She has abandoned you. She would be pleased by how much loyalty you show her, but it's misplaced. Look what she *left you to*," Shadow Weaver tells her, punctuating her words by picking up one of the implements and twirling it in her hand. "Adora doesn't love you - she can't," Shadow W eaver finishes with a sneer. Catra's heart clenches painfully. The certainty in Shadow Weaver's voice is terrifying. Catra swallows, looking up at Shadow Weaver as her breath comes labored and heavy.

"What do you mean?" she whispers, the question quiet and terrified. A manic light enters Shadow Weaver's eyes as she stalks forward, the heavy metal rod still in her hand.

"It' s time you learn why you're so worthless to her. Immortals are special, individuals chosen to have *soulmates*. They only regenerate if they didn't get to be with their soulmate before they die for the first time. But you've been together for years in secret, haven't you? You've been defiling her, and now that the Alliance has told her the truth, she has discarded you," Shadow W eaver tells her, words crooning with vindictive pleasure as all the air leaves Catra's lungs.

Ordinarily, she thinks Shadow Weaver would hit her now, but nothing she can do to Catra is as bad as those words. Catra feels tears well up, ugly sobs choking her throat without Shadow Weaver even having to touch her. She curls into herself, her chest pounding as her mind scrambles for *she's wrong, she has to be*. Shadow Weaver has to be wrong about how someone becomes immortal.

Adora has always cared for Catra like she was something precious. Adora would nurse her wounds and hold her gently. She would kiss her with passion and excitement. Sure, she never said she loved her, but it always felt inevitable that they would be together. Catra can't believe that it was all some fleeting connection. Adora cares about people, unlike Shadow Weaver. She has to be wrong, to be lying-

Shadow Weaver grabs her by her long mane, forcing her head up as Catra gasps out from the pain. Shadow Weaver's eyes are burning when she forces Catra to make eye contact with her again.

"Do you really think anyone less could care about *you*? Immortals are wells of love. Only someone with so much to give would waste a fraction of it on you," Shadow Weaver accuses her. Catra flinches, the words worse than the pain in her scalp. "You're nothing to her. You were something shiny that caught her attention for a while, like a crow collecting trash. And now that you couldn't hold her attention, you've lost her. You've lost *me* her," Shadow Weaver continues, her voice turning from sweet, to deadly, to enraged as she talks.

Catra can hardly breathe, trembling as she reaches up to scrabble uselessly at Shadow Weaver's grip on her hair. Shadow Weaver is too angry to even care about Catra's claws. Desperately, Catra slices at her own hair, severing it to drop back down to her knees and groaning with pain, but at least the knives stabbing into her head are gone. It can do nothing to ease the wounds to her heart as Shadow Weaver snarls and tosses the chunk of her mane aside.

"You've been less than useless to me, but I'll give you one chance to lure her back and redeem yourself. Fail me again and you will discover what happened to Scorpia's mothers," Shadow Weaver

threatens, and with that she turns away, leaving Catra alone in the cell. Catra can't even be bothered to panic about the fact that Shadow Weaver is locking her in here without food or water as the door seals shut behind her. She's too busy picking up the shattered remains of her heart and trembling in fear over what *lure her back* means.

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Okay, planning to hit a Horde stronghold with such a tight turnaround time was *dumb*, but they did it. Adora took a bullet to the shoulder and Perfuma got one in the thigh, but they managed to set the vault burning. The Alliance always carries poison pills on them during jobs, just in case, and they both took them once they knew that the job would be successful. Adora was both looking forward to waking up with Catra and dreading it in eqal measure.

She was worried about how she was going to justify this to Shadow Weaver considering how she has reacted so far. It turns out she didn't need to worry. She wakes up, to her own shock, back in the Alliance base. She breathes a sigh of relief, changing into her clothes there. The Alliance is ecstatic she has woken up there – Perfuma insists they need to have a *welcome home* party – but Adora has other concerns.

She retrieves her phone when she goes to store her gear and texts Catra to ask how her heist last night went. She gets the curt, one-word reply of *perfect*. Adora's heart drops. They're going to have a lot to talk about when Adora manages to get her out. She returns to the impromptu party, but she isn't really in the celebrating mood. The vault will hurt the Horde, but not for a few days, and in the meantime Catra is in the thick of it and at risk.

They barely text all week, which does nothing to ease Adora's nerves. She spends the week doing everything she can to plan out Catra's rescue just to distract herself. She has already decided to reveal there is a mastermind behind the scenes at their meet up this Friday. Hopefully Shadow Weaver will be appeased with that. If not, no matter how mad she'll be about the vault, Adora explaining they only told her about the job right beforehand and stressing that it shows they're starting to trust her might be enough to spin it positively.

She's hoping it will be enough to buy Catra another week. Adora knocks on Catra's door on Friday bouncing up and down on the balls of her feet. She's nervous, but lying via pen and paper is easier than doing it verbally, so she's fairly certain she can pull this off. Mostly she's worried about what Catra's state will be when she opens the door. Catra has been so curt with her, she can only imagine what Shadow Weaver has done.

The lock scrapes, causing Adora's heart to jump into her throat. When the door opens, it's a whirlwind a movement. Adora is catching Catra before she even fully registers her, grunting in surprise as Catra kisses her with the force of a hurricane. Catra's arms wrap around her shoulders, clutching to her as Catra pulls her back into the apartment. As much as kissing Catra makes her heart swell, the desperation in the embrace worries her.

As the door is kicked shut behind them, Adora pulls back to look down at Catra, her gaze as desperate as Catra's kiss. Catra whines softly, a pathetic sound that hits Adora in her heart like a knife to the chest. Catra doesn't open her eyes, turning her face away as if to hide it, but she can't hide her suddenly-short hair. It confirms Adora's suspicions that something has happened. The fear that Catra's mane became matted with blood and she was forced to cut it without Adora there to help her rises in her throat.

She reaches up, cupping Catra's cheek and turning her face back up to inspect it. Catra still doesn't open her eyes as Adora gently ruffles the fur on her cheeks. She isn't bruised and she doesn't appear to

have any new scabs or scars either, but she isn't okay. Her fur is rough, uncared for, and she has bags under her eyes in addition to the severing of her mane that was her pride and joy. She looks exhausted and sick, like she has been rung out over the last week. Her breath trembles as she leans into Adora's touch, swaying closer to her again. She still doesn't open her eyes. She doesn't seem able to.

"Please, Adora. It was a bad week. Just- just show me. Come to bed and show me," Catra whispers. The words break her heart as surely as the rough rasp of Catra's voice does. Catra doesn't need to finish the sentence – they both know she means *show me someone cares*. Adora nods, determination setting her features as she leans down and kisses Catra as softly and delicately as she can. Catra trembles in her arms, her claws barely holding back from digging in as she clutches to Adora's shoulders.

Despite Adora's attempts to be gentle, Catra kisses her just as desperately as she did the first time. She tugs on Adora, leading her in a stumbling path through the apartment as they make their way towards the bed. Catra has to be feeling like shit to be as clumsy as she is as she pulls Adora through the apartment. Halfway to the bed, Catra stumbles and turns, her back thudding against the wall to catch herself.

Adora tries to pull back from the kiss, terrified of what is wrong with her, but Catra clutches on, holding Adora tightly against her with seemingly all the strength she has left. Her entire body feels *weak*. Panic spikes in Adora's chest as she puts the signs together and realizes Catra probably spent the last week in the cells. Her heart thudding in her throat, she forces herself back from the kiss. She needs to ask what happened-

"Now ," Catra gasps out, her face screwed up and tone desperate. It isn't a shout, it can't be when she is like this, but it's still an exclamation – one that Adora doesn't understand until the bathroom door, only a few feet from them, bursts open. Adora startles, but Catra hangs onto her and holds her in place as Rogelio and Lonnie

come out of the bathroom. Adora stares in shock, trying to pull away without hurting Catra, but her claws dig in and then it's too late. Rogelio and Lonnie are on her.

They yank her arms behind her back and cuff her wrists together. Adora tries to fight them, but Rogelio has always been stronger than her. When it's two against one with the element of surprise, she loses the struggle before she can even ask what they're doing. Her hands and ankles are bound as she is forced to kneel. Adora looks up, panting for breath, to find Catra still leaned back against the wall, seeming to need the support to stay standing from the way she is quivering. She has tears in her eyes.

"Shadow Weaver wants you brought home," she whispers. She sounds *wrecked*. Adora swallows, staring up at her best friend, girlfriend, maybe even lover once upon a time.

"Catra, don't do this," she begs. She doesn't know what else to say. She's trying to save them. She's *close* to it even. Catra shakes her head, looking up to make eye contact with Lonnie, and then gestures with her hand. Adora's heart pounds as she is yanked to her feet and dragged back to the Horde.

Chapter End Notes

> *That's right motherfuckers it's been a soulmate AU this entire time.* More details will come out over time on how they ended up here, but immortality and "soulmates" in this AU are actually a metaphor for the inherently different way queer people experience love and the world. I'm going to go off about it in the fic notes at the end of the fic probably.

Death of a Bachelor

Chapter Notes

We're not even halfway through the outline y'all. Buckle up.

Catra does what little she can to make Adora's trip comfortable. Shadow Weaver got them one of the Horde's modified vans for moving Adora. It's a commercial van with no windows in the back, intended for transporting things, but it has hard benches running along each wall. Catra takes their old blanket from their bunk and folds it in the seat as Lonnie and Rogelio hurry Adora down to the waiting van as soon as enough darkness has fallen to use as cover.

Catra shakily straps Adora in and tucks the blanket around her lap. Lonnie and Rogelio sit on the opposite bench from them, near the front of the van. Catra doesn't know if they sat so far away to give them privacy, or if they just couldn't stand to be close to her. She told the team that the kidnapping was part of the cover. She had to. She told them that Adora was actually being brought back to report in and then stage a release to build trust with the Alliance, but given that Catra just spent four days in the cells, she knows they didn't believe her.

Lonnie and Rogelio are visibly rattled. They didn't have any more choice than she did in following Shadow Weaver's orders, but she was hoping that this lie would make it easier for them to justify it to themselves. In the back corner, Catra sits beside Adora, curling into her side and nuzzling into her shoulder. She was afraid Adora would pull away from her, but after Rogelio added a gag onto her binds, she almost seemed to resign herself to what was happening. It was too late at that point, after all.

"It was always supposed to be us, Adora," Catra whispers, her voice low and rough. She was only let out this morning and her throat still hasn't recovered. She's so thirsty no matter how much water she

drinks. She doesn't know what she's doing. It's too late to talk Adora into not abandoning her. It's too late for them. It has been since the moment Shadow Weaver spotted a passionate little girl on the street and decided to take her in despite the stray attached to her.

She doesn't lift her head from Adora's shoulder as Adora draws in a sharp breath in response. She doesn't say anything, but it isn't like she can with the gag. Catra's heart races despite how weak it is as Adora pulls out of the parking lot. She has spent four days in confinement, going over every moment and searching for any explanation other than Adora defecting, but she can't find one.

Shadow Weaver would come in to bring water. She would taunt Catra and force her to agree that Adora had left her or she wouldn't get to drink at all. What little she did get wasn't enough. Shadow Weaver boasted about how she has studied immortals for decades. She is the most knowledgeable mortal in the world on them, and she recognized Adora's boundless love the moment she saw it, but she never understood why she chose to focus it on such a *mangy target*.

"Immortals needs bonds, though. You satisfied her needs until she found others like her. Now she knows she has a soulmate, she has no need for you. She only pretended for as long as she did so she could operate with impunity. She was *using* you," Shadow Weaver sneered at her on the third day. Catra was crying, only deepening her need for water. Catra refused to believe her at first, but that just got the water withheld.

She knows it is actually true. Adora has been lying to her since her very first meeting with the Alliance. There's no other explanation for why. She'll bring Adora back and then it won't matter whether Adora loves her or not. Adora will be with the Horde and Catra can have her again. The thought rings hollow in her chest despite how it was the only way she could comfort herself when Shadow Weaver ordered her to capture Adora and bring her back to base, being careful not to kill her or let her hurt herself.

Shadow Weaver is certain that she wouldn't regenerate with Catra anymore. Immortals regenerate at wherever they call home. That isn't the Horde anymore. It isn't Catra. It's a shitty air mattress with the Alliance. Catra sits next to Adora, leaning into her side as the van starts on its journey to the headquarters.

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They stripped her of her phone and poison pills before they finished tying her up. Adora has nothing but her bindings as Rogelio and Lonnie haul her to her feet again and drag her through the halls to the interrogation rooms. Catra walks in front of them, her steps slow and shoulders slumped with defeat them as she leads them on the familiar path to the cells where Catra has been too many times.

Adora's heart is shattered. She is as despondent as Catra as she is brought into the chamber and shackled with her elbows bent painfully around a metal bar behind her, her ankles bound to her wrists so she is forced to balance on her knees. The only mercy is that her metal cuffs aren't too tight, but they aren't loose enough for her to have any hope of working herself out of them. Her only options for escape are death or a key.

Catra doesn't leave with Rogelio and Lonnie, kneeling in front of Adora and reaching out to cup her cheek. Adora's heart is pounding as she looks up at the pained expression on Catra's face. Catra can't seem to take the hurt in Adora's eyes, drawing her hand back like she has been burned and then turning quickly away. She wraps her arms around herself, her previously-lifeless tail flicking with nerves as she clutches herself in the center of the room for a long moment.

"Shadow Weaver will be in soon. She already knows you defected, Adora. Just tell her everything she wants to hear. That's what you always told me to do," Catra whispers, her voice quiet. If there were

any shards left of Adora's heart, they would crumble at the words. It's true – that is what Adora told Catra to do whenever her insolence would earn her punishment as kids. Adora never understood why Catra would continue to disobey. Catra never understood why it would be worthy of the retribution she received.

Catra was right. She always was. Shadow Weaver is a cruel woman. She's the one that drove them to this point. Adora doesn't know what she did that tipped Shadow Weaver off, but she must be certain of Adora's wavering loyalty for it to have come to this. Adora has never been in this room before – at least, not to be shackled herself. Catra walks away, the door thudding shut behind her, and Adora drops her head, going mostly limp except for the tension forced in her body by her weight balancing on her knees

It hurts, but it's the least of her concerns. Her priority has to be finding a way to kill herself and regenerate back at the penthouse. Finding a way to explain to Catra that she wasn't abandoning her has to come later. Adora can't believe she would do this, but given that Shadow Weaver apparently *already knows she has defected* and Catra's overall state, Adora can guess that she has been tortured.

Adora is still wracking her brain for a plan when Shadow Weaver pushes open the room's heavy door after a few minutes of silence at most. Adora doesn't look up at her, partially because it's difficult in this position and partially because she doesn't want to. They were so close to finally being free. Adora closes her eyes, her face screwing up when Shadow Weaver crosses the room, grabbing the gag and yanking it down. They were *so close*.

"Y ou failed me, Adora,"Shadow W eaver says, her tone cold and collected. Adora doesn't acknowledge her. She didn't fail anyone. Shadow Weaver failed her first by being a *monster*. Without her, Adora could be happily holding Catra right now, totally unaware she had some stupid, fated soulmate out there. The two of them could be happy. Catra would at least be safe.

"I'll give you one chance to tell me what you learned about the Alliance. If I'm satisfied, then you and Catra can share a cell. I'll even give you both enough food and water while we work on reforming you," Shadow Weaver tells her. Adora swallows, fighting the urge that says *protect, protect, protect*. She can't. She can't endanger the Alliance for another one of Shadow Weaver's lies. If Adora manages to kill herself soon, Shadow Weaver won't have a reason to keep hurting Catra anyway.

Catra did everything that Shadow Weaver asked. It isn't the same as it was with Scorpia's moms, where they were traitors too. It can't be. Adora doesn't have any way to get Catra out of here. She'll be punished if Adora escapes, but hopefully not too badly. Adora can work on formulating a new plan to kidnap Catra – for real, this time – once they get out of this mess.

Shadow Weaver isn't happy with her silence. She hisses with anger, reaching down and grabbing Adora by the front of her jacket, yanking her painfully up to look her in the face. Adora's eyes fly open, fear beating in her chest as she meets Shadow Weaver's enraged gaze. Adora has never seen her out of control like this. The realization that there is an even crueler beast inside this woman that she has been caging sends a cold flood of dread through Adora.

"You useless, ungrateful girl. I spent years training you and this is how you repay me?" she demands, shaking Adora as she sneers in her face. Adora flinches back, but the words galvanize her. She draws her head back and brings it forward as hard as she can, headbutting Shadow Weaver. She cries out as Adora gasps, having been able to prepare for the pain herself but still sent reeling by it. She pulled no punches – if she got a concussion, all the better for her.

"You sent me to the fucking *slaughter* with no guarantee that I was anything but human. I don't owe my murderer anything," Adora gasps out once the pain of the headbutt and landing back on her knees subsides enough for her to speak. Shadow Weaver snarls. The sound is nothing like Catra's snarl. Catra's is kind of *cute*, even

when it indicates true anger. This sound is dark, coming from a deeply angry place. Shadow Weaver stands, still clutching her head with one hand.

Adora watches the movement in her periphery. Shadow Weaver shudders for a few moments, no doubt suppressing any sound that would indicate she is in pain – it would mean admitting that Adora got the upper hand for a moment – before she straightens, rolling her shoulders and looking down at Adora. She is probably trying to look intimidating, but Adora can't see her face at this angle and she isn't tilting her pounding head up to meet her gaze.

"Is that why you left, Adora? Did they poison your mind with lies? I knew that only an immortal could love like you do. No one else could find room in their heart for that *stray*," Shadow Weaver croons to her, her voice dripping with disdain when she refers to Catra. Adora's heart feels like it has been pierced hearing Catra referred to that way, but the Alliance aren't the ones who have tried to poison her mind. Immortals are beings of love, but there isn't anything supernatural about the way they love. Adora's love for Catra couldn't have tipped Shadow Weaver off that she was immortal.

"Catra isn't my soulmate. The way I behaved with her was the way a mortal would. You knew *nothing*," Adora grunts back, despite how the words pain her. Shadow Weaver is silent for a long moment before she turns away, folding her hands in front of her.

"Yes, a disappointment, that. I spent so long keeping you apart so I could arrange your death at an age where you would be useful, and it turns out it was just you all along," Shadow Weaver says, her voice casually cruel as she walks to the table in the corner of the room and leans over it, gripping its sides so she can pull it back towards Adora. The scraping of it dragging closer fills the room as Adora's blood turns cold. She doesn't know if it's from the words or just fear of what comes next.

"I suppose it makes it easier to control you now, though. I gave you permission to be together so the bond would be fulfilled and she

would become mortal, but it was unnecessary. She was always worthless,"Shadow W eaver muses, casual as she admits to trying to *murder* Catra in the long run by locking her into mortality.

Adora shudders, and this time it has nothing to do with the prying instrument that Shadow Weaver is holding. Shadow Weaver turns to her, the tool still in her hand as she approaches Adora and grips her chin, forcing her head up to look her in her cold eyes. Adora can't believe this is the woman who taught her how to swim. In front of her is a heartless monster, someone who doesn't have care for even the youngest life.

"Her mortality makes her *fragile*. Let's see if I can't encourage you to talk myself. If not, we can always bring her in instead. Tell me, is your soulmate so important to you that you would still let Catra die?" Shadow Weaver asks her. Adora swallows. She doesn't care about some potential soulmate out there. She cares about Catra, but she also cares about the Alliance.

She bites down on her tongue and says nothing.

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Catra curls up in a small ball on their old bunk. She shivers as she waits. She didn't think to bring the blanket from the van, but her shivering isn't from cold. She keeps swearing she can hear Adora's distant and echoing screams, but that isn't possible, not even with her enhanced senses. The Horde has one interrogation room and another with small cells, barely enough room in them to lay down. Both rooms are soundproofed. Catra would only be able to hear anything if she were standing right outside.

The bunkroom is far, but that doesn't stop the screams in her head. She can't fucking take it. She never wanted Adora hurt, just *home*.

She wanted the two of them together. She didn't want to be left behind. She wanted the emotional torture to stop. By the time Friday arrived, she would have agreed to do just about anything if it meant being let out and finally given food and enough water.

What she agreed to was this: the woman she loves in unknown agony. A small, bitter part of her mind shoots back that *she doesn't love you*, but what difference does that make to the feelings in her own chest? She lies curled up in the bed and aching until lights out hits. Under the cover of darkness, she cries silently in their small bunk. Her body can't take it with the dehydration still racking her.

She thinks she passes out, but when she comes back to herself, it's still during the six-hour window where the lights are automatically shut off in the bunkroom. She forces herself out of the bed. She feels like a ghost as she silently slips from the room and pads down the halls, following the echoing screams. They don't grow louder, confirming her suspicion that they are just in her head. Catra halts a hall away from the interrogation room, listening intently.

The air is still except for the slight shift of the guard outside, likely the same lizardfolk who was there earlier in the day . Catra's entire body aches thinking of Adora being subjected to even a few hours of what she went through for the last four days. Part of her says that Adora can't have been through that – it was emotional torture on top of the deprivation, and apparently Adora doesn't *care* about her – but the rest of her just feels broken.

No wonder Adora doesn't love her when she is capable of doing things like this to her. She trembles in the hallway, feeling small and insignificant and *worthless*. Shadow Weaver isn't in there anymore. Catra can smell the lingering traces of her scent mixed with blood from when she left, and this close she would be able to hear Adora screaming for real. Now she has confirmed that the torture has stopped, Catra hears nothing except the guard giving a light cough.

She *feels* nothing except pain and aching. She has tears on her cheeks. She reaches up to wipe them away. She wants to sniffle, but

it would alert the guard to her presence, and she definitely isn't supposed to be here. Shadow Weaver said she would be freed if she brought Adora to her, but Catra also knows that she won't want Catra near her. Catra needs to see her though – she needs to see what Shadow Weaver did to her friend. Adora might not care, but Catra can't stop now.

She's weak, but she can tread silently around the corner. The guard is sitting in his chair, seemingly fucking around on his phone to kill the time. He's a lizardfolk, but small for his species, and Catra has been training alongside Rogelio long enough to know their weak spots. She digs her toe claws in and rushes forward, sprinting down the hall as the guard startles up, lagging at the late hour. Catra leaps at him, smashing his head back into the floor as he hits it. The only sound is the rush of movement and the groan he gives.

Catra definitely passes out this time. She thinks it is brief, but one moment she's knocking the guard unconscious and the next she's struggling up from the floor beside him. She's so *weak*. She didn't come this far to fall asleep on the floor and earn more torture for disobedience once discovered, though. She struggles up onto her hands and knees, her entire body screaming with protest. She stumbles dangerously when she pushes up to her feet again, but she catches herself on the wall.

She leans against it as she fumbles with the door lock. It's a simple bar, intended for keeping people in and not out. Catra barely has enough strength left to lift it and force the door open. The moment it swings open, the scent of blood, salt, and sweat hits her nose. She almost vomits. Instead, she forces herself to push off the wall and step through the doorway. The scent warned her what to expect, but she still isn't ready for it.

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Adora is mostly unconscious when the door scrapes open again. She doesn't know how long it has been, but some of her wounds are still dripping. She has been slipping in and out for awhile now. Realistically, she knows Shadow Weaver didn't actually hurt her that badly. She's bleeding, but nothing is missing. She's pretty sure that Shadow Weaver knew she wouldn't get information from Adora this way and was just beating her to satiate her anger. She vowed to be back tomorrow with Catra when she left.

Adora has never cared about herself and she thinks that Shadow Weaver knew that from the moment that she spotted the two of them in a back alley. Catra though – Adora would die for Catra. It can't be tomorrow already. Every inch of her body hurts and she still hasn't figured out what she is going to do when Catra is the one being tortured. She has already started to rationalize in her head that Bow doesn't live in the headquarters full-time. If she gives up their location, maybe he will be out somewhere safe. The others can all respawn elsewhere and regroup.

The sharp intake of breath in the doorway tells Adora that Catra is here. Her heart was already beaten and crushed on the concrete floor, but it descends a few more floors to the sewers below. She whimpers involuntarily, too exhausted and pained to look up. She hears the quiet pad of Catra's feet as she walks forward on her own. Adora wants to yell, to tell her to bolt before Shadow Weaver locks them both in, but the best she manages is screwing up her eyes and releasing a pained grunt.

She thinks her ribs are bruised. Maybe broken. Speaking is too painful. She opens her eyes to find Catra's feet in her line of sight. Catra kneels down, practically falling to the floor in front of Adora. She's still too weak to regulate her descent. She probably couldn't run if Adora had even managed to call out. It doesn't comfort her as Catra reaches up and cups Adora's cheeks with both hands. Her touch is gentle and soft, the same way Adora always cradled her when she took a beating. Adora leans into it. She can't fight the moment of connection before it all goes to shit.

"Why , Adora? Why wouldn't you stay?" Catra asks, her voice small and broken. Fresh tears start down Adora's cheeks. She shakes her head slightly, but her ribs aren't the only thing that's bruised and she can't speak, not between the pain in her chest, throat, and mouth. She bit her own tongue more than once during the whole thing, but the rest is all thanks to Shadow Weaver. Catra sniffles slightly, beginning to cry properly now.

"It could have been us," she whispers.

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"We could have worked our way up until we were the bosses. That's what you said you always wanted. I did everything to make it happen," Catra continues when Adora doesn't speak. Adora is awake, but she doesn't seem capable of speech. That's fine – well, it's not, nothing ever could be after seeing Adora like this – but Catra isn't expecting an answer. She doesn't know what she did to be born hated, but it has always been the case.

She could do everything right, excel at any challenge they put before her, but it still won't be enough. She sobs a little as she shifts to hug Adora. Adora groans a little with pain, but Catra can't pull away. She needs this. The pain will all be over soon. She knew what she needed to do from the second she brought Adora to this room, really. It's clear that she has truly defected, and she isn't going to answer any of Catra's questions.

Catra clutches to her for a long moment, burying her face in Adora's shoulder. She can't even get a true moment of comforting herself with Adora's scent. There's too much blood in the air and salt from her tears, churning Catra's gut and making her feel sick. She still can't force herself to pull back and do what needs to be done. Catra

just clings to her, burying her face against Adora and listening to the beating of her heart, steady despite everything.

It's the last moment before everything Catra has been clawing for her entire life ends, and she clutches to it cruelly, despite how she can smell the pain on Adora's scent and knows the embrace is hurting her. Adora says nothing. Catra knows she probably just can't, but she still gets the sense from her that she knows that Catra needs this and is giving it to her. Adora always gave so much of herself away. It turns out the result of that is that there is nothing left for either of them anymore.

Catra doesn't know that she could force herself to let go if she didn't hear the distant echoing of heavy footsteps. The new guard is on his way. From the weight of the steps, it's probably Grizzor . Catra cringes, forcing herself to pull back and reach for her pocket with shaking hands. She doesn't have a fucking chance against Grizzor in her current state. She needs to do this quick. Luckily , she still has the poison pills she took off Adora in her apartment.

She left the phone behind so it couldn't be tracked back to the headquarters, but part of her knew that she would need these. She watches Adora's eyes go wide as Catra struggles to uncap the bottle and then shakes one out. Catra just has to hope these are the same pills that Adora told her about the Alliance carrying on them during their meeting last week. Her hand is unsteady as she raises it up to Adora's lips. Adora watches her with a pleading look as Catra presses the pill in between them.

"Go *home*, Adora," Catra whispers to her , dropping her hand to Adora's chin and shoving it up with all the strength she has so left Adora bites down on the pill. Tears sting at Adora's eyes as the pill audibly cracks open in her mouth. Catra doesn't know if it's from relief or fear, but considering that she keeps her mouth shut and swallows, she can guess that she was pleading with Catra to do it. Catra's hands are shaking terribly – she drops the bottle as Adora's eyes fall closed.

Catra hugs her again. She doesn't smell pain from Adora this time. She's too far gone, apparently. Catra buries her face in Adora's hair as she feels her breaths go shallow and then stop beneath her. She still doesn't let go as she hears a shout in the hallway, and then sustained yelling. It doesn't matter – Catra isn't listening to it. She clings to Adora's body even as someone comes charging into the room.

It's okay. Catra wasn't expecting to make it out of this anyway. She doesn't care. They can do anything to her now Adora is gone. Adora is safe. Catra goes limp with relief as she is hauled to her feet. She doesn't want to be pulled away from Adora, but she also doesn't want to keep holding her dead body either. The sudden movement causes her to lose conscious again, black flooding her vision and noise around her fading out like static as a piercing whine replaces all sound.

The next thing she knows, she is being dropped to the floor, pain awakening her. Her eyes fly open to find she isn't even in the interrogation room anymore. She knows the ceiling above her well. Shadow Weaver is seething, probably yelling at whoever brought Catra into her office, or maybe at Catra herself. All Catra hears is that whine, like a heartrate monitor flatlining. She stares up at the ceiling, dazed and exhausted. She wants to pass out again. That was peaceful.

She gets her wish when Shadow Weaver descends on her, searing pain blooming in her stomach as Shadow Weaver's hidden knife drives into her gut and drags up in a long line. She hoped death would feel more peaceful, but she's pretty sure she screams, even if it just sounds like static. As she bleeds out, blackness crowds around her vision. Catra is far too numb to care. Nothing has mattered since she finally realized that Adora doesn't love her .

At least Adora is safe. Catra got her out. She clings to that as she fades into blackness.

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Adora wakes up with a shout. She bolts upright on her mattress, flailing to reach for Catra, for anything, but there's nothing there. She's back in the penthouse, dawn light spilling through the window and calm in the air. Adora's heart pounds in her chest as her mind catches up with her body, healed and whole again.

Adora hunches forward, wrapping her arms around her knees and clutching them tightly as she hears feet pounding down the hall. Scorpia is the first one to find her, a stream of *we were so worried*, *what happened, are you alright?* spilling forth from her . The rest of the Alliance isn't far behind her. Adora finds herself surrounded qickly , the qestions dying of f as they seem to realiz how broken she is.

They settle on just wrapping around her in a loose hug. In the center of the pile, Adora shakes. Catra saved her. Even after everything, Catra set her free. Adora cries as Scorpia envelopes her in her strong arms, cradling her and shushing her gently. Adora knows it is meant to be soothing, but she can't be qiet.

She doesn't know how long she shivers and gasps in the embrace. If she felt broken in that locked room, she feels worse now. Eventually, she runs out of tears and her throat goes raw. Someone brings her water and she drinks it eagerly. Her body was regenerated from the hours of pain and dehydration, but the tears have wracked her again.

Her hands shake, clumsily guiding the glass as Perfuma holds it to her lips for her. When she can't drink anymore, she goes slack in Scorpia's arms, staring blankly at the concerned faces around her. She opens her mouth, intending to speak, but all that comes out is labored breathing. She can't. She is out of tears, but she begins to cry again.

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Catra wakes up. *She wakes up*. Not in a hospital bed, or in some dreamy golden heaven, or even the fires of hell. She wakes in the dim and musty back of the converted van, all the weakness suddenly gone from her body. She knew she felt like shit, but she feels superhuman in comparison now with the sudden absence of pain, exhaustion, and dehydration. Catra swallows, forcing herself upright and blinking down at the ground beneath her.

She's curled on the bench, her fingers wrapped tightly around her and Adora's old blanket. Catra stares at it for a long moment before she forces herself to look down at herself. There is a hole in the stomach of her shirt, the tearing slit from the knife almost identical to how Shadow Weaver killed Adora weeks ago now. Catra swallows, lifting a hand to push her shirt up and ruffle her fur. She already knows there will be no marks beneath it. She stares down at herself, her heartbeat echoing loudly off the metal walls of the van.

Her weakness is gone, but she feels a bit faint from the emotions threatening to crush her. She sinks back down onto the blanket, kneading it absently to make a proper bed to curl up on. If what she thinks just happened did, she has no one that loves her and no bed that feels like her own. This blanket and the memories associated with it are the closest thing she has to a home. She buries her face in it, breathing in the mix of her and Adora's scents. She doesn't know what is happening.

She should be planning how to sneak out, but she did her scheming already. She's too numb to think, much less feel. She wasn't expecting to wake up. She has always clung on stubbornly despite what life threw at her, but the emotional terror of the last week has drained her as surely as the dehydration did. The van was parked in the headquarters' garage when she left it and will be difficult to escape from, anyway. She isn't in any state to think through her options right now.

She is curled up there, numb and only half-aware, when the driver's side door opens and she startles, falling off the bench in her panic. Her only thoughts are *this can't be happening*, *it can't be restarting already*. She is halfway into a panic attack when a mop of blonde hair appears in the small window into the back seat, he's expression as shocked as hers is afraid. For a long moment, they just stare at each other.

And then he's head disappears and the car starts. Catra's heart pounds as the van pulls away from its parking spot. No alarm goes up. She scrambles back over to the bench, snatching up the blanket and curling around it. She looks like an idiot kid with a special blankie, but the memories of Adora are all she fucking has. She doesn't know what he is doing or where they're going. She's too scared of being spotted to get up and look through the window.

After what feels like an eternity of driving, the van pulls to a stop and shuts off. Catra swallows as she hears the driver's door open and then slam shut. He is light enough that the asphalt hardly rustles beneath his boots as he walks around and opens the back of the truck. Catra shrinks back from the light flooding in, wincing as she squints to make out the world outside the truck. The scent of the city, exhaust, and hot asphalt makes its way into the truck, causing Catra's nose to scrunch up.

It takes a few moments for he's expression to come into focus as more than a silhouette against the light, pinched and nervous as he offers Catra a small smile and then steps aside, as if to make room for her to pass him. Catra swallows, edging towards the end of the bench, and pokes her head out the car doors. She is greeted by an empty parking lot, a rundown strip of stores on the other end of it. Her ears twitch, swiveling to listen to the sounds of the road that he has parked facing. She turns to look at him, confusion and hope clutching at her chest. He shrugs a bit sheepishly.

"I was taking it to go get cleaned between jobs. We're at Bruce Street and Thirty-Seventh. Outside of Horde territory," he tells her. Catra's heart flutters impossibly in her chest, feelings of warmth she

forgot were possible causing her breath to catch as she cautiously slips off the bench and climbs out of the back of the van. He closes the van doors behind her as Catra hugs the blanket close, shivering a little in the breeze ruffling her fur despite how it is warm outside.

It's just too *real*, another detail added on with the scent of gas, rough gravel beneath her feet, and bright shine of the sun, all working together to prove to her this isn't some manufactured afterlife. She actually regenerated the same way Adora does. She was emotionally numb when she woke up, but in the bright daylight of freedom, she begins to breathe again. She turns back to He to find him already walking back to the front of the van.

"Wait," she rasps, her voice uneven. He hesitates, turning back to look at her. He is nervous, shifting where he stands and sending glances around the parking lot. That's fair considering he is letting her walk. This will have terrible consequences if anyone ever finds out. He sighs, sending her a pitying look.

"Shadow Weaver thinks you're dead. She had you hauled from her office and thrown down the body chute. I wasn't expecting you to be in there when I came to collect the van. Just- go somewhere far. Uh, meet me on Sunday night at the meet-up spot for the Palatial job. I'll see if I can salvage some of your stuff. I'll bring your bike, at least. I can tell Shadow Weaver that Lonnie wants it," he tells her. Catra's heart pounds as she nods, feeling a little breathless.

"Thank you," she breathes to him. He actually brightens, smiling back at her hopefully. His smile spreads to a grin as he nods and bounces on his feet a little.

"We're a team. We'll have your back. Good luck," he tells her. Catra's heart doesn't stop pounding as He climbs back into the van. She steps aside, getting out of the way of the van so he can back up and keep up with his schedule. Her chest flutters as she waves goodbye to him, her hand not dropping to her side until He has pulled out of the parking lot. Within the space of a minute, she is alone in the city and dead to the Horde.

Maybe dead to everyone. Adora doesn't care, leaving her behind in favor of her new shiny immortals. Catra feels dead inside, so count herself on the list too. Maybe not to Kyle, but she doesn't know that he really counts. She just stands there, breathing in the city air, polluted but fresh, and feeling the warmth of the sun in her fur. She doesn't have a direction or any idea of what she is going to do expect for where she has to be in a day and a half.

She can't imagine walking back into the death trap of the Horde and giving Shadow Weaver the information that she and Adora both apparently have some unknown soulmates that aren't each other. She has lived on the streets before. She can do it again for another day. Adora swore they would never steal another meal when Shadow Weaver took them in, but it turns out a lot of Adora's promises were bullshit. Catra's too numb to figure out any purpose but survival for now. That's a problem for Sunday night.

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"Can you tell us what happened?" Perfuma asks, her voice gentle. Adora blinks, but she isn't seeing much except for outlines. Slowly, she nods an affirmation before dropping her head back onto Scorpia's shoulder. She just regenerated. She should have all her energy back, but the emotional toll of the last twenty-four hours can't be taken away by her wounds healing.

No one saw, Adora tells herself. Catra snuck in silently. She heard nothing between the door opening and blackness taking her. Catra freed her in the night. Hopefully Shadow Weaver will think that Adora succumbed to her wounds. Even if not, Catra clearly isn't being held in chains. She could have fled the base after freeing Adora. She's okay. She has to be. Adora would just know otherwise.

There's shifting around her as the silence stretches. Scorpia is cradling her in a hug. It's nice. Adora has only ever been held by Catra. She and Rogelio fist bump, and Lonnie often throws an arm around their shoulders after a heist, but Scorpia has Adora fully in her lap, offering comfort as Adora barely begins to process everything that happened. She couldn't really think about it with all the pain, but now that she is no longer fighting for survival, her emotions are raging in her chest.

"You stopped responding to messages. Scorpia went to check Catra's apartment. She found it abandoned. She managed to retrieve your phone, but we knew you had to have been kidnapped then," Glimmer says beside her when she continues to be silent. Adora blinks, though her eyes don't focus properly still. She nods mutely, licking her lips and gearing herself up to speak.

"Shadow Weaver threw Catra in the cells," she whispers. Scorpia winces, hugging Adora tight to comfort her. Adora draws in slow and shaking breaths as she forces down the tears that want to well up. "Deprivation torture. Catra agreed to help Shadow Weaver bring me back. They were waiting for me at the apartment," she adds in a rasp. She hears movement around her as people react to that, but it doesn't really matter to her. She has to finish.

"Catra, she- she broke into my cell during the night. Gave me my poison. Even helped me chew it. She freed me," Adora finishes before her tears overwhelm her. She curls into herself. Catra may have betrayed her to the Horde, but she didn't *want* to. She didn't have a choice after what she had been through. She shouldn't have even helped Adora escape, but despite how hurt she clearly was, it's always been the two of them. She can't leave Adora anymore than Adora can leave her.

No one asks more questions after that. The group talks in murmurs around her, but Scorpia just hugs her close. Her arms are stronger than Catra's, but they still aren't as comforting.

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When darkness falls on Sunday, Catra leaves her temporary shelter beneath an overpass and heads for the side street where he parked on the Palatial job that kicked this whole thing off. He isn't there when she arrives, but part of her is expecting an ambush and the rest isn't expecting him to show up at all. He probably only helped Catra because he's too stupid to know what a risk it is, but Lonnie and Rogelio would know better and stop him from coming. Catra winces at the thought.

It's a cruel thing to think about someone who likely saved her from being captured and eternally tortured. She's just used to thinking of him like that – of *people* like that. Given that everybody in her life except the twink seems to have left her, she thinks it's fair to have such low expectations of people. She's shocked when he pulls up beside her. She stares at him. He frowns, glancing around and motioning for her to get in. Catra swallows before she opens the passenger door and climbs in. To her surprise, he pulls out of the street immediately.

"Where are we going?" she asks. Her voice is a bit hoarse from a day out in the elements. She winces at the way it cracks, but he doesn't seem bothered, offering her a small smile as he continues driving. Catra's heart is pounding, paranoia warning her that he's taking her back.

"The Motel Mod. It's outside Horde territory and cheap. We got you three nights there. Lonnie figured you wouldn't trust us enough to stay longer," he tells her. Catra's chest squeezes painfully. She nods mutely as she fumbles for her seatbelt, finally putting it on and clicking it into place. It's a relief to be in the safety of four climate-controlled walls again. She can't deny that as much as the Horde was a den of misery, having a roof over their head, bathroom facilities, and food provided was worth sticking around for, at least at first.

She feels the first true measure of peace that she has in weeks curled up in the passenger seat, her fur lightly ruffled by the AC and Kyle singing along terribly to pop songs beside her. Normally she hates Kyle's taste in music and the songs that he sings, but tonight she smiles to herself as she curls around her blanket, carefully folded in her arms. The blanket isn't even soft or all that warm, but it's all she has.

When they arrive at the motel, Lonnie is lingering on the railed-off sidewalk in front of the motel room doors. She's leaning against the railing and browsing her phone, but she looks up and straightens as they approach, shoving her phone back in her pocket and eyeing Catra dubiously. Catra offers her a tremulous smile. She knows she looks like shit after sleeping on the roadside and scrounging, but she's as grateful as she is capable of being right now that her team is here.

"Well, if it isn't public enemy number one. Rogelio has your stuff inside," Lonnie greets as Kyle brushes past her so he can unlock the room's door. Catra's ear flicks at the casualness in Lonnie's tone despite her words. Lonnie just eyes her for a moment more before Kyle gets the door open and gestures inside with a smile on his face. He seems proud of what he's done. Catra isn't talking about opening the door. Helping her was a still monumentally stupid thing to do.

It might be the stupidest thing that Kyle has ever done. If it was Catra's best friend who had done something like this, she would be wary too, but she also would have helped Adora bury a body if necessary, regardless of who it was. She decides to just be grateful that Lonnie and Rogelio are seemingly going along with all this as she ducks into the motel room. It's kind of beat up, but it's clean at least.

Rogelio is sat on the end of the bed, looking up from where he was watching the TV. Catra isn't paying attention to what's playing, too focused on the two cardboard boxes and one duffle bag at the foot of the bed. Kyle steps up behind her and Catra is forced to walk further into the hotel room than the entry way to let him in. Lonnie leans up

against the wall to the bathroom, crossing her arms as he gestures to the pile of stuff.

"I talked Shadow Weaver into letting us go over to your place to salvage anything useful. We couldn't take any of your magicat stuff because that would look too suspicious, but this is some of your gear that Lonnie can also fit and half of the cash we could find around," he tells her. Catra's breath hitches, emotion welling up in her chest. She looks up and gives him a watery, grateful smile. He beams in response, bowing a little. Rogelio looks pleased too as he stands, placing a hand on he's shoulder. Against the wall, Lonnie coughs.

"It's *almost* half of the cash from your place," she corrects. Catra doesn't even care. They can have the excess. They've already done so much for her. She nods. Lonnie pushes off the wall, inclining her head towards Rogelio. "We didn't want to grab clothes and make Shadow Weaver suspicious if she went there herself, but I noticed you had one of Adora's shirts, so I grabbed that for you," she adds as Rogelio steers him over towards the front door.

"Thank you," Catra manages to whisper. He beams while Rogelio and Lonnie merely incline their heads. They care – saving their boyfriend's ass aside, they wouldn't have gone to these lengths if they didn't – but they also both know what a risk this was. Catra has to rearrange her blanket in her arms so she can take the room key when he holds it out to her.

"Don't mention it. Seriously, never tell a soul about this or I'll hunt down your ungrateful ass and kill you," Lonnie warns her. Catra has heard Lonnie actually threaten people before. She's terrifying, like staring down a hurricane. This isn't that. It's a warning that needs to be said, but Catra just nods. She won't. Shadow Weaver called her ungrateful a lot, but Catra *is* grateful of kindness, that's just not what Shadow Weaver ever showed to her.

Lonnie nods, satisfied, and turns to follow her partners out of the room. She pauses as he opens the door, reaching down into her pocket and digging out a pair of keys. She tosses them in Catra's

direction. Catra catches them easily, feeling oddly settled by having the familiar weight of her motorcycle's key in her hand again, though it is lighter with her apartment key taken off the keyring.

ft' s parked around the other side of the motel. She's a beauty," Lonnie tells her. Catra wrinkles her nose at the gendering of her motorcycle, but she nods her agreement. It really is. She's grateful Lonnie was willing to give it up after Shadow Weaver already gave her permission to take it. Lonnie throws a wave over her shoulder and then she steps out of the motel doorway, closing the door behind her. Catra takes a deep breath, suddenly alone again, but this time indoors at least.

She puts her keys and blanket down on the boxes at the foot of the bed. First things first: finding Adora's shirt, and then showering. After that she can order food and figure out what the hell she's doing with her life from here on out. She has some things back, at least, and she has the cash to get more. She'll survive. She always does.

Lone Wolf

Chapter Notes

CW: discussion of starvation/choosing not to eat.
Vocal stim rights. All my bitches love vocal stimming.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora goes numb after she tells the others what happened. She sits in the corner, staring blankly at the wall ahead of her and trying not to think about it. There are only two options – Catra's dead, or she slipped from the cell before she was discovered and she escaped retribution. Adora's heart won't let her believe that Catra is dead. Catra is so skilled, so strong, so determined. She was too stubborn to die when she was an orphaned kitten and Adora can't imagine it happening now.

The logical part of her mind calls it *denial*, but it's all that Adora has. A rescue attempt would be unlikely to work and only endanger Catra further if she's being kept at the base. If she isn't, there's no way that Shadow Weaver can hold her down enough that Catra couldn't slip away – if she wanted to. She knows Adora's number and can get in contact. Adora's options are waiting and either never hearing from Catra again or being reunited.

She retreats to her room. She emerges to go to the kitchen or the bathroom, but no one really tries to interact with her, giving her room to mourn and process. She feels like a ghost of herself, haunting the penthouse full of people who fall silent when she passes, not wanting to disturb their poltergeist. Every day that passes in silence drops her spirits lower. On Monday morning, Adora can't even be bothered to get out of bed to make breakfast. She just lays there feeling hollow.

All along, her plan was to get Catra out and then repay the Alliance by helping them. After that, she just kind of assumed she and Catra

would ride off into the sunset with their ill-gotten gains. Figuring out what to do about the lifespan discrepancy between them was a problem for later. Addressing the whole soulmate thing was a problem for *much later*.

There is no later now. Catra is alive, or she isn't. She turned Adora in, and then she regretted it. She was tortured for her either way – not just this time, but every other as well. All of them were Adora's fault. If Shadow Weaver hadn't been convinced that Adora was immortal, she never would have treated them any different than the rest of the street kids. They could have had the exact same upbringing as Lonnie. It would have been harsh, but unremarkable. Catra wouldn't be bearing *scars*.

Adora lies in her pity pile for a long time. When the sun has gotten high enough in the sky that it isn't shining into her window anymore, someone knocks at her door. Adora forces herself to roll over to face the door, watching Entrapta enter the room with some surprise. Entrapta smiles with her usual thousand-watt grin, though Adora can see a pinch of concern in her brow as she walks over to the bed carrying a bowl. Adora stares at it as Entrapta places it on the bed beside her. It's full of quinoa with meat and vegetables mixed in.

"You didn't come out for breakfast," Entrapta volunteers, sitting on the edge of the bed beside her and folding her legs to sit crisscross. If the bed was any higher up than an air mattress on the floor, Adora would be worried about her falling off from her precarious perch. Adora's heart beats heavily as she twists to sit up. She isn't feeling up to eating, much less cooking, but she can't turn away a meal that has already been fixed for her.

"Thank you," she murmurs, picking up the bowl and taking a few cautious bites. Okay, scratch the 'not up to eating' thing – once she starts eating, she realizes she's *starving*. Entrapta beams as she begins to dig in, the only thing slowing her down the fact that Entrapta brought her chopsticks. She hasn't seen Entrapta ever use any other utensils to eat, but Entrapta also only eats small bites that

can fit in her mouth all at once. Chopsticks are convenient for the way she eats, but Adora isn't used to them.

"Perfuma always makes food for me when I'm not up to it," Entrapta tells her with a shrug. Her tone is cheery despite the fact that Adora can't be described as anything but depressed. She locked herself in her room partially because she wasn't up to anything else and partially to avoid bothering the others, but Entrapta doesn't seem brought down by her lack of energy, happy to sit on the end of her bed as she makes soft clicking noises to herself with her tongue. Adora has her mouth full, so she just nods.

Aside from the noises that Entrapta seems to be making to occupy herself, they sit in silence. Adora has watched Perfuma fix food for Entrapta already, making a regular meal for herself and then arranging another one into small portions and carefully scattering them around a plate to make every piece visually distinct. When Adora asked her why, Perfuma just hesitated and replied that Entrapta didn't like the sensation of having her mouth full.

Adora is kind of surprised that Entrapta thought to bring her a regular-sized bowl, but she appreciates the gesture. It's sweet, Entrapta making sure that she gets enough to eat. Usually Adora was the one making sure that Catra had gotten enough nutrients, but that was never for lack of trying on Catra's part – Shadow Weaver just withheld food if she didn't think that Catra had earned it.

"When Perfuma found me, I was doing better than I had in years, but I still regularly starved to death," Entrapta says, apropos to nothing. Adora almost chokes on her food, just barely managing to swallow it down the right pipe. She looks up with her eyes watering to find Entrapta's expression unchanged, the other woman still looking at the blank wall opposite her.

"That was my first death, you know . The recession hit us hard. I always struggled with food, and we couldn't afford the things I could stand to eat anymore. My little sister needed it more than me, anyway. I always gave it to her. I was surprised when I woke up

feeling alive for the first time in weeks. Once I figured out what happened, I didn't see the point in taking resources from someone else,"Entrapta elaborates. Adora swallows, her heart heavy . She nods silently. If her and Catra had still been living on the streets the first time she died, she likely would have taken the same route.

"W e could afford to eat by the time Perfuma found me, but it was just...habit. I forgot sometimes. Perfuma convinced me that I had to take care of myself or I would get foggy. When I wasn't as sharp, my work got sloppy. I try to do better now, but when I don't, she takes care of me,"Entrapta continues, finally turning to blink at Adora slowly. Adora nods. She gets the message. Entrapta is here for her – they all are. Entrapta's smile is bittersweet but encouraging. She doesn't seem to have more to say on that, standing and patting the top of Adora's head as she goes.

"Scorpia rented a trailer this morning. She' s going to go over to your place today to get anything for you that she can. She didn't want to tell you and get your hopes up in case the Horde destroyed it,"she informs her. Adora hunches over her bowl, blinking down at the cooling grains as she thinks that over. It has been two days. It's likely that Shadow Weaver has gone on a rampage through the place, but Adora still has some stuff of Catra's there.

"I'll come. It'll give me something to do,"Adora replies. She also doesn't want Scorpia to do all that work for her by herself. No one else can go and risk having the Horde learn their face. In her periphery, Entrapta gives a bobbing nod.

"I'll have her come tell you when she goes. If you need to rest, just do that,"she adds, and then she turns away , leaving Adora in the privacy of her bedroom to eat. Adora has a lump in her throat, but she clumsily picks up another bite with the chopsticks. Entrapta made it for her. She isn't going to let her care go to waste.

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Lonnie was right – even after taking the risk of letting her go and bringing her gear to her, Catra doesn't trust them. Her two weeks of being a captain pay off. She had to research targets, and now she knows a few places to hit that she has the advantage of Horde intel on. Better still, she doesn't really have to worry about a job gone wrong. She switches motels when her three nights are up, and she hits the two targets that she is confident she can take by herself.

Before she leaves for the jobs, she spreads her blanket out on the bed, but she never needs to regenerate. Being her own getaway driver and fleeing a scene on a motorcycle is a new experience, but she gets enough cash on hand to start working with. She doesn't have a plan. All she knows is that she's alive and apparently that isn't going to change. The only thing she really knows how to do is steal, even if she's on her own in it for the first time.

She heads back up to her room after renewing her stay for the fourth night in the row feeling antsy. She can't keep staying here. Motels aren't secure. She might come back to find cops on the scene any day now. She needs somewhere more permanent, but she has been reluctant to look into apartments. She hasn't bought a new phone to replace the one that Shadow Weaver swiped from her locker while she had Catra locked up in the interrogation room. She'll need one, or at least an internet connection, if she's going to find a place to live.

The real reason she hasn't tried has nothing to do with her current resources, though. Finding a new place means putting down roots. It means making a decision on what the hell she is doing other than *surviving*. She was going to do that even before her old team helped her get back on her feet. Having all her gear and a place to stay accelerated the pace at which she started gathering resources again, but she would have done it anyway. All she's doing now is dragging out a decision she should have made when she was sleeping under the overpass.

Catra sighs, flopping back on her bed. This motel is a little dirtier than the last, but that's what she gets for not letting room service into her room for five days. She stares up at the ceiling, her stomach roiling at the idea of choosing any route. That means admitting that everything she has been doing with her life up until now is worthless. She was never going anywhere in the Horde, only ever kept around to be an eventual hostage for Adora. Now even Adora doesn't want her.

They used to dream of climbing to the top one day. It was Hordak's operation, but he wouldn't live forever. They thought Shadow Weaver was priming Adora to be his successor and just wouldn't tell them out of paranoia that Adora might try to accelerate the process. It's not something Adora would ever do, but Shadow Weaver would, so of course she would fear it. When the time came, Adora would take over as boss and Catra would take up their mentor's old position as her second.

They dreamed of grand heists. They talked about strolling through the streets of the territory that would be theirs. Adora would talk about leading the Horde and taking care of the people on the streets of *her territory*. Catra always scowled at that. She didn't care about the glory, not really. She just wanted the safety and respect of being in charge – and she wanted Adora.

If she had that, she would have been happy, but Shadow Weaver never intended anything but death for them. Adora was her sacrificial lamb and Catra was going to be her hostage. They earned the Horde millions with their heists, but it wasn't enough. They could have been the best team that the Horde had ever seen, but Shadow Weaver had fucking designs for them, and they were worthless if they weren't fulfilling them. Catra can't go back and be defined only by what she is or isn't to Adora.

She's a damn good thief. Shadow Weaver never recognized that. Well jokes on her, Catra's just as fucking special as Adora. She rolls over in the bed, glaring at where she has the blanket carefully folded in the shitty armchair that came with the room. She doesn't want to

sleep with it and wear it down until it's threadbare. Right now, it's all she has, maybe even the only thing tying her to life. The thought is sobering. She sighs, shivering a little in the motel AC.

She crawls up to the head of the bed and tucks into the bedding, thinking over her options, but she always knew what she was going to do once she was able to admit to herself that she wasn't with the Horde anymore. She could go back, determined to prove them fucking wrong, but she can't after she saw Adora fucking suffering like that. Sure, Catra has been beaten by Shadow Weaver many times, but she's *Catra*. Everyone sees her as worthless. Adora is better than that and Shadow Weaver was still willing to torture her.

Catra wants all that suffering to result in *something*, but she can't give Shadow Weaver the satisfaction of running back to her either. Right now, Shadow Weaver doesn't even know she's alive. Catra can use that to her advantage. Maybe the suffering was just suffering. Maybe it didn't earn her anything but scars. She can at least get revenge for it. She can show Shadow Weaver that she was wrong to ever discount Catra. She has these abilities, after all.

She only knows how to steal, so she'll steal. It will anger Shadow Weaver even more when she realizes because she won't be profiting from it. Maybe she'll even begin to regret the way she treated Catra since it lost her this opportunity. Okay, that's definitely wishful thinking, but Catra will cling onto whatever manages to make her smile, and right now that's the image of Shadow Weaver seething in her office as she puts together the web of seemingly impossible heists and realizes how much she lost by throwing Catra away.

She still doesn't know what she's going to do about the whole Adora situation, but her first priority has to be finding a new base, gathering resources, and selecting targets. Adora is a separate problem that she isn't prepared to deal with right now. She doesn't know if she ever will be.

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Adora's apartment was trashed when they arrived. Seeing the decorative tapestry that Catra picked out torn off the wall and thrown to the floor woke up something in Adora. She set to shifting through the wreck with grim determination. They loaded any furniture that wasn't broken into the trailer. Her and Catra's old trunk *was* broken, the latch torn off from the main body and only connected to the lid, but Adora wasn't leaving it behind.

It took longer than it should have because of the mess, but no one from the Horde shows up while they're working, and Adora finally has a real mattress again. She lets Scorpia help her carry the furniture up to her room in the penthouse, but then she insists on arranging the room and putting everything away on her own. She has emotions and two decades of history with a vanished girl to work through. She doesn't know what the Horde was looking for in her place, but they wouldn't have found anything.

She has kept the gear the Alliance got her to match them at the penthouse. Everything in her apartment she either brought with her from the headqarters or bought before she went undercover . Adora even moved some things to the penthouse after she regenerated there, so there wasn't that much other than furniture left in her apartment. Maybe Shadow Weaver just wanted to be an asshole. Adora would never care about things more than she cares about what their mentor did to Catra, but Shadow Weaver has always loved adding insult to injury.

Afterwards, Adora sits on the edge of her mattress and stares at the same wall that Entrapta did when she was in here that morning. Her stomach is clenched tight, and she still feels a bit numb, but she also knows what she needs to do. She had a mission even before the kidnapping. She was too numb to care about fulfilling it these last two days, but it's all she has. She might even find out what

happened to Catra if she continues down this path. If she's still out there, Adora could get a lead on where she went.

Adora emerges from her room feeling *something* for the first time in days. She heads towards the living room to find a large group gathered in the kitchen, eating dinner. Perfuma is the first to spot her, lighting up with hope and beckoning her over. Adora takes a deep breath and walks forward, taking the invitation to occupy the empty air by her side. The others notice her as she approaches, the conversation stuttering as people halt for a moment and then try to fling themselves back into it like it never happened.

Adora feels weird surrounded by life and warmth again, but it only reminds her of what she's missing. A hollow pang resonates in her chest at Catra's absence, only hardening her resolve. She looks up and forces herself to meet Glimmer's eyes. Glimmer's attention immediately focuses in on her, and within a few moments the others pick up on it and fall silent, waiting. Adora clears her throat a bit awkwardly.

"I want to hit the Horde. They'll upgrade security now that they know I've defected, but if we hit them before they have time to make changes, we can cause some real damage. Take away their cash stores and they won't be able to put in the resources to make those upgrades. We can go at them without holding anything back now that they know," Adora says. Her voice is a bit raspy , rough from disuse, but the entire room watches her as she speaks.

Glimmer's expression sets as she nods, turning to look to Mermista. Mermista straightens, standing up from her seat and turning away with a beckoning motion thrown over her shoulder. Adora is a bit confused, but she moves to follow as Mermista walks away from the kitchen.

"I've been planning shit ever since you vanished. W e were going to hit them as hard as we could to help make you an opening to kill yourself and regen. With your intel, we can refine the plans and hit them at key points," she tells Adora. Adora realizes they're heading

towards the heist planning room. She nods to Mermista, almost eager, but she can't quite make it to that emotion yet. What she does feel is determination.

They're going to make the Horde hurt for all they've done, both to civilians and to their own people. Almost all the people in the Horde didn't get much of a choice about joining it. It was often survive with the Horde or die on your own. The Alliance isn't trying to set the police on the Horde and send all those people who didn't have a choice to jail. If they undermine the Horde, those people will temporarily lose their immediate source of money, but they'll be free to pursue something else.

Even if it's still a life of crime, if they aren't being forced into it at gunpoint and encouraged to hurt people by a higher body, then they will have done good overall. They aren't trying to reform anyone, just stop innocent people from getting hurt and crushed beneath the heel of organized crime. Adora knows the Horde's internal structure intimately. She has more insight on what will hurt their integrity than Scorpia ever did.

She can dismantle the system that abused Catra for years. She owes it to her for letting her go through all that. Her purpose has always been to protect Catra. Now she can finally finish it. Whether Catra is here to even see it, she doesn't know, but it's all she has, and she owes it to her friend.

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Catra finds a basement space sprawling beneath an office block that has sat empty for years and, most importantly, has its own garage that leads directly into the space. She can come and go in an area where people aren't concerned with knowing their neighbours or too

suspicious of criminal activity. The basement provides privacy and security.

She'll get an apartment to use as a bolt hole once she's done a few more jobs and can afford it. She doesn't like keeping the blanket on her. She would rather have it elsewhere as a backup. An apartment she never uses except for regenerating will be perfect. For now, she sets to hitting any target she knows of that she might be able to take on her own. She wants to turn the space into a proper base, but she needs money if she's going to acqire all the resources that the Horde gave her.

High reward jobs reqire investment in tools upfront. She used to go to a locker room and just grab what she needed, but she doesn't have that anymore. Luckily, she also doesn't have to worry about dying or even being injured anymore. She can forgo some things and take risks. She fills out the space with some thrift store furniture, using the money she might have used on body armor once upon a time, and she sets up a planning room in one of the dozen inter-connected concrete rooms that makes up space.

Despite how it shouldn't be her top priority, she gets a police scanner and sets it up in her main heist room. She said that she would leave the Adora problem for another day. After all, Adora fucking *abandoned* her in the Horde without a second thought. Catra should leave her behind too, moving on and focusing on pulling off the kinds of jobs that could make Adora regret casting her aside. Despite what she tells herself, she still can't stop feeling cold and lonely every night she falls asleep alone. She wakes up every morning wishing Adora was petting through her hair.

It's short now. She didn't know what to do with it after she cut it in a jagged and uneven bob to escape Shadow Weaver's grip. Throughout her four days in the cells, she kept trying to fix it and even it out with her claws, despite not having access to a mirror. Shadow Weaver seemed pleased every time she entered the room to find Catra's hair shorter. It was a visual indication of her declining mental state. She could control nothing, but she could control her

hair. Eventually she just sliced it all off in a pixie cut. It made her feel a bit more in control.

She can't help but wonder what Adora's hands would feel like petting through it now. She always loved that when it was long, and she thinks she would be able to feel more now, but it doesn't matter. Adora isn't here, and if she were, she wouldn't care about petting Catra now that she has her shiny new crew of immortals to hang out with. Catra wants to show up and tell Adora that she's like them too – she's *worth keeping* – but Adora already cast her aside when she thought Catra was mortal. The fact that she isn't doesn't change that Adora was willing to do it in the first place.

Catra wasn't worth anything as a mortal – why should she be now that she's immortal? She's utterly alone. She plans heists for a crew of one, alone in the side room that she has decorated with whiteboards, maps, and that fucking police scanner. She tries to take time off, lounging in the room she has designated as a living room by rolling out a rug and installing a couch and TV in its center. It still isn't *homey*, but neither was the Horde. The only thing that made that place feel warm was Adora.

Adora. Catra gave herself a goal: pull off legendary heists and make Shadow Weaver rue the day she ever considered Catra as less. Adora isn't a part of those plans except as someone that Catra needs to measure herself against. She should forget her like Adora did her, but she *can't*. She curls up in her basement bedroom, or stretches out on her couch, or spends all day pacing around her study, but she can't ignore the bleeding wound in her heart.

She shouldn't be this easy, this desperate, but every time she picks up on something with the police scanner that sounds like it could be an Alliance job, she stops everything she's doing to listen. When she sees a news report on the Alliance, she takes fucking notes. Soon she has an entire whiteboard dedicated to the jobs the Alliance is taking, reverse engineering their strategy to realize that they are hitting the Horde at key financial points for them.

Adora's trying to take apart the very system that made her, Catra realizes, but she's doing it *wrong*. Catra stares at the board, thinking about her last heist. She was about to slip inside when she stopped to take stock of her surroundings to see if it was safe to voice a quip. A moment later, she remembered that Adora wasn't in her ear to hear it regardless. The realization was like a knife in her chest, leaving her struggling to take calm, measured breaths for several moments.

Catra growls and turns to her police scanner. She shouldn't break this easily, but she's also shocked that she lasted this long at all. She lied when she said Adora was a problem for another day. Adora is always going to be at the forefront of her mind, despite her best efforts otherwise.

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There are things about regenerating that Adora didn't realize. Like, if she dies with no one around, her body can return to her bed within minutes. If there's someone around, it tends to linger. Mermista refers to regenerating as "the universe correcting," but it doesn't seem to like to break its own rules in full view of anyone living. When she chooses to regenerate after cutting herself while cooking and then dies on two jobs in a row, she just assumes someone was lingering around her body and that's why it took so long to wake up.

After her body regenerates, she usually sleeps for a while. The others assure her that's normal, her body resting and settling while it has the opportunity to do so. If you let the rest run its course and wake up naturally, you avoid post-regen fatigue. Apparently that fatigue worsens with multiple regens in a short timeframe, however. When it takes her six hours to wake on her third regen that week, Glimmer orders that she take a backseat.

Glimmer still isn't the leader, but everyone else is giving Adora the same look. Well, they're giving her wildly varying looks, but they all come down to the same sentiment of *take care of yourself or we'll do it for you*. Adora can't afford to take a break though. The Horde has already started increasing security measures - that's how she died, anticipating a safe approach that was qickly thwarted. Still, the Alliance is placing pressure on them, and they need to keep going if they're going to make a difference.

Adora isn't about to go rogue though – the last thing she wants to do is piss off the Alliance and have *nobody* – so she begrudgingly lets herself be regaled to a completely unnecessary role in the next job. Bow usually keeps an eye on police scanners to warn them if the cops start heading their way, but Glimmer insists that she wants him around the penthouse as little as possible for a few weeks just in case the Horde manages to track them down somehow.

It's a flimsy excuse to station Adora on a roof half a block away from the action, but Glimmer insists that she needs someone to keep an eye out for Horde reinforcements coming as well. The Horde has to be preparing for their attacks by now, but whether they can deter them is a qestion of if they have been able to arrange the security and manpower to face them down. It's a tight timeframe to move or reinforce a location on, and hopefully the hit to their finances is only making things harder for them.

Adora isn't really expecting any backup to arrive. She lies out on a laundromat roof a little further down the street from the money laundering operation that the Horde doesn't own but often utilizes for cleaning their dirty money. It's an odd target for the Alliance, but the Horde won't be expecting them to hit it, and Adora is pretty confident that they're leaning on their dirty money heavily right now to get qick cash after losing their largest vault, so it should hurt them just like a direct attack.

Despite how confident Adora is in this being a good target, she's bored. She's just lying down behind the lip of the roof and listening for cars. She can hear gunfire ringing out down the street and in her

earpiece, but no backup is coming, so she's just tracking who is still standing in her head and forcing her fingers not to twitch towards her gun. She wants to dive into the fray herself. She could do more damage than the others.

The entire Alliance uses rubber bullets. They hurt like hell, even break skin or bone sometimes, but it's a safe bet that you won't kill anyone. Adora has a gun with them loaded up, and she even uses it, but she won't give up her real gun either. She has spent her entire life training how to shoot without killing people, and though the chance is definitely higher than with rubber bullets, she also doesn't trust them.

The Alliance is iffy on it, but they allow it after a serious talk with her. They still won't tell her about Mega Death – she's depressed, she gets it – but Glimmer does warn her that if you kill someone, you lose your immortality. All the wars in the world have never increased the count of immortals. Soldiers don't get to regenerate, even if they were immortal going into it. Immortals' purpose is to love, not kill. Adora doesn't want to kill, but she knows how to use her guns without doing so. If she does lose her immortality, well-

Well, sorry to her soulmate, but she already had a love of her life and lost her. Adora sighs, listening to Mermista bark out *pill* before her earpiece shuts off. That's one down now. Adora can smell smoke, though, so they've at least gotten started on wrecking the operation. If everybody else goes down before they finish, then she can probably dive in without being labeled as too disobedient. She isn't going to let the mission fail just because Glimmer thinks she needs to rest.

Sirens. Adora qickly rolls over , peeking over the edge of the roof. She can't see any cars approaching and the sound is distant, but it's getting closer. The Horde isn't coming to secure their partner operation, but they're outside of Horde territory now, and this is qite a lot of noise. Someone must have called the cops. Adora kind of forgot that people do that.

"Cops are on their way . No sign yet, just sirens," Adora informs, one hand raised up to her earpiece to switch it on for a moment. She gets swearing and grunts of affirmation in response. She quickly shuts the earpiece's mic back off, not wanting to clog up the channels when she – sadly – isn't doing anything that puts her in immediate danger. This is why they should have had Bow watch the dispatch channel. He would have been able to warn them the moment the call went out and not just when the cops were close enough to hear.

It doesn't really matter though. This is a burn operation, so they don't need to make it out with anything. As long as none of their gear falls off or anything, they'll wake back up with it still on, so there's really nothing to lose here if the cops do pin them in, it will just interfere with their ability to complete the operation if they're fighting on two fronts. Adora watches the streets for the moment when she catches the glow of lights to switch her mic back on.

"Less than a minute," she warns, quickly shutting of f again. Her hand falls back to the roof surface so she can shift back a bit further from the edge and hunker down. She needs to be out of sight for the cops' visual sweep of the area when they arrive or they'll open fire on her. It might be a good distraction, but the cops in this city aren't known for being great shots, and she doesn't want to endanger any of the workers in the building below her. She shifts back, the sound of the roof gravel shifting just barely audible beneath the commotion, but it's louder than it should be-

A body lands on top of her, taking her by surprise and going for a pin on her lower half. Adora barely suppresses a yell that could alert others to her presence. Clearly she has been made, but by *who* is important. If they can't inform others of her location, she might be able to deal with it herself. The assailant, interestingly, doesn't go for her hands. Adora shoves herself back from the rooftop, attempting to dislodge her attacker, but they're somehow latched onto the roof and don't budge.

"Hey , Adora," Catra purrs out above her . Adora freezes, her heart stopping as Catra chuckles and then pushes her body down, plastering Adora back down against the roof with the length of her body. Adora isn't fighting anymore, her heart hammering in her chest as she lets Catra duck them back down out of view from the street level.

"Catra, what-" Adora starts, struggling for breath from her shock, but she's cut off by discovering what Catra was doing with her hands when she wasn't using them to pin her down. She was preparing a mask, which she has stretched between her hands as she brings it down over Adora's head and pulls it tight against the bottom half of her face because she can finish her sentence. Adora releases a muffled exclamation that translates roughly to *what the fuck* as she reaches up behind her head, but Catra fucking bites her hand when Adora tries to stop her from tying the gag in place.

"So you can't take your pills. Leave it, Adora. I'm not going to hurt you," Catra tells her , sounding honestly annoyed that Adora is fighting being gagged. The words – and the blood dripping down her hand – make Adora pause though, breathing heavily into the fabric of her gag. Catra seems pleased with that, her chest vibrating a little as she secures the gag in place while Adora takes her moment to think.

Her heart is still hammering, her entire body lighting up in Catra's presence. Some of it is *definitely* their current position – Catra pinning her always did things to her, even when they were supposed to be training – but her desire is secondary on the list compared to the adrenaline pouring through her, her body sagging a little with the relief that Catra is here.

Satisfied that Adora's gag is in place, Catra's hands fall away and then she shifts them. Adora is still a bit too shocked to fight her as Catra flips her over and pins her again, this time with their fronts pressed together. Adora's eyes roam greedily over Catra, doing her best to take in every detail even as Catra doesn't spare a glance for her own face, her gaze instead flicking down to take in Adora's body.

Catra looks a hell of a lot better than when Adora last saw her. She doesn't appear to have any injuries, though some could be lurking beneath the surface. She doesn't look sick either. She looks like she's eating and drinking again, even if her coat will likely never be as shiny and soft as it should be. At least, not while the Horde has a say in it. If Shadow Weaver still has her clutches on Catra, she isn't torturing her for Adora's transgressions at least.

Adora doesn't know if she has ever been as relieved as she is in this moment, Catra above her, alive and uninjured. She doesn't know why she's here or why she's worried about Adora taking one of her pills, but Adora somehow manages to go limp with relief despite how it feels like every inch of her is straining towards to Catra. She *must* go limp, because Catra notices it and snorts, finally glancing up at her face.

"Bottom," she comments, a satisfied quirk to her mouth when Adora immediately releases an indignant sound. Adora reaches up, now determined to take off the gag, but a micro expression flashes across Catra's face and she snatches her hands out, quickly pinning Adora's wrists to the roof. "Not until you give me your poison," she orders. Adora blinks at her, unsure what her angle is. She would never want to escape Catra, and she's fairly confident this isn't some weird game to drag her back to the Horde.

After a moment's hesitation, she lightly tugs on her right wrist in Catra's grip. Catra narrows her eyes, but she lets Adora go, watching as she reaches for the pocket hidden over her chest, right next to her jacket's zipper. She pulls out the small bottle of pills. It only has three in it. She's been burning through them lately, and they keep a limited number on them so they don't lose too many if something happens. Catra immediately snatches the bottle from her, reaching back to tuck it into her pocket.

Catra shifts to drape over Adora properly. No one leaps out of the shadows. It seems like she really just wanted to take the pills from Adora. After a moment's hesitation, Adora slips her other wrist out of Catra's slackened grip and reaches up to undo the mask ties. Catra

watches her with a burning gaze, but she doesn't stop Adora as she undoes the tie and pulls the cloth away, taking a deep breath of the fresh, undampened air.

"Catra, what-" Adora starts to ask again, but Catra shuts her up for the second time, though this one is much more pleasant than the last. Catra surges forward, kissing her with a burning passion that almost completely wipes Adora's mind of anything but *Catra*. Catra bites down on her lower lip and she releases a gentle cry into the kiss. Catra's hands drop to her hips as she pushes back just enough to narrow her eyes down at Adora.

"Keep quiet. Like we're back in the showers. There's, like, a dozen cops down there," Catra orders her before her hands fall to Adora's waistband and Adora realizes her intentions. Adora gapes at her, but that turns out to be a bad move because Catra just grins wickedly and leans down to kiss her with tongue. It's the kind of messy kiss that Adora secretly loves, the kind that feels like it should come in the throes of passion, but despite how her body is reacting to Catra undoing her pants, her heart is set on other things.

"Catra, wait, we need to *talk*," Adora tries, turning her head away from the kiss. Catra growls, her tail lashing behind her as her hand stills just short of reaching into Adora's pants. She pulls back just far enough to glare down at Adora. Any further and she risks being spotted by those below. There are sirens, cops shouting, vague yelling, and gunshots ringing out in the background, but if Adora's honest, that's not really a turn off for her and they both know it.

"No, we don't, and if we did, we certainly wouldn't do it fucking here. We both have shit to apologize for – now, do you want to get off, or are you too good for me now that you're on the other side?" Catra asks. Adora winces, swallowing around the lump in her throat. Catra phrasing it like just goes even further to prove that they need to talk. Catra is right that here and now isn't the time to apologize, but it also isn't the place to fuck either and that apparently isn't stopping her.

f”m not on the other side, I was trying to-”Adora starts, thinking back to everything Catra said during the kidnapping that made it clear she thought Adora was leaving her behind, but Catra cuts her off by baring her fangs at Adora and kissing her roughly. This time, Adora lets her. She has no idea how Catra even found her or what her current situation is, but she is clearly unwilling to talk. She often is. Adora has learned how to approach her cautiously, only prodding when she’s open to it.

She doesn’t think Catra has ever been more closed off. The idea of touching each other with this bleeding wound between them makes Adora’s heart ache, but if it helps Catra to soften, then it will be worth it. Despite the harsh kiss, Catra’s hand hasn’t moved from resting on Adora’s abdomen, where she stilled it upon Adora asking her to wait. Catra pulls back, looking down at her with a burning gaze.

Their faces are still close enough for Catra’s breath to be hot on her face as she breathes heavily, her gaze only tearing from Adora’ s to glance down at her hand between them for a moment before making eye contact again. Adora can see the question in her eyes despite how clouded it is by Catra’s own lust. She is wound tight, but given what her last few weeks have been like, Adora certainly doesn’t blame her for needing some stress relief.

‟W e do need to talk, but we can do this if you want,”Adora finally agrees, uncaring about the chaos on the street below. Glimmer could be yelling her name in her ear and she probably wouldn’t notice. It isn’t like her job is essential to the mission anyway. Adora is never going to turn down a moment with Catra. This wouldn’t even be the first time they’ve hooked up on a roof before, although the other two times were during stakeouts and not the middle of a firefight at least.

Catra narrows her eyes at the words, growling a low warning before she takes the invitation and kisses her, slender fingers sliding beneath the waistband of her pants to properly touch Adora. They can’t truly fuck here – they’ve both been touching the roof asphalt, it’s not sanitary – but Catra can work her clit over her underwear. Adora hasn’t even thought of touching herself since the kidnapping

and she knows this won't take long, especially not with Catra kissing her like *this* after Adora thought she might have lost her for good.

Adora has so much she wants to say to Catra, but Catra seems determined to kiss like a hurricane as she works her over fast and rough, just like they're on their old fifteen-minute time limit in the showers before things might start looking suspicious. Adora can't fight the pull of her lover after she feared she would never see her again. She sinks down into Catra's touch, gasping softly into the kiss but keeping quiet beneath her even as her body quickly locks up, her legs cramping from all her muscles tightening before she comes gasping.

"Meet at the rendezvous," are the first words that Adora makes out from her earpiece in a long time. She's pretty sure her brain just shut off that input when it was faced with Catra. Adora's still trembling slightly beneath Catra as she purrs with satisfaction, slipping her hand out of Adora's pants and not bothering to redo them.

"Don't forget who knows how to get you off when you're galivanting around the Fright Zone on your crusade," Catra tells her. She sounds smug, but not in her usual satisfied way that makes Adora want to rip her clothes off. It has a bitter tinge to it, an almost cruel tilt that makes Adora swallow and remember *Shadow Weaver*. She told Catra about soulmates. She taunted Adora with how it broke Catra while she was torturing her. Adora's chest feels tight as she struggles to prop herself up on her elbows so they can make eye contact.

"I don't care about anyone else, Catra. I just want you," she tells her. It doesn't have the desired effect. Catra immediately snarls, her ears pinning back as hurt flares in her eyes. She pushes back, sitting upright and straddled across Adora's thighs as she crosses her arms and glares down at her.

"So that's why you fucking lied to me for weeks and then defected the moment you found out there was someone else out there for you? Cut the bullshit, Adora," Catra snarls. Adora flinches, shaking

her head quickly, but before she can reply, there's a call from down on the street of *up there!* and a bullet goes whizzing past Catra's head. Adora twitches violently, her entire body jerking up to grab Catra and pull her down out of harm's way, but they've been spotted by the cops below. Catra struggles against her chest as Adora's heart hammers at the thought that she just almost lost Catra.

"You abandoned me without a second thought, but don't think that stops you from being *mine*," Catra hisses against her chest, and then Adora hears a *click* as Catra manages to free her arm from the hold. The next thing Adora knows, her own gun – the one loaded with real bullets – is pressed underneath the edge of her jaw with the safety off. She only has a fraction of a second to realize what is going on, but she knows without a doubt that Catra is going to pull the trigger and send her back to her own bed.

"Yours," she breathes back in agreement, and then an echoing crack rings out and darkness descends over her vision.

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Catra wakes up with her back hurting from however long she slept before she woke back up after turning the gun on herself. She has the blanket laid out on the floor of a small concrete room she didn't have much of a use for considering it's roughly the size of a laundry room. She wanted to keep the blanket somewhere special and contained until she got an apartment for it, but she forgot about the lag time between regenerating and waking up.

She'll have to figure something else out, she notes in the back of her mind as she stands and cautiously reaches into her back pocket. Even though she has watched Adora regenerate with the gear she had on her at the time, she's still relieved when she finds the pill bottle where she stashed it. She frowns when she opens it and finds

there are only three left – how many of these things has Adora taken? – but it'll be nice to have her own assurance on hand for her riskier jobs.

She tucks the pills away, slowly stretching out her limbs as she heads out into her apartment proper trying not to think about Adora's whisper of *yours*. If that were true, they would be soulmates. If that were true, Adora never would have fucking abandoned her, lied to her, defected and left her for dead. None of that altercation went as planned, but when Catra heard the police scanner warn about shooting at a location that she knew the Horde used to clean cash, she couldn't resist going to see.

She was supposed to just observe. All logic abandoned her the moment she spotted Adora laying out though, vulnerable and open for a predator to take advantage. Catra needed her. She needed to show Adora what she was fucking missing, and she needed to hear the soft gasps that *she* had been missing. She didn't anticipate Adora trying to convince her that she cared – she figured that ship set sail already – but despite how angry it made her, it felt good to have Adora eager to please her.

Catra might be nothing to her, but it doesn't matter. Adora still *wants* her. Catra can have her in that way. It's all the benefits of being a loner without the crushing loneliness and touch craving that has been overcoming her these last few weeks. They're both immortal and Adora is willing to play. Catra can dance around her as long as she likes. Until Adora's soulmate shows up, she thinks Adora will let her.

Chapter End Notes

- Just a clarification note: "killing" another immortal doesn't count as killing someone, Mermista kills Sea Hawk all the time.

Drag-along

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora wakes up with Catra's taste still on her tongue. She knows it probably isn't possible after a regeneration, but her body is buzzing and alive after being under Catra's attention. Nothing can cut the relief of Catra being alive and okay, not even her being mad at Adora. Her anger is misplaced and Adora can convince her of that. She practically bounces out of her bed, bounding out to the living room.

It's night – how late, Adora doesn't know, she just sees darkness and city lights outside of the windows – but Mermista, Entrapta, and Glimmer are all in the living room. Entrapta offers Adora a vague wave without looking up from her laptop. It draws Glimmer's attention to her. To Adora's surprise, she scowls when she spots Adora, pointing an accusing finger in her direction.

"You were supposed to stay *safe*, and you didn't even tell us you were regenerating. We were worried about leaving you, Adora," Glimmer chastises, crossing her arms and giving Adora her best firm glare. Adora blinks at her before glancing at the others in the living room. Entrapta still isn't looking away from her laptop, but Mermista gives her a long-suffering look. Glimmer stayed up to lecture Adora when she woke up, then, and she's already complained to Mermista about it since she regenerated herself – likely twice.

"I got shot and dropped my pills. And gun. Listen, it doesn't matter," Adora tells her, rushing forward. Glimmer startles when Adora places her hands on her shoulders, squeezing and staring down at her with a look that she knows is wild and intense, but Adora has never held back even once in her life. "Catra's alive. She showed up on the roof.

We got in an argument and that's when the police spotted us,"Adora tells her.

She is pretty sure telling Glimmer what happened in between Catra showing up and getting caught would make her pop a blood vessel right now. The Alliance may have accepted her with open arms, but that side of her is a lot. Their old team definitely knew about them making out in secluded corners during downtime on jobs, but it's not like Lonnie and Rogelio were much *better*, so they never commented on each other's quirks.

Glimmer blinks up at her, wide-eyed. A few cushions down on the ridiculously large sectional – it's big enough to fit the entire Alliance and wraps around half of the living room – Mermista straightens up a little. The sounds of simulated combat coming from Entrapta's computer even pause as she saves or something and looks up at Adora. Adora knows she's doing her *intense* thing, but Catra always liked it when she got like this.

"She thinks I was abandoning her there. I need to tell her that I was trying to get her out too. But she still kissed me. She still cares. And she's okay,"Adora adds on. It' s all that she cares about. She can fix things between them, even if it's going to be a painful process. Adora was afraid she lost Catra. She can't let her slip through her fingers again. Adora will convince Catra that they need to leave the Horde behind. Adora will protect her. She has to.

"Y ou two have a complicated relationship, don't you?"Mermista comments a bit too knowingly from further down the couch. Her tone of voice makes Adora blush. She doesn't *think* she implied anything more than a kiss, but Glimmer is blushing now too. Adora hastily releases her, straightening up and rubbing at the back of her neck.

"W e grew up being tortured for expressing any disobedience or *affection*. Everyone who grew up in the Horde is complicated, but especially anyone who had direct exposure to Shadow Weaver," Adora tells her. It's not really a defense, just an explanation.

Mermista purses her lips, looking considering. Adora sighs, turning back to Glimmer.

“Just be prepared for me to go running after her. And to bring her back here at the first opportunity,” Adora tells her. Glimmer looks a mix of thoughtful, curious, and doubtful, but she just nods her agreement. They’ve only known each other a few weeks now, but Adora knows that her dedication to Catra is one of the most obvious things about her. It’s what made Shadow Weaver pluck them off the streets, after all. Glimmer knows better than to try to deter her.

Everyone saw how depressed she got when she thought that Catra was lost to her. Glimmer still looks considering, but she nods. It’s all the approval Adora needs. She grins and flings herself down on the couch beside Glimmer, wrapping her arms around her and squeezing her in a tight hug. Glimmer tends to be touchy – all of the Alliance is – and Adora is only just starting to get used to it, but she can’t contain her excitement right now.

She’s going to bring Catra home, no matter what.

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Catra puts together a map of Horde operations, marking off the ones she has heard about on the police scanner as hit, as well as making notes on the one she knows the Alliance already targeted before this. Some locations, like the gambling dens, they’ve robbed more than once and might again. Things like the vault would be abandoned and relocated after being hit once, so Catra knows they aren’t going to be re-targeted.

She looks at their schedule. They don’t do things on the same days every time, but they’re pretty consistently hitting the Horde twice a week now. Catra can guess that they want to put on the pressure

and take everything out that they can before the Horde manages to relocate things now that they're so compromised by Adora leaving, but keeping such consistency makes them *predictable*. On only the third night of slipping around in the shadows to case potential targets, Catra finds Adora.

She's lurking a block away with her hood up and hair down to be less recognizable, but Catra has her gait memorized, and once she gets close enough she can pick up her familiar scent, laced with a touch of coconut. Catra watches Adora with her tail twitching in anticipation as she wanders out of the gas station she ducked into when she spotted movement at the storehouse down the street.

She's casing it for security changes, probably, staying far enough away that she likely won't get much info, but she at least won't be spotted. Catra doesn't know what the Alliance is planning considering they seem to favor fire and useless rubber bullets, but maybe that's why this job needs casing. The Alliance could just be learning its lesson. It took the Horde three weeks, but Catra is pretty sure they're on high alert now and jobs won't be as easy as a match in a vault.

Adora ducks around the corner of the gas station. There isn't anyone at the pumps right now, and even if there was, Adora is out of sight right now. As long as Catra keeps her quiet, they won't tip anyone off. She prowls to the edge of the roof, peeking down to find Adora sending off a text on her phone. Reporting in or something. Perfect. They'll probably have at least a few minutes together before anyone worries about Adora going dark.

Catra waits until Adora shoves the phone back in her pocket and turns back towards the street before she slips out from the shadows, landing in an elegant and near-silent crouch directly behind Adora. It's loud enough for Adora to pick up, though. She gives a half-start, raising her hands as she turns to face whoever has dropped down behind her, but Catra was prepared for that. She leaps forward, grabbing Adora's wrists and using her momentum to twist them until Adora's back hits the wall of the gas station, pinning her there.

"Geez, calm down, Adora. You'd think you were paranoid or something," Catra greets, grinning at her prey. Adora's eyes go wide and then she breaks into a grin, all the tension seeping out of her body. Catra feels her tail twitch with interest. She can't help how her entire body stands at attention for the way that Adora goes limp beneath her, ready to give her whatever she wants. Well, at least in sex. Catra already asked her to stay once and that got them nowhere.

"Probably because you *attack* me. You can just walk up like a normal person, you know," Adora replies, cocking a brow at her. She's still smiling, her tone casual and playful. Catra took her by surprise last time, but she is recovering faster now. Catra narrows her eyes at Adora, tightening her grip on her wrists and pointedly letting the tips of her claws dig into Adora's skin just enough to excite her. It works. Adora draws in a sharp breath and flushes.

"I like having my way with you," she responds, smirking enough to show Adora her fangs. Adora releases a small sound suspiciously close to a moan, shifting a little against the wall. Catra takes the opening, pressing forward and kissing her hungrily. She's grateful that Adora showed up tonight – Catra was *starving* for her. She desperately fucked herself for an hour in her bed last night, but none of it did anything. She was imagining Adora and nothing less was going to satisfy her.

Relief pours through her as Adora opens her mouth eagerly for her, sighing softly and tilting her chin down to give Catra a better angle without her having to stand up on her toes. Catra shoves her knee forward, heat spiking between her legs as Adora lets out a quiet *hah* and then shifts to accommodate her so Catra can press her thigh up against the front of Adora's pants. Adora is quiet, but nowhere near silent as she rolls her hips up to meet Catra.

It's just like when they were on the roof. Catra has Adora beneath her hands and she can't stop. She just wants to have her. She would never let Adora touch her in this precarious of a position – the time they fucked in a hotel stairwell doesn't *count*, it wasn't a Horde guard

that would have caught them if they were discovered then – but Adora doesn't seem to have the same qualms over being exposed in public. She happily spreads her legs for Catra, giving her plenty of room to grind up against Adora.

Catra nips at Adora's lip before ducking down to her collar, dropping her hold on Adora's wrist so she can shove her hoodie aside. She buries her nose against Adora's pulse point, breathing in deeply. Adora's scent is heavy with desire. It's the kind of desperation that makes Catra's mouth inexplicably water. Her tail lashes behind her, satisfaction flushing through her. Adora is enjoying this, eager for it, and that's the exact high that Catra needed last night when she was trying to get off.

Adora buries the hand that Catra was pinning in her hair. If Catra had any sense left, it abandons her now. She moans, biting down on Adora's neck and purring when Adora strangles a cry in her throat before it can grow too loud, desperately rutting her hips down against Catra. She already knows Adora likes being bit, but the part of her mind that desperately needs Adora's pleasure can argue that Adora also likes the mark that will be left behind. Catra ramps up the pressure of the bite, careful not to break skin with her fangs.

"*Ah*...Catra," Adora gasps, her tone soft and pleading. Catra growls with satisfaction, sucking against Adora's skin as she laves her tongue over it. Adora whines, shifting beneath her. She isn't trying to get away, just writhing in the face of the onslaught. The movement causes her to tug on Catra's hair, something she *thought* she hated, but in this context it sends a jolt of pleasure shivering down her spin and sets her tail to lashing furiously. Adora's tug isn't harsh, just needy.

"Miss you. I think about you all the time," Adora gasps out, clearly trying to whisper, but she's a little far gone and it comes out as a desperate hiss. The words are a knife straight through Catra's heart. Adora is the one who fucking *left* her. Catra growls, digging her teeth in a little more as a warning this time. It doesn't work. Adora chokes

down another cry, rolling her hips down relentlessly now, but their position leaves her mouth free and she seems determined to use it.

"I was trying to get you out. That's why - *ah!* – I was playing both sides. We were going to kidnap you that week," Adora rushes out, the final word drawing short as Catra releases her neck and kisses her just to shut her up. Adora seems satisfied with what she managed to get out – or maybe she's just too far gone now to care about convincing Catra to come crawling back – and she kisses Catra back just as eagerly.

Catra's body was already on fire, and now so is her heart. The words relieve and also infuriate her. Adora wanted Catra to come with her – that's *better*, but the fact still remains that she decided she was happier with the Alliance. She was willing to leave everything behind to join them, planning to haul Catra around like a stray she expected to follow her anywhere. The worst part is she is kind of right. Catra wants to give in. She's so fucking lonely on her own. She wants to fall back into Adora's arms.

She won't. She already decided she would be a lone wolf. She's here to have her fun with Adora and that's it. Catra bites Adora's lower lip, tugging on it as she yanks herself back, illustrating her point by leaving Adora high and dry. Adora blinks at her in surprise, her gaze clouded over with lust, cheeks flushed, and chest heaving as she draws in panting breaths. She looks confused, making a small questioning noise as she shifts her hips a little. Catra forces her lip to curl.

"I'm not following you and your immortal gang around, Adora. What if I didn't want to leave? What were you going to do then?" Catra demands. She's fucking wet, but she doesn't really care anymore. The fire of arousal can easily be relit with anger. Adora blinks, the lust haze clearing from her eyes as she furrows her brow at Catra, seeming confused by her anger.

"They hurt people, Catra. Why wouldn't we leave if we could?" she asks. Catra stares at her. Of course the Horde hurts people, it

always has. They've known that since they were small children. They're not really in a better position to leave now than they were before. At least, *Catra* isn't. Adora is immortal. She can run as far as she wants and operate with impunity. Scorpia escaping already proved that.

Catra might not actually be mortal, but Adora doesn't know that even now. She just decided that she alone would be enough to protect them. They've already proven that isn't true. Catra has gone through hell for Adora, but Adora was willing to put her through more if it meant that she didn't have the guilt of helping the Horde on her conscious. Catra would have *killed* for her. She still fucking would.

"I never cared what they did. Not when we had each other . But that wasn't good enough for you," Catra returns. Adora looks stricken, opening her mouth, but before she can speak Catra turns and flees. Adora can't call after her or cause a scene by chasing her, not without risking drawing the attention of the Horde and compromising the job before it even happens. Catra can safely flee before tears sting at her eyes.

Adora is *everything* to her. She just wants to be the same to her, but it seems that even when people do care about her, it's as an afterthought.

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Adora tried to hide the dark hickey Catra left her beneath her hoodie when she got back, but she only managed to keep it secret for about five minutes before Perfuma asked her how Catra was, her voice faux-casual and gaze knowing. The hippie can be a little shit when she wants to be. The others were concerned that Catra might warn the Horde about the upcoming job, but when they hit the storehouse

two days later, the job goes off without a hitch. They manage to recover a decent number of items.

They can't burn this place like they do with the Horde's money. These are stolen objects. Some of them are just jewelry and gems, but others are weapons that could go off in a fire, and one or two are paintings that would be lost to history. They only manage to clear out a portion before four of them go down, but Adora is in charge of driving and in the relatively safe position of the car's cab. Glimmer wasn't subtle about glaring at Adora when she placed her there.

"I told you Catra wouldn't turn us in," Adora says, a bit proudly, as she settles on the couch after breakfast the next morning. She only waited to gloat because Glimmer was one of the four who needed to regenerate last night and she was the one most concerned about it. Glimmer rolls her eyes as she chucks a throw pillow in Adora's direction. Adora could catch it, but she chooses not to. It bounces harmlessly off her still-grinning face.

"If she's not actually helping the Horde and not being held prisoner, why is she even working for them? It was fair to be concerned," Glimmer shoots back. That sobers Adora. She doesn't know the answer to that. Catra said she knows that the Horde hurts people, but Adora can't imagine not caring, especially not when Catra was one of the people they hurt. There's a gap between them that opened the moment Adora went undercover.

Actually, it opened the moment Adora was promoted to captain and started taking big risks to better their position, it just became a yawning chasm once she went undercover. Was that what Catra meant? That she was happy enough when they were just an unremarkable heist team? She certainly hasn't been happy since, even when they had more freedom to be together. The pressure and the distance it forced between them was all too much.

Catra has been afraid of losing Adora ever since she was promoted, but those fears should have vanished once they found out that it wasn't possible. Fear isn't always reasonable, though. The way she

spoke was almost like she thought Adora cared more about the Alliance than her. Adora likes them, but she's known them for weeks, and she doesn't know if anyone can ever be as important as Catra, not even her supposed soulmate. They've been through so much together.

Adora doesn't have answers. She just knows that she needs to see Catra and explain what her plan really was. Hopefully she can find a way to word it where Catra will understand. Unfortunately, she has no way of finding her. She just has to hope Catra will show up again, but the job passes, and then a few days, and nothing. Adora is beginning to get worried all over again that Shadow Weaver locked Catra up again when she turns on the news and sees headlines about a heist at the nearby modern art museum.

It isn't technically in the Fright Zone. It's only a daytrip away though, and as the news anchors discuss what the police have discovered about the heist since last night, Adora puts together a picture in her mind that could only equal *Catra* even before the news anchors announce that the police believe the thief was a magicat. Adora doesn't know what Shadow Weaver is thinking sending Catra out on her own. Sure, she did it flawlessly, but she had no backup for if something went wrong.

Adora clenches her fist as the news anchor announces that the police have found a clue that links this case to several other heists in the Fright Zone. Yeah, no shit they did. It's Catra, but she had no one to watch her back. Things would slip through the cracks when you have to haul out seven paintings by yourself. This explains why Catra hasn't shown up again – she was busy prepping for this job – but it only makes Adora worry all over again.

Catra isn't locked up in a cell, but she isn't safe. Adora watches the police report intently, scanning for any detail that could help her find Catra. There aren't any. That's probably good, anything Adora could pick up on would probably be serious enough that it could put Catra at risk of being caught, but all she knows is that the job is tied to

several in the Fright Zone and that the thief only took impressionistic paintings.

The museum had paintings worth more, but they were untouched. That means a buyer that made requests, probably , but Adora never worked directly with buyers. She knew of a few of them, but generally Shadow Weaver would just tell her the job and the targets and leave their team to acquire the goods for sale. It's a dead end. Adora slumps on the couch. She knows that Catra isn't locked up, at least, and she has to hang onto that.

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Catra sells one of the pieces immediately, just to make a bit of profit, but they're too hot to move right now, and she didn't really take them to make money. Shadow Weaver took them to that museum when they were eight. It was weird that they got a daytrip out to be normal kids, but in the car on the way back, Shadow Weaver quizzed them about the museum's security measures that they had observed. It was all a test, one that Catra passed and Adora failed, though Shadow Weaver still blamed her for distracting Adora while they were there.

Catra never forgot the museum, though. It felt like it was almost a normal day. She liked the art, at least some of it. She hated the cubism, and some of the expressionism set her teeth on edge – Adora actually had to pull her away when a low growl started in her throat while she was looking at it – but Catra found the small impressionism section of the museum almost peaceful. She saw a world enhanced with imagination and beauty in the paintings there.

She's a free agent, she can do what she wants, including stealing priceless artwork for herself. She'll sell them when things have cooled off and she has found an appropriate buyer, but Catra has

stolen art before and she knows how to care for and transport it. She already has some climate-controlled displays for it hooked up when she gets back to her base. It adds life to the space that helps make up for the lack of windows.

The heist was more about drawing Shadow Weaver's attention than anything else. It will get under her skin, knowing Catra has ties to that museum. She will suspect, but she won't have any evidence. Catra hopes it drives her up the wall trying to get answers. She hopes she's so far up her own ass that can't even allow herself to believe that Catra could be special enough to be an immortal too. Actually, she's pretty sure that's going to be the case, that's why she's been leaving the calling cards.

They're literal cards. Business cards, actually, for a bar the Horde secretly owns. Catra snuck in and swiped a whole display of them. She slices a crescent into them and leaves them in the place of one of the things she has taken. She has only done it on the last two jobs, but three makes a pattern, and the attention has to be putting heat on the Horde now. There's no way the police won't investigate the bar, and even with their inside men on the force, pressure from another city might lead to action against it.

Adora really is going after the Horde all wrong. Catra hardly has to lift a finger, just doing what she would anyway, and she directs suspicion onto their operations. The bar could open an investigation that topples the whole thing, though most likely the police will realize that it's being used to launder money and paying its profits up to the Horde and just shut it down. It'll still hurt either way.

Catra lounges on her couch, gazing at the soft and almost romantic landscape she has displayed in the living room. It's the oldest piece, nestled in a heavy glass box with a humidity and temperature control unit to make sure it doesn't decay. It's kind of like having a glass-top coffee table with an art display inside. Catra has seen them at some of the bougie places they've robbed. This table is more expensive than all of those combined, probably.

She looks at the rolling hills and imagines laying amongst the soft grass decorating them, breathing in a fresh breeze with sun warming her fur. In her mind's eye, a hand pets through her hair, soothing her-

Fuck. Why can't she do anything without making it about Adora?

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The thing about hitting the Horde is that there was always a time limit on it. Adora goes to scout their next location and realizes it's empty. They've moved. Their territory has shrunk by a few blocks, but that doesn't stop them from hurting others. They need to do more, but Adora doesn't know what it is. Glimmer agrees that they'll keep trying, but her and Mermista switch focus to their regular style of jobs while they leave Adora and Scorpia to chase Horde leads. They haven't been taking in much from their smash-and-burn jobs against the Horde, after all.

They don't usually keep much from their jobs except what they need for equipment and a stipend for each of them, the rest going into donations, but after weeks of focusing solely on taking, Glimmer thinks it's a good idea that they add back in giving too, so she starts investigating a tip on a private art collection from her mother – apparently she's an art historian, because being a real historian was far too frustrating when she had to watch her colleges whitewash and sanitize history, especially wars – and Adora returns to her list of Horde locations.

She finds one that isn't outright abandoned after two weeks. She doesn't see anyone who seems to be a guard, though, so it could be that the Horde has moved on and a legit operation has replaced it. She sets up on a roof nearby to do surveillance. Hanging out on a street corner for too long gets suspicious, and she has a feeling she is going to have to wait awhile to determine if this is the Horde or

something else. She brings a blanket with her and spreads it out to make herself more comfortable.

Okay, so maybe she was hoping to make more than *herself* comfortable. She also brought hand sanitizer. She wishes she could just text Catra and they could meet up to talk. It was pretty clear that Shadow Weaver stole her phone after Adora kept getting responses – albeit brief ones – during the week that Catra was locked up. If she calls her, Shadow Weaver could track it, and if she texts her to arrange a meet up, Shadow Weaver could likely read it without Catra ever having to tip her off.

She just lies on the rooftop, trying to stay out of sight while keeping a careful eye on the storefront. She's lying on her stomach again, her arms pillowed on her backpack as she takes occasional notes on her phone. It was hot in the day, but the evening air is starting to cool down now as the sun sets. Adora is in the middle of making a note about the yellow car she has seen circle the block more than once now – she definitely doesn't trust it – when she feels a slight shift in the air.

She was waiting for it, so she's ready this time when Catra sneaks up behind her and then drops down to drape over her back. Adora smiles to herself, putting her phone to sleep and slipping it inside her backpack. She reaches back, clumsily petting the top of Catra's head blindly. She fumbles with her ear a bit as she does so.

"Can I turn over to see you?" she asks. Her tone is openly affectionate. Catra huffs and nips lightly at her hand. It's nothing like when she bit Adora as she was trying to gag her. This is light, the mere brush of teeth that Catra learned to use to avoid hurting Adora when they were kids. Catra turns away, giving a small and tiny sneeze to the side before she drapes heavily over Adora's back again.

"No, I like it here. I can't believe you brought fucking sanitizer with you," Catra responds. Right, the alcohol smell lingering on her hand would burn Catra's nose. Adora still can't help but smile as she

drops her arms back down to prop herself up again. She feels so at peace with Catra lying over her, a comforting weight. She opens her mouth to comment, but draws to a halt when Catra reaches around and covers her mouth with her hand.

"Don't speak and ruin it like last time. I might even let you get of f," she says. Adora frowns beneath the hand. She stays silent, waiting for Catra to remove her hand. Catra knows her though, so she waits. They're both expecting the other to break first. After a long moment, Catra huffs, withdrawing her hand and reaching into Adora's backpack. After a moment of fumbling around, she finds the hand sanitizer , sitting up straddled across Adora's ass to use it.

Adora uses the moment to check on the storefront. Nothing suspicious still, just two shoppers browsing inside. Either they've moved on, or this is a serious attempt at setting up a cover that might be more expensive than just finding a new location. Catra drops back down, putting the sanitizer back and immediately shoving Adora's shirt up her back to bunch it up around her armpits.

"Are all your scars going to fade?" she asks as her hands land on Adora's skin to stroke over the path of faint lines that webs her back. Adora mimes locking her mouth with a key, making Catra huff with irritation behind her. Adora smiles, letting herself relax a little as Catra sets to kneading against her back. Her claws hurt, yeah, but Catra knows to be mindful and not dig them in too much. It's the benefit of her being a magicat and not just a *cat*.

"Only major ones from before I froze linger , and even then they fade. If I had lost a chunk of my ear before becoming immortal or something, it wouldn't come back all the way, but over time it would be less noticeable," Adora answers. Catra hums behind her , a quiet purr starting as she shifts back to straddle her upper thighs and kneads against the top of her ass. Adora flushes, but she knows Catra probably just wants something proper to grab onto.

"The Horde abandoned this location a week ago," Catra volunteers from behind her in return for the information. Adora pauses, blinking

across the street at the storefront. Yeah, that fucking tracks, but she narrows her eyes as she thinks about the yellow car. She's been here just over two hours and seen it three times now.

"I think they're still watching it in case we show . Might be a lead," she returns. Catra releases a hum of acknowledgement before letting go of Adora's ass – and then firmly bringing her hand back down against it in a loud *smack*. Adora gasps, her hips stuttering involuntarily, making her twitch against the rooftop. Catra purrs, seemingly pleased with the reaction as she drapes back over Adora and sets to happily feeling up her sides.

Adora considers her options. Catra is more comfortable now. She could try telling her something, but she also doesn't want to send her running again. Adora isn't a patient person. She can't hold back long and they both know it, not even with Catra's lips pressing softly against the back of her neck, placing a slow, open-mouthed kiss there. It makes the hair on Adora's arms stand on end, a shiver passing through her body. She's missed this so much.

"Come home with me?" Catra breathes against her skin, her breath hot. Adora's heart leaps into her throat as she nods eagerly. She knows she should be suspicious given what happened last time, but Catra was always logical, and it doesn't make sense to go to the work of freeing her just to capture her again. Catra didn't have a choice the first time. She was pushed to her limit. That's not the Catra against her now.

"Please," Adora responds.

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Catra insists on driving them, even though it's Adora's car. She doesn't want Adora knowing where she lives, and giving her

directions is kind of counterintuitive to that. Adora lets her do it with minimal fuss. The car would actually be a good place to hook up, but Catra really wants to lay down in a bed today. She's supposed to be a lone wolf, but fuck, she *misses* Adora.

She just wants an hour or two of companionship, and even with Adora's attempts to make the roof comfortable, it wasn't going to be enough. On any other day, Catra would be annoyed by that, but she can't be bothered today. Adora was expecting her to show up and she doesn't even care. It's been long enough that she's desperate. Adora hasn't tried to talk it out so far at least. She frowns when she sits in the passenger seat and Catra hands her a blindfold. Catra rolls her eyes, shoving it closer to her.

"I'm not telling you where I live, you'll try to *kidnap me*," she points out. Adora's frown deepens, turning into full-on puppy eyes, but she takes the blindfold and reluctantly ties it on. Catra relaxes a little, the tension that was entering her body as she worried Adora wouldn't go along with this easing. She turns on the engine as Adora goes to buckle her seatbelt blind. Her backpack has already been tossed into the backseat. Adora is silent at first, reaching out blindly for Catra and landing a hand on her knee.

Catra's ears twitch as she keeps her eyes focused forward, but she drops her hand down and tangles her fingers with Adora's as she pulls out of the parking lot. Adora hums, seeming satisfied as she leans back in her seat and settles in for the drive. Catra shouldn't feel such a sense of calm just from having Adora's hand in her own again, but she catches herself purring just a little as she drives them away from the fringes of Horde territory, keeping an eye on the cars and streets around them to make sure they aren't being tailed.

"I would have told you the plan if Shadow Weaver wasn't listening. I didn't want to lie to you, just her," Adora says quietly, after a few moments of blissful silence. It doesn't shatter the peace – Catra has been expecting it from the moment she first spotted Adora on the roof. She sighs. She's had some time to think about what Adora said

at the gas station, and back on that first rooftop. Shit like *yours* and *I think about you all the time* aren't casual declarations.

Shadow Weaver is a poisonous bitch. She knew Catra was in the dark and she used it against her. Adora wasn't trying to leave her behind, but she still wasn't thinking about what Catra wanted. She was still taking a big risk with her life. She got caught up with her shiny new immortal friends and Catra became secondary. She always feared it would happen, but she thought it would be when Adora was eventually promoted and she was suddenly the most important person in the Horde.

Catra was a convenient companion when they were just cadets together, but at that point Adora could have anybody. Catra struggled to imagine Adora choosing her in the end. She still does now, knowing Adora has some soulmate out there that she must be yearning for. Catra doesn't give a shit about hers or even believe they really exist. The universe probably just cut her a break after a lifetime of shit – or maybe it only saved her to extend her suffering.

"Shut up, Adora," Catra returns. Adora hesitates in the passenger seat. Catra didn't put the kind of venom into her voice that threatens to drop Adora on a street corner if she doesn't stop talking. She's tired. She just wants to get Adora home and hold her. She's mad at her, but she won't be played by Shadow Weaver. Adora was an asshole, but she didn't totally abandon her – she just didn't think about what Catra wanted, assuming she would be happy to be dragged along in her wake.

"You were never going to be safe in the Horde. The Alliance promised to protect you," Adora adds, her voice quieter like Catra won't notice she's breaking the rule if she just speaks softly enough. Catra glares at the road ahead as she purposefully doesn't take the direct exit that would lead to her base. She doesn't think Adora is paying attention other than maybe counting how long it has been, but she wants to be safe.

"I didn't want protection, Adora. I'm doing fine on my own," Catra tells her, bitterness creeping into her voice. That makes Adora actually fall silent, slumping a little in the seat beside her. Catra sighs, shaking her shoulders out to release the tension of the conversation and squeezing Adora's hand in her own. Adora squeezes back and doesn't lessen her grip, just hanging on. After several moments, Adora shifts to petting along the back of her hand instead. She seems deep in thought. Eventually, she sighs.

"What can I do for you if it's not protection?" she asks. That throws Catra for a loop. She sends Adora an incredulous look out of the corner of her eye, but Adora can't see it around the blindfold, just frowning at the windshield as Catra pulls off the freeway. That question is stupid. All Catra ever wanted Adora to do was love her, not play hero and treat her like she was incapable. Catra has already been considered incapable enough.

"You can come home with me and fuck me like you mean it. I never asked you to protect me *once*, Adora. I can take care of my damn self," Catra throws back. Adora bites her lip, but she nods, tipping her head back to lean against her headrest. Apparently she has resigned herself to the rest of the drive. It's a good thing, because they're almost home.

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Adora agreed to the blindfold because she knew it was that or not getting to go home with Catra at all. She wants to know where she lives, but she figured she would at least get clues when she took the blindfold off upon arrival. It turns out she doesn't – Catra parks them in a garage that opens directly onto her current place. Adora stares at the concrete rooms as Catra drags her through them.

She sees what must be a planning room for Catra's solo jobs as they go, even if they only pass it briefly. It makes Adora frown as she glances in long enough to spot whiteboards, a computer, and what appears to be a police scanner. She really wants to ask Catra about these solo jobs – and just what the fuck is happening with the Horde in general – but given that Catra just told her to stop protecting her, she doesn't think it would be well-received.

Adora isn't sure how she is supposed to show Catra she gives a shit if she isn't allowed to protect her, but Catra says that she needs this right now, so Adora is going to focus on giving it to her and then figure out what's next later. On the way to the bedroom, she spots three of the paintings that Catra stole, all seemingly on display as Catra waits for the buyer to pick them up. Adora smiles a little bit at the way that Catra has them set up, as if she just wants to appreciate the art while she has it.

"What is this place?" Adora asks when they enter the bedroom and she finds it to be a concrete room just like all the others. Catra grabs her by the front of her shirt and raises her eyebrow as she walks them backwards towards the bed.

"A basement, obviously . Are we going to fuck or not?" Catra asks. Adora huffs, rolling her eyes, but she lets herself be pulled down onto the mattress. She has already pushed Catra as far as she can go today, she thinks. She doesn't seem as hurt today, even if she's clearly still mad. It's progress, and Adora will take that for the moment. If she doesn't, they're just going to slide backwards. Besides, she *really* wants to touch Catra. She kisses her eagerly as they fall into the sheets together.

Catra lets Adora lay over her, though she shoves at her clothes, seemingly eager to strip her. Adora is kind of desperate to get her hands on Catra too, though, so she guesses that is fair. She lets Catra yank her shirt up until they have to break the kiss to toss it aside, her sports bra following moments later. Catra purrs, her eyes immediately zeroing in on Adora's chest. She raises her hands, groping her happily.

"I've missed my two best friends," she says, grinning a little as she glances up to find Adora rolling her eyes. Catra has always had a thing for her tits, but she's just being ridiculous as she plays with them now. Despite that, Adora holds herself over Catra so she can have her fun, flexing her core to keep herself suspended and *maybe* show off a little while she's at it.

"You're an idiot," she responds, but her voice is dripping with affection. Catra just grins, leaning forward and nuzzling into Adora's chest, seeming determined to bury herself in tits. She purrs as she nudges against her. Adora doesn't miss the way that Catra rests her head against her chest for a long moment, her ear pressed right over Adora's heart to listen to its beat. She reaches up, burying her hand in the back of Catra's hair and softly stroking her fingertips through it.

She still doesn't know the story of the short hair, but it definitely isn't good, so she'll leave it for the moment. She pets through it, scratching a little at Catra's scalp. It ramps her purr up to a rolling vibrato, a sound that makes Adora sigh softly with happiness. It indicates true contentment from Catra. It makes Adora relax, happy to cradle Catra against her. Catra likes her tits, yes, but she suspects that was just a ploy to rest her chest here and relax for a moment.

After several seconds, Catra seems to realize how suspicious she's being and pulls back with her cheeks blazing, squeezing Adora's chest firmly as if to prove that was all she cared about before dropping her hands down to fumble with Adora's fly. Adora would promise her that she can lay there as long as she likes, but she doesn't want to put Catra on the defensive again. Instead she reaches for the collar of Catra's shirt, tugging on it as she undoes Adora's zipper.

"Do I get to have you naked too?" she asks, raising an eyebrow at her. Catra rolls her eyes, sending Adora an unimpressed look as she pulls down on her pants and underwear in one go as if to prove a point. Adora doesn't know what point she thinks she's making. She will happily let Catra fuck her if that's what she wants, but she's pretty certain it's not. She shifts off of her so she can kick her pants

off, tossing them aside to land on the rug that is substituting for a bedroom floor.

Adora has known Catra all her life, but she'll still never be used to how fast she moves. When she turns back to face her, Catra has already stripped off her shirt and pants, leaving her in just her stirrup socks and underwear. Adora freezes, her gaze sweeping down Catra's body. She's checking her for injuries as much as she is appreciating her. Well, okay, almost as much. Her gaze sticks on the way that Catra's underwear is already clinging to her. She doesn't even think about it when she involuntarily licks her lips, but Catra grins and wiggles her hips.

"Want a taste?" she teases. Adora rolls her eyes before she shifts to kneel between her legs, already reaching up for her underwear. The answer is, of course, *yes*.

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Catra slices through Adora's ponytail holder quickly, holding her mouth against her using her hair, but Adora shows no signs of stopping. She works her tongue over Catra eagerly, Catra's legs hooked over her shoulders. Adora's arms are draped over her hips to hold her against the mattress so she can work. If it weren't for the way Adora gives her total control over her head, tilting to follow Catra's tugs obediently, she might feel trapped. As it is, what she does feel is *amazing*.

She comes nearly screaming. She isn't as loud as Adora was when they were back in her apartment, but fuck, the way Adora sets to pleasing her like it's the only thing in the world that matters does things to her. The filthy noises of Adora's mouth against her are almost as loud as Catra's moans, and she moans herself when

Catra can’t contain herself and ruts up into her mouth. Catra really fucking needed this.

Pouncing on Adora in alleys is fun, but her body feels at peace after the orgasm rushes over her. Adora is beyond worked up from getting her off and she comes after just a few minutes of riding Catra’s fingers. Catra barely even does anything, watching with lazy satisfaction as she holds her hand in place and Adora works herself down onto her until she can’t take it anymore and drops a hand to touch herself.

What Catra really wanted comes after: Adora dropping into the sheets beside her so Catra can press their bodies together and cuddle her, purring with contentment as she rests her head on Adora’s shoulder. Adora is a sweaty, panting mess, but Catra loves her that way. She rubs scent marks against her collarbones and rumbles as Adora strokes her short hair with one hand and pets down her back with the other. After a few moments of just soaking it in, Catra sighs and rolls over, feeling a spark in her chest when Adora responds by whining and reaching for her again.

“I’ll be back,” she assures her. Adora frowns, but she lets Catra slip from the bed. She isn’t going far, just to her kitchen fridge and back. She knew what she was going to do when she left this evening and she prepared. She fetches the soda she left there to chill and brings it into the bedroom. Adora hasn’t moved from the bed, though she has pulled on her underwear. She raises a brow at Catra as she holds the glass out to her.

“What is it?” she asks, eyeing it dubiously. Catra rolls her eyes, but Adora looks no less wary. That’s fair considering she’s right.

“It will take an hour to work, but it’s what I could get my hands on that’s painless,” Catra tells her, climbing into the bed while still holding the glass out to Adora. She doesn’t want to ruin the post-orgasm contentment by heading back into Horde territory tonight. Adora pulls a face, wrinkling her nose at the drink.

"And you can't just drive me back because?" she prompts. Catra flushes, looking away as her tail thuds against the bed. She knows she's being pretty blasé about this, but it's easier to deal with Adora's immortality now that she has been through regeneration herself. Besides, she has other motivations for this. She doesn't want to *say* those, but she also doesn't want Adora to think she's totally disregarding her life. She huffs, fixing her gaze on a point on the wall as she speaks.

"Maybe I want to fall asleep with you. I'll drop your car off in the morning. I need to get my motorcycle anyway," Catra tells her in a rush of air. She tries to bury the confession by talking about the cars and logistics, but Adora still draws in a sharp breath of air. Catra risks sneaking a glance at her and finds her looking up at her with big puppy eyes again. Catra blushes furiously and shoves the cup in her direction.

"Just drink it so I know you won't go through my shit in my sleep," Catra orders her. After a moment of continuing to look at her with that weirdly-touched expression – Catra is handing her *poison* to drink, she shouldn't be looking at her like that – Adora reaches out and takes it. Catra made sure to get a soda Adora likes, but Adora still pulls a face after chugging half the glass, sticking out her tongue.

"That tastes like shit," she tells her, eyeing the glass dubiously. Catra rolls her eyes, but she reaches out for the glass, placing it on the end table instead. Adora doesn't need to drink all of it. Catra figured she wouldn't be able to drink a ton of the sugar water, so she used more poison than necessary. She makes a mental note to return to her research as she shifts to lay next to Adora's side again. Adora smiles despite the increasingly bizarre situations she finds herself in.

Catra sighs softly, happily wrapping herself around Adora's side and dropping her head onto her shoulder. She purrs to herself as Adora begins to slowly pet her to sleep. She's missed this so badly. The fact that she has to poison Adora to get to drift off to sleep with her is fucking dark, but their entire lives have been twisted. Catra hasn't

been sleeping on her own lately. She needs this, and Adora seems willing to give it to her with minimal complaint.

They drift off in each other's arms, a hand stroking through Catra's hair just like she has been desperately wanting.

Chapter End Notes

> Ive added a rough estimate chapter count. I think the fic is going to be 14-16 chapters, so Im putting the low-ball estimate up there and Ill bump it if need be.

Rendezvous

Chapter Notes

> Catra is not practicing motorcycle safety in her attire because she's immortal (Adora doesn't have a helmet either, but is also immortal). Don't be like them, folks. You will not regenerate. Seriously, wear the proper attire if you're gonna ride a motorcycle.

Okay, so ideally she and Catra would have woken up naked and happy together, and then Catra would have driven them back to her motorcycle with the blindfold off. It's embarrassing as hell to explain what happened – no matter how much she leaves out, she can't leave out the fact that she let Catra lead her around blindfolded, or the implications of what she followed her to do – but at least half the Alliance goes red in the face laughing. Mermista claps her on the shoulder and Glimmer gives her a fist bump.

They would probably berate her for being so reckless if they weren't busy making *congrats on the sex* jokes. Things certainly don't ease up when Glimmer volunteers to drive her out to her car and she spots Adora's clothes from yesterday folded in the passenger seat. They regenerate in whatever they were wearing, but Adora's clothes were on the floor when the spiked drink started making her eyelids heavy. She wanted to fall asleep with every inch of her pressing into Catra's fur.

It was worth it to get to hold Catra in her arms as hazy blackness clouded her vision. Besides, seeing Catra's place gave Adora an idea. She has no fucking clue where – or even what – it is, but she didn't forget the police scanner she spotted in the heist room. She can guess that Catra has been using it to track her down, but Adora is going to need a bit more to go on if she is going to do the same. She goes scanning through news sites for a place to start.

She finds mention of two robberies that look like they could be the work of her old team, but they're small. It makes sense given that they've lost Adora – it makes even more sense given that they seem to have lost Catra too. Both jobs were in the Wastelanders' territory, which at least gives Adora a lead. They're the Horde's biggest rival under normal circumstances, and it looks like they're both gearing up for a turf war now that the Alliance has weakened the Horde.

Adora asks Entrapta for a portable police scanner. She sets it up in the back of her car and drives to the fringes of the Wastelanders' territory, lingering and listening. She gets nothing the first night and a whole lot of nothing on the second. Things are busy, but none of it sounds like heist stuff. It isn't until the third night when she hears a call over the radio, consults the cheat-sheet of police codes that Bow gave her, and realizes it's for a silent alarm at a bank nearby.

Adora leaves her car behind – she can kill herself to escape, but she is *not* letting the cops get their hands on Swift Wind – and sprints towards it. A quick cast around reveals an alley with an opening just around the corner from the bank. It's a good spot both for hiding and loading the car. She isn't surprised to find Kyle parked there, smoking as he waits. His eyes go wide when he spots Adora, staring at her as she walks up to the passenger side door and opens it, dropping down into the seat. She grins at him as he swallows, looking her over and offering her a thin smile.

"Hi, Adora?" he says, his tone high and anxious. Adora's appearance seems to have undone all the work that his joint did. She reaches up, tapping her cheekbone just in front of her ear as a silent signal to switch his earpiece on. Kyle's eyes are still wide as he reaches up and switches his mic on.

"Cops are coming to a silent alarm tripped at this address a minute ago. Hi, Lonnie. Hi, Rogelio," Adora warns them. She can't hear any response from the passenger seat, but she doesn't have Catra's hearing. Kyle winces, so the team must have said something in response.

"I don't know , she just showed up!Now get out of there," he responds, reaching down to shift the car into drive. Adora snorts, glancing at the clock on the dash. She has a minute, maybe two, before she needs to get out of the car and head back to where she parked Swift Wind if she wants to avoid getting caught up in this shit.

"What happened to Catra?Why are you going on jobs separately?" she asks. She isn't prepared for the way Kyle twitches and then casts his eyes around. He was anxious before – now he looks shifty in a way she didn't even know that he could. He rapidly taps his finger against the steering wheel as he glances around. Adora raises an eyebrow at him. She doesn't have much time, but she can and will wait him out. After several long moments, Kyle sighs, seeming to give up.

"… *If* she is still around, she's working independently," he answers after a long moment, putting a suspicious amount of emphasis on *if*. Adora blinks at him as he winces, likely in response to something Lonnie is saying in his ear. Before Adora can ask him what the hell that means, there's a flash of movement behind them as Lonnie and Rogelio burst into the alley, both sprinting to the car.

"What are you waiting for?Go!" Lonnie half hisses, half yells as she flings herself into the backseat practically on top of Rogelio as they both rush to pile in before the cops arrive. Kyle gestures violently at Adora in the passenger seat.

"I'm not taking her with us!" he replies. Lonnie groans, fighting to sit up and pointing a finger so far in Adora's face that she startles back to avoid getting jabbed in the nose.

"Shadow W eaver gutted Catra for helping you, but Kyle' s dumb ass helped her escape. We haven't seen her since and as far as the Horde is concerned, she's dead. Now *fuck off*. We already saved your girlfriend. Don't repay us by getting us arrested," Lonnie tells her. Adora's heart is pounding at that information, but shit, Lonnie's right. Adora has a thousand follow up questions, but her first minute

is up already. She nods, opening the car door and hurrying to get out.

She takes off at a run back towards Swift Wind as he pulls out of the alley. As she jogs, her head pounds. Shadow Weaver *gutted her*. The Horde thinks she's dead. The wound was bad. Somehow, he got his hands on her. Was he tapped to drag her to the body chute? He's not a good choice for it. He would need help, but Lonnie would have mentioned if that help was Rogelio. Adora can't imagine anyone else that would have helped him just going along with it.

The rest of them are clearly still working for the Horde, but if Shadow Weaver knew he betrayed her , she would have disposed of him as swiftly as she tried to do with Catra. If he didn't happen to have access to her after the injury, then that means he somehow came across her and helped her sneak away without it being caught on camera.

Adora is gasping by the time she reaches Swift Wind, and it isn't just from the run. She pulls out of her parking spot calmly, but adrenaline is pumping through her body as a flicker of hope begins in her chest. *What if* .

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Catra tries to give Adora a bit of room after bringing her home. She doesn't want to give her any ideas about this being anything more than what they had together in the Horde. They care about each other – Catra tried to stop loving Adora as she was lying on the floor of the interrogation room and all she ended up doing was hurting – but Adora still left.

Catra didn't force herself to walk away from the Horde just to have Adora treat her like a sidekick that she can drag around however she

likes. She's tired of being second-rate. Her urge for intimacy satisfied, she refocuses on planning her next heist. She has a big one planned, the kind of heist that will definitely get Shadow Weaver's attention, but she needs funds to pull it off, so she decides to go for the tried-and-true classic of a bank robbery.

It doesn't work out. For the first time since the panicked gunshot on the roof, Catra is forced to regenerate as the cops close in on her. She didn't expect to be scared like she is. She knows that she has regenerated twice already. She'll do it again. She can't let herself be fucking arrested, if only to avoid giving Shadow Weaver the satisfaction of her failure. She takes the first of her three pills with shaking hands. She wakes up back on the blanket.

She means to leave Adora alone, but she just feels cold after that. She gives it a day, and then two, but it doesn't fade. She would worry a piece of her got left behind somehow if she didn't already know that a piece of her is always missing. Adora carries it with her. Catra just died, and despite being fine, she wants the comfort of Adora against her. She's so fucking weak for her. She should be better than this after all the proof she has that Adora doesn't care about her with the same intensity, but she's craving her touch.

It could be any touch, she tries to rationalize to herself as she forces herself to put in the footwork to case the area around the auction house that she is planning to hit soon. Their vault is no joke and needs a good plan if she's going to get in, especially now that she doesn't have the funds from the failed bank job. She's exploring the area on her motorcycle, looking for possible entranceways, when the sound of sirens catches her attention, seemingly just a street or two away

She tells herself she follows the sound to make sure someone else isn't going after her target, but she knows what she's hoping to see when she arrives. She knows she'll probably be too late and it likely won't be the Alliance anyway, but she's desperate. She doesn't expect anything, but she's greeted by a car chase taking off from the scene when she arrives. That interests her even if it isn't the Alliance

– it's a distraction from the ache in her chest – so she takes off after it. Her motorcycle is far more maneuverable than the van or the cop cars.

It takes her only a few seconds to get alongside the van. A glance at the driver's seat confirms they're wearing the black helmet and gear that all of the Alliance wears for jobs where subtlety isn't reqired. This car chase is the furthest thing from subtle. Catra rolls her eyes and speeds her bike up, easily overtaking the van and slotting herself in front of them. Her position at their side was vulnerable – if she got shot by one of the cops, Adora would *freak* – but she also wants to lead them.

Catra doesn't have much of an escape plan for the job, but Adora can still benefit from Catra's planning. When she peels off to the side, she is pleased to find that the van follows her. Catra smirks to herself as she leads them on another sharp turn, this time in the opposite direction, and then immediately loops into a parking garage. She carefully swings her bike around the barrier, but the van smashes through it as Catra leads them through the underpass to the sister parking garage across the street.

A tunnel that spans the block lets them out on the other side of a set of apartments after dodging – and smashing – another barrier. Catra can still hear the cops scrambling in the distance, but she knew that weaving tactic would lose them. Now it's just a matter of getting away before they spread out the search. She eases up on the gas to not draw too much attention. She almost feels like preening as the van continues to follow her until they're just driving, eventually coming to a halt in a small, rundown parking lot for an abandoned drive-through.

Catra parks her bike, the van pulling up two spots away from her slowly. With her back turned to the van, she slowly pulls her helmet off. Her ears twitch back at the sound of the van door sliding open. Catra shakes them out, taking a deep breath of relief now that they're free. Casually, she hangs her helmet on the handlebars of

the bike before she turns around to find Adora hopping out of the van, grinning from ear-to-ear.

"Hey , beautiful. Come here often?" Adora greets, because she' s an unoriginal *dork*. Catra blushes, her ears twitching as she rolls her eyes. She sends Adora an unimpressed look as Adora crosses the parking lot in a few strides and pulls Catra into her arms. Catra spotted at least three others in the back of the van with her, plus the driver, but neither of them have any regard for Adora's new team as Adora drops one hand to Catra's hip and the other to her shoulder, pulling Catra in for a kiss that is far too sensual for public.

Catra's tail lashes against her bike as she reaches up to hook her arms over Adora's shoulders, sighing softly into the kiss. Adora's hands on her tighten, holding Catra close and kissing her slowly despite the fact that they are in the middle of a parking lot with the adrenaline of a car chase fading behind them. Adora's movements are purposeful as she sets to exploring Catra's mouth. She knows all the contours of it already. Behind her, someone clears their throat.

"Seriously? W e need to get out of sight," a woman' s voice says. Catra melts a little at how Adora doesn't *stop*, not right away at least. They weren't really expecting to see each other, and apparently Catra's sudden appearance is just as tempting to Adora as hers is to Catra. Adora slows the slide of their lips to end the kiss naturally and pulls back to nuz e Catra' s cheek instead. Catra trills before she can stop herself, flushing and burying her face in Adora's neck. Adora seems delighted with the noise, grinning as she tucks her chin down to press a kiss into Catra's hair.

"Y ou guys go on ahead," she calls back, shifting to wrap one arm around Catra's waist and waving the other vaguely behind her as she shoos her crew away. Catra absolutely wants Adora to herself, but she still pulls back to raise an eyebrow at Adora. Adora is still grinning. "W anna get a hotel room?" she asks. Catra glances down at her gear and snorts. She's definitely paying for this one – there's no way Adora has her wallet on her, it would be a stupid thing to

bring on a heist – but she's okay with that if she gets to have Adora in a bed.

"What, you're too good for parking lots now? You weren't picky last time, princess," Catra shoots back, just to watch Adora flush and shift with embarrassment. Adora is standing between Catra and her team, but a glance over her shoulder confirms that they're all looking back and forth between each other. Catra definitely picks up someone muttering '*hoe*.'

"*Catra*," Adora hisses, but the flush on her cheeks doesn't make Catra want to stop. She grins from ear-to-ear as she steps back and grabs her helmet.

"You can't scream in a hotel either, princess. You'll get us kicked out," Catra tacks on. Adora is flushed up to her ears now, raising her hands up to bury her face in them as one of the women in the car responds with a long and drawn-out wolf whistle. Catra continues to smirk as she swings her leg over her bike, scooting up on the seat to give Adora room to get on behind her. Catra looks past her to send the smirk towards the Alliance.

"Don't worry, I'll have her home by ten AM," she tells them, only grinning more when Adora releases a noise caught between *affronted* and *turned on*, moving quickly to climb onto the bike behind her. Adora hooks her chin over Catra's shoulder, digging it in a little just to be a little shit as she wraps her arms around Catra's waist.

"You're an asshole," Adora hisses in her ear, still flustered as the Alliance gapes at them. Catra's smirk is pure amusement now as she reaches down and takes Adora's thigh in her hand. Adora releases a brief, strangled sound before she realizes that Catra is repositioning her leg to be in the correct position for riding, quickly moving to mirror it on the other side.

"Don't fucking kill her this time. She's regenerated too much lately," someone from the van finally says as Catra feathers the gas with the break still on for the hell of it. That makes Catra's smile fall, replaced

by a frown as she looks over and nods seriously. She's going to have to ask Adora for details on that, but it can wait. Once she is satisfied Adora won't fall off, she releases the brake and swings them out of the parking lot. She doesn't know what hotel she's taking them to, but the answer is likely going to be the first one she sees.

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Adora really wasn't expecting Catra to show up given they were on a job unrelated to the Horde. She's eager to spend time with Catra, but she's also grateful for her knowing the area and leading them out. She's confident the others will be fine now, so she happily follows her to a hotel. Catra isn't subtle when she asks for a room for one, but the receptionist looks at worst indifferent and at most envious as she gets them a room.

Catra has the exact kind of confidence to her that makes Adora want them both naked immediately. If Catra was over everything then she would just call Adora, so clearly they still have problems, but she doesn't seem bitter today as she unlocks the room and then promptly grabs Adora by the front of her jacket, grinning as she pulls her into the room, absently kicking the door shut behind them as she pushes Adora against the wall.

Adora gets a moment to draw in a breath and feel her desire spike at the man-handling before Catra stretches up on her toes and kisses her. Her pride is well-earned, but that doesn't stop Adora from wrapping her arms around Catra's back and fisting her shirt in her hands, holding her close and establishing a little dominance of her own. She has had an idea forming in her mind ever since her hopeful epiphany a few nights ago.

If she wants to go through with it, she needs to be on top. She might have to work her way to that, though. Back in the showers, they only

ever had time for one of them to get off each day. Here there is no time limit. As long as Adora keeps her mouth shut and doesn't get them kicked out, they can both lay out naked on the mattress together. Catra's confidence has affected her. If Catra wants to have first go, Adora doesn't have any problem letting her.

Catra kisses her eagerly, worked up from the chase. Adora is too, but the hope in her chest has her even more excited. She tilts her head down, giving Catra better access. Catra purrs softly, her hands running along Adora's sides to feel her up as she pins her bodily to the wall. Adora misses the feeling of their bodies pressed against each other – in bed, in the shower, or even innocently as they passed through the halls with an arm thrown over each other's shoulder when they thought they could get away with it.

Adora is completely pressed against the wall, Catra pinning her there with her mouth. She likes it – fuck, does she like it – but she would also really like to lie in the bed with Catra again. She tugs on the back of Catra's shirt, never breaking the kiss but still encouraging Catra to pull back. She seems reluctant, pressing in harder for a long moment before she acquiesces. She probably thinks Adora is going to talk, but she's willing to wait until she gets her confirmation for that.

"Bed?" Adora asks, breathlessly, when Catra has pulled back enough for her to breathe. The pinch in Catra's brow smooths away as she grabs Adora's jacket and pulls her in a stumbling path back towards the bed Adora had taken about two seconds to glance at before deciding it is the place she wants to be. To her surprise, Catra releases her when they reach it, dropping down to sit on its edge and crossing her legs as she looks Adora up and down slowly.

"Strip for me, *princess*," Catra orders. Adora's mouth grows dry, a shiver running down her spine as her hands immediately fly to undo her jacket's clasps and zipper. She shrugs it off her shoulders, letting it fall behind her to expose the white tank top she's wearing underneath. It's tight because it's an undershirt, but Catra's pupils

dilate and she licks her lips when she sees it, her eyes roaming greedily over Adora's torso.

Adora smirks as she goes for her waist, undoing the buckle and letting her fly fall open to expose the tease of her red boy shorts. Catra's eyes dart all along her body as Adora steps forward, her feet on either side of the one that Catra has planted on the ground. Adora leans down, hooking a hand behind Catra's neck and pulling her up into a kiss. The embrace is hungry, their tongues meeting awkwardly as they both try to take control, but Adora certainly doesn't mind. She has always loved competing with Catra.

One of Catra's hands lands on her lower back, fingers splayed and claws *out*. Adora shivers as Catra drags them slowly up her back, careful not to draw blood, though Adora is fairly certain she rips the shirt a little. She's going to have traces of the marks on her back at least and it makes her heart pound as Catra's other hand drops into her waistband, curling around it and tugging down. A possessive growl buzzes against Adora's tongue, a new sensation even after how long they've been doing this. They had to be quiet before.

"*Naked*, Adora," Catra orders, her voice rough with desire. Adora feels sparks of heat dance through her as she obediently straightens and pushes her pants down all the way. Catra grumbles with displeasure at the lost of the kiss, but she gave Adora an order, and she's merely following it. Adora grins as she toes off her boots and steps out of her pants, kicking them aside to join her jacket without a second thought.

"You're only having me strip because you didn't know how to undo the jacket, aren't you?" she asks as she reaches for the hem of her tank top. Catra narrows her eyes at her, watching Adora pull off the shirt. She makes sure to flex her torso and send Catra back the exact kind of cocky smirk that drives her up the wall as she does so. She's in just her underwear, bra, and socks now.

"I promised to send you back alive, but I said nothing about your clothes being intact," she threatens, which is a resounding *yes*.

Adora just grins as Catra reaches out, grabbing her by the hips and swinging her around to the edge of the bed. Adora lets herself be maneuvered until she lands on the bed lying on her back. She's totally at Catra's mercy in this position, and even though Adora knows that pretty much always means *orgasm* and nothing else, the thought sends a jolt of excitement up her spine as Catra slips her hand inside her underwear and proceeds to not touch her.

Instead, Catra snaps her claws out and cuts a careful slit outwards, leaving her underwear as a decorative frame around her and not much else. Adora flushes, her hips shifting as they desperately seek Catra's touch and an involuntary whine escapes her throat. Catra chuckles, only looking up from where she was keeping a careful eye on the cut after she has slid her claws away. All that sure confidence is back, but she just made Adora fucking whimper without touching her, so she's earned it.

"So easy for me," Catra teases her , her voice so faux-sweet it dips right back into genuine as her hand finally drops to trace over Adora. Adora is still partially dressed, but she's also totally exposed before Catra, and the thought makes her clench down on nothing as Catra's touch rubs almost lazily between her folds. The movement doesn't go unnoticed. Catra grins, slow and predatory as she slides her fingers down and presses against Adora's entrance.

Maybe Adora was rubbing herself against the motorcycle seat on the way here. Maybe she's been a little wet since she spotted Catra's motorcycle in the midst of a car chase. Maybe she can admit that she's only a top some of the time and Catra's cocky air in bed could make her bend over, drop to her knees, or spread out facedown if Catra requested it. Whatever the reason, Catra presses in with two fingers and sinks down to the second knuckle without even trying.

Adora whines, her entire body lighting up with the excitement of *yes, finally*. Catra's grin doesn't fade as Adora shifts her hips, desperately trying to fuck herself on Catra's fingers since Catra isn't doing it for her. Finally, Catra rocks her fingers forward, immediately setting a brutal pace that has Adora choking down a sob of relief. She needs

it, her breath coming fast and heavy. Her hips are twitching to meet Catra as she takes everything she will give.

It's exactly what Adora needed. She tips her head back, her eyes falling closed as one hand fists the sheets and the other drops to rub at her clit as Catra fucks her. Half of her expects Catra to bat her hand away and draw this out, but she seems to realize how badly Adora needs to come at this point. She seems happy to rail Adora through the mattress, only shifting to cover Adora's mouth with her other hand when her moans and gasps begin to slip out.

A few minutes of Catra above her, and Adora is totally lost, the heat between her legs flaring and overcoming her entire body until she collapses back against the mattress panting.

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Watching Adora fight for dominance and then crumble so easily has Catra clenching all by itself. Watching how she completely loses herself as Catra fucks her almost has her awestruck, but luckily Adora seems to be so far gone that she doesn't notice. She can barely keep her eyes open, her lids fluttering as she keens beneath Catra's touch until she can't take it anymore and touches herself. It's still Catra's name that she has to muffle beneath her hand as Adora comes.

Catra is riding some kind of endorphin high. She stretches out in the bed beside Adora, watching with amusement as she tries to sleepily fumble with Catra's clothes, whining when they don't just magically disappear in her hands. Catra snickers, propping herself up and dropping a kiss into Adora's hair that earns her a happy hum. She can't hide the fond smile on her face as she sits up and pulls her shirt off over her head, tossing it to the foot of the bed.

She never wears bras. Her clothes for heists are secure enough that she doesn't need the extra support at her size, unlike Adora. Today she's just wearing some jogging shorts and a t-shirt, though, so once she has discarded the top, she's most of the way to naked. She flops back down on the bed beside her and gets another happy hum as Adora reaches out and wraps Catra in her arms, petting her hands through every inch of exposed fur she can touch. Yeah, Catra kind of figured that was what she was after.

"You're ridiculous," Catra tells her, but her voice is fond as she leans forward and presses a soft kiss against Adora's forehead. Adora does nothing to disprove Catra as she immediately ducks her head forward and buries her face in the fluffy patch over Catra's heart. The sigh of content she releases has Catra blushing as she drops a hand into Adora's hair and strokes the back of her head.

"I miss you. I just want you back," Adora whines against her chest, apparently lost in the post-orgasm haze that has never turned her into a whiny brat before, but there's a first time for everything. Catra's heart skips a beat. She shouldn't be so happy to hear that, but it shows that Adora wasn't lying back at the gas station. Catra has been thinking about her declarations ever since she processed the revelation that Adora – however stupidly – wanted Catra to come with her when she defected.

"Roll over for me?" Adora requests, softly. Catra, grateful for the reprieve from the tangled emotions threatening to well up in her chest, shifts back, turning to stretch out on her stomach beside Adora. Adora shifts closer, ducking her head to kiss a knotted scar along Catra's shoulder blade. Catra sighs, content to soak in some physical affection. When Adora touches her like this, it's easier to believe that she really does miss her.

"Your scars have faded. Some of them are gone," Adora whispers against her skin. The heat of Adora's breath penetrating her coat from this close is the only reason Catra shivers. She hates how her heart leaps at the idea of Adora paying such close attention to her, but maybe she shouldn't. Adora was always an attentive partner

before all this. She still is now. She says shit like *yours* and *I think about you all the time* after all.

Part of Catra is too hurt and damaged to believe it. No one could feel about her that way, least of all someone with a soulmate out there for them. She can't take believing Adora could love her only to have it ripped away, especially when Adora was already careless with her heart once, but the rest of her is too cold and lonely right now to resist the warmth of Adora's lips grazing over her back. She's apparently on a quest to kiss all of Catra's scars.

"That's what scars do, Adora," Catra points out, fighting to keep her voice level. She turns her head, glancing awkwardly over her shoulder at Adora. It is supposed to be a quick glance, but she finds herself trapped when she catches Adora's burning gaze, her lips still pressed to a faint line disturbing Catra's coat pattern. It did used to be a lot worse, but Catra doesn't know why she cares.

"Not this kind. Not this fast," Adora returns, her eyes dropping down to sweep along Catra's back again. Apparently she finds a new cluster of scars, because she shifts down and sets to kissing the small of Catra's back. Catra shivers, letting her head drop back down to the pillow if only to avoid getting a crick in her neck. Her heart pounds, remembering her conversation with Adora about her own scars. Does she know?

Catra has been justifying hiding her immortality by telling herself that they just haven't really been talking, but she knows the truth. Any time she and Adora lie in bed together, there's the ghost of Adora's soulmate between them. Catra couldn't stand the distance if her own soulmate's body was added in, especially when Catra doesn't care about her. She doesn't want to tell Adora she is immortal and have more distance forced between them.

She needs a distraction. She can't take this. Adora's touch is too soft, too caring. Catra's starting to believe in it and she already swore to herself she and Adora were just going to be a physical thing from now on. Outside of four horrible, starving days, Catra has

always known that she and Adora care about each other, but there's a difference between care and love. She isn't letting herself down again.

"What was the Alliance talking about with you regenerating too much?" Catra asks, deflecting the topic. Not by much, but she does need to ask about that anyway, and she grabs at the first excuse that she can think of. Adora sighs, kissing a spot near the base of her tail that has Catra shivering before she shifts back up to wrap her arms around Catra's waist, holding her from the side.

"When you regenerate too much in a short span it starts taking longer. Like, you can still reappear in your bed after just a few moments if no one is looking at you, but you'll spend hours asleep while your body catches up. I just had a run of bad luck. Did you keep the gun you took from me back on the roof, by the way?" Adora clarifies for her. Catra frowns into the pillow. That's definitely important information for her to know, though she hopes she never has to regenerate that frequently .

"No. Why , are they making you use rubber bullets now that you don't have it?" she asks, trying for teasing. They're both damn good shots and neutering Adora like that is just ridiculous. The truth is that Catra dropped it when she shot herself to escape as well. Her clothing and gear seem to move with her, but anything that she's just holding or touching doesn't. Behind her, Adora sighs dramatically and nods.

"Y ou lose your immortality if you kill someone, but I have no intention of doing that. I know what I'm doing. They all prefer to stick with rubber bullets, though," Adora tells her , kissing her shoulder. Catra grunts a low acknowledgement. That is important information to have. Clearly other immortals don't count considering what she has done with Adora, but she is going to have to be careful. She isn't about to let this ability slip through her fingers.

Adora's words are giving her an idea, actually. She might know how to compensate for the failed bank job. She needs to go review her plans. She never planned to see Adora today anyway and she was

supposed to go buy a phone tonight to call her potential buyer with. She's been putting it off to avoid the temptation to call Adora with it. Reluctantly, Catra sighs and shifts to sit up. Adora whines a little, clinging onto her. Despite herself, it makes Catra smile.

"It's time you went home," she tells her, reaching over to ruffle Adora's hair only a little patronizingly. This dalliance has lasted long enough. She feels calmed in some ways and ruffled in others, but the cold that permeated her bones is gone. Seeing Adora settled her, even if she hates the space between them that only becomes more obvious when they're in the same room.

"We paid for the night," Adora points out. Catra's tail thuds. They did, but if Adora's new crew has any decency to them, they'll be concerned anyway.

"And I got my money's worth already. I need to get you back before the magic wears off at midnight. Come on," Catra returns, moving to sit up in the bed. Adora sighs, but she lets Catra go.

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Catra realizes when they get to the parking lot that she has to drive Adora home. Adora is ridiculously happy about that. It means that Catra knows where she lives now. She has a way to find Adora outside of jobs and gunfire. Adora would have been worried about bringing her over when she thought she was still with the Horde, but only because she might be tracked. Now that she knows Catra has been a free agent for a while, she has no problem listing off the address of the penthouse.

Catra drops her off on the sidewalk outside the apartment complex. Adora rides there with her arms wrapped tightly around Catra's waist. They didn't get to switch before Catra decided she was done,

but they didn't need to. As soon as Adora saw Catra's back, she knew. She knows Catra's scars intimately. Most of the ones on her back are the permanent kind, and yet many of them are now faint or *gone*. Her back is mostly stripes and soft fur.

There's only one explanation for it all that makes sense to Adora. She was trying to bring it up when Catra shut her down. She wishes they could just talk and *be*, but if Catra died freeing her, Adora doesn't blame her for being a bit resentful. That seems to be her main issue. She's been more than willing to bed Adora like before, even with the question of their soulmates between them.

Adora pouts at Catra until she takes off her helmet and gives her a goodbye kiss, and then heads back up to the penthouse bouncing on her toes a little. She has research to do before she pushes the subject further with Catra. Upon entering, she waves vaguely at Scorpia and Entrapta, curled up together on the sofa as Entrapta talks a thousand miles a minute about something and Scorpia listens, nodding intently.

No one else is out in the main area, which means Adora has a bit of deliberation on who she's going to disturb with this. Her obvious options are Mermista, Perfuma, and Glimmer. Mermista and Sea Hawk are the oldest, but Adora doesn't think Sea Hawk is going to be an amazing teacher. Perfuma is the second-eldest compared to them, but she explained soulmates to Adora the first time around, and that wasn't helpful.

Glimmer knows a lot from being raised by her mother, but she doesn't like to talk about soulmates. Her relationship with Bow is so complicated. They aren't together, but they kind of are, but they've also never even kissed. Bow professed his love to Glimmer after she died the first time, panicked by losing her. Glimmer reciprocated, but she was afraid that he could be her soulmate and was now locked in as mortal. They've never pursued a real relationship despite knowing they both have feelings and could.

Adora found this out from Bow when she asked how he fell in with the Alliance as a mortal. Glimmer won't start a relationship with him and definitely lock him in as mortal, but she also thinks that he already is, so she worries about him dying. She doesn't want a repeat of her mother's situation, so she denies them both happiness. Bow had sounded resigned about it when he explained it. Yeah, Adora's not touching that tangle of bitterness tonight.

She heads to Mermista and Sea Hawk's room, knocking on the door and getting a response after a moment. When she enters, she finds Mermista splayed out between her aerial trapeze strap-things – the ceiling in this room goes up two stories, that's why Mermista got it as her room – in a split that makes Adora wince. Sea Hawk is settled on a loveseat, seeming to be just watching his wife do her thing.

"Back from your sexcation?" Mermista asks, switching her position to some kind of upside-down flip. Adora doesn't know the name of any of this or what century Mermista even picked it up in, but it is beautiful, and it's good exercise as well. Adora rolls her eyes, closing the door behind her as she steps into the room and leans against the wall.

"I have something to ask you about soulmates," Adora tells her. She can't respond to the sexcation comment – it's true and there's no denying it. She knows she and Catra have a relationship that is a bit...much, but if there's anyone who can't talk, it's Mermista and Sea Hawk. Adora has watched her kill Sea Hawk to win an argument and he didn't even seem slightly perturbed. After hundreds of years together, they're just used to it.

Mermista immediately pauses, turning her head to exchange a glace with Sea Hawk. Wordlessly, Sea Hawk stands and goes over to deal with Mermista's counterweight, lowering her raised fabric trapeze down so she can slip out from them. Yeah, that's definitely nerve-inducing. Adora watches Mermista extricate herself from the trapeze and walk up with a building feeling of dread. It isn't lessened when Sea Hawk salutes them both and then leaves the room, giving them privacy.

"It's complicated," Mermista warns her, crossing her arms and looking Adora up and down. Adora is still wearing her gear over her partially shredded underwear. She knows Mermista can't actually tell that, but she shifts a bit beneath her gaze regardless. Complicated is actually good for Adora in this case.

"You said you don't get to be immortal if you've been with your soulmate before dying. How do you know who your soulmate is?" Adora responds. It's diving straight into the heart of what's complicated, most likely, but Adora needs answers. The corner of Mermista's mouth quirks up. She seems to have been expecting the question.

"They're the person who your life wouldn't be complete unless you got to love. If you got to, then your purpose is fulfilled and you get locked in as mortal. You learn who your soulmate is by loving them and realizing how much they mean," Mermista explains. She's describing Catra, and yet Adora should be mortal. She frowns, looking down at her boots while she thinks. Hope won't stop beating in her chest. She can't imagine finding anyone else who makes her feel like Catra does, not when their bond was forged in a fire that hopefully will never be recreated in their lives again.

"Catra and I were together for five years, but I never really got to love her. I never even got to *say* it. It was all secret rendezvouses when Shadow Weaver wasn't looking. We never got to just be happy," Adora whispers. She doesn't dare voice it louder. It feels like the universe will take it away if she does. Mermista doesn't say anything for a moment. Adora glances up to find Mermista looking contemplative.

"Listen, when we told you that Catra had to be mortal, we just heard that it had been five years and assumed you weren't being fulfilled. It isn't as simple as just saying 'I love you' or kissing them, but if you feel like you never got to share your love, then it's possible. The rules aren't hard and fast. It's hard to be happy together in secret. I've had my suspicions ever since the kidnapping," Mermista tells her. Adora's heart feels like it's beating in her throat.

She's had so much hope ever since Lonnie told her about Catra's miraculous escape. Shadow Weaver gave them permission to be together after Adora died, but given that they couldn't say anything without her listening and then Adora immediately went undercover, it still wasn't getting to *love* each other. Adora loved Catra, but she never got to express it, not the way she wanted to. She never felt like they fulfilled their relationship. She always wanted them to be able to have more.

"We don't know a lot about the nature of soulmates. Some people believe you're born with a predetermined soulmate. I think that's bullshit. It's just the person who makes you happiest. If it's some fated individual, then the universe played a cruel joke on Angella by having her other half be born two thousand years later. She isn't the same person now that she was back then either. It doesn't make any sense for destiny to have put her through millennia to become Micah's soulmate," Mermista adds on after a moment of silence where Adora just thinks.

Adora blinks at Mermista. That makes more sense than the fate angle. It also means it's possible for someone to only become your soulmate after you've died. If that's the case, then Adora has even more hope for her and Catra. They have fucking problems and they always have, *clearly*. Maybe that was what was getting in the way. Adora loves Catra with every fiber of her being, and she can't imagine outliving her. She knew Catra was it for her since she was a fucking child.

Adora releases a breath that she didn't realize she has been holding for weeks. Catra is her soulmate. She has to be. Now she just has to convince Catra of that.

A Little Messed Up (like you)

Catra doesn't know what to think after their hotel date. It felt so good to just *be* with Adora. As much as she was immediately resistant to Adora's words, they worm their way beneath her skin, echoing in her heart as she goes about her day. She tries to distract herself by working on the big job she has been planning for a while, especially since the conversation with Adora gave her an idea for how to compensate for the botched bank job. She doesn't have the funds to acqire the supplies to get out, but she doesn't have to.

She just needs to get into the auction house, grab the jadeite necklace, and kill herself before security can reach her. If she wears it and dies out of sight, she should regenerate qickly with it. It' s a risky plan, but the security around the fifteen-million-dollar necklace is tight. Catra's pretty sure the Horde would have stolen it already if they thought that they could. They have several gemstone buyers, and luckily, Catra has a perfect fucking memory. When she calls, Eddie is still at the same number she glimpsed on Shadow Weaver's phone once. When she asks if he wants the necklace, the silence is deafening.

"The Horde told me it wasn't possible," he replies after a long moment. The corner of Catra's mouth qirks up.

"I told you the Horde gave me your number , not that I worked for them. I can get it," she returns. She swears his breathing gets *heavy* at the mere thought. Catra's personal opinion is that the semi-transparent necklace is ugly, but it's expected to beat its previous price tag of fourteen million at this auction, so she's invested regardless of the necklace's looks. Eddie is eager for it if she can deliver. He has no faith that she can, but Catra doesn't give a shit.

She proves him wrong. She gets her hands on the necklace, throws it on, and then shoves herself into a corner and takes her stolen pills as the alarms blare. He's fucking shocked when she arrives at the

meetup point still wearing it. It's insurance in case the deal goes south, but Catra walks away from the whole thing with ten million and a new spot at the top of Eddie's speed dial for any future jobs in the Fright Zone. That will piss Shadow Weaver off even more than the stolen necklace.

Catra wonders if she knows yet. The museum job would have been a big tip off if she was paying attention. Shadow Weaver must have noticed the calling cards, regardless of if any investigation came of them or not. She was so certain that Catra was unremarkable. Catra wonders if she is so blinded by her hatred for her that she denies the obvious. She hopes that it's eating her up. That's the whole reason she went down this route, after all. All she could think to satisfy herself with was revenge.

Despite knowing that she's just pulled off a massive job, Catra doesn't feel much satisfaction. She has enough money to live off of for the rest of her life – well, for a mortal to live off of, it turns out that she's going to end up needing infinite money – but aside from being comforted by the security of that, she didn't enjoy the job. She doesn't like plans that rely on her dying, and she had more fun when she and Adora were working alongside each other, even with the danger hanging over their heads.

She was afraid of being tempted to call Adora if she bought a phone, but that turns out to be nothing compared to the temptation of knowing where she lives now. Catra held out for an impressive week while she completed the job that she'd already spent two weeks planning, but once the job is done, she can't stop thinking about the option available to her now. She can't stop yearning for the intimacy they shared these last two times in a bed.

Calling somehow feels more desperate and pathetic than just showing up and demanding Adora make time for her. At the same time, Catra wants nothing to do with her new team. She doesn't want to knock on the penthouse door and deal with any of them. She knows they probably aren't actually stuck up, but she doesn't want to

deal with the people that tore her and Adora apart and shattered all their dreams.

Except they didn't really do that. Their dreams were never happening regardless. Catra was always meant to be a hostage, they just saw that before she did. She can't keep herself away from Adora no matter how hard she tries. This whole revenge crusade isn't making her feel half as content as she did lying in Adora's arms as they drifted off together. Catra refuses to let herself be drawn into being her sidekick again, but fuck does she want to be in her bed.

It takes a week, and she crumbles like a edenga tower .

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Adora is spending all her free time following leads on the Horde. Unfortunately, she doesn't have much to go on at this point. Locations have been abandoned other than their public operations that have to stay consistent. The Alliance has hit them repeatedly and they can do so again, but just stealing from them isn't enough to undermine such a violent operation. It's stressful. She feels like she can't think, unable to find the path that lets her get from where she is to her goal.

She decides to go for a walk. It's a new habit of hers. She just does laps around the block, hoping a bit foolishly that Catra will materialize. She knows where Adora lives now , after all, and now that she isn't really going out to case Horde targets, she doesn't know how else they are going to meet up. She doesn't even know how Catra turned up on that last job. When six days of silence pass, however, Adora's hope starts flagging.

She is kind of shocked when she stops at the street corner, standing just past the curb as she waits for the light to change, and she feels

the familiar presence of Catra slipping up to her side. It's a feeling she has missed dearly. She turns, blinking in shock at Catra standing beside her in a ripped shirt that shows off *so much* and makes Adora's mind blank out a little, never mind the tight athletic shorts that show off the stripes on her thighs.

"The walk sign's green," Catra points out. Adora startles a little, glancing forward to confirm that it has in fact changed. Without thinking about it, she reaches over and takes Catra's hand in her own, pulling her forward with her as she hurries to cross the street. Catra seems to be amused by Adora zoning out at the sight of her, following along until they reach the opposite sidewalk. Adora gets them out of the way of the corner and then turns, her eyes sweeping over Catra eagerly.

"I don't know how you expect me to go a week without you," Adora greets, tugging on Catra's hand to pull her closer. Catra blushes, sending Adora an exaggerated look of exasperation even as she lets herself be pulled into a kiss. The kiss is brief, chaste and sweet in a way that their embraces haven't been since this all began. It's a hopeful hello. Catra is here without any bullets raining around them after all. They might be able to just have a date – or better yet, *talk*.

"You've gone a week before and you will again. Stop being overdramatic," Catra returns when they pull apart. She drops Adora's hand, but Adora doesn't let go. Catra looks down at their hands pointedly and rolls her eyes, but she returns the gesture after sending Adora a look that is definitely trying for exasperated but not quite making it there when paired with her blush.

"I'm sorry, is the drama queen herself chastising me?" Adora asks, squeezing Catra's fingers a little bit in her grip. *Don't pull away*. They're both dramatic, Adora can acknowledge that, but that just makes Catra calling her out on it even more ridiculous. The corner of Catra's mouth twitches, a light sparking in her eyes as she rolls them. She almost scowls at Adora for a moment before she starts forward, tugging Adora along with her. Adora follows happily.

"I assume you have your car parked in the garage. Do you have the keys on you?" she asks, not acknowledging Adora's words. Adora blinks at her, a bit surprised. She reaches into her pocket to pull out her keyring with her free hand obediently, hope sparking in her chest that Catra is taking her home again. She nods as Catra takes the keys from her. Adora falls in step beside her, happy to go on a walk with her girlfriend.

Maybe girlfriend? They really never figured out words for what they were beforehand, and the whole kidnapping thing definitely complicated the hell out of it, not to mention the soulmate issue. Adora is hoping to resolve that one today, but she thinks Catra is planning to take her somewhere, so waiting to broach the soulmates topic until after they've arrived is probably her best bet. That issue is extremely volatile, but Adora might be able to get away with another one now.

"We're girlfriends, right?" Adora asks as they walk, watching Catra's gait *falter* as her eyes go wide and she nearly trips. Adora smirks a bit to herself as Catra flushes and shoots her an annoyed glare. It hasn't made it all the way to angry, so that means it was a fair question to ask. Catra growls, tugging her hand away as they turn into the side entrance of the parking garage beneath the apartment building and gesturing vaguely before she crosses her arms in a huff.

"Where's your car?" she asks, not responding to the question. Adora frowns, glancing down at the keys in Catra's hand.

"His name is Swift Wind, and I want to be your girlfriend," Adora returns. It's presumptive, but she has always assumed it would be her and Catra until the end of time. Now that seems to be a very real possibility. Catra twitches and then looks down, scowling as she hits the remote unlock button on the key fob. Swift Wind beeps from deeper in the garage. Catra's ears twitch, listening for the direction of the sound before she sets off after it. Adora follows, still frowning.

"I know you're mad at me, but we're never going to fix it if you won't talk to me. You aren't blameless either,"Adora continues. Catra clicks the keys again, listening for the sound and correcting their course through the garage a little as she continues walking forward silently. Adora sighs. She has been trying to be patient so she doesn't spook Catra. She has let Catra have her way, but so much has happened and Catra won't let Adora get a word in edgewise.

"I can't believe you named your fucking car ,"Catra says, in front of her. Adora blinks at her back. She's pretty sure that if she said something like that to Catra while she was trying to talk to her about something serious, she would get mad at her for dodging the question, but she isn't Catra. She does know her well though, and if Catra truly wanted to avoid talking then she would just run away.

She's delaying it, but it's still an opening. Adora picks up her pace, falling in line with Catra's side again as Catra tenses. Adora takes her hand, turning to lead them straight to the semi-private part of the garage reserved for the penthouse where she parks Swift Wind. When Catra spots his rear bumper and realizes what Adora is doing, she relaxes some, though the underlying tension is still there. Adora is pretty sure that it isn't going anywhere until they've resolved this.

"I had to get him new plates to make it harder for the Horde to locate the penthouse if they managed to call in enough favors to search through traffic cameras for him. Custom plates meant giving him a name. I'm getting him repainted with our next take,"Adora returns, shrugging a little as she drops Catra's hand to walk around to the passenger side door. She searched her car after she picked it back up from the street corner where Catra left it after the last time. Catra left the blindfold in the glove box. She was always intending to use it again.

Catra just raises an eyebrow at her and sends her an exasperated look as she unlocks Swift Wind. They both settle inside, buckling their seats, and Catra looks to the glove box pointedly. Adora twists in her seat a little to face the driver's seat, ignoring Catra's obvious prompt. They're doing this first. Catra's look turns into a glare fixed

on the dash. After a long, silent moment, she sighs, her ears drooping as she does so.

"I'm not your soulmate," she says. Yeah, Adora doesn't actually believe that. Especially not when Catra looks near-despondent saying it. She swallows. Has that been it this entire time? Catra was mad about her leaving, even after she found out that Adora wanted her with her, but maybe they could have worked through that if it weren't for Catra's worry about their unknown soulmates.

"You're going to believe something Shadow Weaver told you? The bond is complicated. Fulfilling it isn't as simple as just fucking. We could be soulmates still, and even if we *aren't*, I don't give a shit about being with my soulmate if she isn't you," Adora returns. Catra *twitches*, her entire body staying locked tense, but she can't hide the way her breath catches. After a second, she turns her burning gaze on Adora.

"Is this why you were asking about my fucking scars at the hotel?" she accuses, though she sounds like she's reeling a bit. It's a distraction as much as it's a clarification. Adora smiles a little, reaching down for Catra's right hand and guiding it to her lips so she can kiss a spot on the heel of her palm that has borne a thin white scar for years. It was hardly visible before, but now Adora sees nothing.

"I tracked down Kyle. Lonnie told me how you escaped," Adora explains. Catra flinches, her ears pinning back as she looks away, staring out her side window. She doesn't pull her hand away from Adora's grip, though. Adora kisses it again, her heart beating heavily. The words brought Catra down instantly, sapping her of life as she looks away, visibly tense. It can't be a good memory.

"I'm sorry. Whatever she did, it wouldn't have happened if it weren't for me. Then, and every time before," Adora whispers into her fur. Catra twitches again, but her hand still doesn't pull away, and Adora clings onto the connection selfishly. After several long moments of silence, Catra finally clears her throat.

"I'm sorry for helping her capture you. I was delirious by that point. I just wanted it to stop. I wanted you back," Catra mutters, her voice rough. Adora's heart leaps up into her throat. They should probably say more, but considering how much of a battle it was to get this far, Adora is willing to accept it. If it eases both of them, it's enough. They might just have forever to figure this out, anyway. Softly, she kisses Catra's palm again.

"You have me. You always did," she assures in a low whisper. Catra shivers, her fur fluffing up a little as she turns and looks at Adora with entirely round pupils. Her gaze is burning as she meets Adora's eyes and looks at her for a long moment, as if waiting for the other shoe to drop, but it's true and it always has been. After a long moment, Catra twists her hand in Adora's grip so she can hold her hand back.

"I'm your girlfriend. But I'm not joining your fucking crew. I like being solo," Catra returns. Her voice is low despite her attempt at dismissiveness. She's trying to cut the emotions and not express weakness. It was always a danger in the Horde, but it isn't here. Adora feels herself smile, pressing a kiss to the back of Catra's hand and nuzzling into it for a moment.

"Okay. However you're comfortable being together. Does this mean I get to know where you live now?" she asks. Catra huffs, rolling her eyes as she leans forward and opens the glovebox herself, pulling out the blindfold and holding it out to Adora with her best unimpressed look despite how her pupils are still mostly round and she has color dusted on her cheeks.

"No. I'll come to you," Catra responds, seemingly flustered. Adora pouts, but she takes the blindfold and ties it on. As long as she doesn't wait a week again, Adora is willing to accept that for now. They already made huge progress today. Blindfold secured, she leans back to settle into the passenger seat as Catra finally turns on Swift Wind. She smiles to herself as the AC mercifully begins circulating.

"You'll come for me," Adora corrects. Catra releases an indignant squeak, reaching over to smack Adora on her midsection as she begins laughing.

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Catra was expecting to talk, but she certainly didn't want to. She knew Adora wouldn't let them keep crashing into each other without addressing it for long. She's shocked that Adora let the subject go so quickly, honestly, but Catra breathes easier on the drive back, so maybe the relief was enough for Adora to also let things settle. Their hands are intertwined as Catra drives with one hand, her heart beating heavily.

She doesn't know what to think. Adora shocked her with the girlfriend stuff and then completely floored her by suggesting that they could be soulmates. Hope wants to well up in her chest – she has always clung desperately to the thinnest scraps and implications of love – but the rest of her says that she had her heart broken once and it will only happen again. If Adora is willing to let her stay her own agent, though, maybe they can make this work.

They have forever to try, after all, and Adora seems to be aware of that now. She didn't say it outright, but the implication is there in the fact that she thinks they could be soulmates alone. The thought causes Catra to shiver all over again. It implies love – it implies *more* than love, a bond meant to last for lifetimes. She always thought she had that with Adora, but then they got the opportunity to be together and they just.weren't.

Maybe it was all the Horde. Maybe it was the fact that Adora just found out that she was immortal and was reeling from dying. Maybe it was the stress of the cover. Maybe they really aren't meant to be and they already found that out when they tried. Catra doesn't know

what the answer is. She just knows that she feels numb and lonely without Adora. Whether they're fucking or talking or even fighting, she feels more alive with her. Catra has fucking millions and they don't mean anything compared to Adora.

"Did you see the auction house heist?" she asks, only half-casual as she drives them in a loop around her block. They should park, but she's extending the length of the trip, and Adora has been happy to sit quietly in the passenger seat up until now. Catra kind of just wants to spend time with her outside of falling in bed together, at least while Adora is willing to not talk about emotional stuff. She glances over to see the corner of Adora's mouth quirk up as she nods.

"How the hell did you get out of there? Or even *in*? Their security is insane," Adora asks her. Catra, despite herself, feels herself perk up. She preens a little at the praise, grinning as she finally pulls them up to her garage and pulls the remote out of her pocket. She clicks it as she forces down a purr that would be a bit too smug to voice.

"Trade secrets. Let's just say it's a job that would have made Shadow Weaver jealous. Eddie says she turned him down. Looks on her, I'm independent now and that means I get to keep the take for myself," Catra tells her, smirking as she watches Adora's cheeks darken beneath the edge of the blindfold. She parks the car, closing the garage door behind them, and then leans over to purr in Adora's ear, tracing one hand down her bare arm with her claws out and dragging along her skin just a little.

"That turns you on, doesn't it?" she purrs, satisfied with the way Adora's desire spikes in response. Adora swallows and nods, causing Catra to grin. Which part that Adora likes so much, she isn't sure, but she can provide all of it easily. If it keeps Adora interested, all the better. An idea forms in Catra's mind, causing her to bite her lip as a jolt of excitement shoots up her spine, her tail lashing with anticipation.

"I think," she adds on, her breath hot against Adora's ear, "that you should keep the blindfold on, princess," Catra proposes, purring at

the small noise, half moan and half whine, that escapes on Adora's answering breath. Adora's ears are flushed now, but to Catra's surprise, she seems hesitant. After a moment, Adora blows out a slow breath.

"I wanted to take care of you. I didn't get to last time. I miss you so much," Adora returns, her voice soft and a bit cautious. Catra's breath catch as she stares at Adora. She can only see half her face, but it's sincere. Of course it is. Adora only lies when she has to. Catra leans closer, kissing her cheek as she reaches up and hooks her claws beneath the edge of the mask, cutting it in one movement so it falls away. The garage light is dim, but Adora still blinks in surprise, turning to look at Catra and squinting. Catra smiles at her, leaning up to kiss her slow, lingering before they pull apart.

"Show me, then," she tells her. Adora lights up.

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Adora lets Catra take her hand and lead her through the weird basement space that must be her new base, but once they reach her bedroom, Catra lets her take the lead. Adora can't help running her hands along every inch of her as she strips her, partially searching for scars she knows she should be there – and finding only traces of the ones that are still present at all – and partially just luxuriating in having Catra against her again.

They kiss for a long time in the sheets, clothes being pushed aside slowly for both of them. Adora wants to make Catra feel good, she really does, but she also just wants *this*, a soft embrace between them both. She has missed having Catra in her bed desperately. She feels like the only time she really gets a restful sleep is when she's recovering after regenerating. She can't seem to feel fully rested without Catra beside her.

Her absence isn't just noticeable during the night. Adora wakes up in the morning missing her. She sometimes catches herself eyeing her plate and mentally dividing it up to give Catra some despite how she hopes they'll never have to scrounge food like that again. She stares at her map of known – and now, mostly abandoned – Horde operations and thinks that if she just had Catra with her, she would be able to see what Adora is missing.

Entrapta has invited Adora to play a video game with her multiple times and Adora keeps turning her down because she doesn't want to play one for the first time without Catra. She misses her. It feels like a piece of herself is missing – like a piece of her soul, her *soulmate*, is gone. These rendezvouses help, but-

"I miss you. I miss you so much. Every time I realize you aren't there I start to ache," Adora murmurs to her as she scatters soft kisses along the length of Catra's neck. They're both mostly naked. Adora is in her underwear and Catra is in just her torn t-shirt, mostly because Adora could push it up around her armpits to get it out of the way and it wasn't trapping a bra or anything beneath it.

Catra shivers a little, tilting her head further back as her tail sweeps in the sheets and then curves around the back of Adora's legs, as if she is subconsciously trying to hold her close. Adora keeps the next few kisses sweet and loving despite how her hands are on Catra's thighs, holding them spread so Adora can settle between them. The long, slow kisses have gone a long way to relax Catra beneath her. She seems limp with contentment, uncaring about how naked and displayed she is for Adora.

"You're everything to me. I don't think about anything else. Mermista decided we were soulmates because of the way I would drop everything for any trace of you," Adora adds, ducking to kiss along Catra's collar bone this time. Her shirt is in the way a little, but she isn't releasing Catra's thighs to adjust it. When she pulls back to kiss the edge of Catra's jaw, she catches Catra pulling a face.

"Who?" Catra asks, though she definitely doesn't seem interested in the answer. Right. Catra doesn't know fucking anything about her team. Adora came up with code names for them all on the fly and concealed Bow's existence completely. She only knows that they work out of a penthouse now because Adora told her that when she was giving her directions after their hotel stay. Adora kisses her jaw again.

"I'll tell you about my team after. I think you'll like them, but there's probably some kind of rule about talking about other women in bed," Adora tells her. Catra snorts, shooting Adora a narrow-eyed, unimpressed look before she smacks her once with her tail, letting it settle draped over her again.

"Get back to worshipping," Catra orders her. That makes Adora grin, her hands shifting to massage at Catra's thighs for a moment before she drags them up towards her center.

"Yes, my queen," Adora returns, shifting up a little so she can brace one forearm on the bed, allowing her to drape properly over her as she finally traces her fingers over her folds, feeling out the shape of her that she has missed so much. This position allows her to press their bodies together in a similar position to what they would use against the shower wall, only horizontal this time instead of vertical. It's all the familiarity with the comfort of the mattress added in.

Catra, despite purring a little as Adora drapes over her, tenses. Adora shifts back a little, intending to make eye contact and make sure Catra's alright, but instead Catra shifts beneath her and Adora realizes she's rearranging to get comfortable beneath her. She gives her a moment to settle in before she carefully drapes over her again. This time, Catra wraps her arms around her back and nuzzles into her shoulder, happily settling into the embrace.

Adora touches her almost lazily. It isn't from lack of caring – her heart feels like it is bursting seeing Catra laid out and relaxed beneath her – but rather from contentment. Their quick hookups have always been fiery and passionate. In the shower, they would

have to go hard and fast given their time limit. It only worked because they both knew what was coming and would be turned on from anticipation going into it. After they found what worked, they never really had time to experiment.

Adora never touched Catra slow like this, scattering soft kisses across the backs of her ears as Catra nuzzles into her and purrs. She never got to just relax with her girlfriend as she mapped the shape of her with her fingers before setting to touching her in slow, methodic circles. Catra doesn't gasp out in pleasure or moan, and usually Adora is chasing the high of those sounds, but Catra just seems *content* beneath her, so she doesn't pick up the pace.

She isn't going to come gasping and shaking. She doesn't need to. She seems happy like this, and Adora is always overjoyed by any time she gets to spend with a happy Catra in her arms. Adora just closes her eyes and nuzzles into the top of Catra's head, enjoying the sensation of her short hair against her face, even fluffier than it was before now it isn't weighed down by its own weight. She can't help that everything about her girlfriend is soothing.

Okay, if she voiced that thought out loud, everybody who has so much as met Catra in passing would gape at her, but it's true. Catra has always being caring and loyal, even if Adora is seeing less of that side of her right now, it's still there in small moments. Catra's passion is an explosive fire, but her love is subtle and quiet. Catra is a study in duality in every way. Her fur is soft and comforting, but beneath it is hard muscle that excites. Her purr indicates happiness, but she also does it when she's stressed and needs to soothe herself.

Catra takes learning, but Adora has studied her with more dedication than any other subject on this Earth deserves. She embraces her girlfriend, luxuriating in every second of her rumbling purr and her soft sounds of content interspersed within it, tiny gasps and subtle moans when Adora hits her just right. She slowly ramps up the pressure she is using, but she never goes too fast, happy to soak in

Catra's quiet whimpers and chirrups as the sustained touch eventually brings her over.

Catra comes sighing, purring, and shivering a little. Adora isn't even sure that she comes, but she trembles and moans a little before shifting back from Adora's touch and wrapping around her, a clear signal that she is done at least. Adora happily lets Catra curl around her, lying out on her side as Catra latches on, slipping a knee between her own so their legs can tangle together. Her purr is slower, more spaced out and rumbling compared to the buzzing that it had worked up to.

Adora loves this woman with so much emotion it feels like her chest could never contain it all. She hugs her back, clinging to Catra just as tightly until they're wrapped around each other like nothing else exists in the universe that is worth their attention. Nothing does, not when Adora could be having this instead. She kisses Catra's ears to quiet her heart before emotion comes spilling of f her tongue.

She loves Catra. It's true and she will tell her one day, but they have forever, and she doesn't want to shatter this afterglow. Catra has already hit her emotional limit for the day. Now, Adora just wants to cradle her and luxuriate in her girlfriend.

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For a while, they just cuddle. It's been so long since they've held each other. Catra can't stop purring, nudging into Adora until the pretense of nuzzling is gone and she' s rubbing dozens of scent marks against her, her purr only growing stronger as she breathes in the mix of her and Adora's scents. Adora hums happily as Catra does it, sighing with quiet satisfaction.

Unfortunately, the quiet peace has to be shattered by Adora's phone ringing. Catra growls and clings onto Adora when she tries to get up, digging her claws into the bed to hold Adora down so she can't leave. Adora just chuckles at her clinginess, kissing Catra's cheek before she reaches back and gently extricates Catra's claws from the mattress.

"If I don't answer it, they might actually turn on my phone tracking," Adora warns her. Catra scowls and releases her, rolling over to climb out of the bed as Adora goes digging through the sheets for her pants. Catra grumbles to herself as she pulls on her underwear and then slinks from the room. Despite leaving, Catra can hear Adora's end of the conversation once she finds her phone as she heads to the kitchen to grab Adora's soda.

"Hi, Perfuma. No, I'm fine. Catra wanted to go on a date. I'll be back tonight," Adora says, pauses between her sentences as she responds to someone on the other end of the phone. Catra wrinkles her nose as she pads back to the bedroom. She doesn't know who Perfuma is, or Mermista for that matter. Adora gave her code names for the Alliance, but clearly that is bullshit. Adora is just saying goodbye as Catra reenters the bedroom. Adora glances at the glass in her hand and wrinkles her nose.

"Have you regenerated recently?" Catra asks as she climbs into the bed beside Adora, careful not to spill the glass. Despite the face, Adora shakes her head and takes the glass from Catra when she holds it out, though she doesn't begin to drink, just continuing to eye it. Catra feels a prick of doubt in her heart as she bends to find Adora's shirt so she can wake up covered at least.

She wants to fall asleep together, but she doesn't know that she's ready to wake up with Adora in the morning. Still, if Adora doesn't want to, Catra isn't going to insist on it. She would be no better than Shadow Weaver then. If Adora had rejected the poison last time, Catra would have dropped her off with the blindfold on again. She can't help but wonder if it would be worth it to just have Adora *stay*

this time. She needs room to think after their conversation in the car, but she also needs Adora.

"I haven't died since the last time you gave me poison, it just tasted awful," Adora explains as she narrows her eyes at the glass. Catra's ear twitches as she files that information away. Okay, so she won't have to confront the possibility of Adora staying the night for real. She shifts to lie out on her side in the bed, blinking slowly at where Adora is sat up, completely topless with the glass in her hand and her ponytail askew from lying down while cuddling.

"This is a new one. It will take longer, but it should be tasteless, and you'll still fall asleep and wake up back in your bed," Catra tells her. Adora pauses, turning to blink at her with an owlish expression before the corner of her mouth twitches. Catra flushes. She doesn't know why she's embarrassed. Caring was a weakness in the Horde, but everybody knew who Catra's blind spot was regardless, and the Horde isn't in bed with them.

"Aw, for me?" she asks. Catra rolls her eyes, her tail thudding against the bed beside her, but she can feel herself blushing. Adora just grins as she takes a cautious sip. She considers the glass as she waits for the taste to permeate her tongue, and then shrugs and takes a proper swig. She passes the glass off to Catra in exchange for her shirt. Catra passes it silently, mournfully watching the muscle tank cover Adora's fabulous tits.

When Adora takes the glass back, Catra realizes that muscle tanks are actually marvelous and wonderful inventions when worn without sports bras. Catra can still see everything from the side, purring to herself a little when Adora lowers the glass and catches her looking. Adora rolls her eyes, muttering *pervert* before she takes another sip. She's smiling. She has never disliked the attention that Catra pays to her body.

Adora manages to drink half the glass while Catra appreciates her before she seems to be done, sending Catra a questioning look. Catra sits up, taking the glass and moving it to the bedside table

before she all but tackles Adora down onto the mattress, purring as Adora laughs and wraps her up in her arms. They're both relaxed, in just their t-shirts and underwear as Adora lets Catra pin her down and get comfortable in her arms again.

It's the kind of casual domesticity that Catra always dreamed of having with Adora. Their stolen moments were like flashes of heaven and she doesn't know how she would have made it through everything without them, but they are nothing compared to her dreams of a lifetime like *this*. She nuzzles into Adora, settling happily into Adora's arms as Adora kisses the side of her face and nuzzles her back.

"I want to tell you about the Alliance. It's weird that you don't know anything about them," Adora tells her after a few long moments of comfortable silence. Catra purses her lips, narrowing her eyes. "I *would* have told you everything about them if it didn't mean letting Shadow Weaver find it out too. I thought you might be more comfortable knowing," Adora tacks on, seeming to have caught onto her displeasure despite how she can't see much of her face from this angle.

Catra sighs, but she acquiesces with a nod. She does want to know. Not that she gives half a shit about Adora's new team personally, but tactically she should know about these other players in Adora's life that drove such a wedge between them. Adora kisses her temple, seemingly as a thank you, and Catra leans into the affection for a long moment before Adora pulls back and launches into the explanation of who's really on her team.

She starts with Scorpia – specifically, Scorpia wandering into a meditation session in hopes of finding purpose or at least some sense of clarity in her new life away from the Horde and immediately tripping head over heels for the instructor. Perfuma already had a girlfriend, but she felt equally pulled to Scorpia, and only a few weeks of being together had Scorpia breaking down and admitting her second chance at life.

She was lucky she told someone who not only believed her but understood her. Perfuma's almost fucking eighty at this point, so she had the connections to reach out to Sparkles' mother – Adora tells her that her real name is Glimmer, but Catra is so amused that Sparkles was the best codename for that Adora could come up with that she isn't about to stop using it herself – and put the Alliance as it is known today together.

Well, almost as it is known today. Adora explains in a quiet voice how they all helped pick her up after the kidnapping, giving her space and taking care of her while she refocused on dismantling the system that hurt Catra. The way she phrases it like that makes Catra want to pull back and stare at Adora with disbelief, but Adora's words are starting to slow down as the poison takes hold, so she stays pressed against her front.

The *system* had just tortured Adora physically, but apparently she was more upset about how Shadow Weaver hurt Catra emotionally just before that and over the years. Catra wants to get annoyed by it – she can *still take care of herself*, thanks – but she can't manage it when she can hear the tinge of hopelessness that had overtaken Adora then creep into her voice.

"I made my vow , but I'm stuck. Running out of targets. That's why we did that job with the car chase instead of continuing against the Horde. I could use you," Adora mumbles, nuzzling into her hair and absently kissing Catra's head. Catra's tail thuds against the bed. Adora sounds upset that she's *failing*. It's ridiculous. Failure used to have a price for the both of them, but it doesn't now.

"I told you, I'm staying solo. And Shadow W eaver won't hurt either of us if you don't succeed. It's okay. There's no stakes here," Catra comforts her. Adora releases a soft sound, nuzzling into her and clinging on a little tighter for a moment before she sighs.

"I know . But I can't just stop. Giving me a fresh pair of eyes on it doesn't have to mean joining the Alliance," Adora responds, her words a touch slurred. Catra wants to tell her no, but Adora sounds

so broken up about it. It's probably just her entire body slowly shutting down that's making her emotional, but it doesn't matter why she's upset – Catra has never been able to turn her down when she's like this.

"I'll have a look. Go to sleep, princess," Catra promises her, turning her head to press a soft kiss against her cheek. Adora releases a soft sound, halfway between contentment and complaint.

"You won't be there when I wake up. I miss having you around," Adora complains, whining a little as she weakly tightens her arms around Catra. Catra's heart stutters and she curls back tightly, holding Adora close and kicking to life a purr in her chest to help soothe Adora. Like a kitten, Adora immediately quiets some, humming back herself.

"I'm always going to be here, Adora, even when I'm not in your bed," Catra assures her. It's true. She tried to fight it. She tried to reduce this to just sex. She tried to tell herself that Adora was going to leave her anyway. None of it worked. She loves Adora – she always has, she always will. It never mattered to Catra if they were soulmates or not. It's always going to be Adora for her.

Catra is still scared of the possibility that Adora has another soulmate out there that she might leave her for, but if Adora *is* meant for someone else, she'll definitely leave when she finds her if Catra doesn't give her enough now. They have the potential of an eternity together and Catra doesn't want to throw away one moment of it, whether their relationship is borrowed time or not.

She's pretty sure Adora would reply to her if she wasn't so far gone. Catra readjusts her position, curling around Adora and closing her eyes. Her heart is a storm – it always is – but if there's anything that's going to soothe her, it's having Adora in her arms. Catra has missed sleeping with Adora as much as Adora has missed her.

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Despite Catra's promises, Adora wakes up alone. Night is falling outside, but Adora's sleep schedule without Catra was already fucked anyway. She gets out of bed, blushing when she catches sight of herself in her bedroom mirror. She thinks she actually looks pretty good like this, but a lot is on display. No wonder Catra was leering like that while Adora was drinking her soda. Adora pulls on a pair of lounge shorts and swaps her muscle tank – which is just the suggestion of a shirt when she wears it braless, it turns out – for a normal t-shirt.

Wandering out of her room, she finds Glimmer, who might have a worse sleep schedule than Adora – although no one will top Entrapta – watching Perfuma cook eagerly. Entrapta is passed out on the sofa in the living room, laid out with a pillow beneath her head, so she definitely passed out hunched over her laptop and Perfuma rearranged her to be sleeping in a better position. Entrapta's laptop is still open, though powered down, and resting on the coffee table.

Mermista, tucked into the corner of the kitchen and eating all the marshmallows out of a bowl of Lucky Charms, is the first to notice Adora. She waves vaguely, looking either bored or half-asleep. Glimmer is definitely supposed to be cooking for herself under Perfuma's supervision, but the moment she spots Mermista waving she gives up all pretense of participation herself, turning to eye Adora up and down. Adora, for some reason, flushes. She feels caught even though her biggest crime right now is being braless.

f never saw you come in,"Glimmer accuses, amusement dancing in her eyes. Ah, there it is. Adora ducks her head, feeling her cheeks burn as she walks past Glimmer into the kitchen. Perfuma is using the stovetop, but Adora can find something to eat that doesn't reqire cooking. She' s not really hungry given that she just regenerated, but she should give her body some fuel to prevent fatigue.

"Catra found me while I was going on my walk. She was willing to listen to me about the soulmates thing, but she still gave me poison instead of driving me back. She'll drop Swift Wind off later," Adora tells her as she opens the fridge, scrutinizing the contents. The only thing that really catches her attention is the milk. Looks like she's going to be joining Mermista in cereal for dinner.

"Adora, I'm gonna say it: your relationship is a little fucked," Glimmer returns, pulling a face at the mention of poison. Adora rolls her eyes, grabbing the carton of milk and setting out a bowl for herself. Glimmer can't get it. She also had a weird upbringing, yes – she speaks fucking Latin after all – but she didn't have the violent and dangerous childhood that Catra and Adora had. This isn't that extreme for them.

"So are we. Anyway , I think she just needs time to find her footing outside of the Horde," Adora returns as she ducks into the pantry and settles on Frosted Flakes. When she steps out of it, she finds that Glimmer is still pulling a face, but Perfuma is giving her a dubious glance too. Adora gestures to Mermista, still eating cereal and passively watching. "It isn't like Mermista doesn't kill Sea Hawk all the time," Adora justifies.

"They aren't an example you should follow for *anything* and they've been at this for a lot longer than you have," Glimmer retorts. Mermista grins, apparently pleased to be called a bad example. Adora pouts. She thinks she has a fair point. Mermista and Sea Hawk are not only happy together, but they've had a number of other lovers over the years because they're secure in their love for each other. Yes, they're a bit irresponsible with their own lives, but they'll be fine and so will Adora.

"It still can have a psychological impact when you die or kill each other. It usually takes new immortals awhile to be comfortable with their immortality. Look at Glimmer. She does things just for shock value because she's still getting used to always being fine," Perfuma speaks up from the stove, waving in Glimmer's direction. Glimmer

immediately pouts, crossing her arms and sticking her tongue out at Perfuma, clearly unhappy with having this be turned around on her.

Perfuma is right about Glimmer, but she isn't right about Adora and Catra. Maybe that's true for the average person, but Adora and Catra have a pretty traumatized perspective to start with. They've always had to fear losing the other to starvation, an angry superior, or a stray gunshot on a heist. It's just a relief now that they don't have to worry about chance pulling them apart, especially as they struggle to find their footing together again.

"I found it sweet that she got a new poison for me since the last one tasted bad," Adora shoots back. Perfuma's eye twitches, Glimmer drops her head into her hands, and Mermista raises a palm up to Adora for a high five. Adora gives it to her. The loud smack cause Entrapta to jolt upright on the couch, apparently awake again. Uh oh.

Perfuma takes a deep breath – the kind that contains the rage of an elder god – and turns to Adora with a deeply unsettling smile. Perfuma is usually chill, but no one can be zen twenty-four-seven, and she's fiercely protective of Entrapta given her history. Adora isn't sticking around to receive the retribution for waking her girlfriend. She's already pushed her luck enough today.

"I'm gonna eat in my room," Adora decides, gesturing over her shoulder with her thumb and then bolting before Perfuma's patience can snap. She appreciates the concern of the intervention, but it really isn't needed. She and Catra are maybe in the best position they've ever been together. They're talking and free to pursue each other, at least. Catra said she would come to her. Adora just has to hope it will be soon.

The Scarlet Ibis Job

Jobs like the auction house heist don't come up often, not if you're staying in the same city. Catra isn't interested in traveling to chase another job like that. She doesn't want to be away from Adora, and regenerating when she's staying away from the Fright Zone would be inconvenient as hell. She has plenty of money to be comfortable for a while and still have the funds left to invest in the next job.

She never cared about a luxurious lifestyle, just surviving. She splurges a little, deciding to get her bike tricked out and repainted. It's an indulgence she can more than afford, and besides, it's practical as well. She hadn't thought about her bike being trackable once Shadow Weaver figures out that she's alive again, too focused on getting her revenge to think that far ahead, but the last thing she wants to do is lead Shadow Weaver to Adora.

Taking care of the bike takes up a bit of time, but it's nothing close to what she is used to spending on Adora. She can't help but look up at her board of the Alliance's activities, still scattered with Horde targets and strongholds, and wonder about Adora's request for her help. Back in the Horde, Catra would point out the flaws with plans often, and Adora was receptive to her input – at first. Once she was promoted, she stopped listening to Catra.

It made her bitter. It was the very first wedge between them. Adora then quickly began her self-sacrifice tear and everything fell apart, but that was the very start. Adora couldn't really do anything about the plans though – they came directly from Shadow Weaver at that point. Now that there isn't a higher power cornering them, will Adora be willing to listen? Catra has always been a superior strategist to her, but it felt like Adora was beginning to discount her like everyone else already did.

She wants proof that things are different now. She's afraid to find that they aren't, but if that's true, then it's best she finds out now

before she starts falling for Adora's bullshit again. She tells herself that's why she is taking Adora up on her offer. She has had a few days to think about Adora's implication that she thinks she loves Catra like a soulmate, but her deep-seated feelings of inferiority scream that it just can't be. It's an internal conflict, but it is one she knows she is only going to resolve by seeing Adora.

She needs to make a dozen excuses to herself to make it happen, but she goes seeking Adora out again.

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Adora wakes up slowly on Monday morning. At first she just thinks it's the lack of sleep fighting to keep her under, and then she realizes it's *contentment*. Adora blinks her eyes open, shocked by the gentle purring filling the room. Catra is plastered against her back, her arms wrapped around her waist as she nuzzles against the back of Adora's neck. Adora draws in a sharp breath, causing Catra to rumble with amusement behind her.

"How'd you get in here?" she asks, barely above a whisper as she shifts to properly tangle their legs together and drape her arm over Catra's own at her waist. Catra chuckles as Adora squeezes her hand, every inch of her fighting between total contentment and shock. She's missed this *so fucking bad*, but Catra has never been in the penthouse before, much less her bed.

"Through the door," Catra offers in return, shifting to lick at the back of Adora's neck. It's an instinct for her, but Adora swears that she just does it because it to be annoying. Without fail, it makes all the hair on Adora's arms stand on end. It's a weird sensation that her body always fights with her heart over whether it makes her skin crawl too much to recognize that it's meant to be sweet.

"Is it still on its hinges?" Adora asks, thinking of the locked private elevator doors and the bulletproof glass in the foyer. Catra could force the elevator doors open and climb up the shaft easily if she knew the elevator was out of the way and not a danger, and her claws could cut through the glass, but Adora kind of assumes there would be screaming or something if Catra had broken in. Peaceful morning light is pouring through the window and the air is still. Catra huffs.

"I *knocked* like a civilized person. Well, I used the intercom," Catra returns. Adora can hear the eyeroll in her tone of voice. There is an intercom down in the lobby so visitors can let anyone in the penthouse know when they arrive, but Adora hasn't actually seen anyone use it. She doesn't even know what happens when you do. Presumably the panel in the kitchen lights up, but that would require someone being around to hear it.

"Who let you in?" Adora asks. Only a handful of the Alliance has even seen Catra. Adora assumes they wouldn't let just anybody into the penthouse and then her *bed* while she was asleep. She's glad they did, waking up in Catra's arms is pretty much the best thing she could have hoped for, but she's still surprised.

"Entrapta? Pigtails," Catra tells her, turning to rub her cheek against the spot that she just licked. Yeah, alright, that checks out. Entrapta has been encouraging Adora to pursue Catra regardless of her mortality status from the beginning, and she might not have met Catra, but she did transfer Adora's data from her old phone and saw all the pictures on it. Adora hums, content to be marked. She *loves* smelling like she is Catra's.

"How soundproofed are these walls?" Catra asks behind her, a sly tilt to her voice. Adora flushes, shivering a little in Catra's arms. She has no idea what the answer to that is, but she's a bit too excited by what Catra's proposing to care. Waking up in Catra's arms is a dream – morning sex is a fantasy. She squeezes Catra's hand.

"I live with three couples and haven't heard anyone else having sex," Adora responds. Okay, so Glimmer and Bow's couple status is questionable at best and Adora is certain they aren't having sex, but Mermista and Sea Hawk's room is directly across from hers in the hall, and the trio's room shares a wall with Adora's bathroom. It's fine, probably. Catra snorts, marking along her shoulder now.

"Just don't scream," she tells her as she tugs on the arm around Adora's waist, shifting her so she rolls onto her back. Adora's flush deepens as she blinks up at the predatory look on Catra's face, her eyes darkened with a lust that was already taking hold of Adora, but now it flares like a fire as Catra pins her. Adora would protest, but she really *can't*. She knows she's loud when she gets in bed with Catra.

Catra shoves her sleep shirt up, grinning with glee at how Adora is already braless beneath it. She immediately leans down and takes Adora's nipple in her mouth. *Fuck*. Adora bites down on her lower lip, whining as Catra sucks against her chest and laves her tongue over her. Catra discovered what that does to Adora quickly and she's using it against her now. Her claws are out as she kneads against Adora's other breast, though she's careful to keep her claws free of her nipple.

Adora likes some pain, but she doesn't like *bleeding*. She knows that she's freaky, they both are, but there's a difference between the thrill elicited by the suggestive tips of Catra's claws and getting stabbed in one of her most sensitive areas. She trusts Catra's control of her claws though, so she just tries to keep her body's desperate shifting to a minimum and focuses on biting down on her sounds so they don't peak too high. It's hard when Catra is so skilled with her tongue.

Adora started getting wet the moment Catra proposed this, but she's soaking now. Catra kneads against her chest with her hands and mouth, scattering love bites across the tops of her breasts and working her up until Adora is hardly quieting herself at all, desperate for her. Catra's attitude doesn't help her cool down. She is sporting a

lazy and satisfied grin, like nothing strokes her ego more than seeing Adora come apart for her.

Actually, that's probably true. Adora can't think of any other explanation for why Catra drags it out so long before finally touching her. It feels less like Catra getting her off and more like she is finally giving her permission to come. She doesn't manage to silence her moans, but she's pretty sure she manages not to scream.

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Adora totally screamed. It's hilarious. Catra informs her of that while they're lying together afterwards and Adora groans. She seems set on getting revenge, feeling Catra up until Catra happily settles down on her fingers and rides them, but Catra remembers how to be *quiet*, and all Adora gets are the same small gasps and moans that she has always been holding down. Still, Adora seems happy with that, scattering Catra with kisses and praises as she comes.

"You're so beautiful," Adora whispers, stroking one hand almost reverently down Catra's side as she pulls on her clothes again afterwards. Catra shivers a little, leaning into the touch before she returns to dressing. Adora is laid out in her bed, her pajamas back on, watching Catra's stripes disappear beneath her clothes intently. They're both greedy when it comes to seeing each other naked, but Catra loves it when Adora voices her thoughts.

Adora is so *much*. She says shit like *I think about you all the time* completely casually during sex. Catra gets what Shadow Weaver meant when she said Adora loves like an immortal. She supposes she does too, but it's silently. She obsesses over Adora, completely infatuated with her, but she never makes casual declarations of affection out loud like Adora does. Voicing it still feels dangerous.

Catra pauses, frowning down at the floor as she gathers up her stirrup socks.

"Always nice to get a compliment from a bombshell," Catra returns, her cheeks blazing for some reason as she pulls on her socks. She's not used to this kind of verbal exchange and she just feels awkward. It's easier to show Adora how much she wants her than to say it. Her socks on, she has no excuse to keep her back to Adora. She glances back over her shoulder to find Adora flushed and beaming at her, clearly flustered. She can dish it but not take it. Catra is the opposite.

They really are a pair. Catra rolls her eyes, crawling forward to kiss Adora firmly if only to hide her own blush. It certainly distracts her. Adora sighs happily and slides a hand into Catra's hair, gripping it firmly near the base of her neck but not quite tugging on it. It makes Catra's tail lash behind her, a soft chirrup muffled between their lips. Adora grins, breaking the kiss because the dork is *smiling too hard* to keep kissing back.

"You're such an idiot," Catra admonishes, pulling back far enough for Adora to see her eyeroll. Adora's grin doesn't fade, though she does let Catra's hair go so she doesn't tug on it, her hand shifting up to scratch at the base of her ear instead. Catra sighs happily, leaning into the wonderful attention that sends a pleased shiver down her spine. She's purring a little as Adora radiates happiness like the sun at her.

"I can't help it, I'm *happy*. You're here, and we're not fighting, and you're so cute, and I *woke up with you*," Adora lists of f, a breathless rush of excitement as her eyes roam almost greedily over Catra's face. Catra flushes, her ears twitching as she chirrups despite her best efforts not to. Adora just grins harder, leaning forward and resting their foreheads together since she's still smiling too hard to manage a kiss.

"I told you that I missed having you around. I like the Alliance, but they aren't you. They're just also not the Horde," Adora tells her .

Finally the words are enough to bring Catra down from her flustered high. She's still blushing, and her tail has yet to still, but she sighs a little. She's still.she doesn't know if she will *ever* be able to understand Adora leaving, not if she supposedly loves Catra the same way that she loves Adora.

It's why she struggles so hard to believe Adora gives a shit, but Catra is well aware of how terrible the Horde is. They'll find some kind of middle ground, or maybe it will all fall apart, but as long as Adora is willing to be hers, Catra will cling to it greedily. She just has to be careful with her own independence so she isn't left reeling when everything comes crashing down again. She shifts, pressing a light kiss to Adora's cheek before she pulls away.

"Speaking of, you should probably show me those plans you wanted help with. I have to take my bike into the shop this afternoon," Catra tells her. It's part of how she justified coming over this morning. She just repainted the bike, but the chop shop where she's picking up her new plates is in the Wastelanders' territory – it's where most of the illegal operations Catra knows of that aren't Horde-owned are located – and the penthouse was on the way there.

Adora nods, shifting to stand from the bed as Catra pulls away. She reaches for Catra's hand and Catra rolls her eyes, but she lets Adora weave their fingers together. The way Adora smiles, so soft and easy, at just the sight of their intertwined hands threatens to take Catra's breath away as Adora leads her out of her room and through the penthouse. The heist planning room is apparently on the opposite side of the penthouse from Adora's room, which means they have to walk past half the Alliance to get there.

Catra was dreading coming into contact with them, but it turns out to be hilarious given what they just overheard. Pretty much every person they pass makes a lewd gesture or comment at Adora, causing her to turn bright red and pick up her pace until she's speed-walking them into the planning room and pointedly shutting the door behind them, glaring at the grinning gremlin that Catra can only assume is Sparkles based off the description Adora gave of her.

"Ignore everything over here, that's Mermista's stuff for our next job, but this corner is what I have for the Horde," Adora tells her, waving vaguely to the entire right side of the room. Catra raises an eyebrow, glancing over to the wall Adora indicated. She can't miss the words *Scarlet Ibis*, as well as the hotel's floorplan hanging on the back of a clear whiteboard with arrows and labels written over parts of it.

To her knowledge, the hotel doesn't have much worth stealing itself, so there must be a guest staying there that they're targeting. Catra has no intention of getting in the Alliance's way, but she does steal several glances at the plans. She notes with great interest that Adora's position in the heist leaves her isolated and the exact right kind of vulnerable as Adora pulls down a rollaway map of the Fright Zone and clears space on the desk so Catra can review her information.

There's not much that Catra doesn't know already. A few targets the Alliance has hit that she missed and one or two locations she hadn't checked herself to see if they were abandoned, but she also adds a few to the list for Adora. Catra ends up lounging in an office chair, her feet propped up on the desk and one arm thrown over the back of the seat, as Adora does the legwork for her of making notes on the maps and whiteboards.

"You can't just keep going after their money. They have the people and supplies to get more. They've had to pull back their range of influence while they rebuild, but they can still recover," Catra points out, waving vaguely at the map. Adora pouts at her, crossing her arms as she does so. Catra raises a brow at her, engaging in a silent battle of wills with Adora.

She's the one who asked for Catra's advice, but Catra is still waiting to see if the golden child will even listen to her. Adora has run out of vaults to hit, though, and repeatedly swiping the Horde's earnings from its casinos won't help if they can make that up by just robbing another. It will certainly make them desperate, but it won't collapse them.

"What do you suggest then?" Adora asks, still pouting a little, though Catra is sure she would deny it if she pointed it out. Catra presses her mouth in a line.

"What's your goal here, Adora?" Catra asks her. She watches Adora stop, blinking at her a bit owlishly. Catra stares back. She can't have seriously not thought about this. After a moment, Adora's expression settles into a frown and she turns to the board, pursing her lips a little as she thinks, her eyes roaming over the map.

"I don't want anybody to ever be hurt like you were hurt again," she says after a long moment. Catra's heart does a painful, almost sickening flip that causes her to swallow down on the uncomfortable feeling in her throat.

"You can't do that," she returns after a second of silence. The fur on her shoulders is bristling. She doesn't know if it's touching or *annoying*. It's definitely sweet, but- "I'm not some damsel in fucking distress, Adora. I knew that place was bad before you did, but you were the one who thought getting food was worth staying," Catra returns, her voice a little too bitter. Her tail lashes against the side of the seat as Adora winces, turning to look at Catra with pleading eyes.

"You think I don't know that, Catra? I'm the one who couldn't see it. Every one of your injuries from that point on was my fault. I don't know that we could have gotten away even then, but it was definitely too late by the time I realized you were right," Adora returns, gesturing a bit wildly at nothing. Catra flinches. She doesn't really know why. Maybe because of how upset Adora sounds, even if that emotion is aimed at herself, or maybe just from the words themselves.

She thought that she wanted to hear Adora say she was right, but hearing her take responsibility for it is almost worse. Adora's eyes immediately widen with horror at the way Catra flinches, Adora's entire body tensing as she freezes in place. Catra looks away quickly, her ears pinning back. Her tail twitches beside her as she

tries to swallow down the sudden emotions. She kneads at her own thigh through her jeans, just trying to calm herself.

Adora steps forward slowly. Catra doesn't turn to face her. She hates showing weakness like this, but she doesn't pull away as Adora approaches and then cautiously reaches out to gently pet through her hair. Catra has a lot of shit to say, but the words well up and die in her throat. She leans into the touch, and a moment later Adora steps right up to the edge of her chair and bends a little to pull Catra into a loose hug.

With Adora standing and her sitting, she's basically burying her face in her tits, but the thought makes Catra snort a little and nuzzle in, so that's not really a bad thing in her book. She draws in a few steadying breaths, just breathing Adora in for several moments before she forces herself to pull back, clearing her throat as she slinks down in the chair again. Her tail is still tense, but at least the rest of her is relaxed. Adora eyes her with worry.

"Don't erase my own agency from it, Adora. And don't take an ounce of the blame off Shadow Weaver. She's a fucking monster and she deserves to be remembered as such," Catra manages. She was never going anywhere without Adora, but she hates this hero narrative Adora has created. She clearly feels guilt from it. It isn't just about rescuing Catra, but also seemingly punishing herself.

Adora sighs heavily, reaching a hand up to shove her hair that she hasn't bothered to put up yet out of her eyes, but she nods, her gaze distant and a bit haunted. Catra clears her throat, pointedly looking back to the map. After a moment, Adora turns back to it as well. She stares at it for several seconds before she reluctantly reaches up and begins to erase the markers for moved targets.

"What I want can't happen. I couldn't stop Shadow W eaver from hurting you, so I want to at least stop her from hurting others now that I can, but I don't want to do anything to hurt the people who didn't have a choice in the Horde either," Adora acknowledges, her tone a bit defeated. Catra's tail twitches against the side of the chair

as her heart falls heavy in her chest. She hates seeing Adora like this even more than she hated the guilt. She looks back to the board, her mind spinning for a long moment.

"There' s no way to hurt the Horde without hurting the people inside it. Especially the street kids. You can shrink them, though. You already have. Undermining their authority will make it easier for people to leave if they want to," Catra tells her . Adora blows out a long breath, her shoulders slumping a little before she nods, turning to look at Catra with wide, hopeful eyes. Catra knows that look. That's an Adora desperate for something to grab onto. When she used to get that look, Catra would lead her to a dark corner, or up onto their platform, and take her hand in her own, giving her something to hold.

Adora turned on the Horde, but she can't leave it behind anymore than Catra can, she realizes. Catra couldn't take all that pain being for nothing. Adora has the same need, but she has channeled it into destroying the Horde rather than digging in deeper like Catra always planned. The pain earned them nothing either way, but Adora can only handle it by destroying its source. Catra slips from her chair, walking up to stand beside Adora in front of the map.

"Hit big targets before they can, undercut their buyers, keep cutting into their take, hit their gambling dens repeatedly, and encourage their feud with the Wastelanders. Keep them on the defensive and they can't rebuild," Catra advises her . At her side, Adora takes a steady breath and nods. Catra reaches down for her hand, taking it and twining their fingers together. She can't help the way her heart skips a beat at how such a simple gesture relaxes the tension in Adora's shoulders.

"You can hurt them just by doing normal jobs and stealing something before they can. It doesn't have to be a vigilante crusade," she tacks on. The corner of Adora's mouth twitches as she shoots Catra a look that is far too tired for this early in the morning, but grateful.

"No, but that would be a lot more badass," she returns, humor in her voice. Catra snorts, rolling her eyes and sending Adora an exasperated smile despite how the slight tilt of Adora's lips is enough to lift Catra's spirits.

"I don't want a knight in shining armor , Adora. I want a thief," she returns. Adora's smile is real now as she turns to face Catra with her entire body, reaching up with her free hand to place it on the small of her back and guide her closer. Catra lets herself be drawn into the kiss, happily draping herself against Adora's chest. When they break apart, Adora rests their foreheads together instead, squeezing Catra's hand in her own.

"That I can do," Adora returns. She always could, but the moment she left the Horde, Catra began to fear that Adora would choose not to. She purrs to herself a little as she turns her cheek and purposefully rubs a long scent mark along the side of Adora's face. Adora just laughs, a bright and joyous sound that makes Catra's breath catch. She kisses Adora again. There's nothing stopping them here.

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Adora wishes she could do more about the Horde – she can't just let the torture Catra went through *go* – but Catra is right that stealing their scores is probably her best bet for doing it. She's a thief anyway, and this way she doesn't have to worry about hurting people directly. It's her, the Alliance, and rubber bullets going after the targets that Glimmer, Bow, and Mermista find for them for now. Anything they take is more profit that didn't fall into the Horde's hands, at least.

The Scarlet Ibis job is a big one. It's a good way to distract herself, even if Glimmer once again insists on putting Adora largely out of

harm's way on the grounds that she just regenerated a few days ago. Adora is definitely turning down poison the next time Catra offers it to her – she's hopeful at this point that Catra will let her stay even if she does – because she's *bored* waiting in the stairwell while she listens to Entrapta coordinate her hacking of the hotel's security cameras with the main team's movements as they work their way up to the room they need to break into.

Adora should really know better than to worry about boredom by now. She's leaned up against the wall of the stairwell, doing a rough count in her head and realizing she probably has another fifteen or twenty minutes of nothing before her phase of the plan, when the doors onto the stairwell open beside her, startling her.

She wasn't expecting anyone to come into the stairwell considering it's for emergency exits only and no one should be aware that Entrapta disabled the alarm. She should have expected Catra, though. She was in their heist room for a while just a few days ago, of *course* she swiped their plans just to show up with that feral grin.

Adora doesn't know how she got the memo, but Catra is wearing black dress pants and a button down to match the dress Adora is wearing specifically so she can hide things in holsters beneath the skirt. Adora can't deny that she kind of likes the swishiness of the petticoat, but she feels awkward as hell in it, and she'll be glad to take it off when the job is over.

"Hey , Adora," Catra purrs to her , her tone low and excited as she stalks up and effortlessly pins a flustered Adora against the wall of the staircase. Adora flushes, unsure if it's the implications of Catra showing up now that are exciting her or just the sight of her dressed up like this. She's put the money from the auction house job to *work*.

If Adora was a woman with a fraction less control over herself, she would call Catra *droolworthy*, but as it is she lets out a flustered squeak as laughter and sighs of exasperation filter through her earpiece. Catra's grin only grows more feral as she leans forward to whisper in Adora's free ear, one of her hands on the wall beside

Adora's head and the other casually stroking along the curve of Adora's waist.

"What are you hiding beneath this, princess?" Catra asks in a heady whisper before pinching the fabric of Adora's skirt beneath her fingers. Adora's whimper is *tiny* and doesn't deserve the uproarious laughter it gets from Mermista, the only person in a position on the heist where she can randomly laugh without endangering them.

"Adora, I swear to fucking god, if you try to have screaming sex in the middle of a job-" Glimmer hisses, suddenly cutting of f no doubt to avoid getting caught. Adora is flushed up to her ears as Catra, in no way deterred, effortlessly drops to her knees and places her hands on Adora's calves, tugging gently to encourage her to widen her stance. Despite Glimmer's warning, Adora does so. She has never seen Catra look so smug in her life as she is when Adora rearranges to be leaning on the wall for support while giving Catra room to work.

"I know how to be quiet, Glimmer ," Adora returns, already reaching up to shut off her mic. Mermista is gasping for air at this point. Entrapta is the only other person in a position to talk freely on the comms right now, but she has been largely silent.

"All evidence is to the contrary ," Entrapta pipes up, her tone helpful but her words *not*. Adora huffs, looking down to Catra to send her a glare that informs her that assumption is her fault. Catra just grins before ducking beneath Adora's skirt, causing her to draw in a sharp breath.

"I'm turning my mic of f. I'll let you know if anything happens," Adora shoots back, already reaching up to follow through on her threat. Mermista chokes out an amused *please don't* as Glimmer releases a hissing sigh. Adora hits the button to switch her earpiece off at the exact moment that Catra hooks her claws into the waistband of Adora's underwear.

Adora *does* remember how to be quiet. This is just as high stakes as the showers used to be, and it's on a similar time limit too. She sighs

softly but holds down on her sounds as Catra licks a long stripe along her, causing Adora to wiggle her hips a bit desperately. Catra smirks against her, her hands coming up to pin Adora's hips back against the wall. When Adora looks down, she can see the outline of Catra's head beneath her skirt as she sets to properly sucking against Adora.

It's ridiculously hot. Everything about this is. Catra showing up unexpectedly, her suit and matching cocky attitude, how quickly she drops to her knees for Adora when she knows that Catra would never kneel for anyone else, and the added thrill of the danger of getting caught all instantly sets Adora's blood on fire as she tucks her chin down and hungrily watches the movement beneath her skirt.

Biting down on her sounds is difficult, but no one outside of the fire doors will overhear her heavy breathing, and she manages to be silent otherwise even as Catra's mouth and delightfully rough tongue work against her, small spikes of pleasure and pain intermingling until Adora is biting down so roughly on her own lip that she knows she must bruise it. It's the only way she can contain herself as heat flushes through her skin, desperation burning between her legs until her body can't take it anymore.

She clenches down on nothing as she comes. She gasps a little, blood rushing in her ears and endorphins flooding through her body like relief, but she manages to keep quiet. Catra purrs with satisfaction as she keeps Adora's hips pinned just to support her for a long moment before she pulls back. Adora is still struggling for breath, her entire body warm, as Catra fixes her underwear back in place – yeah, she's fucking soaked and now her underwear is too – and ducks back out from beneath her skirt.

Adora's mind is mostly blank watching Catra in her all-black outfit slowly rising to her feet and wiping off her mouth. Her smirk is deadly, her gaze still hungry as she roams it over a *ruined* Adora. Distantly, she notes that at least she has an excuse now for why she is in the stairwell if she does get caught, even if she is certain that it

would exasperate her team. They're coordinating in her ear, but it doesn't matter when Catra is pressing their fronts together again.

"T aste yourself," Catra breathes to her . Adora is flushed up to her ears, but she opens her mouth immediately, meeting Catra's messy kiss. Any hybrid who encounters Catra for the next half hour is going to know what she just did, but Adora doesn't see that as a negative. She kisses Catra back happily, *hungrily*. They don't have time to do anything more, but Adora wants to get her hands on Catra far more than the information that they're here to steal now.

"Hey , hoe, we're going to be heading your way soon," Frosta mutters in Adora's ear. Adora pulls back from the kiss to sputter. Catra looks infinitely amused, rolling her eyes as she reaches up to turn on Adora's earpiece for her so Frosta can hear her indignation. Right. Adora forgot.

"It' s all clear," Adora hisses back, flustered, but it' s not like she has much of an argument other than the fact that she's only like this for Catra. Catra is still grinning, seemingly very pleased with the impression of Adora she has made on her team. Not that it's *wrong*, but Adora isn't used to people even acknowledging their relationship, much less making fun of how horny they are.

"Is it? Because I don't want to walk in on you anymore than a security guard. Finding out Perfuma is a rigger was bad enough," Frosta responds. Catra snorts, pulling back to raise an eyebrow at her. Adora waves her off, still flustered. That was like a year ago, apparently, but according to Sea Hawk, Frosta's resulting screaming could have shattered glass.

"Are all immortals just wildly horny?" Catra asks, snickering as it makes Frosta release what is probably the only sound she can make, a short, annoyed hiss. There's a long-suffering sigh over the line.

"*Apparently*. Unless Catra's going to take on an actual role on these jobs, she needs to stop showing up and distracting you by fucking in

a stairwell,”Glimmer huf fs. Her tone drips of jealousy. Yeah, Adora is going to have to talk to her about her whole thing with Bow at some point, but she should probably wait until she and Catra are a bit more settled so she doesn’t look like an idiot preaching shit she doesn’t understand. Catra releases a faux-offended gasp, placing a hand over her heart.

“She wounds me. I do more than *fuck*, Sparkles. I’m a giving lover,” Catra shoots back, before pressing forward and kissing Adora deeply. Caught off guard, Adora releases a soft noise into the kiss. The earpiece definitely picks it up because Frosta releases a grunt of disgust and Mermista starts laughing her ass off. Actually, that might just be because of Catra’s statement.

“*Adora*,”Glimmer hisses in her ear , admonishing. Adora really doesn’t care about the job as long as Catra is against her, but Catra slows the kiss and then pulls back, smiling at Adora a bit more softly than the smirk she has been wearing this entire time.

“Good luck with your job, babe,”Catra tells her , stretching up and kissing the tip of her nose. Adora feels part of her immediately qiet and relax, closing her eyes and humming as she soaks in the last few seconds of attention before Catra pulls back, throws her one last smirk, and walks away with a teasing wave thrown over her shoulder. Adora watches her ass as she goes.

Yeah, okay, it’s disruptive to the heist, but Adora definitely doesn’t care when the view looks like this.

--

Catra is feeling satisfied as she strolls out of the Scarlet Ibis, hands in her pockets. The plan calls for another fifteen minutes in the hotel at least, so she has plenty of time to wander out of sight of the hotel

and its security cameras and then double back around to the spot that was marked on the map hanging in the Alliance's planning room for their getaway car. Catra stole several peeks at the Alliance's plans while she was helping Adora.

It was definitely worth it. The danger of doing things in the heat of the moment is electric for the both of them. Catra isn't eager to be caught with her pants down while out and about, but that's why she's heading to the getaway car. She'll slip in, maybe chat with Bow a bit, and then ride back to the penthouse for some post-heist fun with Adora. She's interested in meeting Bow anyway, since Adora says he's "probably" mortal.

When Adora was planning to *kidnap* Catra and bring her to the Alliance, she thought that Catra was mortal. Catra isn't going to just magically stop being bitter about Adora assuming she could drag her around as a sidekick, but she wants to see how Bow is treated by the group, especially on these jobs, to get an idea for what Adora was actually expecting Catra to deal with. It will either help her settle her anger or cause it to spike, but she needs to know.

After nearly ten minutes of wandering, Catra loops around to the alley that leads up to the hotel's service entrance. A nondescript black SUV is parked there, facing away from her and out towards the alley's other exit for a smooth getaway. The alley is silent for any noise other than the sounds on the street as Catra approaches.

She doesn't know why that's odd to her until she gets close enough to realize that despite the strong scent of gasoline in the alley, the car's engine isn't running, the hum noticeably absent from the air. Catra frowns, the back of her neck bristling as she throws her silent approach out of the window, marching up alongside the driver side. If Bow is at all competent as a getaway driver, he should have the car on and ready to go this close to-

Shattered glass. On the ground beside the car. Catra's heart pounds in her ears as she switches sides to approach from the passenger side. The window there isn't shattered and she safely treads barefoot

as she approaches and squints through the tinted window with adrenaline flooding her veins. She is on edge, but she isn't ready for the sight she sees regardless.

Blood. On the windows, and the steering wheel, and on *Bow*. He's slumped back, his eyes open and seeing but no sound coming through his throat despite the hole in the windshield that sprayed glass over the hood and off to the driver's side allowing for sound to escape the vehicle. Catra feels instantly sick, a high whine overtaking her hearing. She hasn't felt adrenaline like this since she was holding a dying Adora in her arms. Her entire body just screams to *help*.

She reaches up with a shaking hand, reaching for the door handle. Bow's eyes flit to the side despite the bullet wound in the side of his head as Catra yanks the door open and climbs inside with no regard for the glass-covered exterior. He manages to make eye contact with her as she climbs in. The entire right side of his body covered in blood. Now Catra is within the car, she can hear yelling and chaos coming through his earpiece.

He's alive, but for how long? He's bleeding out. She has no idea what went wrong in the last fifteen minutes, but there's no one else in the alley now. His wound is bleeding fast, but there was enough time for whoever hit him to flee without Catra even hearing the gunshot over the city noise. Catra swallows, shifting to awkwardly climb over the center console so she can easily make eye contact with him. It's too late to stop him from dying, at least not without a blood transfusion, but she still might be able to save him.

Adora told her about all the members on the Alliance as they lay together last week. That included the fact that Glimmer and Bow thought they were soulmates but were too scared to pursue a relationship and make Bow mortal. Catra swallows. If Adora is at all right that they could be soulmates, then that means that despite Bow's declaration of love, he and Glimmer aren't locked in since they never got that supposed happiness.

"Focus on Glimmer , on how much you love her. Everything you wanted to have with her but never did. Only think about what you could have had together," she instructs, her voice a rough rasp. Bow's gaze wavers, but he doesn't seem capable of movement. "This is important. *She's* important. Just her . Think about how nothing matters as long as she's safe. And she is. She's immortal. She'll regenerate. No matter what happens, she'll keep going. She'll want you to do it too," Catra adds on.

"*Catra!*" Adora demands over the earpiece. Catra reaches up, carefully plucking it from Bow's ear and crushing it in her hand easily. The adrenaline helps. She doesn't even have to use her claws. She never breaks eye contact with Bow and neither does he. Catra hates that she can recognize the look in his eyes and knows he's slipping away.

"You love her, but you never showed her. You have to come back for her. She'll be lost without you," Catra says. She doesn't know that it's true, but she knows how she felt when she lost Adora. Soulmates or not, it was devastating. She can see the understanding in Bow's eyes as the light slowly fades. Catra has tears in her eyes as she reaches back behind her and turns the key in the ignition, preparing the car for the getaway.

She's going to throw up. She's having a panic attack, but she forces the car door open, ignoring her gasping breaths, the blood, and the shattered glass as she crawls over Bow's lifeless body and steps out into the alley. She cuts through his seatbelt with shaking claws, too unsteady to undo the buckle. She's hauling a dead body away, she thinks she can be forgiven for being unable to worry about the car right now.

She yanks the back door open and lays him out on the floor. If he doesn't regenerate, the Alliance will want his body, but he needs to be out of the way so they can drive. She closes the van doors with shaking hands. Her heart is pounding, the only sounds she can hear a distant, but approaching, commotion and that high whine that started dominating her hearing the moment she saw all the blood.

She turns and flees. The glass shards in her feet sting, but the pain hardly registers. She isn't thinking. She just needs to get away. She needs to give him time alone to regenerate. She can't have just watched a man die for real. He has to be immortal too. As she runs, she begs whatever force governs all this to be kind, just once.

Please. Regenerate.

--

The Horde showed up. Of course they did. How many times will a courier with information worth this much be passing through the Fright Zone? It all went wrong the moment they opened the door to the hotel room. It wasn't her old team – thankfully, Adora wouldn't have been able to handle it – but gunshots immediately rang out over the line as Frosta and Scorpia interrupted the Horde's own heist.

Frosta, pretending to be Scorpia's hard-of-hearing niece and the only one on their direct infiltration squad wearing an earpiece, went down immediately. There was yelling over the line from everyone, panic and chaos ensuing as the screams went up in the hotel as well. Scorpia manages to reunite with Adora in the stairwell, relaying that the Horde was already there when they arrived. They're halfway down the staircase, fleeing the scene, when another gunshot rings out over the line.

They don't freeze – alarms are going off, they have to run – but horror dawns on all of them as they desperately take account of whose comm that came from and they slowly realize that Bow is silent.

Then Catra begins talking. Cold ice floods through Adora's veins as she processes Catra's words and realizes that she is coaching him

through dying. She's telling him to think the same things that she must have when she died to give him the best chance at regenerating. Adora calls out for her, but she gets no response except for the unmistakable screech of the line cutting out.

She sprints for the car.

Soulmates

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When they get to the car, there's a bullet hole in the windshield. Bow and Catra are gone. Adora grimly jumps into the driver's seat as Scorpia and Mermista haul a crying Glimmer into the back. Adora has a car chase to focus on, her only thought that she needs to get them back to the penthouse so that they can see if Bow is there.

It's their only option. She doesn't think Catra would have had time to haul a body away, nor does she know why she would have. She drives until she's satisfied that no one is following them and swiftly returns to the penthouse. Glimmer is broken in the backseat. When they finally parking, Scorpia practically carries a crying Glimmer up to the penthouse elevator. Adora stays behind with Mermista so they can cover the SUV together.

The penthouse includes a private parking area that no one else should even be driving into, but if someone did wander in, they can't let the bullet hole in the windshield stay visible. They have a few car covers for this exact scenario though, so between the two of them they get the windshield hidden beneath the sheet while the others go up to the penthouse.

Mermista is silent beside her as they ride up the elevator together. Adora's heart is beating heavily in her chest. If Bow and Glimmer are soulmates, he'll be waiting up in the penthouse for them. There's no way he won't. They never got to be happy, just like her and Catra. The question still remains of if they are soulmates in the first place, though. Bow could just be mortal.

The elevator draws to a halt. The wait between reaching their floor and the doors opening has never felt like a heart-dropping eternity before, but it does this time. When the doors finally slide open,

they're greeted by glass separating an empty living space from the foyer. They walk forward in unison, Adora typing the door code with shaking hands.

When the door opens, they hear distant and hysterical crying. Adora's heart drops to the floor as Mermista takes a deep breath and then starts forward. Adora follows her a bit numbly, her heart pounding as they make their way down the hall towards Glimmer's open door. Sea Hawk is standing outside, shooting Mermista a relieved look when he spots them coming and immediately opening his arms to offer Mermista a hug.

His expression isn't pained. Adora is able to take in a breath as she steps into view of the doorway. Mermista glances in, breathes out a sigh of relief, and then immediately crashes into Sea Hawk's arms. Glimmer's bedroom is crowded, Scorpia, Perfuma, and Entrapta all inside and crowded around the bed. Frosta must still be regenerating.

Adora thinks, vaguely, that this is what it must have looked like when she regenerated for the first time, the entire bunk room crowding around her as Catra clung onto her and sobbed. Glimmer is a bit more hysterical than Catra was, but Catra was all cried out by that point. Bow seems only vaguely aware – Adora doesn't blame him, regenerating for the first time with someone crying on you is rough – but he has an arm thrown over Glimmer's shoulders and is mumbling vaguely to her.

The main difference is that Glimmer keeps kissing his face as if to be certain that he is real, but Catra probably would have done that with Adora if she could have. Adora swallows, choked up by the display, the fear, and the proof before her.

She's important. Just her. Think about how nothing matters as long as she's safe. That's what Catra thought to herself as she died. It has to be. Adora's hands shake as she wraps her arms around herself to steady herself. She- she needs to see Catra. She has to. She has no way of doing it without Catra coming to her first, but

surely she will after this, right? Adora will probably wake up tomorrow with Catra in her bed again.

She sounds like she's trying to convince herself even in her head. Glimmer and Bow are soulmates. She and Catra are soulmates. She needs Catra back, *here*. She needs to hold Catra in her arms and tell her that something else does matter in the universe – her.

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Catra hasn't felt like this since Adora died for the first time. Watching someone die is shattering. She doesn't *break* like she did when Adora died, but she still cries as she flees the scene. Her clothes are black and hide the traces of blood smeared on them from moving Bow, so she is able to flee to her bike and take off without being stopped, but she can smell it on her and it makes her feel sick.

Her helmet isolates her from the scent of blood. The wind stinging against her dries her shirt as she drives home. She is nearly having a panic attack when she pulls into her garage, pulling her helmet off with shaking hands and bracing herself to feel sick again as she yanks it off.

She doesn't. She isn't sure why the relief of the blood not just being dry, but being *gone* causes a panic attack, but she gasps for breath as she stumbles out of her garage. Bow is probably fine, then, regenerated with the traces of his death vanishing along with his body. She just watched him die, but she didn't, and she hasn't gotten any better at processing the weird trauma that comes from that since Adora died for the first time.

It doesn't help that this reminds her of how she felt then. She had to watch the love of her life die. There's relief in knowing about immortality this time around, but worrying about how all of this works

isn’t that much better. It at least stops the haunting vision of Bow soaked in blood from swimming before her eyes, though. Her life has taken a serious turn if thinking about the whole soulmates thing is more relaxing than anything else – especially because her emotions around it haven’t gotten any less knotted.

Adora said she thinks they could be soulmates, but a part of Catra didn’t truly believe her. Bow being immortal despite his not-relationship makes the possibility that Adora was right *real*. Catra hates that she doesn’t feel euphoria at that. She’s scared she’s going to get her heart broken again. Apparently Adora never meant to leave her the first time, but four days in the cells changed Catra. She was already treated as worthless by everyone except Adora, but in just a few days she started to believe it, feeling reduced to a stray, a sidekick Adora only cared for as long as she was convenient, a worthless-

They are Shadow Weaver’s words. The torture didn’t stop when Shadow Weaver let her out of the cell, the words echoing in her mind and convincing her that Adora can’t be her soulmate because no one would fucking love her. She hears them every time her hope rises as she fights her way through the panic attack. It gives her something to focus on to slow her breathing and take control back, but she can’t say it helps. When she manages to make her way to her bed, the words continue to taunt her as she twists in the sheets, exhausted but unable to get comfortable.

Normally the concrete walls feel solid and secure. This space protects her and feels like hers, but what she wants right now isn’t hers, it’s Adora’s. Adora’s bed, Adora’s arms, Adora’s love. Catra wants to crawl into her arms and let herself be loved, but she feels so cold without her now, how will she feel when she’s gotten used to her love again and then Adora leaves her for someone better? *If* Adora leaves her, she reminds herself. Maybe just when. She doesn’t know that there’s a difference, not in her heart.

She doesn’t sleep. It’s not surprising. She sees Bow’s face every time she tries to close her eyes. She gives up, wandering her

basement until she ends up in the bathroom, staring at her disheveled reflection. She stares at her short hair and asks herself: Could Adora love her with the same unwavering loyalty that Catra loves her with? Is that even possible when she was planning to walk from the Horde with Catra dragging behind her?

She never gave Catra an answer for what she would have done if Catra insisted on staying. The longer Catra is on the outside, the easier it is for her to see why Adora walked after experiencing life without Shadow Weaver looming over her, but she still knows that she never would have done it herself. She would have stayed there with Adora until the end of time. Does that mean she loves Adora more than Adora loves her, or just that she's selfish?

Adora is so determined to stop the Horde from hurting people. Catra doesn't care about that, just Adora, but she wouldn't love Adora the way she does if Adora were selfish like she is. She feels Adora's pull even as she turns away, unable to stand the sight of her own face. She ends up in her heist room, curling up awkwardly in her desk chair and staring up at her map of Alliance activities. It's uncomfortable, but she isn't going to sleep anyway. She's just going to see Bow's cold eyes. She can't look away from them as the phantom scent of blood hits her nose.

She's being haunted by a man that lived. She reaches for the computer, hoping to find some solace in a news report. Quick searching gives her a clip from the evening news: *Horde and Alliance operatives clash at Scarlet Ibis Hotel*. It mentions an unidentified person killed inside the hotel, but no one else. Catra should have known it was the Horde. Every one of her demons is because of Shadow Weaver. Adora's death, Bow's, and her own inability to believe Adora loves her all trace back to the woman.

She sags in her seat. She can't let Shadow Weaver *win*. Okay, Adora might move on one day, but as long as Shadow Weaver isn't still alive to see it, she'll never know she was right in the end. They could have decades of happiness together just to rub it in the hag's face. She feels so fucking numb after watching Bow die, but the idea

of Shadow Weaver rotting away bitter at their happiness does light a spark of vengeance in her chest.

She checks the clock. It's mid-morning. It has been half a day since she watched Bow die and this is the first time she has felt anything but numbness. She should have a better solution to sorting herself out than fire and brimstone, but all of this is the Horde's *fault*. Everything traces back to them. Maybe if she rids herself of them, she will finally get to be fucking happy. She certainly hasn't been so far, at least not outside of stolen moments with Adora, and she doesn't want Adora to see her like this.

She can burn the Horde down to the ground and maybe in the ashes she will find the glimmer of warmth she has been chasing. She's so cold on her own. It isn't the kind of cold any blanket could solve. She has to just hope that in the flames she will finally be able to feel love.

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First a bomb workshop that the Alliance has left alone due to it, you know, containing *bombs* goes up in flames. They all watch on the TV, gaping with shock, as the firefighters put out the inexplicable house fire and then discover the traces of bomb components and explosive chemicals. Clearly Catra got the actual bombs out of there before she did it, but it's so reckless that Glimmer pulls Adora aside and asks if it's possible that Catra somehow led the Horde to their job at the Scarlet Ibis.

"She *wouldn't*," Adora grits out, her fists flexing at her side. Bow fucking died. Catra would never let that happen. She tried to save him after she saw what happened. This was risky, but clearly she took the necessary precautions, and no civilians died. Two got injured trying to put out the fire, but Catra couldn't have prevented

people from running towards it. When Glimmer looks cautious but not fully convinced, Adora forces herself to unclench her fists.

"She' s wild, but if she was that reckless, she would have gotten caught a long time ago," Adora manages to point out, her tone mostly level, though she still sounds annoyed. Glimmer winces a little and nods, dropping the subject. Not twenty minutes later, Adora walks in on her and Bow making out in the gym. Adora is kind of convinced that they get to have that now because of Catra coaching Bow and she isn't going to let people accuse Catra anymore. Shadow Weaver used to blame everything on her.

Adora isn't about to let that happen in the Alliance, not if she ever wants Catra to come back. She hasn't slept right – well, *ever*, when she sleeps without Catra, but especially not since Bow's death. It has been a three days and things are starting to settle – Bow was comfortable enough to make a joke about regenerating again on purpose so his top surgery scars will heal over, even if he isn't qite to the point of actually doing that yet – but the entire vibe in the penthouse is *uneasy*.

Bow's death was a breaking point. They could have lost him forever. They're all immortal now, sure, but the sentiment that the Horde must be stopped is stronger than ever now. Angella herself is flying in to give both Adora and Bow some kind of orientation on immortality, but there have been unspoken expectations for her trip regarding what she's really coming for. Despite how everyone is on edge and focusing on the Horde, Adora is still just aching for Catra.

She isn't doing well, she can't be if she's doing things like stealing bombs, burning the workshop, and then *planting those bombs in the Horde' s own warehouses*. She does it the day after the housefire, probably to avoid letting the Horde prepare for her, but it's still reckless. Adora watches the police and firefighters swarm around the crumbled remains of one of the Horde warehouses they left untouched due to its cache of weapons.

The bombs the Horde makes are either small, meant for taking out rivals, or targeted, designed for breaching. Large bombs are more unpredictable and a waste of materials when something smaller would achieve the job. There doesn't seem to be a lot of collateral damage, but this is a dangerous game, and its indicative of the headspace Catra is in. Adora wishes she had a way to fucking reach her.

She knows – at least, she *hopes* – that Catra wouldn't feel the need to do all this if she was sleeping in Adora's arms at night, but neither of them are stable without the other. Adora needs to find her. Catra surely must have more bombs left. Adora just needs to be close by the next time one goes off. The fact that she isn't sleeping herself after hearing Catra's words to a dying Bow over the comms is irrelevant.

Catra needs her. They need each other. For some reason, she isn't coming to Adora right now. That's fine – Adora will go to her.

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Catra didn't like stealing the bombs. It was nerve-wracking, and there wasn't any of the usual fun to be had in beating a security system. There's no joy in creeping into a rundown home, silently bringing down its occupant, and then painstakingly loading their own van with such dangerous contraband and searching the place up and down before she lights it up, still knowing there could be something she missed in her sleep-deprived state.

She leaves the van, loaded with contraband and an unconscious bomb-maker, on the corner of a rich neighborhood and calls in a tip. She hangs out in the area just long enough to see the police open the van and panic before she slinks away. There were too many explosives for her to feel comfortable keeping, but she kept some

small directional breaching charges for future heists, and crucially, three larger bombs.

She sets one off in a Horde warehouse that includes their illegal weaponry. The Alliance wouldn't burn it – Adora said they were worried about civilians getting injured by weapons discharging in the heat when Catra suggested it back during their planning session in the penthouse – but Catra knows that taking the Horde's money does nothing in the long run if they have the gear to just get more.

She hangs around for a long time to make sure no civilians get hurt. It's what Adora would do. Part of Catra – the rational part that she hates – says that she should just *go* to her, but she immediately dismisses the idea and returns to planning. She doesn't like having the bombs in her base and she needs to get rid of them. Once she's done with this, she'll find Adora and fuck her through a mattress. Or maybe the other way around. It doesn't matter, she's focusing for now.

Just a day after the first bomb, she sets the second one. The Horde never had many storehouses away from their main base, just two deep in Horde territory for goods, the vault that Adora took out kicking this whole thing off, and a few small caches that the Alliance has already hit or that have moved. During their planning session, however, Adora turned her onto the lead she got from that yellow car she saw circling one of their old locations.

Entrapta was able to hack a vehicle database for her and get the owner and registered address for it. That owner was supposedly named *Kdroh* . It wasn't a very clever anagram. All Hordak did was reverse his name, which tells Catra that he's been using this car since before Shadow Weaver took over all the logistics in the Horde. The address was a seemingly-random street address. Adora hung around it for a day and saw enough people coming and going – or rather, the *right* people coming and going - for her to know what it was.

The house is a front for meeting buyers. It's at the fringes of Horde territory, in a more neutral area. Anyone who doesn't have a home turf to insist meeting them on for a pickup would come here. Their takes from the heists that aren't pure cash end up here to be sold. While the house won't be storing anything unless a buyer happens to be making a pickup, destroying the place will send a strong message and damage the Horde's reputation with outsiders.

When Catra arrives, the yellow car is in the driveway. Adora mentioned a drow lives here – to make the place look legit, likely, and to act as the middleman for buyers – and Catra finds him qickly . He doesn't even put up a fight, startling at her presence. She easily knocks him out and drags him to the passenger seat of his yellow car, driving it down the block to get it out of harms way while making it easy for rescuers to find. She's trying to hurt the Horde, not *people*. She hasn't forgotten Adora's warning about what happens when an immortal kills someone.

The bomb goes off on its timer. There's more fire than she expected, which makes her worry that she missed something when she swept the house for any other residents, but the first bomb caused an even larger fire, so probably not. At the time, she wrote that off as being because of the chemicals present in the home, but maybe they're just like this. The second one didn't cause much fire, but the structure it blew up was mostly concrete. She waited before and she waits again now, retreating to a safe distance to watch the fire and keep an eye on the surrounding houses.

The main structure of the building has collapsed, but it still has some exterior walls standing, so as long as the fire doesn't spread too fast, it should be fine. She listens to the sounds of sirens growing closer, her ears pinned as she waits. She isn't really nervous, she just- she's feeling *something* watching the burning fire. She doesn't know what it is, but she knows that it's bad. At least it isn't numbness, but that's not much comfort.

She doesn't like it. She doesn't like the bombs, or using them. She did it for a reason – the warehouse needed to be taken out, and the

bombing was safer than fire that would likely set off the weapons and gunpowder within – but she understands why Adora didn't consider this route. It will *work*, especially once Catra uses her final bomb, but she suddenly finds herself understanding Adora's more pacifistic approach.

She hates watching the flames and hoping no one else is caught in them. She shivers, wrapping her arms around herself despite the summer night and the blazing fire. Part of her mind is wondering if she would lose her immortality if that happened – it would be an indirect and unintended death, but still her fault – but most of her is just straining her ears for the sound of screaming as she watches the fire. She blames that, and the lack of sleep, for why she doesn't notice the person approaching behind her.

The sirens are so *loud* when the fire engine arrives. They drown out the approaching footsteps. The debris and ash in the air overpower the scent until Adora is close enough for Catra to feel her body heat at her back. Catra startles, yelping and hissing from shock. Her hands automatically tense to snap her claws out in preparation, but the jolt of adrenaline eases when she whirls around and finds Adora before her, hands already up in surrender.

She is only two steps away. After a second of processing, Catra slides her claws away and nearly trips forward, a combination of exhaustion, relief, and adrenaline jitters bringing her crashing into Adora's arms. Adora catches her – of course she does. She lets out an *oof* as the air knocks out of her, but her arms come up to catch Catra on instinct, drawing her in against her chest and holding her in a tight embrace. Catra draws in a shaking breath, feeling off-balance and exhausted.

"Catra? Are you okay?" Adora asks, her voice pinched with worry, though she is clearly trying to keep herself calm. Catra manages to raise her arms to hug Adora back, clinging onto her. Her face is mashed into Adora's shoulder, protecting it from the stinging sensation radiating from the fire down the block. She doesn't know if

it is the smoke or heat, but she feels infinitely better in Adora's arms anyway. Now the firefighters are here, she'll be able to leave soon.

"Did you get hurt? Is it a concussion?" Adora asks, her anxiety clearly rising despite how she is trying to stay calm. Catra sighs, shaking her head a little. It rubs her face into Adora's shoulder. She takes advantage of the position, turning her head to rub a scent mark on Adora. The stinging sensation returns and she quickly hides her face back against her shoulder once she has marked Adora.

"I'm tired. Haven't slept," she mumbles. Adora draws in a breath, releasing it again slowly. After a moment, she rearranges her arms to hold Catra more properly. To the firefighters down the block, they probably look like a mourning couple, but Catra isn't really thinking about anything but the fact that she has Adora holding her again.

"I want to go home," she whispers. She shouldn't go home with Adora – she's a fucking mess, they could be tailed, and it leaves her bike parked a little too close to Horde territory overnight than she's comfortable with, the list goes on – but she also can't imagine going back to her own place alone right now, much less driving there herself. Adora makes a soft, somewhat distressed noise as she pets a hand soothingly down Catra's back.

"Okay . . . I'll take you home," Adora promises, her voice low and loaded with emotion. Catra purrs a little, nuzzling into Adora. After a long moment, she sighs, forcing herself to pull away and turn to look back at the scene behind her. The fire seems to be under control. It's still burning, but it's smaller than it was, and it hasn't spread to the nearby buildings. It's probably safe to leave now.

She turns back to Adora. Adora offers her a gentle smile, raising an arm to wrap around her waist. It's sweet, but Catra suspects it's also intended to help keep her upright. She's okay with that. She lets Adora tuck her into her side and begin leading her down the block. Adora presses a lingering kiss into her hair as they walk, leaving behind the scene that many people have emerged from their homes to watch in horror.

"Where's your bike?" Adora asks, her tone soft like she's trying to avoid waking Catra. If an explosion couldn't do it, a question isn't going to. Catra can barely make her out over the sirens and shouting.

"Few blocks away so it's outside Horde territory," Catra mumbles. It will probably be fine overnight – she parked it in an alley behind a dumpster for cover from the street – she just doesn't like leaving it. Adora squeezes her arm around Catra's waist as they turn the corner and – to Catra's surprise - head back towards Horde territory.

"We'll go get it in the morning. I want to drive with you," Adora responds. Catra would roll her eyes if she wasn't so tired. She *knows* Adora is worried about her and just making up an excuse to save her pride, but it's still a relief. She lets out a soft grunt to acknowledge Adora's words, her only thoughts right now the image already forming in her mind of crawling into the softness of a bed – *Adora's* bed – with her girlfriend's arms wrapped around her.

She isn't really paying attention, her eyelids drooping as she trusts Adora to lead them. She doesn't think anything of the car driving past until she hears the sound of the brakes being hit so it can turn around. Her entire body stiffens, the last vestiges of her adrenaline forcing her to life as she whips around on instinct. Adora startles as Catra watches the car drift into a turn so it can turn around to face them. Through the windshield, she makes eye contact with Griz or ,no doubt sent to check out the explosion.

"*Run, Adora*," she grits out, turning back around and shoving Adora as hard as she can. Adora's eyes go wide, her mouth opening to protest. "Run, Adora! Get out of here!" Catra yells, her voice breaking in the middle. She knows Adora will be fine. She still doesn't want her to die like this, gunned down in the street, or even worse, captured by the Horde. Catra has her last pill on her, but she doesn't know if Adora does. Adora still seems stunned, though her eyes have darted towards the car and gone wide, so at least she *knows* now.

“Go,” Catra grits out, and then she turns and sprints for the car. It’s a distraction to buy Adora time to bolt. It’s a sacrifice as much as it’s anything else. She can’t take watching Adora get hurt again. Grizzor has a gun out before she’s halfway down the block. The first shot hits her shoulder, causing her to cry out, but she keeps barreling forward, running on pure adrenaline.

She doesn’t feel where the second shot hits. Everything just goes black.

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Adora drives home shaking. She knew Catra was immortal, but watching her die is still *devastating*. She understood the moment she had to see it why Catra sacrificed herself like that – watching Adora die instead would have been too hard. She threw herself on the sword before she had to do it. Adora barely manages to make it out between her grief and Grizzor, but she ducks into a narrow alley that Grizzor can’t follow her in with the car, and by the time he has gotten out, Adora has darted away.

She makes it back to her car. She cries at every fucking stoplight. Catra is fine – she’s immortal, she *has* to be, it wouldn’t make any fucking sense for her to do that if she wasn’t – but it doesn’t make it any easier to watch. Adora has become desensitized to her own death thanks to the Alliance explaining how all this works, but none of that knowledge matters when it’s Catra. That’s the love of her life dying in front of her – what happens afterwards doesn’t matter.

“You didn’t find her, did you?” Entrapta asks, her voice sad and sympathetic when Adora finally makes her way into the penthouse. She knows she must be showing how shaken she is, but she can’t bring herself to really correct Entrapta. She just shakes her head and keeps walking. She needs to collapse in her bed and cry. As she

fumbles with the door handle, she promises herself that Catra *has* to know she needs to come see her after that. She has watched Adora die before, after all, she knows what it's like-

Catra is in her bed. Adora draws in a sharp breath, staring at Catra's face mashed down into her pillow. Blood pounds in her ears, joy and relief and love all compounding as she stares at Catra, alive and well in the safety of her *home*. For a moment, she just stands there stunned, and then she rushes forward, practically running to climb in her bed. She feels Catra stir, jolting a little as Adora gathers her up in her arms and squeezes her tight against her chest, tears wanting to escape her eyes.

Catra is *here*, in her bed, in her arms. Catra wakes enough to realize she is being crushed and hisses, flailing to free herself, but Adora doesn't let go as she snarls. She doesn't want her to pull her away, and she knows that growl. It's blind, pure instinct. Catra hasn't realized she is being hugged and not held down yet. She probably hasn't even registered who is holding her.

"Shh, it's alright. You're home," Adora promises her. She wants to pet through her hair, but Catra is struggling wildly, and she'll likely free herself if Adora shifts her grip. The only thing that has saved her from getting clawed thus far is how close together they are, making it difficult for Catra to get her claws between them. At the words, Catra freezes, her ears twitching against the side of Adora's face. Adora's heart squeezes painfully at the way that Catra instantly quiets.

She is panting heavily from her struggling, her body still tense and ready for a fight, but she holds still and takes stock of her surroundings. Adora turns her head and presses a gentle kiss to the tip of Catra's ear, the only part of her that she can reach in this position. Catra draws in a deep, shaking breath, turning her face into Adora, and then relaxes, the tension in her body seeping away as she decides that she is safe.

Adora releases a breath too, easing her grip on Catra and laying them down so they can lay side-by-side. Her door is still open, but

she really doesn't give a shit, not when she can pull back a few inches and see Catra blinking at her, seeming a bit shocked. Adora offers her an encouraging smile, reaching up to brush some of her hair, wild from the struggling, out of her face. She finishes the motion with a gentle scratch behind Catra's ear.

"You're in the penthouse. You just regenerated here. You're safe," Adora promises her, dragging her hand down to rub Catra's cheek. Catra rubbing her cheek against Adora has always helped calm her. Whether that's a sensory reaction or just because she is more at ease when Adora smells like her, she doesn't know, but she brings her fingers up and runs them along the side of her own neck to spread the marks regardless. It can't hurt. Catra's eyes actually go a bit wide at the sight, her pupils blowing out as she intently watches Adora's fingers trace down her neck.

Adora smirks a little, satisfied Catra is at least somewhat calmed again. She shuffles a bit closer, kissing the bridge of her nose as she drops her arm to drape over Catra's waist now and hold her close. Catra purrs, the sound small and vibrations weak as if exhausted, but considering she was already running on empty before she died and she just got jolted awake before her body could settle naturally upon regenerating, Adora suspects she has some fatigue issues.

"You can sleep. I got too excited about you being here and didn't think about you needing rest. I'll be here when you wake up,"Adora promises her, squeezing Catra a bit tighter. Catra doesn't respond verbally, just ducking her head beneath Adora's chin and licking weakly once against the side of her neck that she didn't mark. Adora draws in a breath, but Catra seems to just be settling in, because she goes limp in the sheets after the single grooming mark.

She must be *exhausted* to just go back to sleep like this. Adora cradles her in her arms, her heart beating with love as she cradles her girlfriend close. It's a huge step that Catra regenerated here. Adora is hopeful that Catra will be willing to just *stay* after this. She seems happy to fall asleep, at least, so Adora takes the opportunity

to cuddle her while she has it. Catra's gentle rumbling as she drifts off again is comforting to them both.

It's late. Adora is going to join her.

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When Catra wakes, it's to light streaming into her face. She hisses, twisting around and seeking the darkness she is used to. Above her, there's a gentle chuckle, and then a hand at the back of her head directs her into the dark safety of a pillow and the warmth of a neck. Adora doesn't move her hand after directing her, gently petting through her hair instead.

"Good morning," she whispers, her voice fond and loaded with affection. Catra tries to grumble and a purr comes rolling out instead. Well, she tried. Adora lets out a short, delighted sound above her. Adora's other arm is wrapped around Catra and she squeezes her close as she pets through her hair, scratching a little and causing Catra's rumbling to ramp up. It feels *good*.

"Feeling better?" Adora asks her. Catra sighs in the midst of her purr, nodding a little. She's felt like utter shit for days. When Adora roused her after regenning last night, she didn't have that same sick-inducing exhaustion in her limbs, but she was so tired that she felt completely out of it. Once she realized Adora was with her, part of her just let go completely, already eager to drift into true rest. She could finally do it – she was safe.

"Yeah. I couldn't sleep after- watching," she admits, her voice a bit raspy from sleep. She stumbles over addressing what really happened, but Bow didn't haunt her dreams last night, and that's progress. She probably should have thought of this before, but she needs to make sure she sees him while she's here. It could help.

Adora's hand on the back of her head stills, just cradling her for a moment, before she returns to petting through it.

"You slept the whole night when you were with me," she breathes. Her tone is almost cautious, like she knows what a dangerous topic she is bringing up. Catra sighs. She did. She was at her breaking point anyway, but she did. Adora takes the sigh for argument, quickly scrambling to continue. "Catra, I need you too. You can be a free agent and be with me – be *here*," Adora asks, her words a desperate whisper. Catra swallows.

She wants to. All she has ever wanted was to make a home in Adora's arms. First Shadow Weaver stood between them, and then their soulmates. Catra knows that if she has a soulmate, then she loves Adora with the intensity of one. She thinks Adora loves her the same way, but doubt claws at her, dragging her down into dark, spiraling paths.

"What if we aren't soulmates? What if you're wrong? What if you find someone else one day and she's- not me?" Catra whispers, a terrified rush of air against Adora's neck. Adora stills against her, still holding Catra close, though her fingers on the back of her head twitch a little before they resume their careful stroking.

"It's more likely that we chose our soulmates than that the universe chooses for us. And no matter which is true, I'm always going to choose you, Catra," Adora promises her , her voice soft and gentle like she is afraid of scaring her away. Catra's heart pounds in her chest as Adora shifts to gently kiss the top of her head. She wants to say it isn't true, that she already has proof of Adora not choosing her once, but after the anxiety of fighting the Horde for the last few days – and the freedom of the last few weeks – she thinks she finally gets it.

"The moment they told me I had a soulmate, I assumed it was you. I only ever doubted it because I had already become immortal, but the bond is about getting to be happy together before your first death," Adora continues, whispering like she is nervous to say the words any

louder. Catra swallows, her tail thudding heavily against the bed and drawing Adora to a halt. After a moment of silence, she hesitantly resumes.

"Shadow W eaver made sure we were miserable. We were never fulfilled. We never got to say-"Adora starts. Catra' s heart pounds as she realizes where Adora is going. She cuts her of f with a hiss, panic and hope and adrenaline all mixing in her chest as Adora nervously draws to a halt.

"Don't fucking say it. Not if you don't mean it now and forever . Now and then and *always*,"Catra cuts her of f, her voice loaded with emotion. If Adora says it, then that will break her, she already knows. She'll never leave this bed again. She can't take throwing herself into this with all she has and being left behind one day. She can hear Adora's heart pounding along with her own for several moments.

The silence stretches too long. *Fuck* , she should have known. She needs to go, to crawl back to her own base and fucking break down in the privacy of concrete walls. She starts to pull away, but Adora clutches to her, causing her to snarl as she fights the urge to slide her claws out and thrash until she's free and can run from the girl that she gave so *much* to but who-

"Catra, of course I do. I love you,"Adora promises her , her voice forceful. Maybe from conviction, maybe just to be heard over the struggling and growling. Catra goes limp in her arms, all the fight leaking out of her just like she knew it would. Her heartbeat doesn't slow as Adora shifts her grip to cradle her close again instead of holding her down.

"I always have. It was always going to be us, before all this and after it,"she adds, her voice softer now , but no less certain as she gently kisses Catra's temple. Catra's next breath is wet and labored, fighting for control. Adora's hands are soothing as they gently pet over her, giving her time to process and relax again.

"I love you so much, Adora. I couldn't stand losing you," she whispers back. Her fear shows in her voice, but Adora shakes her head immediately, tightening her embrace despite how it was already near-crushing.

"We're immortal, Catra. You'll never have to. We're always going to be together. I'm your *home* now," she returns. The final sentence is delivered almost teasingly, Adora unable to hide the hope in her voice. Catra blows out a slow breath. The problem with that is where this whole thing started, actually.

"You never regenerated with me," she whispers, doubt and hope mixing in her voice. Yes, Adora did back at the beginning, but that was when she had nowhere and no *one* else to regenerate with. Ever since joining the Alliance, she has woken up back in this bed. It has been another point of doubt in Catra's mind. She had to keep her hope in chains, so she clung to it as proof that Adora didn't love her the same. Above her, Adora shakes her head.

"I can't. I don't know where your base is. You're my soulmate, Catra. Of course you're my home. The first time I regenerated back here was because I was afraid to regenerate back at the Horde and get caught planning to run away with you," Adora tells her . The words wash over Catra like cool waves of relief. The last of the fight retreats from her along with the tide, leaving her limp in Adora's arms. She draws in a deep breath, nodding a little.

"Okay ," she whispers. It' s the best she can do right now. She's run ragged. Adora seems willing to accept it, pressing a light kiss against her temple and loosening her embrace so she can resume petting over Catra's back again despite how she's still in her ash-laced clothes from yesterday.

"Just let me love you. I'm always going to. I can't fucking sleep without you, Catra. I need you," Adora tells her . Her voice is shaky with relief. She seems to know, or at least hope, that Catra is going to let her now. Catra swallows. How can she say no to that? How can she deny Adora from the one thing that Catra has always

wanted her to do? Her tail lashes as she buries her face into Adora's shoulder and nods.

"Please," she manages, which isn't the response she was planning to give, but it causes Adora to release a sound that is both happy and desperate and hug her like she's secretly been a boa constrictor this entire time, so she guesses it's alright. Especially when Adora releases a barrage of kisses across her ears.

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For a while, they just lay together. Adora pets Catra as she slowly settles in. Adora can tell she's coming to terms with the idea of no longer running still, and she tries to give her the room to do so. Catra's shirt ends up discarded – Adora's door is closed now, though someone else must have done it during the night, because she hasn't moved – and Adora pets directly over her back, gently soothing Catra as she asks why she stayed away for the last week.

"I thought we decided to try," she whispers. She's trying to keep her voice gentle and non-accusatory. She just needs to know what happened. Catra obviously wasn't doing well in their time apart. Catra sighs, shuffling closer to hide against Adora's chest. Adora just keeps petting her, hoping to soothe her anxiety as she grapples with the right words to say.

"I was just scared. I couldn't sleep after watching Bow-" she cuts off with a sigh. "It sent me in a spiral. I probably would have come back here last night if I hadn't died anyway," she explains. Adora nods, bending down to kiss each of Catra's ears to soothe her.

"Do you want to go meet him?" she asks. It might help, it might make things worse. She assumes Catra knows which. Against her, Catra nods. She stays close for a moment, hugging Adora, before she

forces herself to pull away. Adora sits up, dropping a kiss into the softness of Catra's hair before she slips from the bed to go fetch them both a change of clothes.

"I know we have to pick up your bike today , but you should probably bring some clothes back here. For the next time you regenerate," Adora calls from in the closet, tacking on the last part despite how she wants Catra to stay here tonight and every other. When she emerges, she finds Catra blushing but leveling her with an unimpressed look. Adora smiles hopefully to her, throwing her new clothes in a bundle. Catra catches them effortlessly, scoffing despite her smile as she yanks on the shirt.

"Only because I don't want to be stuck with just your drawstring pants,"she returns as she lays back on the bed to tug of f her leggings. Adora feels her heart stutter as she watches Catra strip and pull on her new clothes. It has nothing to do with her nakedness. She swallows, tugging on her own fresh clothes and then crossing the room in a few long strides. Catra eyes her with amusement as Adora climbs up onto the bed and straddles her lap.

"Y es, Adora?"Catra prompts, her mouth qirking up with amusement as she holds still so Adora can settle in her lap. Adora rolls her eyes, wrapping her arms around her shoulders to pull their fronts together. She leans down, kissing Catra gently. As much as she wants to pin her to the bed and never let her go, she doesn't want to overwhelm her right now, and she did promise to introduce her to Bow. She just needs to feel Catra in her arms after the thought that struck her in the closet doorway.

"I know you want to be solo. I know you probably even want to maintain your base. But I've been dreaming about the day where we can share a bed that is truly ours and have our clothes mixing in the closet for years. No Horde, no Shadow Weaver, just getting to love you,"Adora pours out when they part, the words a bit of a rush, but she really has been thinking about this for years and never gotten to express it for fear of retribution.

Catra flushes, chirruping a little as her eyes go wide and round, her tail lashing over the mattress. Adora grins, satisfied that that's a good reaction. She leans forward again, kissing Catra's cheek this time before she pulls back and slips from Catra's lap somewhat reluctantly. Catra is visibly flustered, ducking her head as if to hide her blazing cheeks. Adora's grin grows wider as she offers Catra her hand – a hand that Catra takes, letting Adora pull her to her feet and tuck her into her side.

"Come on. I'll give you a proper introduction to whoever is up and then we'll find Bow if he isn't in the common area," Adora tells her, kissing the top of her head before she pulls her towards the door. At the mention of Bow, some of Catra's blush fades, her nod determined as she lets Adora lead her out to *finally* meet the Alliance for real.

Chapter End Notes

> Entrapta spotted the open door and closed it a bit after they went to sleep.
> I think I'll be wrapping this up in two more chapters, but it might end up being two shorter chapters and a mini epilogue. We'll see. Regardless, there's two "real" chapters left.

The Matriarch

Chapter Notes

> I got sick and couldn't write for a while, but I'm back to finish this fic off.
> CW for mentions of weight changes/starvation. I just have a lot of feelings about Entrapta.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra didn't expect to walk out of Adora's bedroom to find nearly the entire Alliance eating breakfast. The only member she has really met before is missing, but minus a mess of purple hair, they all seem to be there. The pipsqeak – Frosta, Catra remembers from Adora's stories – is on the living room couch, moodily biting into cinnamon toast as on the opposite end of the couch, nearly a room away on the stupidly large sectional, Glimmer and Bow appear to be sharing a single piece of French toast between the two of them despite how they have two more untouched on the plate in Glimmer's lap.

"They're disgusting like that. Actually , everyone in the Alliance is," Adora tells her, smiling a bit to herself when she catches Catra raising her brow at the pair. She sends Catra a sickeningly sweet look that makes it clear she counts both of them amongst those ranks. Catra flushes, ducking her head as Adora chuckles and keeps leading them on to the kitchen. Catra has only seen Scorpia in photos, but she's pretty recognizable, so Catra can guess who the blonde next to her is. They're sitting at the otherwise neglected dining table.

"Ah, Adora! And an addition! My lovely wife requested French toast this morning. Would you like some?" a man greets them. His voice is a bit too energetic for first thing in the morning. That has to be Sea Hawk, then. Adora smiles at him as she leads Catra past where said

wife is seated with a stack of four slices just for herself, but she shakes her head.

"Catra can't have it. What do you want to eat, babe?" Adora asks, glancing at her as she heads for the fridge. Catra feels herself blush. The pet name is new, but she supposes she should have expected Adora to retaliate for *princess* eventually. Catra sniffs the air, thinking it over. The scent of eggs is already in the air thanks to the French toast mixture. Catra waves her hand over towards the egg carton on the counter.

"Can you be trusted with a sunny side up?" she asks. Adora immediately pulls an affronted expression, turning towards the eggs and *rolling her sleeves up* as she approaches them. Catra is struck with two things at once. One, Adora is definitely going to be too rough and break her yolk, and two, she's completely head over heels in love with this moron.

The epiphanies are not of equal weight, but Catra purrs to herself as she watches Adora set about making her the breakfast she requested with the same determination that she faced down the Horde with.

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Adora fucks up the egg. She googles instructions, but the yolk doesn't run. To her surprise, Catra still seems impressed.

"I mean, my first attempt wasn't much better . At least it didn't turn into scrambled eggs," Catra tells her as she stabs at the too-cooked egg with her fork. Adora has made a French toast sandwich out of her very first try, which she mangled a bit, but it still tastes just as good between two pieces of Sea Hawk's toast, so she doesn't mind. She rolls her eyes despite how she's smiling.

"Your confidence is appreciated," she returns, leaning over to kiss Catra's temple and then elbowing her as she pulls away. Catra yelps – not a real yelp, more indignation than anything else – and kicks Adora under the table in retaliation. Within moments, they're engaging in a small war, elbowing and kicking each other without getting out from their seats. Catra has to be careful of her toe claws – they don't retract like the ones on her hands – but they've been doing this since they were kids. She has plenty of practice.

No one wins. They never do. They just dissolve in giggles eventually, snickering despite Frosta pretending to gag in the next room over. She's been complaining about Glimmer *abandoning the single huddle to be sickening with Bow* for the last week. Being the only member of the Alliance without a soulmate has to be annoying, but Adora isn't holding herself back from Catra for anything now. By the end of breakfast, she has Catra's tail draped over her lap and is petting along it.

She introduced Catra properly to everyone in the kitchen as she was cooking, but once both their plates are empty, she catches Catra glancing into the living room. Glimmer and Bow have likely noticed their presence but are mostly in their own little world. Adora can only hope meeting Bow helps Catra settle. She struggled after Adora's first deaths, but at least they were beside each other every step of the way then.

She had to watch Bow die. Adora told Catra her theory about Glimmer and Bow's not-relationship when she was telling her all about the Alliance, but it wasn't a guarantee. Bow could have just been a mortal that Glimmer fell in love with. Regardless, Catra didn't even know if he regenerated. Bow told them about the Horde trying to drive their getaway car through the alley and spotting him. They shot him without hesitation.

He remembered pain, and numbness, and then Catra appearing to talk him through it. They still don't know what happened after Bow died, but Catra must have left if his body was already gone by the time that they returned to the car. She couldn't have known what

happened. Adora stands, gathering up their plates to bring them to the dishwasher, and then returns to offer Catra her hand with an encouraging smile.

Catra clearly knows what it's time for. She draws in a breath, her ears twitching back as she steels herself, and then she takes Adora's hand and lets her guide her over to the living room. Frosta lets out a noise of disgust as she notices their approach, standing and practically fleeing to go wash her plate. She probably doesn't want to bear witness to the shit that goes down when Adora and Catra are alone together, but they *aren't* alone here, and they both have something more serious on their minds.

Bow looks up first as they approach, his gaze immediately landing on Catra as he sends her a small, grateful smile that draws Glimmer's attention too. Glimmer eyes Catra, seeming appraising as Adora leads them to sit down with a few feet between them on the couch, tugging Catra down into her lap and humming with satisfaction when Catra allows it despite her eyeroll.

She even lets Adora bundle her up into her arms until she has Catra completely wrapped up in her lap. She likes Catra's solid weight, but hopefully the cuddling also gives Catra enough support for this conversation. Adora doesn't know how much she is looking forward to – or dreading – this conversation, but it seemed like it was something that she felt she needed.

"Thank you, Catra. We don't know if I would have regenerated anyway, but you tried to save me, and maybe you even *did*, so I owe you thanks," Bow says, diving in headfirst as he smiles at her, bobbing his head a little endearingly. Bow is just like that. Catra seems a bit caught off guard, her ears twitching as she blinks at him before ducking her head. A slight blush has gathered on her cheeks.

"I, uh, you're welcome. I knew it worked for me, and I couldn't just sit there and do nothing," Catra tells him, clearly unsure how to respond to the thanks. Adora tightens her arms around her girlfriend, both to assure her and because the confirmation of her thoughts makes her

chest squeeze painfully. She doesn't want to interrupt though, so she just turns her head and kisses the base of Catra's ear. Both of Catra's ears twitch, but she leans a little into the attention.

"Can I ask what happened after? It's weird not knowing," Bow asks, his tone apologetic, like he's sorry to be asking. Catra's ears pin back, not quite a wince, but the beginnings of one. Adora flexes her arms again, shifting to pet soothingly down her forearms. Despite the reaction, Catra takes a deep breath, tensing as she nods.

"I turned on the car and moved your body to the backseat so they could still drive away if you didn't- regenerate in time," Catra explains, her words stumbling over what the case would be if Bow's body had still been there. Glimmer winces as Bow's brows pinch and he nods, sending Catra a grateful smile. It seems to be a signal that he's heard enough. Catra relaxes a little in Adora's lap, though she is still a bit stiff. Glimmer clears her throat, her expression making it clear she wants to move on from that topic.

"Are you finally moving in? We can at least soundproof Adora's room if she screams here. We're shit-out-of-luck if it happens on a job," she says, trying for teasing. Her tone is lighthearted, it's just an obvious and sudden departure from the last topic. Luckily, Catra finds it funny – likely because it's a joke at Adora's expense – and she snickers as she shoots Adora a knowing look. Adora blushes, ignoring Catra's tail swatting at her leg.

"I'm not ashamed that my girlfriend's good in bed," she refutes, grinning when it causes Glimmer to release a relieved laugh as Catra *squeaks*, a high-pitched and outright shocked sound. She flushes terribly, her tail lashing as she shoves at Adora. Adora just laughs, tightening her arms around Catra to illustrate that she isn't going anywhere despite how obviously embarrassed she is.

"*Yes*, I guess. I'm staying solo, though," Catra returns, no less flustered, but clearly trying to take back control of the conversation. The distraction works on Adora at least. Her eyes glaze over, her heartrate picking up as she realizes that Catra really is open to finally

moving in and letting them wake up together every day like they always wanted. Catra can work as independently as she likes as long as they're falling into the same bed together at the end of the day.

Okay, maybe Frosta was right to flee, because Adora can't hold herself back from kissing Catra, joy bursting in her ribcage. After all these years of hoping and hurting and hiding, it's finally *them*.

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They drive out to get her bike, and then Catra instructs Adora to follow her in Swift Wind, leading her back to her base. Adora practically has hearts in her eyes when she steps into the garage. Catra shoves at her shoulder and tells she's *only* showing her where it is so Adora can help her move some stuff since the motorcycle isn't great for transit. Adora doesn't seem at all fooled, but that's not Catra's problem.

"Y ou still haven't sold them?" Adora asks, gesturing to her painting coffee table as Catra hauls a laundry basket she has filled with the clean clothes she wants to bring over back through the living room to dump it in Adora's backseat. Catra raises a brow, shooting Adora a look that informs her she is an idiot.

"I don't have the contacts of many buyers, and I didn't steal those to sell right away. I just liked them," she informs her . She isn't ashamed by it – art is *classy*, thank you very much – but she feels a blush rising on her cheeks when those words make Adora look at her like she's the fucking sun for some reason. "Y ou carry this," she instructs, shoving the hamper into Adora's arms and turning back to get something else – and escape that look. It makes heat rise beneath her fur.

She has trouble being open. She keeps having to backpedal, but Adora is patient with her as they fill the backseat and drive back to the penthouse. She doesn't care when Catra moves her things aside to make room for her own in the closet. Catra is surprised to find that Adora has managed to hold onto almost every one of their keepsakes – she would have thought they were lost when Adora defected – and after just a few adjustments to the room, it already feels cozy.

It smells like Adora, it has both their things in it, and no one is spying in on them. They even have their own ensuite bathroom. If Catra is being honest, she dreamed about Adora leaving all this Alliance business behind when she first defected and moving in with Catra to her bunker instead, but she kind of prefers this. There are others around, sure, but not in this room. This room is full of light and warmth. Adora practically tackles her to the bed when they finish hanging up her clothes.

Catra shrieks, giggling as she wrestles with Adora to come out on top. It is half-hearted. The frame sways slightly when she makes too strong of a movement, and it makes her too anxious about a possible collapse to go at Adora with her full strength. Adora, apparently, has no such concerns, unafraid of death. She uses Catra's reluctance to pin her down on the mattress, grinning down at her. The whole room feels warm, the soft glow of the sunset casting yellow light around them from the window.

"I win," she declares. Catra pulls a face, about to snark back, but she cuts off with a soft squeak when Adora swiftly leans down and kisses her. Instantly, Catra feels herself relax, her eyes fluttering closed as she kisses Adora back. She knows the kiss doesn't actually taste different, but a part of her can't help but feel like it's so much *more* now the word love is hanging in the air between them.

Adora sinks down on top of her, no longer trying to maintain her position on top but instead relaxing to press their bodies together. She shifts to brace herself without holding Catra down now that the competition is over – actually, it's never over with them, but Catra

appreciates the move regardless. She is not one for being held down during sex. She loves the feeling of Adora's body pressing her down into the softness of the mattress, but she wants comfort, not restriction.

"I love you," Adora breathes against her lips. Catra shivers, kissing Adora eagerly in response, pouring out her passion through touch rather than words. It's what she knows best – what feels *safest*. Adora seems to understand, smiling a little into the kiss before she meets her with just as much passion. One of her hands skims along Catra's side, rucking up Adora's shirt that she's still wearing so she can caress her fingers along the stripes on her ribs.

Catra should have known those three words were only the beginning, but she's surprised when Adora breaks the kiss, leaning back to smile at her and then shuffling her position a little so she can run her hands along Catra's body. Catra is far from opposed to being touched, arching up and putting herself on display as Adora pushes her shirt up to bunch around her armpits, but she still shivers as Adora runs her hands up to touch her chest.

"I love how you feel beneath my hands. Your fur, your curves, the- *oh*, that little shiver of your muscles when you get excited," Adora pours out, changing direction midsentence when Catra does just that, flushing as she arches her back a bit further to push her chest up into Adora's hands. She doesn't know why she's trying to distract her with her tits when she likes the words so much, but it's embarrassing that she's already getting wet from just this.

Adora smirks when Catra pushes up into her hands, apparently not fooled, but she does set to touching her properly, massaging her chest and flicking over her nipples carefully to excite her without being too harsh. Adora knows exactly where she is sensitive at this point, and she gives Catra a brief reprieve of careful touches that are *worth* getting worked up for before she opens her mouth again.

"I know I'm super biased, but I think you might be the most beautiful woman in the world," Adora adds on, ducking down and dropping a

few kisses along her neck. Catra whines, tilting her head back as she screws her eyes shut from embarrassment. She knows she's flushed as Adora grins against her neck. "You make such gorgeous sounds, too. All your tiny little noises. It's as good as if I got you to scream for me," Adora adds, placing a careful kiss right on the vulnerable center of her throat.

Catra's ears twitch, her entire body shifting because she's awkward and fidgeting beneath the praise and *definitely not* because she needs to move her hips. Adora shifts down lower, grinning up at her for a moment before she sets to kissing the stripes along her ribs. She used to follow the lines of her scars, too, but those are gone now. Her hands slowly pet down Catra's sides, making her way to her sweatpants and undoing the knot of the drawstring without looking.

"Nothing makes me feel like you do. When we're kissing, or in bed, or just in the same room together. You make me so happy," Adora breathes. Catra trills without meaning too, her face burning as her tail lashes behind her and Adora grins smugly into her fur. Adora tugs her waistband down and Catra decides *fuck it*. If Adora is going to ruin her with her mouth, she might as well do it in a way that leaves her dignity intact.

She fists Adora's ponytail, wrapping it around her hands and pulling down. Adora winces, moans softly, flushes, and then gives up with a laugh, letting herself be directed down between Catra legs. She chuckles, dropping a kiss against Catra's inner knee as she pulls her pants down around her ankles and then reaches up for her underwear too.

"*Bossy*. I love when you get bratty too, though. I love everything about you. Even when you run off and make me work for it," Adora tells her, pulling her underwear down too. Catra would complain about her clothes staying twisted around her ankles – tactically, it leaves her more vulnerable than being naked since she can't easily run – but she doesn't want to add any delay to shutting Adora up.

Her fur is hot, her core aching, and she needs a touch to go with all of these sweet words.

"Then get to work," she orders, tugging on Adora's ponytail again. Adora laughs, but she leans down to seal her lips over Catra and suck against her. Instantly, her embarrassment is forgotten as she sinks into the pleasurable heat of Adora's mouth. Privately, she absolutely loves the words, but they're at risk of making her come apart, and that's just *embarrassing*. She feels no shame in quivering beneath Adora's tongue, sighing and moaning quietly.

She remembers Adora's comment about her sounds right before she works her tongue against her, blanking out her thoughts. She gasps out, arching into Adora's mouth, and privately decides to stop worrying about anything except the building heat between her legs. Her entire body feels flushed, a pathetic whimper slipping from her when Adora eases the pressure again. Soothingly, Adora pets down her thighs to assure her before she does it again.

Fuck, Catra might just see stars. She moans again, panting heavily as she squirms beneath Adora, but Adora just keeps petting her thighs, her touch firm and steadily coaxing her legs further apart. Catra moans, purrs, and gasps as the heat builds. She is soaked, an utter mess not helped by the wetness of Adora's mouth, but fuck her, she kind of likes how dirty it all feels. Adora is willing to get filthy for her – she *likes* it.

The scent of Adora's desire is strong in the room. Adora has always hummed with pleasure, her own version of purring, and she seems to do it unconsciously against Catra's clit. It almost hurts, intense and bordering on too much, but Catra writhes beneath her as finally, the burning between her legs spreads through her whole body and she collapses back limp and gasping.

Adora licks along her and her inner thighs, cleaning her up before she wipes off her mouth and shifts up to lie beside Catra in the sheets. Catra is winded, her entire body relaxed and flush with endorphins as her tell-tale purr rumbles through her. Now they have

the freedom to, Catra is happy to roll over and tuck into Adora's arms, soaking in her embrace for the come down afterwards.

"I love you. And I *love* making you come," Adora tells her, dropping a kiss into her hair. Catra nips at the shoulder she is busy mashing her face against, but she's too busy purring to reply. She would definitely have a comeback otherwise. As it is, she just presses every inch of herself against Adora. Adora doesn't seem to mind, cuddling her back happily.

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Catra sleeps that night. Whether it's because she met Bow and finally comforted her traumatized brain that he lived or because she spent the night in Adora's bed, Adora doesn't know, but she gives herself credit only because it will give Catra a reason to keep staying in her bed. Luckily, she seems willing to stay regardless. Catra spends most of Friday lounging in Adora's bed and complaining about the lack of seating in her room.

The bed is in the middle of a sunbeam and Adora suspects that Catra wouldn't leave it regardless, but she promises they can go shopping for a loveseat. Catra, already a puddle of contentment in the sheets, just purrs and continues kneading the bed. Adora doesn't have seating because there's plenty in the main part of the penthouse already, but for the first few days in the penthouse, Catra mostly stays in her room.

"It's like we've adopted a stray that needs slow introduction to the rest of the house," Glimmer jokes on the third day of Catra tentatively living in the penthouse. Today is the first day she has left, telling Adora she wanted to go get some more things from her place, especially for planning her next job. Adora isn't worried. She asked if

Catra wanted her to come, but she just shook her head and flicked her tail.

Adora knows her. She needs space. She'll be back, though. She took Swift Wind to transport things, and she wouldn't run off with Adora's car. Regardless, she'll come back for her bed. They both sleep like the dead in each other's arms. Adora spends the day helping with Glimmer's cleaning tear. Glimmer is worried about making sure the penthouse is presentable for when Angella arrives. Adora doesn't really know why.

The common areas are uncluttered, anything dirty could easily be cleaned by a maid, and things like the burned circle in the middle of the hallway from when Sea Hawk tried to show off a lighter trick and *failed* aren't going away regardless of what they do. Adora helps Glimmer dust regardless. If it helps her stress a little less, it's worth it, and Adora likes to earn her keep however she can, especially given how useless she has been on the last few heists.

It wasn't by choice, but she's used to earning her place, and she feels like she hasn't done that here. The feeling is only exacerbated by Angella's upcoming arrival. She is basically the matriarch of the immortal community and Adora is getting to meet her *young*. She knows it's a big deal. Even though the meeting is really only happening so Angella can come meet Bow now that he's all but confirmed to be her eventual son-in-law, Adora feels like she hasn't earned her portion of it.

She's glad Catra is at least here to meet Angella too. The mythical woman arrives on Monday night, the earliest leave she could take from her job to fly out. Adora doesn't realize how stupid her vision of Angella was until Glimmer, Mermista, and Sea Hawk return from their trip to the airport with the woman in tow. Somehow, Adora was picturing an obviously Roman woman trying to blend in with modern society. She kind of forgot about the hundreds of years of transitioning that Angella lived through to get to this point.

Angella arrives looking like a modern woman, her hair a pastel shade of pink that matches the flowing loungewear she wore for her flight. With her oversized purple sunglasses, she looks like a celebrity going incognito that forgot the average person can't afford designer clothes. It actually is reminiscent of what little Adora knows about Roman fashion, but it's like if Juicy Couture tried to blend a toga with a pink track suit.

The British accent is even more surprising than her appearance, but the woman enters the penthouse with an air of stately calm that fits her immense age. She is smiling as Glimmer excitedly gushes about a job they pulled off before Adora joined, Mermista on her other side adding in all the unflattering parts Glimmer is purposefully leaving out. Sea Hawk trails behind them, seemingly unbothered by carrying Angella's luggage.

Catra, lounging against Adora's side on the sectional as they wait with the rest of the Alliance, flicks her ear against her shoulder as she takes Angella in. She asked Adora what to expect and the answer was that she didn't know. This is a woman who has lived since before Rome was an empire. Glimmer said Angella felt that she had transcended past when anything could feel transient. She always lived and humanity always rebuilt, sometimes having learned its lesson but often not.

She sounded like a god unbothered by the mortals toiling below her. Instead, Adora watches a mother patiently listening to her child telling her about something far too dangerous for her to be involved in as Entrapta springs off the couch and runs up to Angella. Perfuma just sighs fondly as Sea Hawk deposits Angella's bags at the edge of the living room.

Entrapta excitedly greets Angella with no cares for formality. She hugs her tightly before Perfuma and Scorpia have even stood up, Perfuma greeting Angella over Entrapta's head. It's a bit like watching a family reunion, Entrapta excitedly pulling back from the hug to do her best to grab a handful of her stomach and proudly

show off to Angella how much weight she has gained following Angella's instructions.

"Y ou look lovely, Entrapta. You've filled out. Your discipline is remarkable,"Angella praises. Entrapta beams in response. It' s hard to grow hair, change weight, or undergo any major body change when you're regularly regenerating. You'll often reset to before the change started taking effect. Whenever you regenerate, you heal and get set back some, but if you go long enough in between regens, you can still make progress.

Entrapta showed Adora her calendar tracking how long she had to make sure she stayed alive to gain a few pounds on her last regen the next time she died. It was hard to recover from starvation. Adora kind of wonders if Entrapta would have had the motivation for it if she wasn't also growing her hair alongside her weight gain, but it would have been insensitive to voice it. Entrapta was already opening up a lot just to show how repeated regenerations healed and preserved them with statistical examples.

Perfuma and Angella chat a bit, along with Scorpia, though she mostly blushes whenever her girlfriend says something complimentary and holds Entrapta. Entrapta is apparently too excited by Angella's presence to not hug something, so now she is latched onto Scorpia's side instead. Bow makes his way into the conversation next, grinning when Glimmer makes a grabby hand motion in his direction and walking up to take her hand.

"Good to see you, Dr . Proserpine-" he starts to greet, but Angella scoffs, reaching out to pull him into a hug instead. Glimmer doesn't let go of his hand, stretching up onto her toes to keep holding it despite Angella lifting Bow up a little with the embrace. It looks ridiculous, and Catra's tail twitches with amusement as she watches it, but she manages not to laugh despite the telltale quiver of her ears.

"Bow , I was there when your fathers took paternity leave. I've known you since before you could speak. There's no need for formality,"

Angella chastises him as she lets him go. Bow seems a bit flustered, but he nods as Glimmer, apparently dissatisfied with just having Bow's hand, latches onto his arm instead. Catra does stuff like that all the time, but it's new to see Glimmer doing it when she's been complaining about PDA this entire time. It was pretty obvious she was jealous, but it's still a shift.

It takes awhile for the greetings to get to Adora and Catra. Angella appears to be good friends with Mermista, Sea Hawk, and Perfuma, having known them for a long time, but Entrapta is on the newer side along with Frosta and Scorpia. Adora doesn't feel confident enough to put herself forward when Angella is still working her way through reuniting with previous acqaintances.

Catra swats her with her tail, pointedly flexes her claws into Adora's arm that she's tucked beneath, and even sends her side glances, but despite the obvious encouragement, she lets Adora wait to put herself forward until she doesn't have a choice anymore. Angella's eyes have landed on her and Catra briefly throughout the exchanges, but this time they fall and linger, with Angella holding eye contact before anyone else can pipe up and direct her attention away. Adora offers her a small smile.

"Nice to meet you, uh, Doctor . I'm Adora. This is my girlfriend, Catra. We're, um, both *new* to this," Adora greets, stumbling over herself like the awkward mess she is. She put a lot of stress on this first meeting given that she's probably going to know this woman for hundreds of years, and look at that, she fucked it up exactly like she worried she was going to. At her side, Catra snorts and rolls her eyes.

Luckily, Angella doesn't seem to care about Adora's awkwardness. She greets them just as warmly as she did the others before Glimmer pipes up and draws her attention. All of Adora's worry turns out to be for nothing. Angella isn't Shadow Weaver, and she doesn't demand that Adora justify her presence in the penthouse. She just smiles warmly at her daughter as she begins to trade barbs with Mermista.

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Angella is odd. No one lives as long as she has and isn't. She definitely has that *old soul* energy to her, but her mortal husband must keep her young. She praises Entrapta and Frosta like they're her nieces, talks with Mermista, Sea Hawk, and Perfuma like old friends, and dotes on Glimmer and Bow exactly like a mother would. She's terrible at Mario Kart when Entrapta ropes her into a game with her girlfriends, but she gives it a solid try.

Angella spends most of the evening chatting amongst the Alliance and telling stories. About half of them are recent and the other half are from all sorts of eras throughout history. Catra can't get a clear read on her, but she has no frame of reference for categorizing a woman who has lived so long, and it might not be possible anyway. Angella is a terrible cook, for example. It wouldn't be odd if it weren't for the caveat she adds of *with modern appliances*.

Most people just can't cook, but she complains about how nothing makes sense to her without an open flame when dinner is mentioned. Mermista and Sea Hawk decide to cook a family dinner for everybody. When Catra hears Sea Hawk call it that, she barely suppresses a full-body twitch down to just her ears. Adora notices, offering her a small, encouraging smile and reaching up to pet her. No one is really paying attention to them cuddling on the end of the couch and listening to the chatter, so she allows it.

"Angella, do you know how long it will be before my body starts making testosterone on its own?" Bow asks as he pulls out Angella's seat for her at the dinner table once dinner is ready. The question surprises Catra for a number of reasons, but Angella just looks thoughtful as they descend upon the dining room. She shakes her head as she sits.

"Perfuma was immortal for fourteen years before she realized her estrogen levels were maintaining even without medication. I have been in contact with another trans woman who noticed it after eight years, but she only regenerated once in that time frame. It may be like weight gain, where the longer you go the more likely it is for your body to preserve that as its natural state on the next regeneration," Angella supplies, waving her hand vaguely in the air. Bow dims slightly, but he nods.

"I suppose the one thing I can thank the Horde for is helping my surgery scars heal. Not that I'm eager to die again, but it will be nice when they're gone," he adds. He's clearly trying to add some levity, but Glimmer's expression darkens at the mention of the Horde. She glares down at the table as Sea Hawk emerges from the kitchen with the first dinner plate. Catra feels herself tensing a little at the palpable anger coming from her.

"We have to stop them. They're *murderers*. They have no regard for life," Glimmer says. It's not quite a declaration, but it is far from casual. Clearly she is trying to contain her bitterness over Bow's death, but it isn't working very well. Catra resists the urge to roll her eyes. There are two Horde members sitting almost directly across from her that prove that only the organization is cruel, not all its members, but clearly Glimmer doesn't care about nuance right now.

Many expressions around the table turn dark or outright wince. Adora almost grimaces and quickly takes the distraction offered by the arrival of the food to load her and Catra's plates. For a few moments, it's silent except *can you pass me that* and *me next* as the meal is distributed. Once all the plates are loaded, however, Angella looks down at her dinnerplate with a sigh and then looks up to Glimmer.

"I called in a favor with the FBI, but the agent I know doesn't work in this jurisdiction. He was able to get me some information, but nothing that was useful," Angella explains. Catra resists the urge to scoff. Yeah, if the feds haven't managed to deal with the Horde in the last thirty years, they aren't going to magically do it now. At her side,

Adora's expression turns grim along with Angella's, but there's a fire in her eyes.

"We can't call in the authorities. Probably half the people in the Horde never got a choice. They don't want to hurt people, and might not even know what the Horde is really like. We can't just throw years of their lives away to prison," Adora argues. Her words are met with a variety of responses – Mermista and Frosta look indifferent, while Scorpia and her girlfriends nod, and Glimmer looks *annoyed*. Catra can sense the fight brewing before Glimmer even opens her mouth. She hurries to talk over her.

"Now is probably the time to mention that I was going to take out the Horde for good last week but got distracted by moving in with Adora, huh?" Catra cuts in, forcing her voice casual if only for the benefit of watching several of the table guests' brains break. Adora and Scorpia outright gape at her, while Angella looks at her appraisingly, and the others just stare.

"*Yeah*, it might be," Glimmer returns, the fight in her expression replaced with utter exasperation.

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"Have I told you that you're the smartest, sexiest woman in the world recently?" Adora tells Catra, an arm wrapped around her shoulders and nuzzling into her hair so she can scatter kisses against the base of her ears. Frosta makes a retching sound in the background. Catra, standing in front of the planning board with her arms crossed, fails to hide her smile or the pleased twitch of her tail.

"I could always stand to hear it more often," she returns, tilting her head to direct Adora to kiss on top of her ears too, which she does happily. Adora has been anxious for just about everything about

Angella's visit, and the matter of dealing with the Horde was one of her top concerns. Catra moving in gave her something to focus on these last few days, but it turns out Catra was not just a distraction, but the solution to her problem.

Catra brings a two-part plan to the table. Forewarn their old team so they can make sure the people they know are good aren't there on the day of, and then plant her final bomb along a wall of the headquarters near the armory . Emergency services will respond to the explosion so they can put out the fire, and they'll have reason to enter the factory to help people evacuate. They'll quickly discover that an illegal operation is inside.

The cops can swoop in without any big sting. They'll find plenty of proof in Shadow Weaver's files to arrest her, Hordak, and the other high-level captains who perpetrated the abuse in the Horde. Cadets and associates might have their names added to wanted lists, but they won't be at base, so they'll have a chance to flee. There's too many files for Shadow Weaver to hope to destroy them all if she figures out the plan following the blast.

With their main leadership, base, and resources gone, the Horde will collapse. Shadow Weaver has connections in the city's law enforcement thanks to bribery and blackmail, but they'll know she can't follow through after a hit like this. Letting her escape after the publicity the explosion will generate would just look bad for them anyway. A cop's ego is too fragile for that. They'll arrest her just to make themselves look competent.

Shadow Weaver has ties higher up in the state government that seem to tie back to her true identity, but even they shouldn't be able to get her out of evidence this blatant when she's already been arrested. Those who escape will almost certainly continue their lives of crime, but they won't have to hurt people anymore. The Horde's territory will be free. It will be a positive for everyone outside of the Horde, and even for some within it.

Adora is floored at how easily Catra has solved an issue that has been nagging at her for months. She doesn't care if it makes Frosta gag or even that Angella is watching. She kisses Catra. She's too overwhelmed by the woman before her to hold back any longer.

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Angella came ostensibly to do some kind of immortal orientation class, but it takes the backburner as they spend Tuesday morning plotting things out. They want to do this qickly . Catra knows of a good window for dropping the bomb off every week, and it's fast-approaching. She missed it while she was moving in with Adora last week, so she decided to wait, but she doesn't want to delay again.

There isn't actually a lot to plan, anyway. It's mostly deciding who will drop off the bomb and Entrapta hacking into the city's emergency services systems in preparation. Bow has a private meeting with Angella in the afternoon and for a bit Catra thinks she has delayed orientation for them with all her sudden scheming, but they turn out to just be next in line. Angella asks for a private word with the two of them before sunset.

She leads them to a small sitting room in the corner of the penthouse, tucked between the planning room and the gym. It could be an additional bedroom if needed, but for now it appears to have been untouched by the Alliance, staying the small library that Angella used it as before her daughter moved a band of criminals into her property. Adora and Catra settle on a small sofa together with Angella in an armchair across from them.

f know that Glimmer has informed you about my network. In the digital age, we are able to keep up more easily with a private messaging board, but every member of the network gets a medallion with instructions for reaching us the old-fashioned way carved in it as

well. I've learned it's best to keep something permanent,"Angella informs them, gesturing to two medal-sized wooden boxes on the table. Catra eyes the boxes. She never agreed to actually join this network, but Angella assured her she was under no obligations when Catra hesitated to follow her into the room.

Adora picks up one of the boxes with nervous excitement. Catra sighs, picking up the other reluctantly and flicking it open. She is greeted by what appears to be a gold-dipped medallion, a picture of a stately mansion emblazoned on the front with what appear to be geographic coordinates framing the edge. Curious, she lifts it out of the box, flipping it over to find two more coordinate sets, a phone line, and a website engraved on the back. The medallion definitely isn't solid gold from its weight, but the metal doesn't rust, so it's a good choice for coating something meant to be long-lasting.

"Of course, the estate has been renovated over the years, but that is the current appearance. The coordinates are in longitude and latitude, leading to three of my safehouses around the world. We update these medallions as needed to keep the information current and send out new ones to those who still have active addresses. It will be easier if you just join the newsletter, however,"Angella tells them, lips twitching with amusement as she finishes. Catra snorts and nods as she places the medallion back in its case and snaps it shut.

"We will have plenty of time during my visit to go over more specifics about immortality and the network, but the first question I usually ask new members is how their first death went. It can be difficult to find someone who understands to talk about it with,"Angella adds, looking between them a bit expectantly. Catra immediately feels her heart race. Yeah, she absolutely does not want to talk about that – her death or Adora's. At least they were both there for Adora's.

This would be Adora's first time hearing all the details of hers. Adora seems to pick up on her discomfort, putting the case down in her lap so she can reach over and take Catra's hand. Catra squeezes hers back eagerly, looking up to find Adora watching her with a gentle,

encouraging expression. They hold each other's gaze for a long moment before Catra gives up with a sigh, shrugging and looking away. Adora knows it is permission to go ahead. She looks up to Angella.

"I'll go first," she offers. Yeah, and she'll be the only one to go at all.

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It's not as painful to recount her first deaths now. Angella's expression goes dark like a storm when Adora explains Shadow Weaver's plan to sacrifice her and essentially gain an immortal servant, but despite how wrong it was, it doesn't hurt in the raw way it did back then. Catra clearly feels vindicated by Angella's anger, but she also winces as Adora describes her first death – and then her second, and then her third.

To get a picture of what it was like, she has to describe it all until she met the Alliance. She was just as lost on death number three as she was on the previous two. She still didn't believe she was safe. And the whole time, she didn't know what a risk Shadow Weaver had taken with her life. She just had to hope there was some secret sign that let her mentor know what she was doing, but it was nothing more than a hunch. That's how easily Shadow Weaver gave her life away.

The plan to move against the Horde must be galvanizing her, because she realizes for the first time that she's angry about it. At first she just felt broken over it. The flames are stoked by the fact that she keeps remembering that Catra is going next – that Shadow Weaver was not only careless with Adora's life, but that she killed Catra too. Glimmer was somewhat justified in calling the Horde murderers. Shadow Weaver is the one who leads on a daily basis, and she is heartless.

Adora fists her hands in her lap, squeezing them as she finishes and Angella assures her that she didn't deserve that. Catra covers Adora's hands with her own, ducking her head to make eye contact with her. Adora forces herself to smile at Catra, twisting her hand around to hold Catra's back, though she's careful not to squeeze so hard. Catra could take it, but she wouldn't like it. Adora just wants to assure her. She is okay, just upset. They gave everything to the Horde, and this is what they got in return.

"It's over now. We'll take out the Horde on Thursday, and it will all be fine. Shadow Weaver killing me, killing *Catra*. Well, it will still matter, but she won't be able to do it again," Adora finishes, shaking her head a little as she speaks. Angella's mouth presses into a thin line, her expression darkened with distress, but after a moment she nods almost reluctantly. Adora sighs, reaching up to rub at her forehead. Talking about all this is hard. At her side, Catra clears her throat.

"I would like to spend the evening with my girlfriend now," Catra says. Her tone doesn't leave much matter for debate. Adora knows that means that Catra is trying to get her to take a break, but she's honestly *fine*. She opens her mouth to argue, but Catra levels her with a flat, unimpressed look. Adora folds like a house of cards. She knows Catra is probably just taking the excuse to not talk about it herself, but she can't turn down a quiet evening with her girlfriend regardless.

They have time. Angella is planning to stay for a week. Adora would rather talk about Catra's death privately with her before they discuss it with Angella anyway, and she's sure that Catra feels the same. Angella seems sympathetic, nodding her understanding. Her face is still dark. Apparently hearing about someone being forced to become immortal angers her. She's had two thousand years to develop hang ups around mortals' treatment of them, so Adora isn't that surprised. It's horrifying anyway.

"Of course. We can pick this back up another day. Take all the time you need," Angella tells them. Catra nods her thanks, picking back

up her wooden box in one hand and standing. Adora, still holding Catra's hand, scrambles to pick up her own before Catra pulls her to her feet and causes it to fall from her lap to the floor. The thing is fancy – it feels almost like a medal of honor, something she earned – and she doesn't want to be careless with it.

She does want to cuddle her girlfriend and assure herself they're both fine, though, so she lets Catra leads her from the room as soon as she has a hand on it. The boxes end up tossed at the foot of their bed as they quickly curl into each other , Catra purring like a storm as Adora's hands sneak beneath her shirt to pet her, but it's a safe enough spot for the moment. They won't get damaged right now and that whole conversation unsettled Adora. She's happy to sink into the softness of her girlfriend and forget it.

Chapter End Notes

> Angella's loungewear. Everything "casual" she wears is like this lmao.

Her Love's Like A Funeral

Chapter Notes

ASL for "What" (first video).

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Magicats are naturally inclined to nocturnal habits. They have largely adjusted to live in a human and elven-dominated society, but if Catra spends too much time napping in the daytime, she struggles to sleep that night. Her evening of cuddling with Adora to comfort themselves after having to discuss Adora's death turns out to backfire on her. When it's time to sleep, she has dozed and relaxed enough that she feels oddly wired.

She lays down with Adora until she is fast asleep, but she can't follow her into rest. She slips from the bed, going wandering through the halls towards the gym. Burn off a bit of energy and she'll be able to fall into sleep in Adora's arms. She isn't expecting anyone else to be up – well, maybe Entrapta, but Catra isn't sure the woman has ever slept in her own bed. She seems to just knock out at random hours of the day and then spring up recharged and ready to tackle whatever task she abandoned.

The point is, she wanders the hallways alone, does some quiet weightlifting in the converted gym of the penthouse, and is shocked when she comes wandering out to find Angella in the living room. Catra blinks at her, her tail twitching behind her as Angella turns her head to look at her with an unreadable expression. She is draped over the sectional in an entirely different set of pink loungewear than the one she arrived in, but she seems tense. Catra swallows, her gaze darting around the room as she twitches her ears and confirms that they are alone.

"Please, have a seat. This won't take long," Angella directs her, waving at the other end of the sectional. The words set Catra's teeth

on edge, but technically this whole place is Angella's. Catra squares her jaw and does her best not to stalk forward to take the indicated seat. She shifts uncomfortably on it, feeling stiff and uneasy as she eyes Angella. At least she and Adora have Catra's basement as a fallback if something goes bad here. Angella tilts her head slightly, considering her.

"I don't know how much the Alliance has shared with you. Do you know how immortals pass on into true death?" Angella asks her. Catra's fur immediately bristles, cold dread plummeting like a weight into her stomach as she stiffly shakes her head. Adora told her there was a way, but that new immortals don't get to know it. This seems like a threat. Angella's expression tinges with both relief and disappointment as she sighs.

"Immortals can only die of grief, planned or otherwise. If their mortal soulmate dies, often an immortal will choose to lay down, close their eyes, and never awake. It isn't uncommon for immortal couples to feel they have gotten to love each other after a few lifetimes and choose to pass into death together. It is peaceful in the latter case," Angella explains to her. Catra's ears twitch, but her fur relaxes a little. Angella isn't threatening her then, since their best guess for her soulmate is Adora and she's already immortal. No one can force either of them to pass on. Angella sighs, looking away.

"In the *former* case, it is anything but peaceful. It might be the most painful way to die, alone without your love. For immortals who love so fiercely, it is devastating. My husband is a mortal. That is the death I am likely facing down in a few decades," Angella tells her. Oh, okay, this isn't a threat, it's somehow *worse*. Growing up under Shadow Weaver, Catra is used to being threatened. It's known territory. She has no fucking idea how to comfort a stranger.

"Not wanting to leave my daughter alone is the only thing that could have kept me hanging on without Micah, but I'm comforted now by the fact that she will have Bow," Angella tells her before Catra can think of even a half-assed sympathetic response. She turns to look at Catra again, and Catra is surprised by the fire in her eyes. She

just nods mutely, unsure what to do or what Angella wants. She doesn't know why you would ever admit such vulnerable information to a stranger.

"There is also a way for an immortal to become mortal again without dying: if they knowingly kill a mortal, their regeneration stops. They become like any other mortal," Angella adds on. Yeah, Catra already knows, Adora warned her about this. Why did Angella pick her of all people to unload this all onto? She just nods again, reduced to a bobblehead with her ears twitched back. Angella just looks at her, seemingly uninterested in getting a real response. Her expression is appraising as she looks Catra over.

"You were raised by Shadow Weaver. Are you aware of who she really is?" Angella asks her. Catra blinks at her, thrown for a loop by the change of subject, but after a moment she nods a bit hesitantly. Apparently the FBI information Angella received was more detailed than what the one the police are working with. Actually, the police probably know, they just carefully hide it from the press.

"Beatrix Spinner, daughter of Senator Robert Spinner. Any connections to him were kept hush hush. After her scarring rendered her unrecognizable, there was no trace connecting Shadow Weaver to Beatrix or her father," Catra supplies. Shadow Weaver never told them that outright. Catra pieced it together from a lot of little things said over the years, hidden mementos in Shadow Weaver's office, and one comment by Hordak that made Shadow Weaver twitch.

Catra went digging into the only thing that seemed like possible leverage against her abuser. She never found definitive proof, but it all matched up. It especially clarified how the Horde was able to operate with such impunity. If Shadow Weaver were ever arrested, her true identity would be revealed, and the senator would suddenly be facing the repercussions for both his daughter's actions and his own in covering them up. Angella nods sagely.

"If she were arrested in the raid, the police would find a way for her to escape before she got back to the station and could be officially

identified. If she stays free, she will rebuild and begin this all again," Angella adds. Catra's scruff bristles. She doesn't like where this going. Yes, Shadow Weaver has sway, but it has only kept the police from chasing leads that could lead to her arrest. They'll have no choice but to arrest her with the news cameras around the explosion. This will work. It has to.

"I know I will die like a mortal alongside my husband anyway . This seems a worthy way to lose my immortality, avenging the murder and torture she has committed. I wish to coordinate with your plan so I can kill her when she tries to flee,"Angella tells her . And there it is. Catra's chest seizes. Panic and hope and guilt and fucking *sorrow* all swimming together in a miasma that threatens to choke her. She looks quickly away to hide her spasming expression.

She knows how pathetic it makes her, but she always wanted Shadow Weaver's approval. She still does. Shadow Weaver is a murderer. Shadow Weaver murdered *her*. She deserves this, and yet part of Catra still doesn't want to help her get what's coming to her. Angella has a point about Shadow Weaver escaping – the plan is flawed and Catra always knew it – but Catra wants Shadow Weaver to live to see her succeed in spite of everything that Shadow Weaver tried to do to her. She draws in a shaking breath.

"Glimmer?" she points out. Angella sighs behind her , silent for a few long moments as Catra tries to control her heartrate and fails. She would bet that Angella has thought about this at length already. Asking for the story of Adora's death might have just been a device to learn more about Shadow Weaver so Angella could justify her choice to herself. Catra can't help but wonder whether this is revenge for Bow or if Angella is just trying to seek out someone she doesn't feel guilty killing.

How badly does she want to be mortal again? Catra doesn't understand it. If Adora had been mortal, Catra doesn't know how she would live on without her, but she wouldn't be worrying about turning herself mortal early. Maybe Angella just wants to age alongside her husband and live a normal life again, but it's the last thing that Catra

would want. She spent so long fearing that she and Adora would lose each other young, she can't imagine reintroducing that risk factor.

"I will tell her my intent, but she will attempt to change my mind. My choice has been made. Hordak's only friends in the government are through Beatrix. With her dead, he will be arrested and the Horde will be disbanded. I will return to a mortal life. It has been so long, I crave it now. I wish to live out my days with my husband," Angella explains. Catra grimaces at the empty air. She was hoping to discourage Angella. It seems nothing will. She wants to be mortal again.

Angella isn't a criminal like them. She doesn't live her life dangerously. If she becomes mortal now, in all likelihood she will live for many decades without incident. Her logic is pragmatic and sound, but Catra has always been a highly emotional being, and despite it all, she doesn't want to help kill Shadow Weaver. She doesn't think she would shed a tear at her funeral, but there's a scrap of her that will always be craving her mentor's approval.

"She'll run to her office the moment she realizes what is happening to destroy evidence. If she finishes before the police arrive, she'll slip out the east exit," Catra tells her, hurrying to stand. Angella has to realize what she's asking for here. Despite the fact it's Shadow Weaver, she was all they *had* for so long. Catra has to remind herself of the sound of Adora's screams, the dryness of her throat, and the pain in her gut as she bled out just to force herself to share the information.

"I understand. Thank you, Catra. It's the right thing to do," Angella whispers, her voice low. It might not be a dismissal, but Catra takes it as one, straightening up from the couch and nodding stiffly. She quickly walks away, her tail lashing behind her. Her head is spinning as she returns to Adora's bedroom and crawls into her arms. She definitely isn't sleeping now.

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Angella and Glimmer have a fight in the morning. It wakes Adora up. She ends up cradling Catra and covering her ears, dropping kisses into her hair and humming broken melodies to try to distract her as the pair yell. Catra isn't too upset by the fight, but she is twitchy in a way that makes Adora desperately want to shield her. It isn't good for her, even if she apparently was expecting this.

Catra explains Angella's plan in a low voice as Adora massages at the base of her ears. Finally, the mystery of Mega Death is solved, and Adora instantly understands why the Alliance kept it from her while she and Catra were apart. She doesn't know if it would have worked if Catra was still alive and not technically her soulmate yet, but it's for the best that there was never a chance of her finding out.

She feels sorry for Glimmer, but she understands Angella's decision. Even worse, she knows it's the right thing to do, even if it tears her up inside. Adora can't do anything about it anyway. Now that the Alliance is on-board with Catra's plan, she and Catra aren't even supposed to be part of the bombing. If they or Scorpia gets close enough to headquarters to plant the device, they will risk being spotted. The Alliance will go instead.

Catra and Adora's only role is contacting their old team so they can warn others. They have their contact information, but it's too risky to reach out to them digitally. It's possible that Shadow Weaver has bugged their phones like she did Adora's and that she could intercept their messages. That means they need to talk in person. Entering Horde territory to visit is risky, but they aren't about to let all the street kids get swept up in the raid.

"Are you sure they won't tip of f anyone?" Adora asks, anxious as they drive towards the trio's old apartment. It won't be nearly as well-monitored as the area where headquarters are is, and most importantly, no one should be looking anyway. Catra is keeping a

careful eye out as they drive through the area, but it's a Wednesday night and there aren't that many people out and about. None of them pay attention to the sedan Catra stole as Adora drives them.

They'll return the car to the street corner they took it from when they're done, they just didn't want there to be anything for the Horde to trace if they did get caught. Catra nods silently in her periphery. Adora lets out a slow breath. It isn't that she doesn't trust her old team – she has trusted them with her life many times – it's just that this is a make-or-break moment. If they warn the Horde, they'll be rewarded handsomely. If they don't, they'll be stuck being a part of it.

Catra must sense her trepidation from the passenger seat. She has to keep her attention focused outside of the car, using her night vision to look out for anyone who could recognize them, but she reaches over blindly and Adora quicky takes her hand, threading their fingers together and squeezing. The warmth of Catra's hand is comforting. In truth, Adora is just as worried about what will happen to their friends if they warn the Horde and thus stay a part of it as she is about the plan getting ruined.

"When I died the first time, it was bad. Grizzor caught me in your cell. When Shadow Weaver found out I killed you, she flew into a rage. She ripped out my stomach and watched me bleed out of the floor of her office. They dumped me down the body chute, but I regenerated on our old blanket in the back of the van we used in the kidnapping," Catra whispers from the passenger seat. Adora's heart leaps into her throat, choking her, but she forces herself to stay focused on the road. All she can do is squeeze Catra's hand as she takes a pause to collect herself.

"He found me in the van. He knew I should be dead, but he didn't even question it. He drove the van away and smuggled me out of headquarters. He didn't stop there. Lonnie and Rogelio helped him get some stuff from my apartment and put me up in a hotel for a few days to get me back on my feet. They all knew the risk they were taking, but they did it anyway. They won't warn anybody," Catra

finishes. Adora swallows, forced to keep her eyes fixed forward as she drives through the dark streets at night.

That comforts her some – it explains how Kyle helped Catra, and it means Catra wasn't totally alone through it – but it also makes her heart ache. She realizes she is crushing Catra's hand a little in her lap and hastily lets it go before realizing she doesn't *want* to and picking it back up, making sure to keep her grip slack this time. Catra is here now, she assures herself. They're together despite Shadow Weaver's best efforts otherwise.

"It should have been me. I should have been there for you," Adora returns, her voice a bit strained. To her surprise, Catra snorts, her tail thudding against the side of her seat. She twists her hand a bit to interlace their fingers so they can properly hold hands. She's still focused on keeping an eye out the windows for anyone on the lookout, but her grip is gentle and assuring.

"No, it couldn't have been. I didn't want pity or help. I wanted to build something on my own, prove myself. I did that. I have my millions. I'm satisfied. Now I want you," Catra returns, her voice so soft it's almost a whisper. Adora draws in a sharp breath, her heart rate picking up as she watches the road despite how all she wants to do is turn to face her girlfriend.

"The moment we park, I'm kissing the hell out of you," she warns. Catra's answering laugh is light and happy. The sound alone is enough to settle Adora until she can follow through on her threat.

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Adora follows through on her threat, though only briefly. They don't spot anyone on their way to the apartment, but it's not good to be distracted in enemy territory. They knock on Rogelio's door without

ever seeing another person or camera. Both of them have been here before, although only occasionally between jobs, often to transport things or pick someone up. They weren't able to just come casually visit, and for a long time, Catra wouldn't have wanted to. She isn't a fan of small children.

This apartment used to be the place that Rogelio shared with his family. His mother wasn't in the shape to work, and someone had to look after the kids, so Rogelio joined the Horde when he was a teenager to provide for her and his two younger siblings after his dad died. Now he pays for an apartment for them in a nicer neighborhood so his siblings can go to a good school. He and Lonnie are the ones who pay for this place for the most part, moving in with him instead.

He is the one who opens the door when they knock, his eyes going wide as he freezes at the sight of them. After a moment he seems to come to his senses, hurrying to step aside and usher them into the apartment before they can be seen. Lonnie trails off mid-sentence with Rogelio, looking up from where she is drying dishes and Rogelio is washing them to gape at them. Adora beams a warm smile to her while Catra's expression is far more sheepish.

"What the fuck are you doing here? You want to get us all killed?" Lonnie asks, her voice hushed but annoyed. Catra suppresses the urge to flinch. After everything they have done for her, Catra really can't ask anything else of her old friends, but she's hoping that they see that this helps them too. Adora shakes her head as he closes the door behind them and fumbles with the deadbolt like he's afraid Shadow Weaver will come storming in any minute.

"We won't be long, and hopefully you won't have to worry about Shadow Weaver much longer," Adora promises her . Lonnie raises a brow at her, turning back to the counter to put down her dish and towel. Rogelio turns off the sink, drying his own hands. He takes the signal, smiling a bit frailly at them as he gestures them into the living room. They settle on the couch as Lonnie and Rogelio emerge from the kitchen.

“Alright, spill, but I’m still mad you’re endangering us like this,” Lonnie orders, gesturing to them. She isn’t actually mad – annoyed, maybe, but that’s fair considering the kind of risk that this is. Lonnie mad is a lot more threatening than this. Rogelio looks curious, while looks hopeful, and Lonnie just seems dubious overall. To be fair, if anyone else approached Catra with a plan to be rid of Shadow Weaver, she would be skeptical.

“We have a plan to take out Shadow Weaver and the captains of the Horde, but we need your help making sure the street kids and anyone who wants to leave isn’t there that day. The police are going to take headquarters, and we don’t want anyone who didn’t get a choice caught up in it,” Adora explains, matter-of-factly .

Lonnie stares at her as she and Rogelio exchange a glance. Adora cut right to the heart of the matter, but it leaves their old team lacking a lot of context. *Why help the cops?* Rogelio signs, clearly confused. Lonnie gestures to him, seemingly unconsciously signing *what?* as she does so. Catra sighs, shooting Adora a look before she leans forward and draws the trio’s attention onto herself instead.

“We’re all thieves, but Shadow Weaver’s a fucking murderer and so is half the leadership. We want you to warn the honest criminals so only the assholes who deserve it are there. We’re not working with the cops, we’ll just give them a reason to search the compound on Thursday night. The Horde will be weakened and anyone who wants to walk can. Trust me, being solo is better,” Catra explains. Lonnie still looks dubious, but Rogelio is visibly interested. To Catra’s surprise, she looks anxious. Right, his dads.

“Invite your dads to a family dinner , she. Tell them the truth at the end when it’s already too late for them to do anything about it. There will probably be evidence that incriminates them, but they’re low on the ladder and won’t be anyone’s priority. They’ll have plenty of time to disappear and rebuild,” Catra tells him. She shifts, sending his partners a look that makes it clear he needs help deciding what to do.

Lonnie looks skeptical, but Rogelio launches into a rant in sign about how he has always hated it in the Horde and how they have threatened to hurt Rogelio's little sisters if he didn't comply before. He finishes with the sentiment that *we could be free.All of us* . He must have known that Lonnie wouldn't quite agree or he would have just spoken it and had her translate. Lonnie looks away from him when he finishes, her arms crossed and body tense as she looks to his boyfriend with shining eyes.

She and Rogelio are on board, then. That means Lonnie won't be far behind, but she is visibly struggling with the idea. Lonnie was raised as a street kid, the same as Catra and Adora. She had no other family after her father became a civilian casualty of the Horde clashing with another gang on their block. The Horde may have raised her afterwards, but it was also the reason she needed a surrogate in the first place.

Lonnie clenches her fists where they're tucked tightly into her folded arms, her jaw working as her gaze goes distant and she thinks it over. Adora is offering her a small, hopeful smile, but Lonnie isn't looking at her. Eventually she reaches an end to her internal debate, sighing as she drops her arms back to her sides and looks to them with her mouth set in a grim line. She isn't happy with her decision, but she nods.

"It' s a tight turn around, but I'll find a way to take the street kids out tomorrow. We'll warn the others that we can't get out, but the only people at base should be enforcers and the.captains." Lonnie starts to reply, trailing off as she has a realization. Her eyes snap up, locking gazes with Catra. Catra can see the question of *did you plan this* in her eyes. The answer is of course she did. If she was going to use such a risky plan, she was going to do everything she could to ensure the right people got caught in it at least.

She was going to plant the bomb last Thursday during the weekly debriefs for the teams who were getting assignments, but instead she woke up in Adora's arms. The bombing was the last thing on her mind when she was busy loading her stuff into Adora's backseat, so

she mentally pushed it off until the next week without thinking about it. This week will be better for it. Once a month, the highest-ranking captains meet up just before the weekend rush at the gambling dens, and that should fall on this Thursday.

Shadow Weaver always leaves her office to lurk in the background of the smaller weekly meetings, but she'll be far from it and unable to destroy evidence when she is running a meeting with Hordak. It means that the worst of the Horde – the ones who have perpetuated and encouraged its violence – will all be present at the base. Few others will be around since assignments generally aren't carried out on the same night. If Lonnie can get the street kids out, then it will be the best opening for a raid.

"W e're not trying to send anyone to jail except murderers. Help us with this and there's no way the Horde can rebuild to blackmail people like it has in the past. You'll be free to work how you want," Catra tells her. Earnest is usually Adora's thing, but she means this. She *wants* this for Lonnie and the others. She feels like she owes it to them after they helped her reach this point for herself. She could have gotten back on her feet on her own, but she's grateful that her team was there to help her.

Lonnie holds her gaze for a long moment, and then she nods. She looks stressed, but she and the trio have the hardest part of this plan by far. Well, except Angella, but Catra is resolutely *not thinking about that*. Lonnie's anxiety is justified, but she will help. She'll get the kids just like them out, and then the Horde will finally have to face the music for all that they have done.

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Thursday is spent in tension. Lonnie came up with taking an impromptu bowling trip before they left the apartment last night, so

Adora has faith that she has the savvy to lure away the right people without giving too much away, but even if going bowling with the street kids and cadets makes sense – it involves showing off sports skills and competition, two things the Horde and Lonnie love – Adora has to worry if Shadow Weaver will allow it.

She watches the Alliance prepare with trepidation, unsure if the Horde will even be there to be caught, and if they are, if the emergency services and police will arrive in time. This is her battle, but if she gets close enough to help, she gets close enough to blow the whole thing. She has to sit in the penthouse with the others and just watch Entrapta preside over her hacked access to the emergency channels as Mermista and Sea Hawk drive out to the address Adora gave them.

It should take EMS only a few minutes to reach the address, especially with Entrapta having hacked the city two days ago. She rescheduled a few police patrols to be nearby to the area. Catra gave them the route to take as they approach the armory wall to avoid rousing suspicion. The only Alliance members onsite are Mermista and Sea Hawk. Well, Angella is probably there too. She fought with Glimmer again this afternoon and left before Mermista and Sea Hawk did.

I’ve lived two thousand years, Glimmer . I’m tired. It won’t kill me. I just want to live a normal lifetime now,”Angella practically begged her daughter to understand. They both had tears in their eyes, totally caught up in their argument despite their rather large audience. Glimmer was almost hysterical as Angella drew her close. I love you. I’ll finally be the mortal I want to be again, darling. I’ll still get to watch you get married and grow old. You won’t be alone,”Angella promised her.

No matter her reassurances, it didn’t work. Glimmer tried to actually hold her mother in place, and when that failed, Bow gently took Glimmer in her arms and comforted her as Angella left. It’s not that Angella is dying, but Glimmer has never had to be afraid of that happening before now. Adora knows she would struggle to

understand if Catra had made this choice, but they would be in a very different position.

If it weren't for the fact that Adora was reminded of Shadow Weaver murdering Catra just the day before, she would be right there with Glimmer asking Angella not to do it, but if there's anyone who deserves to be punished it's Shadow Weaver. Adora could never do it, she could never even help, but she sits on the couch with her shoulders tense as she watches Angella leave, knowing full well what her mission is and doing nothing to stop it.

Bow comforts a crying Glimmer in the aftermath. Adora and Catra silently curl into each other, half in each other's laps on the couch. They watch Entrapta stream her laptop to the TV as she tracks Mermista and Sea Hawk's progress. They can't do anything but exchange anxious glances with each other as Mermista and Sea Hawk get in position. Sea Hawk is just there in case something goes wrong.

Mermista sets out on foot, a backpack thrown over her shoulder and headphones in her ears. They listen to the mic jostling against Mermista's hoodie as she makes her way to the drop point. They all watch the feeds streamed to the TV as they wait for Mermista to give the signal. The news channel plays in the corner, just airing the national news at the moment, but it won't be long after the explosion that the breaking news alert interrupts it.

"Go time," Mermista whispers, and then there's a static crackle that cuts off the line. It was too much of a risk to drop the bomb and leave. The Horde would have spotted the abandoned bag and known something was wrong. Mermista will regenerate, so stopping to seemingly change the song playing on her phone and hitting the trigger instead was her best option.

The bomb is too small for them to feel the blast from this far away. For a few tense minutes, which are probably just seconds in reality as people scramble for their phones, everything in the room is silent - and then the channels begin flooding with incoming calls. Adora

sags against the couch with her sigh, Catra going equally limp in their arms. Now they just have to wait for the police to arrive and find out what they've done.

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It takes a long time, even with Entrapta monitoring the channels, for them to find out who got caught as a result of the blast. The news gets there by the time the police has called in reinforcements due to the discovery of weapons in the fire, and they raid the building as soon as they have the men for it. They hear it over the radio and watch it on the news. Even once the raid happens, the cops have no idea who they have arrested, so it doesn't tell them much.

Sea Hawk texts them when he has met up with Angella and is on his way back. Catra takes one look at Angella when she walks in and knows she has done it. Glimmer cries, but Angella assures her that they have an entire happy life stretching before them, and Bow quietly promises that he'll always be there for her. Pretty quickly the small family retreats to Glimmer's room for a private conversation and Catra flattens her ears to avoid overhearing it.

She already feels conflicted enough about this. Having someone else crying around her could very well break her, especially when she feels wrung out worrying about who got arrested. It's like the last two bombs all over again, fear draining all her energy as she worries about who might have gotten caught up in her recklessness. She used to think this was a great idea, the kind of strategy guaranteed to work, but now all she can feel is anxiety.

It's almost midnight by the time Entrapta has the numbers on the people arrested on the scene – just over a dozen. Some of those will no doubt be released without any charges, but the number tells Catra what she desperately needs to know: the street kids weren't

there. At least not most of them. She breathes a sigh of relief, her entire body going limp after a day of being locked up tense.

Most of those people are unidentified, but Grizzor and Hordak don't need to admit who they are to be IDed. Every cop and citizen in the city knows them. They are both counted amongst those captured, and Shadow Weaver got what was coming to her. Finally, the torment is over. The demons that loomed over them for their entire childhood are locked away. Without its leadership, base, or supplies, the Horde doesn't stand a chance as an organization. It will crumble in the scramble to recover.

Catra is weak from her relief. Adora feels it, wrapping her up and struggling for a moment before she stands with Catra in her arms, carrying her a bit unsteadily back to their bedroom. Catra is deceptively heavy and Adora is probably going through a similar weakness from relief that she is. Catra put extra pressure on herself since this whole thing was her idea, but she knows that Adora was worried too. That's just who she is.

Adora places Catra gently in the bed, petting her sides as Catra sleepily pulls off her clothes and then thuds her tail on the mattress beside her, demanding Adora join her. Adora smiles, small and sleepy but still there as she climbs into bed beside Catra and wraps around her. She hums a little as she runs her fingers through all of Catra's exposed fur. Catra already can't imagine sleeping with clothes on and losing Adora's wandering touch as they fall asleep or wake slowly in the morning.

Tonight, Catra is drained and exhausted from the emotional toll of the day, but tomorrow she will wake up into a world where she and Adora are truly free, not just for the first time since Shadow Weaver spotted them on the street, but for the first time *ever.* Now they have a home – two, in fact, even if Catra definitely prefers Adora's room in the penthouse – and the freedom to go wherever they wish. They even have the money to fly all over the world, but Catra doesn't really want to. Everything she needs is right here in bed with her.

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It takes days for all the identities and charges of those caught in the explosion to make the news, but Adora stops worrying the day after the raid when she sees the headline *Shadow Weaver Identified as Senator's Daughter*. She turns to Catra, scattering kisses along the side of her face and breathing *I love you* over and over. There's no one to stop them now. Well, maybe Frosta's complaints kill the mood a little bit, as do the wolf whistles, but Catra doesn't seem to mind as she frames Adora's face with both her hands and kisses her like her life depends on it.

They can *do* that now. After the Scarlet Ibis job, things were tense as everyone minus Adora worried about the Horde. Adora stopped worrying herself once Catra moved in, but there was still Angella's visit looming over them. After that, it was the upcoming bombing and worries about the wrong people getting caught in it and the right ones escaping. For the first time since – well, actually, for the first time in their entire lives – things are just *light*.

Glimmer and Angella have some tension – they aren't totally done fighting about it, though they've mostly progressed to quiet conversations in private – but the overall air in the penthouse is jubilant. They aren't looking over their shoulders anymore. There's plenty of money to be had in the Fright Zone, so the Alliance isn't looking to move on from the penthouse any time soon, and they can settle in, relax, and just spend time as people while they wait for new opportunities.

Adora lays down with Catra that night, undressing her slowly with the luxury of infinite time and then wandering her hands and lips over her body, relaxed and indulging in the sensation of soft fur over hard muscle. Catra stretches beneath her with soft sighs, rumbling and flicking her tail as Adora traces her stripes and ruffles up her fur,

searching for old scars that she used to know so well and finding nothing. It doesn't erase the hurt, but it certainly helps.

"Forever ," she whispers, pressing a soft kiss against the bottom of Catra's ribcage. Catra rumbles, her hand lifting to card through Adora's loose hair, taken down for the night. When Adora glances up, she catches Catra's beautiful, mismatched eyes watching her, hooded as Catra smiles down at her. The love in her gaze snatches Adora's breath away. Without breaking eye contact, Adora ducks her head to press a kiss on Catra's next rib. Her skin shifts beneath her with the small breath she sucks in as a response.

"It always was going to be," Catra responds, her voice low and scratchy. It gets like that when she's half-asleep or *happy*. Adora smiles, ducking her face down to breathe in Catra's softness before she shifts to kiss her next rib – at least she thinks. It's hard to track what she's already kissed when Catra is shifting with every breath beneath her.

"It was always going to be us for our whole lives, but now it' s really *forever*. Now we know this doesn't end until we decide we're done," Adora returns, shifting to kiss a spot where a gnarled scar from training used to be. Glancing up, she finds Catra's eyes intense and burning. They practically glow, catching the dim moonlight from the window and taking on an other-worldly quality as Catra shivers a little beneath her and nods. Her hand in Adora's hair shifts to cup her cheek instead.

"I'm never going to be done with you," she tells Adora, her voice low and a touch seductive as she gently presses beneath Adora's jaw, encouraging her up. Adora feels a slow smile pull at the corner of her lips as she shifts up, letting Catra direct her into a *thorough* kiss. Catra threads a hand in her hair, holding Adora in place as she maps her mouth. Adora happily sinks into the attention, humming softly as Catra has her way.

Realistically, she knows immortals don't hang around forever. They usually choose to pass on after a few lifetimes. According to

Mermista, though, sometimes you just don't want to let go – not only of your soulmate, but of all the mortals you have known and loved over the years. She and Sea Hawk are the oldest immortal couple that Adora has heard of, together for hundreds of years. Even if she and Catra will finally want rest one day, she can't imagine it will be soon.

They don't just have the time to love each other slowly in private now compared to their rushed encounters in the Horde – they have lifetimes worth of slow encounters to enjoy. They have been through a rough life to get here, and Adora definitely wishes some of their misery could have been avoided, but if it led her here, with her hands running over her lover and her mouth occupied, then it was worth it.

Adora would give the entire world for Catra. She'll gladly take their past for this present.

Chapter End Notes

That's it for Knifepoint!Fic notes are up on my tumblr (linked here). I'll be starting my next fic, a pirate/siren AU soon, so subscribe to my profile to make sure you don't miss it!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!